A NOVEL

The Forty-Day Clause

Loop Chronicles Book 3 · A novel that begins at Jonah 4

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The Forty-Day Clause, Part One

The Proclamation and the Flight

Chapter 1. Reading Aloud

The Scales calculates the sentence. But it takes effect only when a person reads it aloud.

I asked why, once. I was eleven. The proclamation supervisor looked at me for a moment, then went back to sorting the papers in his hands and answered.

"That's the rule."

"But why?"

"Because that's the rule."

I didn't like that answer. I didn't know yet that it wasn't an answer at all.

. . .

Herald training begins with the voice.

We read four hours a day. First short sentences, then long ones, then sentences with other people's names in them. A sentence with someone else's name in it is the hardest thing to read.

The training hall had a high ceiling and no windows. Sound struck the walls and came back. Read for four hours in a room where your own voice returns to you, and before long you can't tell whether it's your voice or the wall's.

The supervisor said he'd chosen that room on purpose.

"Out there, when you read, nobody answers." he said. "So get used to it in here. Your own voice, coming back to you."

What he taught wasn't pronunciation. By the third day everyone's pronunciation sounded more or less the same. What he really taught was **how not to stop.**

"Most people trip on the name." he said. "A name is just letters. Why hold your breath to read letters?"

We practiced reading names. Names we didn't know first, then names we did. In the last week we read fake sentence documents with our own names on them.

When my turn came, I read straight through without stopping once. The supervisor nodded.

"Pheugon. Well done."

The boy sitting beside me looked at me. He had stopped three times on his own name.

I took that look for admiration, back then. I know now it wasn't. He wasn't envying me. He was afraid of me.

That boy's name was Had. When training ended, Had didn't become a herald. He never broke the habit of stopping on names.

I said nothing the day Had washed out. Had said nothing to me either. But as he carried his things out, he turned once.

"Why don't you ever stop?"

I couldn't answer.

I carried that question for three years. By the time I could answer it, Had was gone.

. . .

What we read is not the verdict. The verdict has already been handed down by the Scales. What we read is the procedure that makes that verdict audible to the world.

The Scales knows everything. It calculates, without error, the weight of every act committed inside a city. It knows exactly what one stolen loaf of bread is worth, what one lie is worth, what one blow of a hand is worth. People adjust their lives by the figures the Scales gives them.

But the Scales does not speak its own verdicts.

This is the first strangeness of this world. The Scales weighs, the Scales sentences, the Scales executes — and yet reading the verdict aloud, that alone, is left to a person. And not just any person. Someone trained specifically for that one task.

Unread, it has no effect. However precisely the Scales calculates, if no one reads it aloud, the verdict stays a number written on paper.

I used to think this rule was a flaw in the Scales. One old procedure left standing in an otherwise perfect system. Vestigial. Something that would be done away with, eventually.

I doubt I was the only one who thought so. No one asked why the procedure existed. Everyone was satisfied with "because that's the rule."

But that procedure wasn't vestigial. It was the one thing, across every one of these cities, that the Scales could not do — and someone had placed a person in that spot. Who did that, and why, I wouldn't think to ask until much, much later.

. . .

The year I turned fourteen, I became a herald in full.

My first proclamation was small. A merchant in the market who'd tampered with his own scale weights. His weight hadn't crossed the limit, so he wasn't pushed out of the city — only barred from the market for six months.

I stood before him and read the sentence. He watched me the whole time. A man of about fifty, looking up at a fourteen-year-old.

I read without stopping. Name, charge, disposition, effective date.

I folded the paper when I finished. The merchant said something; I didn't hear it. Not hearing was part of the training too.

I went home and washed my hands for a long time. I washed them without knowing why.

That night I tried to remember what the merchant had said. I'd seen the shape of his mouth, so I could guess. Two words, maybe.

I couldn't remember.

I thought that was the training taking hold. That not-listening had settled into my body.

It hadn't. I had heard him. And that same night, I had already erased it. Only the one who erases something knows what was erased. After that I erased a hundred and eleven more times.

. . .

Over the three years that followed, I read a hundred and twelve cases.

I kept count, not to boast. I counted because I couldn't have borne it otherwise. While I was counting, it wasn't a person. It was a number.

Of those hundred and twelve, not one was a misjudgment. Not a single one. I checked. For days after each reading I went through the records, wanting to know whether the Scales had ever been wrong. If it had been wrong even once, my reading would have meant something different.

It never had.

I think I felt reassured, then. If the Scales was never wrong, every sentence I read was a correct sentence. And a person who reads correct sentences has done nothing wrong.

I leaned on that logic for a long time. It took forty days to bring it down.

. . .

I don't do wrong.

My weight is the lowest in my cohort. The supervisor checked it once, and then checked it again, as if to say, is this right.

I don't lie, I don't touch what belongs to others, I don't get angry. Not that anger doesn't come — I don't let it out. I know those are two different things.

Everyone assumed it was because I was conscientious.

It wasn't. I wasn't afraid of weight. I believed there was a sentence I would one day have to read, and I didn't want to lose the right to read it.

What that sentence was, I had known since I was twelve.

There is only me in my family now.

I don't intend to tell it all here. I'm not able to tell it all even to myself yet. I'll write down only this much — a few years ago, someone came to stay in our house, and after that person left, our family came apart.

That person came from the Reckoning.

The Scales calculated it. Calculated it precisely. A weight came out, and a disposition came down. I have no complaint about that disposition. It was precise.

Precise, and nothing came back. I thought for a long time about how those two sentences could stand together, and in the end I stopped thinking about it. Instead I decided to do something else.

I decided to become a herald.

. . .

Around the start of autumn, the supervisor called me in alone.

His room was always cool. The window faced north, and a list of heralds hung on the wall. A number beside each name — the count of cases that person had read. Beside my name it said 112.

The supervisor set a document on the desk.

"This one's big."

I looked at the document. In the first line was a city's name.

The Reckoning.

I looked at those letters. For a long time. The supervisor was explaining something. I couldn't hear it.

"…Pheugon."

"…Yes."

"Are you listening."

"…Yes."

The supervisor looked at me for a moment. Then he tapped the document again.

"This isn't an individual case. It's the whole city. Accumulated weight crossed the limit. A case like this comes once a decade, if that."

"…The whole city?"

"Sentence of demolition." the supervisor said. "Forty-day grace period. Meaning: get your affairs in order and get out, within that time."

"…And the people?"

"They scatter." the supervisor said. "Some go to cities that'll take them in. Some don't get taken in, and live outside."

"…How many people."

The supervisor turned a page.

"A hundred and twenty thousand."

I heard that number. A hundred and twenty thousand. A number I'd never counted to. Counting a hundred and twelve, I had thought that was a lot.

I had no sense, then, that the number was people. I still don't think that was my fault. No one can feel a hundred and twenty thousand as people. I only think, now, that if even one face had been in it, something might have been different — and forty days later I would learn how wrong that thought was.

Even after a face appeared, I still wanted that city to fall.

I noticed, in that moment, that my hands weren't shaking. They should have been. Through a hundred and twelve readings my hands had never once shaken, but this time, they should have. They didn't.

Because they didn't shake, I knew I had been waiting for this.

. . .

"The reason I'm assigning you is simple." the supervisor said. "You don't stop."

"…Yes."

"A whole-city sentence draws a crowd. People cry, they shout, they grab at you. Stop partway through, and you have to start over from the beginning. There have been heralds who stopped more than three times, reading in front of a crowd like that."

The supervisor looked at me.

"You won't stop."

"…Yes."

"That's not a compliment." the supervisor said. "And it doesn't mean this is good for you, either."

I didn't answer.

The supervisor slid the document toward me. He kept his hand on it a moment before he let go.

"Pheugon."

"…Yes."

"Do you have some connection to the Reckoning."

I looked at him. He was looking at the document.

"…No, sir."

The supervisor took his hand off the paper.

"All right."

I told exactly one lie in that room that day. Weighed out, it would have been a very light lie. The Scales would have calculated it, and that figure is probably sitting in my record somewhere, even now.

The Scales never knew that lie was the heaviest one of my life.

I didn't know, then, that the supervisor was worried about me. In that room, that day, he was the only one who was.

. . .

I walked out of the room with the sentence document in my hand.

The corridor was long. Windows at regular intervals let light and shadow cross my face in turns as I walked.

At the end of the corridor stood a terminal of the Scales. Put a hand on it, and your weight comes up. People at the proclamation office rest a hand on it several times a day. Habit.

I passed it and stopped.

I almost raised my hand, then didn't. I'd just told a lie; the figure would be up a little. Checking how much might have settled my mind. It would only be a small rise, after all.

I didn't raise that hand that day. And for the forty days after, not once. I understood why only later. It wasn't that I was afraid the number would be high. I was afraid it would be low.

I already knew, somewhere in me, that what I was about to do would barely register on the Scales at all.

I walked on, unfolding the paper. I didn't mean to read it through. I only wanted to see the city's name once more.

The Reckoning.

I had known that name for a very long time. I had never once said it aloud. Not since I was twelve.

And now I had become the person who had to read that name aloud. And not just any line of it — the city's last line.

I stopped in the middle of the corridor.

And I laughed. Silently, for just a moment.

I remember that laugh. I couldn't have explained, then, what kind of laugh it was. I can now.

It was relief.

. . .

At home I laid the sentence document on my desk.

I didn't read it. A herald isn't permitted to read a sentence aloud before proclamation day. That's a rule too. The moment it's read, it takes effect.

I only skimmed it with my eyes. City name, accumulated weight, basis of calculation, grace period, method of execution. The sentences were short and exact. The Scales always writes that way.

And at the very bottom of the page.

The type was one size smaller than the rest, set close to the margin. The first time I saw it, I took it for a printing error.

Article 4, Clause 11.

I stopped on that line.

It was one sentence.

> *Should this city, within forty days, be confirmed to have turned, this sentence shall be void.*

I read that sentence, and read it again, and a third time.

Turned.

Not a word the Scales uses. The Scales writes "weight decreases," or "the figure falls below the limit." It doesn't use words that name a direction. The Scales has no category called direction.

But this sentence had one.

In a hundred and twelve sentence documents, I had never once seen a sentence like it. This clause doesn't attach to individual cases. Only to whole-city cases. And a whole-city case comes once a decade, if that.

I didn't understand, that night, exactly what the sentence meant. I never asked who "confirmed" meant — confirmed by whom. I assumed the Scales would confirm it.

It would take twenty more days from that night before I learned the Scales cannot confirm it. And standing in the place where I learned that, I would, for the first time, understand precisely why I had run.

I traced the sentence with my fingertip. The paper was thin. The small type set into the margin sat slightly out of line with the body text, as though someone had added it in later.

I don't know how many times I looked at that line again that night. I didn't count. It was the first time in my life I'd forgotten to count.

(Continued in Chapter 2.)

Chapter 2. Weight

> *_Previously_ — Pheugon was the trainee who best mastered reading without*
> *feeling. He became a full herald at fourteen and read a hundred and twelve*
> *cases over three years, not one of them a misjudgment. As autumn begins,*
> *the supervisor assigns him a whole-city sentence of demolition — the*
> *Reckoning. Hearing the name, Pheugon is startled that his hands do not*
> *shake.*

The Reckoning isn't the only city that uses the Scales.

Every city in this region uses it. They differ only in size and precision. Ours was a small one. Three terminals in the square, two at the market's edge, one in the proclamation office corridor. Six in all, measuring the weight of the whole city's people, in real time.

I'd heard that the limit differs from city to city. Some cities have high limits, tolerant of most wrongs. Some have low ones, where a handful of small lies is enough to push a person out. I didn't know then which the Reckoning's limit was. I learned later — the Reckoning had a high limit. And still it was crossed.

People put a hand up to the terminal. A number appears on the screen. That's all. The Scales doesn't explain. It doesn't tell you why this number, why it rose or fell since yesterday. It only gives the number.

As a child I thought that was unkind. I think differently now. The Scales doesn't explain because it isn't unkind. It has nothing to explain. A number is a number. A number has no reason.

. . .

No one knows exactly how weight is assigned. The calculation happens inside the Scales, and there's no way to bring that process out in a form a person can see. We can only guess from the result.

One lie is worth roughly this much. Theft, heavier. Striking someone, heavier still. Weight has units, though no one bothers with what to call them. It's just a number. Low is good, high is bad. That's all, and that's all this city knows.

When accumulated weight crosses an individual's limit, that person is pushed out of the city. Pushed out isn't quite the right word. No one lays a hand on them. Everything that person used — the house, the job, the market pass, the ration — simply stops, one thing at a time. I learned very young that the Scales can push a person out of a city without ever touching them.

When a whole city's accumulated weight crosses the city's limit, a sentence of demolition falls on the city itself. That's rare. Individual cases come out every month, but a whole-city case, as the supervisor said, comes once a decade, if that.

The Reckoning was that rare case. The day I was assigned it, I didn't grasp how rare it was. I understood only after I stood in that city myself.

. . .

I remember the day school first taught us about weight. I was seven.

The teacher lined us up in front of a terminal. Had us put our hands up one at a time. When the number came up, the other children all saw it. Some laughed. Some cried. It wasn't that the crying children's numbers were especially high. They were just afraid of having their number shown in front of everyone.

"This isn't a punishment." the teacher said. "It's just knowing. Knowing where you stand right now."

I believed her. For a long time.

I know now. It was a punishment. In a world with no line between knowing and being punished, "this isn't a punishment" wasn't comfort — it was already, in itself, a piece of the punishment.

The teacher taught us how to keep our numbers low. Don't lie. Don't touch what isn't yours. Don't get angry. That was how the school told us to be good. Not goodness. A figure.

I was the child who learned it best.

. . .

From around twelve, I checked my weight every day.

If you asked why, I had no real answer. I called it habit. It wasn't habit. I checked every day because I wanted to see the number hadn't dropped — no, not dropped, hadn't risen. I wanted to confirm it was staying low.

I tried not to lie. In ambiguous situations, I just said nothing at all. I never touched anyone's belongings. If my hand brushed something, I pulled it back. When something made me angry, I kept my mouth shut. Keeping it shut

enough, the occasions for anger themselves grew fewer. No — not fewer. I simply stopped calling it anger.

My weight was the lowest in my cohort. Low enough that the supervisor checked it, and checked it again.

The other trainees thought it was just my nature. That I was good, and that was why. Whenever I heard that, I said nothing. Saying nothing was, for me, the easiest answer there was.

Had was different. Had was afraid to check his own number. Every time he passed the terminal in the training hall corridor, he looked away on purpose.

"Aren't you scared?" Had asked me once. We were passing the terminal together.

"…Of what."

"Seeing the number. I hold my breath every time I walk past it."

I didn't answer. I didn't know it then. Had thought I wasn't afraid, but in truth I was more afraid than he was. Only the direction of the fear was different. Had was afraid his number would rise. I was afraid that something was wrong even though mine was low.

I had no words for that difference then. I have them now. Had was afraid of what he had already done. I was afraid of what I hadn't done yet. I already knew I would do it, someday.

. . .

The morning after I received the Reckoning's sentence, I passed the terminal of the Scales as I always did.

I put my hand up. A number appeared on the screen.

Low. As always.

I felt reassured looking at that number. But it was a strange kind of reassurance, I know now. I wasn't reassured because I was a good person. I was reassured because I hadn't done anything yet. I didn't know that the word "yet" was already inside that reassurance.

People were lined up at the market's terminal. A morning scene, every day. Hand up, look at the number, move on with a smile or with no expression at all. Smiling is rare. Mostly people just check. Low, and they're relieved; high, and they're careful.

Near the front of the line stood a stranger, a man. He put up his hand and a fairly high number came up. A few of the people behind him quietly stepped back. The man lowered his hand without a word and turned away. No one held him. No one pushed him either. People just spread out, little by little.

That was how this city punished people. No shouting, no hands laid on. Just a slow stepping-back. I never saw that man in the market again, after that day.

I didn't think of the people stepping back as cowards, back then. I'd have done the same. There was a rumor that standing near someone with high weight for too long could somehow affect your own weight. No one knew if it was true. There was no way to check. And yet people acted as if they believed it. Not because they believed it — because behaving as if they did was safer.

I caught the eye of the old vegetable seller as I passed the line. Every morning she stood at the Scales for a long while, staring at it. Even though the number never changed.

"…How's it look today." I asked, passing, as a kind of greeting.

"Same." she said. "Same every day. That's the frightening part."

I let it pass. I didn't understand it then.

I understand now. What frightened her wasn't a number going up. It was the fact that a number never comes down. The Scales only knows how to add weight. It doesn't know how to subtract. No one has any way to lower their own weight themselves. However much time passes, however well you live, the number stays exactly where it was set. The Scales has no function for erasing a past wrong. Only for adding.

I thought that was only natural, back then. Wrongs don't disappear. I think differently now. That a wrong doesn't disappear, and that a wrong cannot disappear — those are two different claims. The Scales never distinguished between them. Not that it had no wish to distinguish — it had no way to.

. . .

I should say a little about my family. Not all of it — only as much as I can now.

I knew everyone's number. All low. Everyone in my house lived carefully, like me. Whether we were careful because our numbers were low, or our numbers were low because we were careful, I still don't know.

There was exactly one exception.

I won't tell that person's story here. Not yet. I'll only write this — because of that one person's number, the rest of our low numbers stopped meaning anything. The Scales calculated each of us separately. For each of us, separately, the calculation was correct. But as a household, as a unit, that calculation explained nothing at all.

The Scales measures individuals. It doesn't know how to measure a family. I learned that too, only later.

After that, every time I checked my number, I found myself picturing that person's number alongside it. Laid side by side, one gave comfort and the other didn't. But to the Scales, those were simply two numbers sitting next to each other. The low one doesn't offset the high one. The Scales doesn't do that kind of arithmetic.

I think I wanted, for a long time, to believe that my low number could pay something back. Even though no such arithmetic exists anywhere.

. . .

In our last year of training, we studied demolition procedure. Not the individual kind — the city kind. No one had actually seen one. We only learned it from the textbook.

The textbook read like this. Once a sentence takes effect, that city's connections to the Scales are severed, one at a time, in order. Rations stop first, then passes, and last, residency itself is voided. People have to relocate to another city within a set period. Those who don't must live on land without the Scales, however that land lives.

The textbook then added: "In some cases, no city will take them in." No explanation followed that sentence. Just a line break.

I remember staring at that line break for a long time.

I thought, then, that sentence had nothing to do with me. Just one of the hundreds of sentences in the textbook. Three years later, I would be standing in front of real people, reading that sentence with my own voice. I had no idea, back then.

The teacher also asked us this: "If a city is demolished entirely, what happens to the infants inside it?" No one could answer. The teacher didn't answer either. She just turned the page.

I forgot that question for three years. It came back to me the night I received the Reckoning's sentence. For the first time, briefly, I tried to think of an answer. I stopped before I found one. I think I didn't want to find it.

. . .

Walking to the proclamation office, I reached into my bag and touched the Reckoning's sentence document again.

I didn't know exactly how much a city's accumulated weight had to reach before it crossed the limit. The supervisor hadn't given me the precise figure either. He'd only said, "it crossed."

A hundred and twenty thousand people had each added a little, and it had come to that number. Some a great deal, some very little. The Scales adds it all together. Only adds. It doesn't know how to subtract.

That morning I had a thought for the first time. Of a hundred and twenty thousand people, how many stood every morning at a terminal, checking their own number, the way I did. Did they too know that number could never come down.

Thinking about it, I felt strangely nothing. Standing before a hundred and twenty thousand faceless numbers, I thought only that the city was getting what it deserved. How cleanly, how casually that thought had settled inside me — I had no idea, at the time.

At the front gate of the proclamation office, I stopped for a moment before going back in.

There was a terminal by the door too. I didn't raise my hand. I'd already checked that morning. But there was another reason too.

Standing at that terminal, I felt afraid to see a number for the first time. I hadn't done anything yet. Hadn't even decided to run. My body seemed to already know. That I was about to enter a different kind of relationship with that number.

Up to that point, in fifteen years of living, I had never once doubted the Scales. Never once thought it could be wrong. That morning, I still believed exactly that. The Scales is right. Entirely right. The problem wasn't the Scales. The problem was what the Scales's being right could make me do.

Our city has a totalizer board too. A large board mounted on the wall beside the proclamation office, showing the whole city's accumulated weight as a single number. People don't usually look at it. Their own number is already more than enough to carry, without minding the whole city's.

That morning, for the first time, I stood in front of it and looked at our city's number. Far from the limit. Safe.

I thought the Reckoning must have a board like this too. The people there must have stood in front of it every morning, checking not their own number but the whole city's. I couldn't imagine, then, what that would feel like. I only understood after I stood in front of one myself — that standing before a board like that, and watching it creep closer to the limit day by day, are two entirely different things.

I just opened the door and went in.

(Continued in Chapter 3.)

Chapter 3. The Last Line

> *_Previously_ — Pheugon retraces the rules of the world the Scales measures: that weight only ever adds, never subtracts; that one person in*
> *his own family carried an exceptional weight. Walking to the proclamation*
> *office, he stops for the first time before the city's totalizer board. He imagines the Reckoning must have one too, and opens the door.*

There's an archive room on the third floor of the proclamation office. A herald can go there to check the full text of any case assigned to him. The ordinary individual cases I usually handled had no full text to speak of — a one-page summary was all there was.

A city case was different.

The clerk at the desk checked my papers and looked at me for a long moment.

"…The Reckoning case."

"…Yes."

"First time, with a city case."

"…Yes."

The clerk went into the back and came out with a thick bundle of paper. Much thicker than the one I'd brought in my bag.

"This is the full text. What you have is the summary. You'll read the summary on proclamation day, but you need to verify against the full text."

I took the bundle. It was heavier than I'd expected.

. . .

The reading room had no window. A desk, a chair, one light coming down from above. A soundless room. The whole archive was designed that way — a place where a person confirms, in silence, sentences the Scales has calculated.

I started from the first page.

The opening part was all things I already knew. City name, coordinates, jurisdiction, the date its Scales connection began. The Reckoning was an old city. Its Scales connection was old too. Over a hundred years.

The second part was the basis for calculating accumulated weight. This was where the unfamiliar content began. How the whole city's weight was calculated, how individual weights were summed, even the history of how the summing method itself had changed several times.

Reading that part, I had a strange thought. That the people actually living in that city had no way of knowing the number produced by such a complicated calculation. They must have just looked at the board every morning. No one would have known what was being calculated behind it.

The third part was the sentence itself. Demolition. Forty-day grace period. Method of execution. This part was nearly identical to the summary. Only the sentences were a little longer, a little more legal.

An appendix was attached at the back of the full text. A weight-calculation ledger. A table organized by household, with names all struck out, only

numbers remaining. District 12, household 3, accumulated 47. That kind of thing.

I turned through that table for a long while. Pages passed and it didn't end. A hundred and twenty thousand lives strung out in numbers and figures. Beside some numbers the weight was very low. Beside others, very high. Between the low and the high, no explanation at all. They just sat side by side.

Turning through that table, I thought of the man I'd seen in the market that morning — the one people had stepped back from because his number was high. I tried counting how many like him might be in this table, and stopped. I stopped because this time I couldn't count. I could count up to a hundred and twelve. This wasn't a number that could be counted.

. . .

The door opened and the supervisor came in sometime in the middle of the afternoon.

"…Still reading."

"…Yes."

The supervisor glanced at the full text on the desk.

"Everyone's like that at first. A city case is a different volume."

I didn't answer, just kept reading. The supervisor stood there a moment, then asked.

"Anything catching on you."

I could have asked, then. About Article 4, Clause 11. But in that moment I chose not to. I didn't know why, at the time. I know now. I was afraid that if I put the question to the supervisor, he would carry the answer away for himself instead of me. It had to be my question. Not yet knowing why, I still wanted to keep it.

"…No." I said. "There's just a lot of it."

The supervisor nodded and left. The door closing sounded unusually loud in the quiet room.

. . .

I stopped partway through and found an item that wasn't in the summary. It was labeled "Precedent Reference."

A few case numbers were listed there. Numbers for other cities' cases. I didn't know what they meant. I thought about asking and decided not to. I didn't think it was information I needed right away.

I learned later what that item was. The precedent database. The place the Scales draws on past verdicts to adjust a sentence. I passed those numbers by, that day. I had no idea I'd walk into that room myself, months later, and lay a finger on one of those numbers.

I kept reading. The sentences were short and exact. The Scales's sentences always were. Almost no adjectives. When they appeared, they were only there to describe a figure.

Reading a long while, I noticed something strange. Not once, in this whole document, did the word "why" appear.

The Scales doesn't use why. It uses what, how much, when. Never why. I thought, at the time, that was the Scales's honesty. That it doesn't invent reasons. I think differently now. The Scales doesn't leave out why because it's honest. The question of why is simply outside the Scales's range of calculation. It isn't hiding a reason. It has no idea what a reason is.

. . .

The closer I got to the final pages, the quieter the room seemed to feel.

Execution clauses, appeal procedure — a clause that was, in practice, meaningless in a city case. There's no way for a hundred and twenty thousand people to file an appeal all at once. Then, transitional measures. Then, supplementary provisions.

At the end of the supplementary provisions, one paragraph was set in type one size smaller than the rest. I'd already seen it once at home. But in the full text it looked a little different. It wasn't only the smaller type — the letter spacing sat faintly out of line with the body text. As though the entire document had been completed, and this had been slipped in afterward, by someone.

Article 4, Clause 11.

> *Should this city, within forty days, be confirmed to have turned, this sentence shall be void.*

I looked for a footnote beside the line. Every other clause had one — what precedent it came from, when it was enacted, how many times it had been applied.

This clause had no footnote.

Nothing at all. A blank. I stared at that blank for a long while. It was the first time I'd ever seen a blank space in a document the Scales had written. The Scales doesn't leave blanks. When it doesn't know, it writes "unknown." This clause didn't even say unknown. There was simply nothing.

. . .

I went back to the desk and asked the clerk.

"…This clause has no footnote."

The clerk took the document and checked it.

"Ah, that one." the clerk said. "That's just how it is. This clause never gets a footnote."

"…Why not?"

"I don't know. I really don't. It's just always been that way."

I stood there a moment longer.

"…Does this clause come up often?"

"Only on whole-city cases. Never on individual ones. And whole-city cases themselves are so rare." The clerk shrugged. "This is only the second time I've seen one in the flesh, myself."

"…And the first?"

"About twenty years ago. When I was new here. The clause was exactly the same, back then. Nobody paid it any mind."

"…What happened, that case?"

The clerk's face went thoughtful for a moment.

"Demolished. That city. Ran out the forty days and was demolished. The clause never triggered."

"…Why not?"

"Who could say." the clerk said, straightening the papers. "Never confirmed, I'd guess. Whatever it took — confirmation, it never happened."

I held onto that answer. Never confirmed. What would have happened if it had been confirmed, nobody knew. It had never been tried.

"…Who was the herald, that time."

"Don't know that either. It's not in the record here. A herald's name doesn't stay on the document. It just says 'the herald.'"

Hearing that, I felt a strange relief. I didn't know why, at the time. I know now. In that moment I first understood that no name would stay attached to the thing I was about to do. And that it didn't feel bad.

Nobody paid it any mind. I heard that and just nodded. I didn't understand, then, what that sentence was doing to me. That "a clause nobody bothers with" could be heard two ways at once — as a dead letter, or as a clause no one had ever tested — I wouldn't understand the difference until that very evening.

. . .

I returned the full text and came down the stairs.

The stairs from the third floor to the first are long. A window at every landing, so light crossed my face once with every flight down.

Coming down those stairs, I kept repeating one sentence to myself. "Should this city, within forty days, be confirmed to have turned." Confirmed. Confirmed by whom. I asked myself that question for the first time, right there.

And having asked it, I didn't try to find the answer. That was strange. I was usually the kind of person who couldn't let a curiosity go. But something held me back in front of that question. I know now. It wasn't that I wasn't curious. It was that I was afraid of knowing the answer. I was already, faintly, sensing that the answer might be about myself.

There was a terminal of the Scales in the first-floor lobby. I just walked past it. The second time that day.

Outside, the sun was low. Afternoon. I'd been in that room all day.

Walking home, I lost my way twice on a route I'd walked a hundred times. A familiar street, and still my feet kept straying somewhere else. I learned that day, for the first time, that when your mind is somewhere else, your body goes there too.

An old man tending a stall at the mouth of an alley called out to me. Someone who usually just gave me a light nod in passing.

"…Herald, you're late tonight."

"…Yes."

"Caught a big one, they say."

I stopped walking. So the rumor was already going around.

"…Who told you."

"Rumor, is all. A whole city, wiped off the map." The old man shook his head. "Handing that to a boy. What a world."

I couldn't say anything. The old man didn't wait for an answer either — he went back to arranging his stall.

Walking through that alley, I thought, for the first time, that no one else in this city knew the Reckoning's story as well as I did. I was the only one in this whole city who had read the full text. That table, with a hundred and twenty thousand lives written into it — no one else had seen it, but me.

That thought weighed on me strangely. It weighed on me, and it wasn't unwelcome. I should have found it more frightening, that the weight wasn't unwelcome. I didn't know that yet.

That night, back home, I opened the summary again. The same sentence I'd seen in the full text. But strangely, the summary felt heavier. In the full text, that clause had been one among hundreds. In the summary, there were only two paragraphs — the sentence, and the clause. With only two paragraphs, the weight split in half.

Demolition and void. Just those two, and nothing else. I didn't know, that night, that I would come to stand between them.

I traced the last line of the summary again with my fingertip.

> *This sentence shall be void.*

I don't know how many times I read that sentence over. I didn't count.

The second time that year I'd forgotten to count.

. . .

That night I ate dinner with the paper set beside me. Eating alone, the sound of my own spoon rang unusually loud.

The table was built for four. Now only one seat gets used. The other three sat empty. I'd long grown used to seeing those empty seats. That night they felt strange to me again.

Three empty seats — I counted them again that night, for no reason. Three. If the Reckoning was a hundred and twenty thousand, our house was three. I learned, that day, that the size of a number doesn't decide how heavy it feels. A hundred and twenty thousand and three both felt equally heavy, inside me.

No — that isn't quite right. To be honest about it — three was far heavier. A hundred and twenty thousand still had no face.

I opened the paper again. I read Article 4, Clause 11 once more. This time without sound, just following the shape of the words with my mouth. A herald isn't allowed to read a sentence aloud before proclamation day. No rule forbade simply moving your mouth along with it. I used that gap.

That night I mouthed that sentence some dozen times, without sound. No sound came out, but I already knew that was a kind of reading too. I hadn't broken the rule. But I knew, even then, that I'd broken its spirit.

That night I stayed up unusually late. Through the window I watched the neighbors' lights go out one by one. This was a quiet city. No one made noise late at night. Everyone had learned to live quietly, to guard their own weight.

I liked that quiet. I wondered if the Reckoning was a quiet city too, like this one. It wasn't. I already knew that. What kind of city the Reckoning was — I already knew.

Whether I had any right to say I knew that city was another matter entirely. I had never walked a single one of its streets. And yet I was certain I already knew what it was. That night I didn't ask myself where that certainty had come from.

Before putting out the light, I folded the paper again. I pressed the crease once with my fingertip. By now the paper was worn from more folds and unfolds than I could count.

That wear was, strangely, a comfort. It meant the paper had been worn soft by how long I'd stared at that sentence. Staring longer doesn't produce an answer. And still I kept staring.

(Continued in Chapter 4.)

Chapter 4. Not Once

> *_Previously_ — In the archive room, Pheugon reads the Reckoning's sentence*
> *in full. Unlike every other clause, Article 4, Clause 11 carries no footnote. The clerk tells him that twenty years ago the same clause existed but was never triggered, and that city was demolished all the*
> *same. That night, Pheugon mouths the clause twelve times without sound.*

The next morning I knocked on the supervisor's door.

I had an excuse ready. Checking proclamation procedure. First city case, so wanting to go back over the steps — that shouldn't sound strange.

I repeated that excuse to myself several times outside the door. It felt strange. Normally I'd have just knocked and gone in. That day I stood there a long while with my hand on the handle.

Looking back, that wasn't hesitation. I already knew what I was going to ask. My body just seemed to already sense where that question would take me. Those few seconds with my hand on the door may have been the last few seconds I was still allowed to have decided nothing.

"Come in."

The room was cool as always. The supervisor didn't look up from his papers.

"What is it."

"…Wanted to check something about procedure."

"What."

I paused a moment, then asked.

"…Article 4, Clause 11."

The supervisor looked up from his papers.

. . .

"What about it."

"Saw it reading the full text. There's no footnote."

The supervisor leaned back in his chair. His face was weighing something.

"There isn't, no." the supervisor said. "In this city — no, as far as I know, across this whole region — that clause has never actually mattered."

"…Not once?"

"Not once." the supervisor said. "I've done this thirty years. This makes three city cases I've seen. All three times, that clause just sat there on the paper. Nothing ever happened."

I nodded, hearing that. But a different question was rising underneath.

"…Why did nothing happen?"

"Because they were demolished." the supervisor said. "All three cities ran out their forty days and were demolished. The clause never triggered because it never triggered — what other reason would there be."

I know now that the supervisor said that without thinking at all. But how it landed on me, he had no idea. He was calling that clause a dead letter. I heard it a different way.

. . .

"…So the clause is just there, then? Meaning nothing at all?"

"That's how rules are." the supervisor said. "A lot of old rules nobody uses anymore. But nobody strikes them out either. No reason to."

"…Who wrote it, that clause?"

The supervisor thought for a moment.

"Don't know. I don't know either. The Scales's articles have just always been there, they say. No one knows who wrote them. When I was new I asked a senior about it — he didn't know either."

"…Isn't that strange? Being applied without anyone knowing it."

"It's strange." the supervisor said. "But have you ever seen the Scales be anything but strange. That's just how it is. It runs whether we understand it or not. That's why it's the Scales."

Something caught on that answer. I couldn't have said exactly what, then.

I can say it now. The supervisor lumped two things together under the same word — "strange." That the Scales runs and keeps running even when it can't be explained, and that one of the Scales's own articles leaves a judgment to a person. But those were two entirely different kinds of strangeness. One is a calculation no one can explain. The other is a spot the calculation couldn't reach, so it was handed to a person instead. The supervisor didn't know the

difference. Neither did I, at the time. But I needed to know that difference far more urgently than he did.

. . .

"…Why doesn't this clause attach to individual cases?"

"An individual case is one person." the supervisor said. "Whether one person suddenly turned or didn't, there's nothing to confirm. You just watch the next figure come up. Lower, it's lower. Not lower, it isn't."

"…But you said the weight already stacked up never comes back down."

The supervisor glanced at me.

"Right. So the clause isn't needed for an individual. What's already stacked is stacked, and after that, you just don't add more. A city is different. A city is a matter of whole or nothing, so that one clause decides everything."

I turned the thought over. A mercy an individual doesn't need becomes everything for a city. A strange structure.

"…Why was this clause written in the first place, then. If no one was ever going to use it."

The supervisor looked at me a moment, then set down his papers.

"I wondered that too, once. When I was new." the supervisor said. "I asked a senior. He laughed. Said maybe it wasn't written so no one would use it — maybe it was written in case no one could."

"…What does that mean."

"Don't know." the supervisor shrugged. "Just something that got said once. Don't take it too seriously."

I took it very seriously. I turned it over all that day. A clause written in case it couldn't be used. A clause written and left on the page even while believing it would never trigger. Why write a clause like that. Why leave it on paper, knowing no one would ever use it.

I know now. That wasn't a clause the Scales wrote. Which is why the Scales's own logic could never explain it.

. . .

"…What does it take, for it to trigger?"

The supervisor looked at me a moment.

"By the text — if the city is confirmed, within forty days, to have turned, that's it."

"…Who confirms it?"

"Not in the text." the supervisor said. "It just says 'confirmed.' Doesn't say who does the confirming."

I think I'd been waiting for that answer. Hearing it only made things more complicated.

"…So if no one confirms it?"

"Then it doesn't happen." the supervisor said, picking his papers back up. "The Scales calculates a city's state every day. But there's no category in that calculation called 'turned.' The Scales measures weight. It can't measure

direction. That's why the clause has never triggered. Not because the condition was never met, but—"

The supervisor stopped.

"…No, I don't know. I don't know that part exactly either. It just never happened. Thirty years."

I held onto the end of that sentence for a long time, that day. "Not because the condition was never met, but—" The supervisor had started to say something else and stopped. I wondered, then, what he'd meant to say. I know now. He knew it too, vaguely. That the condition wasn't unmet — there had simply never been a way to confirm it. But he never put that into words, not the whole way through.

. . .

"…And this one, then."

"This one, what."

"…The Reckoning. What if it really does turn."

The supervisor looked at me. He paused a moment before answering.

"Pheugon. There've been three city cases, once-a-decade cases. All three times, it didn't happen. You just handle the procedure you've been given, exactly right. Read the clause too, along with everything else, exactly as it's written. What comes after that isn't your job."

"…Yes, sir."

"If you're worried, you don't need to be. That kind of thing doesn't happen."

The supervisor meant that as comfort. To ease my mind. Afraid I might be frightened at the thought of a city of a hundred and twenty thousand people falling, he told me that kind of thing simply doesn't happen.

Hearing it didn't ease my mind. Hearing it, I felt some possibility become clear and sharp for the first time. It doesn't happen. But if the reason it doesn't happen isn't that the condition is never met but that it's never confirmed — then turned around, the sentence read like this too: as long as it's never confirmed, nothing will happen, no matter what.

I didn't know it myself, walking out of that room, that I was already reading the sentence turned around. That wouldn't come into exact words until much later, near the very end of the forty days.

. . .

As I was leaving, the supervisor called me back.

"…Pheugon."

"…Yes."

"Why are you asking so much detail about this. The other trainees never ask like this."

I stopped short for a moment.

"…No reason. It's just my first case like this."

The supervisor looked at me a moment, then turned his eyes back to his papers.

"All right. Being thorough is a good thing."

The supervisor must have seen something in my face that day. If I'd ever had the chance to ask him directly, much later, I would have. I never got that chance. What the supervisor saw that day, I still don't know exactly. But I know one thing. He could have stopped me, that day. He didn't.

. . .

I went straight back up to the third-floor archive room. The clerk looked a little surprised to see me.

"…Back again."

"…Could I see the past city cases? Three of them, I heard."

The clerk went in and came back out with three case files. Thin ones. Less than half the thickness of the Reckoning's.

I looked through them right there. All three cities had unfamiliar names. Places I'd never heard of. The clerk said their Scales connections had been severed so long ago they no longer even appeared on maps.

All three cases ended the same way — the full forty days passed, and demolition. But one of them, the most recent one, had a strange sentence attached. A short note in the margin of the results report, written by hand, it looked like.

> *Day thirty-nine: incidents of theft within the city dropped sharply. Observed as a meaningful change, though not reflected in the Scales's figures.*

I read that sentence twice.

"…What does this mean?"

The clerk looked at the note and tilted her head.

"Couldn't say. Probably something the case officer jotted down at the time. It's not part of the official record, though. Margin notes carry no effect."

I traced that note with my fingertip. Day thirty-nine. One day before the city fell. A sharp drop in theft meant that someone who'd been stealing had stopped. But that change hadn't been reflected in the Scales's figures. The weight already stacked up doesn't come back down.

And the next day, that city was demolished.

I wondered who had written that note. That person must have seen something too, the way I had. That the city was changing. But they only wrote it in the margin. Never said it officially. Why not. I didn't know the answer, then. I know now. That person had no way to confirm it either. What you see and what you can declare are two different problems.

The other two files had no margin note like it. They just read, cleanly, "forty days elapsed, clause not triggered, demolition executed." I wondered what the difference was between those two and the third. Maybe those two cities really had changed nothing at all. Or maybe they had changed, and no one had written it in the margin.

What frightened me most was that there was no way to tell the two apart. If it isn't in the record, a thing that happened becomes a thing that never happened. I thought for the first time that what the Scales fails to record might far outnumber what it does.

I held the files a while longer before returning them.

"…Thank you."

"Come back if you need to." the clerk said. "But I've never seen a herald dig into a city case like this before."

I didn't answer. I went down the stairs.

. . .

I walked the corridor past the wall where the herald roster hung. Numbers beside the names. Beside mine, 112. Beside the others, mostly two-digit numbers. Of them, only three on this list had ever handled a city case. The three cases the supervisor had mentioned.

I looked for those three names. Unfamiliar names. People from a generation well above mine. They must have read that clause too. Had they stopped, at that last line, the way I had? I wondered, but there was no one to ask.

I would never come to know what those three people felt, reading that line. Whether they saw something in it the way I did, or simply read it as procedure and moved on. But I can guess one thing. None of them can have been to that city what I was to mine. I didn't know it yet, that day, that this fact set me apart from the other three in a place entirely different from where they stood.

Walking out of the proclamation office, I looked up at the sky. Overcast. It looked like rain was coming.

I stood a moment at the door. I counted the days left until proclamation day. A notice for the Reckoning case was posted on the proclamation office board. Twenty-one days from today.

Twenty-one days. Seeing that number, I began, for the first time, counting time. Until then I'd thought of the clause only as a rule with a triggering condition. From that moment it was different. I felt the clause as something with a deadline. Having a deadline meant there was someone who could do

something within it. I didn't yet think that someone was me. But that the clause needed a "someone" inside it at all — that much, I was already feeling that day.

Rain started on the way home. I had no umbrella. I just walked through it. Feeling my wet clothes grow heavier, I felt, strangely, glad of that weight. At least this was a weight the Scales wasn't measuring.

That night I began planning to run. Though at the time, I didn't call it that. I called it, "needing time to think." I know now. That wasn't needing time to think. I had already finished thinking.

And what that thought had been, I kept hidden even from myself, for a very long time.

(Continued in Chapter 5.)

Chapter 5. That City

> *_Previously_ — Pheugon presses the supervisor about Article 4, Clause 11.*
> *The supervisor tells him it has never once triggered, in three city cases*
> *across thirty years, and tries to reassure him there's nothing to worry*
> *about. Pheugon hears it the opposite way — that as long as it's never*
> *confirmed, nothing will ever happen, no matter what.*

I have never been to the Reckoning.

And yet I know the Reckoning. I know that sounds like a contradiction. To explain it, I have to go back three years.

I've tried to write this several times and stopped. I still don't know if I can write all of it, even now. I can't write all of it. Even I haven't finished sorting through it. But I need to write this much, or no one will ever understand why I ran.

. . .

Three years ago, a person stayed in our house for a time.

Someone from the Reckoning. I won't write the name here. Not yet. I didn't know exactly, then, what business had brought that person to our city, and I

don't fully know even now. I heard it had something to do with some matter between the two cities. That's about all I remember.

My father took that person in. That was the kind of man he was. He was good about letting in strangers.

I still don't want to call that my father's fault. It really was a good thing about him. I learned, then, that a good quality doesn't always lead to a good result.

. . .

The room that person used had been a storeroom. My father hurriedly put a bed in and made it a room. I sometimes passed that door and saw light through the crack. That person wrote something late into the night. He said he was copying over my father's storeroom ledger. Verification work, he called it.

I wasn't curious, then, what kind of verification that was. I thought it was adult business. That was explanation enough for a twelve-year-old.

I'm curious now. Curious far too late. I can still see, when I close my eyes, that light leaking through that crack in the door. What numbers passed back and forth under that light, I may never know, for the rest of my life.

For a few months, that person ate dinner with our family. Talked with my brother and me. When we asked about the Reckoning, he'd answer with a smile.

"Nobody's ever wronged there." that person said. "The Scales measures everything exactly."

I believed that. I thought precise meant good.

I'd come to think of that line again, three years later. I didn't know what it meant, then. I still don't fully know now. I only remember that his face, just after saying it, trembled for the briefest moment.

. . .

What happened after that, I won't write out in detail here. Voices heard through the door, evenings when my father went silent for days, my mother crying alone in the kitchen — I have pieces like that. I can't string them together. I was twelve then, and grown-ups know how not to finish a sentence in front of a child.

The one thing I know for certain is this. After that, something was recorded on the Scales. Someone in our house had their weight rise. Exactly who, exactly how much, I don't know either. I never asked. I didn't have the courage to ask.

I believe that weight was accurate. The Scales is always accurate. But being accurate, and my knowing the full account of that calculation, are two different things. I don't know the full account. I still don't know it now. I may not know it even by the time this book is finished.

I wrote that I heard my mother crying alone in the kitchen exactly once. To be precise, it was twice. The second time was much quieter. It frightened me more than the first. Crying loudly at least gives whoever hears it the illusion they might be able to do something. Crying quietly doesn't even offer that illusion. I stood outside that door and did nothing at all.

I didn't knock on that door. I still don't know if that was right. At the time it felt like I shouldn't. I thought it would only make things harder for my mother, if she knew I'd heard her crying. Thinking about it now, that may have been a judgment made for my own sake. Pretending not to hear was easier for me than hearing and still doing nothing.

That winter, just once, I saw my father's hand at a terminal of the Scales. He put his hand up. A number appeared on the screen. He looked at it for a long time. I was standing beside him. I couldn't see the number from where I stood.

"…Father."

"…It's fine." my father said. Before I'd even asked anything.

I've turned that "it's fine" over for three years now. That wasn't said to me. My father was saying it to himself. I noticed that, at the time, and never once told him that I had.

. . .

It was around then that I started checking my own weight every day. In Chapter 2 I called that just a habit. Here I should write it precisely. It wasn't a habit. It was a beginning. From that winter on, I couldn't bear it if my number so much as moved. Keeping it low, lower still, felt like the one thing I could still do.

I think I said something like this to myself at the time — that since one person in our house had already had their weight rise, the rest of us had to make sure we never let ours rise, no matter what. Whether that's sound reasoning, I know now it wasn't at all. The Scales doesn't calculate by household. My being low doesn't lower my father's number. But I was doing that arithmetic at the time. A child's arithmetic. I never managed to let it go, even after I grew up.

I wrote, in Chapter 1, about the day Had asked me why I never stopped. I wrote that I couldn't answer. In truth, there was an answer. I couldn't afford to stop. The moment I stopped, I felt something would catch up to me. What that was, I didn't know precisely at the time either. I know now. It was that light, leaking through the crack of that door, that winter.

. . .

The day that person left, I walked out to the edge of town to see him off.

I still don't quite know why I did. I think I wanted to ask something. But standing in front of him, in the end, I couldn't ask anything at all.

"…Sir."

That person turned around.

"…Yes, Pheugon."

I stood there a long while before I spoke.

"…Take care."

That person looked at me for a moment. As if about to say something, then deciding against it.

"…All right." that person said. "You too. Be well."

He turned and walked away after that. I watched that back for a long time.

I still remember that back today. I didn't hate that person, then. I didn't know how to hate yet. Hatred grew much later, very slowly. I couldn't even say where it took root.

I didn't go into the room he'd left behind for a while. It was months before I even went in. The bed was still there, the room already reverting to a storeroom's look. A few sheets of paper had fallen in a corner. I picked them up. Dense with numbers. What numbers, I didn't know. I set the paper back down. Somehow it felt like something I shouldn't hold onto.

Thinking about it now, I wish I'd kept that paper. But I was twelve then, not old enough to make that call. That paper is nowhere now. It was probably thrown out, sometime, when the room was cleared out again.

. . .

I wrote about the table in Chapter 3. That the table which once sat four now sees only one seat used. That table had been there since before that person ever came. I remember, every time I look at it, the seat he sat in too. He always sat to my father's right. My brother sat across from him.

After my brother left, I wouldn't let anyone sit in that seat for a while. When my mother asked why, I couldn't answer.

I think I believed, back then, that as long as that seat stayed empty, a place would still be kept for my brother to return to. A child's belief. My brother never came back, and in the end that seat just stayed empty.

. . .

After that, our family came apart.

My brother left home that winter. I still don't know where he went. He left without a word to me.

I remember the night he left. He turned back once, at the door. I couldn't tell if he was looking at me or just checking his direction. That was the first night I learned, on my own, how not to cry out loud. Not taught — learned. No one showed me how. I simply figured it out for myself that night.

My mother went to another city the following year, where relatives lived. She asked me to come with her. I didn't go.

By then I was already training to become a herald, and I told myself I didn't want to give that up. That was the explanation I gave myself. It probably wasn't the real reason. What the real reason was, I still don't have the confidence to say, even now.

My father is still in this city. He doesn't live with me. He lives alone, on the other side of town. I see him now and then. Not often. Even when we meet, we don't talk about it.

We both learned, somehow, how to avoid that subject. We learned it well.

The last time we met was a few days before I was given the Reckoning case. My father said little, as usual. At parting, he said just one thing.

"…What case are you reading these days."

"…A small one." I lied. It wasn't a lie yet, then — I hadn't received the Reckoning case at that point — but in that moment, I think I was already practicing how to hide something.

My father nodded.

"…Take care of yourself."

I know that was the best my father could say to me. He wasn't a man who could say more. That isn't his fault.

Parting from my father that day, I thought, for the first time, whether he too still wore that face — the one where something caves in — whenever he heard the name Reckoning. I didn't want to find out, so I never once said that name in front of him, that day.

. . .

In Chapter 1 I wrote about the lie I told in the supervisor's room. When he asked, "Do you have some connection to the Reckoning," I answered, "No."

That was a lie. Now that I'm here, I can see exactly how much of a lie it was. In that moment I played at being someone with no connection to the Reckoning at all. It was the opposite. I was one of the people most deeply entangled with that city. Without ever having set foot on a single one of its streets.

Why did the supervisor ask that question. Maybe he'd noticed some expression that crossed my face whenever the Reckoning came up. If there was such an expression, I never knew it myself. I always believed I hid my face perfectly. Looking back, that was probably only my own illusion.

The Scales calculated that matter. Calculated it precisely, I'm sure. I don't doubt that.

Precise, and nothing came back. My brother didn't come back, my mother didn't come back, our house never became four again. I thought for a long time about how those two sentences could stand together, and in the end I stopped thinking about it.

No — that isn't true. I didn't stop thinking about it. I went on thinking, in a different way. I decided to pour all that thought into one name — the Reckoning. I set that whole city where that one person had once sat. That wasn't fair. I know that now. I didn't, then.

. . .

The day I received the Reckoning's sentence document, my hands didn't shake. I wrote, in Chapter 1, that this was strange.

It isn't strange to me now. I felt, in that moment, for the first time, that the Scales was right. Just as the weight it had set on my house was accurate, so would this weight, set on the whole of the Reckoning, be accurate too. That city falling felt to me like justice. A city whose name I hadn't even said aloud for three years, finally getting what was owed it.

But I never once asked myself, then, whether I had any right to call that justice. Without asking, I found the clause. The clause that could void that justice.

The moment I read that clause, I thought exactly one thing. That it must never trigger. Whether that thought came from fear, or from something else entirely, I didn't ask myself, then.

That night I stared out the window for a long time. Our neighborhood was dark. Somewhere far off, on the other side of the city, I imagined a light my father had lit alone. I looked that way for a long time.

That night I thought of the word mercy for the first time. To be precise, I admitted for the first time that Article 4, Clause 11 meant mercy. Until then I'd only thought of it as a rule, a procedure, a possibility. The moment I called it mercy, something changed. Mercy had never come to our house. My father's weight was accurate, and because it was accurate, no one ever shaved a single point off it. I was taught that was as it should be. And yet for the Reckoning, for that city, the door of mercy had stood open from the very start.

I couldn't bear that unfairness. That night I didn't call it unfairness, and I didn't call it anger, either. I just quietly decided. That door had to stay shut. I would do whatever I could, so that no one ever opened it.

I didn't know, that night, that the decision would take the shape of running.

(Continued in Chapter 6.)

Chapter 6. The Night Before

> *_Previously_ — At the bottom of the Reckoning's sentence document,*
> *Pheugon found Article 4, Clause 11. If the city turns within forty days,*
> *the sentence becomes void. He admitted, for the first time, that this was*
> *mercy — and that this mercy had never once come to his own house. That*
> *night he made a quiet decision: that door had to stay shut.*

Departure was three days off.

The supervisor had set it that way. Two days' travel to the Reckoning, a day's rest on arrival, then the proclamation. The forty days begin the moment I read the first line in that city's square. So the days I spend traveling don't count against the forty. That's simply passage.

I don't remember well how I spent those three days.

It's strange. I remember all hundred and twelve of my sentences. The merchant's face, Had stopping three times on his own name, even the cool air in the supervisor's room. But those three days are a blur. I must have already been half a different person, by then. Someone who makes memories and someone who has decided not to leave any live different lives.

The third night came. The next morning, I was due to set out on the road to the Reckoning.

. . .

On the second day, I went to the training hall.

There was no reason to go. I was already a full herald; there was nothing left to learn in that room. And yet I walked past it and opened the door anyway.

The room was empty. High ceiling, no windows. The room where my own voice used to come back to me. I stood in the middle of it and said nothing at all.

Our cohort's names were still up on the wall. Had's name too. Not erased. Not erasing the names of the washed-out was this city's way. Weight gets erased. Records don't.

I stood a moment in front of that name. Had's question came back to me. Why don't you ever stop. That night, for the first time, I tried to think of an answer. Because if I stop, something catches up to me. But that night I already knew. I wasn't trying to stop, then. I was about to veer off onto an entirely different road. That was a different thing from not stopping. I didn't know the difference, at the time.

I think I wanted to confirm something, standing there. Whether this room still recognized me. I know how that sounds. But that's exactly the frame of mind I was in, standing there. The room didn't answer. The wall was just a wall. With no one to make a sound, there was no sound to send back.

I walked past the supervisor's door on my way out of that room. It was shut. There was someone moving inside. I didn't knock.

What would have changed if I had. I've asked myself that question many times since. The answer is always the same. I wouldn't have known. And because I wouldn't have known, I still sometimes picture myself standing in front of that

door with my hand raised, and staying that way. A hand that, in fact, I never raised.

On the morning of the third day, I watched from my window as the cart for the Reckoning was made ready. The driver was watering the horse. One of the crates loaded onto that cart would have my name tag on it. A herald's travel provisions.

I didn't watch the cart for long. I looked once and closed the curtain.

. . .

I packed my bag.

What a herald carries on the road is fixed. A change of clothes, a water flask, a wax envelope for the original sentence, and a wristband proving identity. The wristband connects to the Scales. Crossing between cities, it has to be scanned for the passage to be logged.

I packed to that list. And on top of it, I added things not on the list.

Six loaves of dried bread. A second change of clothes. Kindling. I left the wristband out.

I knew exactly what it meant, leaving that wristband behind. Without it, I'm not "recorded" anywhere. No city keeps me on record as having passed through. I wanted to call that an oversight. It wasn't an oversight.

When the bag was packed, I pushed it under the bed. And I sat there a long while, looking at the space under it.

I set the wax envelope on top too. The one holding the Reckoning's original sentence. That was an item on the list. A herald must always keep the sentence

on his person. Packing it, I asked myself. Why am I taking this. I'm not even going to read it.

I had an answer then, and I have one now. I couldn't throw it away. Throwing it away wouldn't have made it cease to exist — it would still be sitting somewhere in the Scales's record, waiting to be assigned to someone else. I couldn't stand that. Neither that someone else might read that sentence, nor that someone else might discover that clause. I decided, then, that this document should belong to exactly one person, in the whole world. Me.

It was a strange kind of possessiveness, thinking about it now. Deciding to hold, all by myself, a document that could save an entire city. At the time I believed that was caution.

. . .

In the evening I thought about going to see my father.

To be precise, I'd already decided not to go, and only pretended to think it over so I could confirm that decision again. I changed my clothes. Walked as far as the door. Went back inside.

I've thought a long while about why I didn't see my father that night. I wanted to write that I was afraid — afraid he'd look me in the eye and know. But I know now. It wasn't that I was afraid my father would stop me. I was afraid he wouldn't. If my father had said just one thing — "all right, don't go" — I would have used that as my excuse, and truly not gone. I didn't need an excuse. I already didn't want to go.

I took out a sheet of paper instead. I meant to write a letter.

I wrote three lines and crossed them out. Wrote two more and crossed those out too. In the end nothing was left at all.

I didn't understand, for a long time, why I couldn't write that letter. I understand now. A letter needs a reason written into it. And I couldn't write my real reason down. Writing it would have meant admitting to myself that it was real. I wasn't ready to admit that yet. So I chose to leave nothing at all. It felt, at the time, like the more honest choice. It was, in fact, the least honest one.

Instead I walked all the way to the other side of the city. To the mouth of the alley where my father lived.

I didn't go up to the house itself. I stood at the mouth of the alley and looked at the window. The light was on. My father stayed up late.

I watched that light for about ten minutes. I started toward it twice, and stopped both times. I still wonder. Did my father know I was standing in that alley. I never asked. I don't think I'll ever get to ask.

The light shifted once, as if my father had crossed in front of the window. I saw that shadow and turned away.

I didn't say goodbye to my father, that night. Even writing this sentence now, it's the thing that troubles me most. Everything else I've managed to put into words. This one, I still can't.

. . .

I left the house past midnight.

I didn't lock the door. There was no need to. Only one person lived in this house now, and that person had nothing left to take.

The street was quiet. In our city, the lamps went out one by one as night fell. I walked through that dark with ease. Fifteen years of living on this street.

There was a terminal of the Scales on every corner. Every time I passed one, I pushed my hands deeper into my pockets.

I had no intention of raising my hand. My body moved that way regardless. Habit outlives reason. That night I felt my body still moving as the old me, while my mind had already gone somewhere else.

I walked not toward the Reckoning, but the other way.

The road passed through the market. Full of people by day, only bare stalls remained by night. The spot where the merchant who'd tampered with his scale weights used to stand was there too. My first proclamation. That man came back into the market six months later, and I saw it from a distance. He didn't recognize me, that time. Even if he had, he probably wouldn't have let on.

Passing that spot, I had a strange thought for the first time. That man had served out his full disposition and gone back to standing in the market, while I was now running in exactly the opposite direction. He had stood his ground before the Scales; I wasn't standing mine. I didn't hold that thought long. Holding it felt like it would stop my feet.

. . .

There was a gatekeeper. Even at night, someone stands watch.

I had to pass him. Without the wristband, I couldn't pass through officially. But the gatekeeper knew me. Proclamation office people get through gates on their faces alone.

"…Where you off to?"

The gatekeeper asked. His voice was sleepy.

"…An errand." I said. "By the supervisor's orders."

A lie. My second lie that night. The first had been in the supervisor's room, saying "no" when he asked whether I had some connection to the Reckoning. The Scales would have calculated each of those two lies. Precisely. And what those two lies together would carry me toward — that, the Scales could never have calculated. It has no category for that.

The gatekeeper nodded. He didn't ask anything more. That I was a herald, that I was under the supervisor's orders, was enough. No one suspects a herald. A herald is someone who reads without feeling, and someone who reads without feeling is assumed to have no reason to run.

I understood, in that moment, for the first time, that the blankness I'd trained into my face was protecting me. The supervisor had taught me how not to stop. He hadn't taught it only to be used while reading. That night I put that same face to a different use.

The steps carrying me out past the gate, I'd expected to feel heavy. They didn't.

That struck me as strange. This was the step turning my back on a city I'd lived in fifteen years. Something should have caved in. But I only put one foot in front of the other. Looking back, I don't think that was strength. I think I had already been practicing this step for a long time. In my mind. My body was only following the practice.

The gatekeeper called something after me. I think it was a good night. I didn't turn around. I only raised one hand.

. . .

Half an hour's walk from the gate, an old road led down to the riverside.

At the end of that road was a well, I'd learned during training. Not part of the formal curriculum. A senior had mentioned it once, in passing. That the wells watering each city are joined underground to one another. Originally a waterway, and for a long time now, a road people walk too.

"The authorities don't know?" I'd asked.

"They know." the senior had said. "They just don't bother to close it off. Whoever uses that road is usually someone who wants to leave the city. Letting them go is a simpler calculation for the Scales than stopping them."

I'd let that pass at the time. I thought it had nothing to do with me.

I'd forgotten that story for three years. And yet that night, walking out past the gate, it was the very first thing that came back to me. What I'd thought forgotten hadn't been erased. It had just been waiting, quietly, until it was needed. I wanted to believe that was coincidence. I don't believe that anymore.

. . .

The well stood at the end of the riverside road. It looked long abandoned. Moss on the coping stones, an old plank laid across it instead of a cover.

I stood in front of it and hesitated for a long time.

I wrote hesitated, but even now I find it hard to say exactly what I hesitated over. It wasn't whether to go in. I'd already resolved to go in. What I hesitated over was something else — that doing this meant I could never be the person I was before, again. Crossing that line took time.

I pushed the plank aside. Cold air rose from inside. Mixed in with the smell of water was another smell, not water at all.

I lowered my bag first, tied to a rope. I heard the sound of it vanishing into the dark. No splash. Which meant the drop to the bottom was quite deep.

I looked in. I couldn't see anything. My fingers found iron rungs set into the wall. Less a stairway than a ladder.

In that moment I thought of the road to the Reckoning. The cart, the highway, the inn we'd stop at along the way, the procedures waiting on arrival that couldn't even be called a welcome. That road was set, recorded, predictable. This well was the opposite. No one knew. No one was waiting for me. I liked that difference. Looking back, that was the trouble. I chose not the safe road, but the one no one knew about.

And I set my foot down.

I remember that moment with strange clarity. The touch of the first iron rung against the sole of my foot. Cold, and slick. Stepping onto it, I thought, for the first time, how deep this stairway might go.

Whether that thought came from fear or from curiosity, I couldn't answer that night. I can answer now. I was afraid. And at the same time I was calculating. The two carried the same weight in me, in that moment.

I stepped onto the second rung. The third. I heard the plank settle back over the opening above me. I hadn't pushed it shut myself. Might have been the wind. Might not have been.

I still remember that sound. Wood meeting stone, short and dull. That was the last sound of the world above ground I heard that night. I gave it no meaning at the time. I hear it differently now. As though someone had closed a door for me. Whether that helped me go, or kept me from coming back — I still don't know.

The sound of water grew nearer beneath my feet. I hadn't touched it yet. The air against my toes just grew steadily damper.

I climbed down. I did not look back.

(Continued in Chapter 7.)

Chapter 7. The Conduit

> *_Previously_ — The night before leaving for the Reckoning, Pheugon packed*
> *in secret and left the house without telling anyone. He turned away from*
> *his father's door without a goodbye, and passed the city gate wearing a*
> *herald's blank, trained face. At the end of the old riverside road, he climbed down into an abandoned well. He heard the plank settle back over*
> *the opening above him, and stepped into the dark.*

There were twenty-two iron rungs.

I counted them going down. There was nothing else to do but count. My foot touched water on the twenty-second rung.

Cold. Far colder than I'd expected.

I've never forgotten that temperature. My body lodged its first protest right then. My mind had made its decision long before. My feet were only just then realizing what was happening.

. . .

The floor wasn't level. The water came to my ankles, then to my knees, then back to my ankles. I felt my way along the wall as I walked.

The wall was stone. Smooth. Worked by hands, for a long time. Not a natural cave. Someone had made this. A very long time ago.

Feeling that wall, I wondered, for the first time, who had dug it. Dug to carry water, presumably — but then why dig it wide enough for a person to walk through? Too precise a width to be coincidence. I never got an answer to that question, walking this road for a long while after.

The tunnel didn't run straight. It curved gently, then bent sharply, and sometimes split into two. I always chose whichever branch had the stronger current. No real reason. I just thought the side the water ran harder must lead somewhere.

The ceiling height wasn't constant either. Some stretches I had to bend at the waist to pass through; others my hand couldn't reach even stretched all the way up. I wondered what the difference meant. Had the stretches meant to carry more water been dug wide, and the ones meant to carry less, narrow? Or had it simply followed the shape of the ground?

I made those questions in the dark, alone, and folded them back up, alone. No one there to answer. That was the first time I learned, in my body, that making a question and getting an answer might have nothing to do with each other. Until then I'd lived believing that a question, once asked, brought an answer along with it. That had always been true at the training hall. Ask, and the supervisor answered. No one was here.

. . .

The sound was strange.

Water sounded from everywhere. But I couldn't tell the direction. It seemed to come from behind, then from ahead. The sound bouncing off the walls mixed with the sound of the actual current.

I understood, for the first time, that in this dark, my ears grew just as useless as my eyes. I thought of the room at the training hall, where sound came back to me. At least that had one wall. Here the walls were on every side, at every angle. I couldn't even count how many times a sound bounced before it returned.

I never let my hand off the wall. The moment I did, I felt I'd lose my direction entirely.

The wall sometimes had grooves cut into it. Feeling along with my fingertips, I found lines of even depth. At first I took them for cracks in the rock. But the spacing was too regular. Someone had cut them on purpose.

I only learned later that those grooves were markers. Left by people who traveled this conduit often, so as not to lose their way. I didn't know how to read them, then. They weren't letters. It was a language read only with the fingertips, and I had never learned that language. I only understood, much later, that the answer had already been carved into the path I was walking.

I walked a long while. There was no way to measure time. No sun, so I couldn't tell day from night either. I just counted steps. A hundred, two hundred, and at some point I stopped counting that too.

I don't remember exactly the moment I stopped counting. That's strange. I was someone who counted everything countable. A hundred and twelve sentences, a hundred and eleven erased words. But in that dark, counting lost its meaning. The numbers weren't taking me anywhere.

. . .

At one point I thought I heard another sound.

Footsteps. Not mine.

I stopped. Held my breath. Nothing but the sound of water.

I still can't be sure, even now, whether that was real. This conduit is said to connect several cities. It wouldn't have been strange for someone besides me to be in it. Someone wanting to leave a city too. The senior had said as much. If so, whoever's footsteps those were, they were here for the same reason I was. I didn't call out to that person. That person didn't call out to me. In the dark, people learn on their own, somehow, how to pretend not to notice each other.

I felt that presence a few more times after that. The water rippling in a different rhythm for a moment, or something knocking, far off. I never once confirmed it. I never once walked toward the sound. I never crossed paths with anyone, the whole time. Maybe that too was one of this road's rules. A rule the water arranged by itself, so that no two people would ever meet.

At the time I thought that was fortunate. I wouldn't have known what to say if I'd met someone. Now I think differently. If someone else had been in that dark besides me, that person probably had no way to speak to anyone either. We were both avoiding each other in the same water.

The footsteps didn't come again. I walked on.

. . .

I was hungry.

I took out the dried bread and ate it. Tore it with wet hands, chewed in the dark. I couldn't taste anything at all. Just the sensation of it going down my throat.

I had a strange thought, then. What were the people of the Reckoning eating right now. I knew the forty days hadn't even begun for them yet. They must be

eating dinner right now, not knowing whether I would come, or wouldn't. I let that thought go before it went further. I didn't want to picture that faceless hundred and twenty thousand again.

I finished the bread and opened my water flask. There was water enough all around me. I found that funny. I wasn't rationing the flask because I had no water to drink — I was rationing it because I had no way of knowing whether this water around me was safe to drink.

When the flask was down to half, I sealed it again. I had to save it. I didn't know how many days this would take.

It was then I began, for the first time, to calculate. Half a flask left. Five loaves of bread remaining. How much to use per day, to hold out how many days. I realized, then, that this calculation calmed me. Numbers were the one thing that answered me, in that dark. Ask, and there was always, without fail, one answer.

. . .

I only learned there was such a thing as a sense of direction after I lost it.

Above ground, you just know where you are — by the sun's position, the wind's direction, the shape of a familiar building. Down here there was none of that. Every wall looked the same. The water ran every direction at once. I couldn't even tell whether I was getting closer to the Reckoning or farther away.

I thought, that day, that this was frightening. I think differently now. I hadn't lost my direction. I had never had one to begin with. I entered this dark with no plan for where to go once I'd avoided the Reckoning — only the thought that I would go somewhere that wasn't the Reckoning. For someone with no

direction, losing a sense of direction is only pretending to lose something that was never there.

Another fork came up. This time I picked left, with no certainty either way, flipping a coin in my head.

I've gone back over that choice many times since. I wrote that there was no reason for picking left. Was that really true? Thinking about it now, I think I noticed, without quite realizing it, that the water sounded a little louder on the left. That a stronger current would lead somewhere bigger, I must have guessed, somewhere in myself. If so, it wasn't a choice with no reason at all. I was calculating even then. Only not clearly enough to call it calculation.

An hour, maybe, or two. Time had already lost its meaning. I felt my legs give out. Walking through water was many times harder than walking on land. The water gripped my legs and wouldn't let go.

Once my foot slipped and I went in to the knee. My bag nearly got soaked. I just barely caught it and hauled it up.

In that moment I made a sound for the first time. Not a scream. Just a sharp intake of breath. Hearing it bounce off every wall and come back, I felt, strangely, reassured. At least I'd confirmed this dark wasn't entirely empty. My own sound, at least, came back.

. . .

The water kept getting deeper.

From ankle to shin, from shin toward knee. I lifted the bag above my head. The wax envelope couldn't get wet. Whatever was inside it, it still had to be mine.

Writing this sentence, I ask myself. Why hold onto it so carefully. It would have been so much easier just to let it go in the water. I think I believed, then, that protecting that document meant protecting my own rightness. As long as I held it, I wasn't a fugitive — only "holding" it. I told myself that lie.

The fingertips resting on the wall began to ache with cold. I didn't know yet that long enough in water does that to you. My body was cooling, and I only registered it as cold.

. . .

Ahead, the sound of the water changed.

Different from anything I'd heard so far. Louder, and more regular. Like something large blocking the water.

I slowed my steps.

Very faint light began to show. Not total darkness — something leaking in from somewhere up ahead. I walked toward it.

Seeing that light, I felt relieved. Looking back now, I laugh at how simple that was. Light didn't mean safe. I didn't know that yet.

The tunnel widened. The ceiling rose, and instead of walls, thick stone pillars stood at intervals. Something like a way station. The current split here and ran in several directions. Somewhere above, a small crack let in a thread of faint light.

I stood beneath that light for a moment. Looked up. The crack was no wider than a finger. And yet the light coming through that narrow crack felt brighter than any darkness I'd walked through so far. My eyes stung.

I stood looking up at that shaft of light for a long time. Who might be passing above it, right now. Does whoever's standing on the ground just above that crack know there's a road like this beneath their feet. I let time pass on thoughts like that. It had been a while since I'd had anything to do besides walk.

And at the end of that station, a large iron structure stood blocking the waterway.

A sluice gate. I didn't know, then, that's what it was called. I just thought of it as a large door of some kind. It stood open. Water flowed freely beneath it. Higher up on the door was an iron wheel with a handle. I could only guess, then, what it opened and closed.

I stood in front of it and caught my breath. A little farther and I thought I'd reach another city. Which city, I didn't know. I didn't want to know. Anywhere but the Reckoning would do.

I felt something like relief, in that moment, for the first time. A mistaken relief. I had no idea how far I'd already come, what time it was, or by what schedule that gate operated. I was only reassured because I'd seen light. People are reassured that easily.

Somewhere, a very low mechanical hum sounded. Distant, regular. I didn't know what it was. It was nearly lost in the sound of the water.

I know now. That was some device, somewhere, running the whole of this conduit. At the time I just took it for part of the water's noise and let it pass. There are things in this world that keep running, always, without anyone paying them any mind. That day, I was standing right in front of one of them.

I moved to where the water ran shallower and passed beneath the sluice gate.

Past the gate, the tunnel narrowed again. The station's light fell away behind me, and ahead was dark once more. I stepped into that dark again. This time it frightened me a little less. My body seemed to have grown a little used to the dark.

That familiarity was an illusion — I would learn that only a few steps further. The dark isn't something you get used to. I only wanted to believe I had.

A few steps on, I turned to look back. The light from where the gate stood was still visible. Very small now.

I turned my back on that light and walked forward again. My legs were heavy. I adjusted my bag on my shoulder, put a hand to the wall. At the next fork, I'd pick a side again, with no reason for it. I wasn't afraid of that. I still didn't know, then, exactly what I ought to have been afraid of.

Writing this chapter, I keep coming back to the same sentence. I didn't know, then. I didn't know, then. When this book is finished, I want to count how many times I've written that sentence. I imagine it will be too many to count. Knowing something, and having known it for a long time, are different things. I already knew a great deal, in that dark. I just wasn't ready yet to call it knowing.

(Continued in Chapter 8.)

Chapter 8. The Gate Closes

> *_Previously_ — Pheugon walked for hours through the dark conduit, with no*
> *way to gauge direction or time. Once he sensed someone's presence but*
> *could never confirm it. He passed the first sluice gate, standing open,*
> *and felt a brief relief. He didn't know yet that the relief was misplaced.*

I met the second sluice gate a long while after that.

By then I was tired enough to have forgotten the difference between walking and standing still. My legs didn't feel like my own. I'd lost count of how many hours I'd dragged my feet through that water. I'd stopped counting long before.

I still remember that exhaustion in my body. Not a muscle ache — an ache in the bone. A kind of tired that four hours of daily reading at the training hall had never taught me.

At the training hall, the hard part was my throat. Here it was my legs, my back, my fingertips. I learned that day, for the first time, that a whole body can grow tired — not any one part of it, but the fact of having a body at all.

The current kept pushing at my calves. My body got no rest even standing still. I had to keep bracing against that current just to stay upright.

. . .

This gate was different from the first.

Shut. Completely.

An enormous steel plate blocked the tunnel. Floor to ceiling, wall to wall. Barely a gap. Water only slipped through a small crack at the bottom.

I stood in front of it and felt it with my hand. Cold, slick. The same iron wheel as the first gate's was mounted here too. I tried to turn it. It didn't move.

I threw everything I had into turning it, that time. It didn't budge. Looking back, of course it didn't. That wheel wasn't built to be turned by hand. I didn't know that yet, and because I didn't know it, I kept trying. Trying something you know can't be done, and trying something without knowing it can't, are two different things. I was the latter.

I pushed at the wheel with both hands, then with my shoulder. Again and again. The inside of my palms scraped raw. The wheel didn't so much as tremble. It sat there like part of the wall itself, as if it had never been a thing meant to turn at all.

Far off, I heard that same low mechanical hum again. This time it felt a little closer. Regular, and indifferent.

Hearing that sound, a strange certainty settled in me. Whatever was making that sound had no idea I existed. I thought about calling out toward it, and decided not to. No one shouts at a machine. I already knew, by instinct, that it would be useless.

. . .

I tried shouting.

"…Hello!"

My voice went out and came back. Bounced back and forth so many times that by the end it barely sounded like my voice at all. No one answered.

I called again. Louder this time. Until my throat felt like it was tearing.

Only my own voice came back.

I thought of the training hall then, for the first time. The room where my own voice returned to me. The supervisor said it was so I could grow used to it. Used to it. That out there, no one answers. I had only ever taken that as training for reading. That it was also how to live — I learned that for the first time, in front of this gate.

It wasn't only true for reading. There are moments in living, too, when no one answers. The supervisor probably never meant to teach that far. But the training ended up carrying me here, all the same.

I sank down where I stood.

I thought of turning back. Retracing my steps, I thought I could find my way to the first station. But in that moment I realized. I didn't remember how many forks I'd passed.

That was the quietest moment in this whole chapter. No screaming, no tears. Just, quietly, the fact settling into place — that I didn't know the way back. Some fears make no sound. They just take their seat as fact.

I retraced my steps a little. Twenty paces, and another fork appeared. I couldn't tell whether it was the same fork I'd passed before. Every fork looked exactly alike.

I came back to the gate.

The station — I'd decided to call that wide space that. From there, at least three paths branched off. I couldn't be certain of any of them. Retracing my steps might carry me deeper in, not out.

In that moment I made a strange decision. To stop moving at all. Better to stay in one place and wait for the door to open than to wander further astray by choosing wrong. I still don't know if that decision was right. But making it, strangely, I felt easier. Having nothing left to choose was, somehow, a relief.

I settled into the shallow water right in front of the gate. Back against the wall, knees drawn up, and sat.

The light leaking from the crack above seemed to dim a little at a time. It might have been my imagination. But watching that change, I felt for the first time that time was still passing, even in this dark. I simply had no way to measure it.

I stared at that light for a long time. Whether the sun was setting, or something else had drifted across that gap, I couldn't tell. But watching it grow fainter, I felt real fear for the first time. Not losing my way. Not the gate being shut. It was that time was flowing on, leaving me behind. That was the most frightening thing.

. . .

I stop, every time I write this part. From here I want to make excuses. That this was an accident, that I didn't know, that I'd never have come if I'd known when this gate closed. All of it is true. But being true doesn't make it an excuse.

I wondered, at the time, why this gate was shut. I didn't think anyone had closed it to stop me. There was no reason to think that. No one knew I was there. I just thought I'd had bad luck.

I was wrong. It wasn't bad luck. This was simply the schedule.

. . .

A plate was fixed to the gate. Letters engraved into metal. I read it by the faint light off the wall.

Scheduled Closure. Alternating Duty Section.

Below that, in smaller letters, a few numbers. I guessed they must indicate times. What time it closed, what time it opened. But not knowing what time it was now made those numbers useless to me.

I ran my hand over that plate again and again, as if doing so might change the numbers. In that moment I understood, for the first time. This door hadn't shut to punish me. This door simply closed at this hour, always. I had only, unluckily, happened to be right here at that hour.

For a long time I couldn't tell punishment from accident apart. Punishment is something someone hands down after seeing you. An accident happens without anyone seeing you at all. I'd thought the two were the same, in outcome — either way, I was trapped in the water. I know now. They're different, from the inside. Someone being punished at least knows why they're there. Someone in an accident doesn't even have that. I learned, in front of that gate, that there's something harder to bear than punishment.

I later learned the details of how this sluice worked, from someone else. Every city joined by this waterway, including the Reckoning, shares the same schedule. While one section is open, another must always be closed. Otherwise one city floods and another runs dry. So this gate opens and shuts several times a day. Someone like me getting caught in that gap couldn't have been the first time. I'd simply had one of the ordinary things happen to me.

That fact made me feel smaller still. I'd wanted, somewhere, to believe I'd been singled out by especially bad luck. That would at least have made this whole thing into a story that made sense. But it wasn't. I was just an ordinary case. The world hadn't recognized and imprisoned me — it hadn't recognized me at all, and had simply gone on running as usual. And I happened to be inside that usual.

I thought of the Reckoning's sentence. A hundred and twenty thousand people. Maybe that city was going through something similar, I thought, for the first time. The Scales hadn't measured that city's weight because it hated it. It simply measures. Cross the limit, a disposition follows. That too is scheduled operation. In that moment I felt, faintly, that being trapped in this gate and the sentence handed down to that city were the same kind of thing. Neither had happened because anyone hated anyone. That thought gave me no comfort at all.

These cities' waterways run on an exact schedule. Some sections open, some close, so the water never overflows, and each city gets exactly what it needs. That schedule had no place in it for something like me. No reason it should. While the Scales was weighing a hundred and twenty thousand lives, this gate weighed nothing at all and simply closed on its own time. It was the first rule I'd met, in this world, that had no idea who I was.

. . .

I stared at that plate for a long while.

A strange thought came to me. My whole life, I'd always been inside some rule or another. The Scales's rules. Herald training's rules. The supervisor's rules. Every one of them had seen me. They weighed my weight, they judged my voice, they wrote my name on a list.

This gate did not see me.

And that was more frightening still. Up to then, I'd always believed punishment was more frightening than being ignored. I learned that day. Being ignored is more frightening. Punishment at least knows who you are, before it falls. This door didn't know who I was. Had no need to.

Water kept flowing past my ankles, ceaselessly, through that narrow gap. That sound of water was the only regular thing left in this place.

I listened to it and thought of the Scales. The Scales sees everything. It weighs one lie, one stolen loaf of bread, down to the last exact figure. This waterway had no such eye. No one was weighing me here. No one was recording that I existed here at all.

I felt a strange relief and a strange terror, both at once, in that moment. The relief was this — nothing here was being added to my weight. The terror was this — nothing here was on my side, either. When the Scales was weighing me, I at least knew someone was counting my existence. In front of this door, I didn't even have that.

. . .

I leaned my back against the wall. My legs had no strength left in them at all.

I set my bag on my knees. The wax envelope wasn't wet yet. I checked, and put it back in the bag.

Even in that moment, I was worried about that document. Laughable, thinking about it now. Sitting in a place where I might drown, I was checking whether a piece of paper that held a city's fate had gotten wet or not. The human mind, even before the largest things, reaches first for the smallest.

I checked the flask. Half full. Five loaves of bread remained.

I began counting numbers again, then, for the first time. I wrote in the last chapter that I'd stopped. That wasn't true. I hadn't stopped — I'd only paused. The moment I sat down in front of that gate, I went back to being someone who counted. There was truly nothing else left for me to do, by then.

How much water was there. How many days would the bread last. When would this gate open again. How many days left until proclamation day.

I set those questions up in order and began filling in the answers, one by one.

The first question had an answer. Half a flask. The second had one too. Five loaves of bread, one a day — five days. The third question had no answer. I had no way to read the numbers stamped on that metal plate. The fourth had no exact answer either. I didn't even know how long I'd been walking.

It was then I noticed, for the first time, that I was setting unanswerable questions beside answerable ones. I solved the ones with answers first. The flask, the bread. Those were easy. I left the unanswerable ones standing as questions. When does this gate open. How many days are left until proclamation day. I didn't throw those questions away. I just set them aside. Like someone who believes an answer will come, eventually.

My body shook. I'd been in the water too long. I pulled myself further up, out of the water, toward the wall. The stone floor was damp too, but better than the water.

That night — though I didn't even know if it was night — I tried to sleep. I closed my eyes. The sound of water filled my ears entirely. I drifted in and out. I don't know how many times. That night I learned, for the first time, that some things can't even be counted.

Once, waking, I forgot for a moment where I was. I thought I was in my own bed and started to turn over, before the touch of the stone floor startled me

fully awake. Those few seconds of mistake hurt worse than anything else that had happened that day.

It was a brief moment, but I remember it. Those few seconds of mistaking this for home. That became, for a long time after, the most vivid moment of everything I went through. A person knows exactly where they are, most precisely, in the instant their most comfortable illusion breaks.

I closed my eyes again. The sound of water hadn't changed. That something, at least, stayed constant felt, strangely, like a comfort, in that moment.

(Continued in Chapter 9.)

Chapter 9. The First Day

> *_Previously_ — The second sluice gate was shut. Not an accident — a*
> *scheduled closure. This world had not closed the gate to punish Pheugon;*
> *it had simply gone on running as usual, and he happened to be inside*
> *that usual. In the dark where no one answered, he held out the night by*
> *counting his water and his bread.*

I don't know exactly when the light disappeared completely.

The faint light that had leaked through the crack above me vanished while I drifted in and out of sleep. I waited for it to come back. It didn't.

That was the first time I knew a day had passed. Not something I saw. Something I felt. If the light went out once and didn't come back, that meant night had come. That was how I counted the first day.

The dark split into complete dark and slightly-less-complete dark. I felt the difference between them with my skin, not my eyes. When there had been light, the air had felt somehow different too. Probably my imagination. But even an illusion was something to hold onto.

I kept opening and closing my eyes, knowing it made no difference whether they were open or shut. My body wanted some familiar motion to perform.

. . .

The water rose to my knees.

At first it had been my ankles. Waking from sleep, it was my knees. I didn't know when. I couldn't tell whether the water itself had risen, or whether I'd simply kept sliding toward the lower ground.

Seeing that water, I felt real fear for the first time. What I'd felt before had come from not knowing which way was which. This was different. Water rising meant that as time passed, my position kept getting worse. I learned, then, that things can get worse even while you sit perfectly still.

I didn't know why the water was rising. Some other gate might have opened somewhere else, sending the current this way. Or this stretch might simply run on a cycle like that. I had no way to find out. All I had was the fact — the water was rising.

Watching it, I thought again of that low mechanical hum. Something, somewhere, running the whole of this waterway, going on perfectly fine right at this very moment. To that device, this was just another day's routine. Send water this way, close that gate. I was an accident caught by chance in one corner of that routine. The water rising wasn't meant to threaten me. It was only flowing toward where it had to flow.

I got to my feet. My legs shook. I felt my way along the wall to somewhere a little higher — a small ledge at the edge of the station. The water there only reached my instep.

That ledge wasn't wide. Two steps and it ended. I crouched in that narrow space and looked up. The crack the light had leaked through was still dark.

On a chance, I tried to reach that crack. If I climbed the stone pillar, my hand might reach. I gripped the pillar and hauled myself up. My foot slipped. Twice, three times. The last time my knee scraped the stone and drew blood.

I only stopped trying once I felt that blood with my hand. Only then did pain seem to properly return to me at all. Before that, my body hadn't had the room to feel its own hurt as hurt. Strangely, the blood from my knee calmed me, in that moment. It felt like one certain thing had appeared. At least the pain wasn't lying.

. . .

I was hungry. I took out the bread.

In that moment I began calculating for the first time. To be precise, I was picking up the calculation I'd started the day before, sitting in front of the gate. From here, it was real calculation. Not a rough count — a calculation to survive.

Five loaves of bread. I'd already eaten one, so four remained. I tore off half of one and ate it, and tied the rest back up.

I decided, then, to eat half a loaf a day. That would hold out eight days. The flask was half full. There was water all around, but I didn't know if it was safe to drink. I had to ration it. A few mouthfuls a day, only.

Doing this calculation, I felt, strangely, calmed. Numbers hadn't abandoned me. Everything else in that dark had abandoned me. Only numbers still answered, when I asked.

Chewing the bread, I thought of home. Of the table, to be precise. The one with four seats where now only one gets used. I tried to remember what our last dinner there had been. I couldn't.

A strange thing. I was someone who remembered everything countable. A hundred and twelve cases, a hundred and eleven erased words. And yet I couldn't remember what our last dinner had been. I learned that day, for the

first time, how easily the things you don't count simply vanish. I'd spent far too long, living, hanging onto only what could be counted.

. . .

I drew a line on the wall with my fingernail.

That was the only way I had to count days. Scratching a mark into the stone with a fingertip. One line. Meaning today was the first day.

I wasn't even confident about exactly which day it was. Counting from the night I left home, this might already have been the second or third day. I decided to start counting again from the moment I got trapped in front of this gate. That was the number that mattered to me now.

Beside that line I began another calculation.

Days left until proclamation day. By the supervisor's schedule, I should be somewhere in the middle of the road to the Reckoning by now. Two days' travel, a day's rest on arrival, then the proclamation. By the original plan, I should have been standing in that city's square in three days.

Doing that calculation, I felt a strange emotion. Relief. I hoped those three days would pass — that the city would cross its proclamation day without me. What happened when a herald didn't show, I didn't know exactly. But I knew something would be delayed. That delay felt, to me, like success.

Reading this sentence now, I look strangely at who I was then. Even in that moment of terror, I hadn't stopped calculating. Trapped in the water, I was still checking whether time was flowing in the direction I wanted. Too precise a thing for someone that frightened to be doing.

. . .

When would this gate open.

I felt again at the numbers carved into the metal plate. I could feel the depth of the grooves with my fingertips, but not what number they made. I stood a long while in front of that plate.

I felt, for the first time, a desperate need to know something. Until then I hadn't been someone who fretted much over what I didn't know. Training had made me that way. Ask, if you don't know. If no one told you, let it go. But this number, I couldn't let go. This was a number my life depended on.

I struck the plate. No response. Of course not. This wasn't a thing you could speak to.

I thought of the Scales again, in that moment. The one they say exists in the Reckoning. It doesn't speak, but it at least shows a number. Put a hand up, and something answers. This gate didn't even offer that much. I realized, for the first time in my life, that I had never before stood this long in front of something that gave no answer at all. Someone raised in the world of the Scales takes it for granted that asking always gets some kind of response. I learned, in front of that door, just how thin that assumption had always been.

Once, amid the water's noise, I thought I heard something like a human voice. I held my breath and listened. Nothing was there. Just water striking stone, sounding that way by coincidence.

I had that same illusion several times after. Sometimes it seemed like someone calling my name in the water's noise; sometimes like someone murmuring something close to a sentence. I learned later that this wasn't rare at all. A person can bear a place with no sound at all better than a place with constant, irregular sound — because in the second kind of place, the mind

starts trying to find words inside it. The ears can't stand being bored. I didn't know that then. I was just afraid.

. . .

Having no way at all to gauge how much time had passed was the hardest thing to bear.

At the training hall, a bell rang. At home, the sun crossed the window. Here, there was nothing. I tried measuring time by how many times I opened and closed my eyes. I soon learned how inaccurate that was. Sometimes I opened my eyes after a single breath's worth of closing them; sometimes after sleeping a long while. And there was no way to tell the two apart.

I experienced, then, for the first time, calculation itself breaking down. The flask and the bread could be counted in numbers. Time couldn't. I found that difference hard to bear. When something countable and something uncountable sit in the same place, the uncountable swallows everything else.

So instead I decided to count paces. Walking back and forth across the station. Twelve steps, wall to wall. I decided that about a hundred round trips meant, roughly, some fixed amount of time had passed. There was no basis for that. I just needed something to count.

One round trip, two, three. I counted the numbers silently, not aloud. I had no strength left to make a sound yet, and no reason to. I was saving my voice, then. Without even knowing why.

I still don't know what those numbers meant. But while I walked and counted like that, I could forget, for a little while, that the water was rising, that the gate wouldn't open. Counting was that, for me. Even when it gave no answer, it still let me endure.

After a long while of walking back and forth, I stopped. Out of breath. Walking in water took far more strength than I'd thought. I sat back down on the ledge and caught my breath.

In that moment I noticed something strange. I was counting my steps, and at the same time, counting something else. The days left until the Reckoning. The forty days that city's people didn't even know had started yet. I was turning those two numbers over side by side in my head. The speed at which my own life was running down, and the speed at which that city's remaining time was running down. Strangely, it comforted me that the two were shrinking in the same direction. Every hour I held out here meant that, over there, the possibility was shrinking too.

My hand shakes, writing this sentence. I truly thought that way, then. I set my own dying time and one city's dying chance on the same scale, and found comfort in it. How terrible a calculation that was, I would only learn much later.

. . .

My body shook. From too long in the water.

I wrung out my wet clothes as best I could. It did nothing. Water was everywhere. There was nowhere to dry.

That night — though I didn't even know which night it was — listening to my teeth chatter, I thought: I could die like this. Strangely, the thought didn't frighten me. I think I already knew, then, that there was something I feared more than death. That the Reckoning would survive. That frightened me more.

I hugged my knees. The wound on my knee throbbed. My clothes were still wet, showing no sign of drying. I curled myself as small as I could. It was the only way I had left to keep any warmth.

I was hungry. I wanted more bread. I held back. I'd already eaten today's share. I kept that rule for myself, exactly. Half a loaf a day. Yesterday, and today too. I checked how much bread was left with my fingertips, again and again. What was left after taking one from four, then half again from that. The number was exact. That exactness was, in that moment, almost my only comfort.

I felt a strange pride, then. That I'd kept the rule even while hungry. It sounds absurd, I know. But that was the one rule left, in that moment, that I could still keep. Everything else had slipped out of my hands — the height of the water, when the gate would open, where exactly I was. In that helplessness, there was exactly one thing I could still decide for myself. How many pieces of bread to eat. I held onto that one thing.

Rereading this sentence now, it makes my skin crawl. In that moment I was setting my own life and one city's fate on the same scale. And without any hesitation, I thought the city's side had to weigh more — no, had to be made to weigh more. What that meant, I didn't know, then.

. . .

I thought of the supervisor.

By now the supervisor probably believed I was somewhere on the road to the Reckoning. Or perhaps he'd already begun to sense something was wrong. A herald doesn't stray far from the set schedule. Running a day late might happen. Going entirely out of contact doesn't.

I pictured the supervisor's face, then. The cool room, the roster on the wall, the number 112 beside my name. I wondered if he might be looking at that number again right now. That thought hurt me, strangely, in that moment. I didn't think I'd betrayed the supervisor. I only felt sorry that if he was worried about me, that worry, right now, in this moment, could do nothing at all.

I didn't hold onto that regret for long. Holding it felt like it would throw off my calculations. I went back to the line on the wall, to the numbers of water and bread. That was the safer place to be.

I traced the first line I'd scratched on the wall again with my fingertip. One. A beginning.

(Continued in Chapter 10.)

Chapter 10. The Second Day

> *_Previously_ — On the first day trapped, the water rose to Pheugon's*
> *knees. He held out by rationing bread and water, counting steps in place*
> *of time he had no way to measure. In that calculation, he found a strange*
> *comfort in treating his own dwindling time and the Reckoning's dwindling*
> *days as the same thing — all while, for no reason he understood, saving*
> *his own voice.*

I scratched a second line onto the wall.

The water seemed to have risen a little higher than yesterday. I couldn't be certain. The bread was down to three and a half loaves. The flask was a third full. I confirmed those numbers and leaned back against the wall.

On the second day, I made a sound for the first time.

To be precise, I spoke. Not a groan, not a cough — a sentence. With no one there.

This is the chapter hardest for me to write. To explain that moment exactly, I have to start by saying why I began with that particular sentence, of all sentences.

I've rewritten this chapter more times than any other in this book. What I wrote first was far shorter. I didn't want to write this night in detail, at the time. Not out of shame. It was hard to hear that voice again. But I came to understand that without this part, nothing else in this book makes sense. So I wrote it again.

. . .

I was hungry. Hungrier than yesterday. My body wanted something bread couldn't fill.

I sat with my back to the wall and opened my mouth. I didn't know why I opened it, at the time. I know now. I wanted to hear a sound. Not water. A human voice.

The only voice I could make, in this world, was one. My own. I realized that, then, for the first time.

Sitting against the wall, I opened my mouth. No sound came. My throat had been shut too long. I cleared it a few times. The sound rang strange. Like someone else's cough.

At the training hall, the supervisor taught us to treat the voice as part of the body. That it stiffens if it isn't used every day. I'd forgotten that. Barely a day and a half without using it, and my throat had already become a stranger to me.

I drank a little water. More than I'd rationed. My throat needed loosening. In that moment, that mattered more than saving the flask.

It was the first time I broke a rule I'd set for myself. A small thing, in itself. And yet I remember breaking it, still, clearly. The one rule I'd believed I could

keep, I broke myself, just to make a sound. The wish to speak was greater than the wish to keep the rule.

The first thing to come from my mouth was the sentence.

. . .

"…The Reckoning."

I said those two words and stopped. My throat was raw. Unused to making sound.

I swallowed and began again.

"…Given that the accumulated weight of this city's acts has been confirmed to exceed the limit."

A trained sentence. The way of speaking bred into my body from a hundred and twelve readings. I hadn't even known I had it memorized. It came out of my mouth on its own.

I've wondered a long time why that was the sentence I started with, of all sentences. The answer was simple. It was the one sentence I owned completely, word for word. A person with nothing else reaches for the most familiar thing first. The most familiar thing I had was a sentence document.

. . .

I kept reading. The entire Reckoning sentence. I made several mistakes. Reversed the order, corrected myself, repeated one line twice.

If this had been the training hall, the supervisor would have made me start again. Here, no one made me start again. I kept going, wrong as I was. The first time. Reading on, uncorrected.

City name, accumulated weight, basis of calculation, grace period, method of execution. I read those sentences again, in the dark, once more. I said the numbers too, as best I remembered. A hundred and twenty thousand people. Accumulated weight past the limit. Saying those numbers, I felt, for one brief moment, that they weren't numbers but people. It faded again quickly.

This time it carried no effect. The rule that reading it aloud gives it effect — that was only true in its set place, its set procedure. Here, however loudly I read, it was only sound.

I found that fact, strangely, comforting, in that moment. Whatever I did here, nothing would happen to the Reckoning. I could play with that sentence freely, with an easy mind.

. . .

The last line came.

"…Article 4, Clause 11."

I said that line slowly, letter by letter.

"…Should this city, within forty days, be confirmed to have turned, this sentence shall be void."

Having said it, I went quiet a long while. Only the water's sound filled that silence.

That was the first time I'd ever spoken that sentence aloud. Reading it on paper and speaking it with my mouth were different. Paper, your eyes can pass over. Your mouth carries the sentence through your body. I felt, the moment that sentence crossed my throat, for the first time, exactly how heavy it was.

. . .

I said the sentence again. And again.

The first time, it was only a sentence. The second time, something caught in my throat. By the third, it had begun to change.

"…Within forty days… if I turned."

I didn't know what I was saying. My mouth moved before I did.

"…I won't turn."

I remember exactly the moment I said that sentence. In the dark, my legs sunk in water, listening to my own voice come back to me. I didn't even know, then, who I was speaking to. The Scales? That city? Or just the wall?

After a brief silence, I spoke again.

"…I won't turn. I have nothing to turn from."

Having said that, I laughed. No sound, just my throat moving.

I couldn't explain, at the time, why I'd laughed. I can explain it a little, now. In that moment I realized, for the first time, that I wasn't speaking toward the Scales, but toward the clause. That clause had been made to confirm whether a city had turned. I wasn't a city. And yet I kept answering as if the clause

were asking me the question too. That I wouldn't turn. Why I answered that way, I still don't fully know, even now.

. . .

"…I was right."

I said that. For the first time, clearly.

"…I have the right to hate that city. My brother left. My mother went. My father lives alone. That was the accurate weight. The Scales measured it that way."

My voice grew louder. So as not to be drowned out by the water.

"…So why does only that city get a door. A door that never came for my house."

I stopped a moment after that, then went on.

"…My father's weight was accurate. The Scales measured it precisely. No one shaved any of it off. I was taught that's how it should be. But the Reckoning. That city has had its door standing open from the very start. Whatever a hundred and twenty thousand people did, if they only turn within forty days, all of it just — never happened."

My voice cracked. I kept going.

"…Is that fair. Is that what the Scales does?"

Only the water answered.

I didn't cry, saying that. Strange, thinking about it now. It was a thing I'd held back so long, and still, in the dark, I held back the tears. Even with no one

watching. I know where I learned that habit. The night my brother left home, I taught myself, that night, for the first time, how not to cry aloud. What I learned that night had followed me all the way into this dark.

. . .

Once the words broke loose, they didn't stop.

I talked about herald training. About Had. About the merchant. A hundred and twelve cases, the erased words. I said all of it to the water, to the wall, to the dark.

I drew my knees up and rested my chin on them. My voice grew a little softer.

"…The night my brother left, he turned back once, at the door." I said. "I couldn't tell if he was looking at me or just checking his direction. I didn't say anything, then. I still don't know, even now, what I should have said to him that night."

I paused a moment, then went on.

"…My mother cried in the kitchen twice. The second time was worse. I never knocked on the door."

Copying these sentences out again, my hand slows down. I realize, all over again, that I had never told anyone these things before that night. Most of what I set down in Chapter 5 was, in truth, first spoken aloud in this dark. I only wrote it onto paper later. This waterway is where it first became words.

I talked about my father too.

"…My father said 'it's fine,' once, at the terminal of the Scales. He wasn't saying it to me. I knew that, at the time. I didn't say anything."

The more I spoke, the stranger it felt, how much easier my voice became. Strange, that easing came with pain. I doubted that ease even as I kept speaking. Even while I doubted it, my mouth didn't stop.

I know the reason now. Those words had been pooling inside my body for three years. Water that pools goes stagnant. That night, for the first time, I let it flow out. Not to the right person, not in the right place. I only let it flow to a place I could let it flow. Even so, it was better than letting it stagnate.

"…I've done nothing wrong."

I said that.

"…I don't lie, I don't touch other people's things, I don't get angry. My weight is the lowest there is."

Having said it, I went quiet.

The water's sound rose loud again. The moment my voice stopped, the water filled that space back in. I found that strange. The world flowed on the same, whether I spoke or not. And still I wanted to go on speaking.

Right after I said that sentence, I felt a strange unease. I know now what it was. In that moment I remembered, for the first time, the lie I'd told. "No, sir," when the supervisor asked whether I had some connection to the Reckoning. The lie to the gatekeeper. I knew the Scales had calculated both those lies. Precisely. I could no longer be certain, any longer, that my weight really was the lowest.

I spoke again, trying to shake off that unease.

"…And still, I'm right."

Once more.

"…I'm right."

Trying to say it a third time, no voice came. Not because my throat had given out. I felt, in that moment, that I myself no longer believed the words. The third sentence simply scattered, inside my mouth.

I still haven't finished that scattered sentence. What was meant to come after "I'm right" — I went on searching for it for a long time after. I didn't find it that night. I couldn't say, even now, that I've found it completely.

I found a different sentence instead. Much later, after I'd come to this city. I won't write what that sentence was, here. I haven't reached that place yet.

. . .

I kept talking, on into that night, without stopping.

The sentences grew shorter. Eventually only words were left. "…Heavy." "…Turn." "…Why."

I remember every one of those words, even now. Everything that came out that night was something I was saying for the first time. Words I'd never said to anyone. I pulled them out, for the first time, into a dark with no one there. That it was a strange kind of first confession, I didn't know, at the time.

I kept talking until my throat gave out entirely and no more sound would come. After that, only my mouth moved. Without sound.

The water kept on the same as before. Nothing answered.

I asked, a long while after. My voice was barely more than a whisper.

"…Are you listening?"

Of course no one answered. And yet, asking that, I couldn't shake the strange feeling that I was asking it toward someone. Not the Scales. The Scales wasn't something you asked that of. So who, then? I didn't know, at the time. I still don't know exactly, even now.

I would go on to ask that question again, in other places throughout this book. Writing this chapter, I realize freshly that it was the first question that ever rose out of this dark. A question with no answer. But that it had no answer doesn't mean it was asked for nothing — I would only learn that much later.

My body gave out and I leaned against the wall and closed my eyes. My voice used up entirely, my body felt strangely light. As if something had been emptied out of it. I was still hungry. But that hunger was a little more bearable than before.

And that night, for the first time, I felt the strange sense that I wasn't entirely alone. Not that someone was there. I mean that, for the first time, I heard my own words. In three years. Until then I had only avoided, erased, and swallowed my own words. That night, for the first time, I let them out, into the open, and heard them come back to me from outside. That is different from someone hearing them for you. And still, it was not nothing at all.

Even now, thinking of that night, I can't tell whether it was prayer or just rambling. Maybe there's no need to tell them apart. I had only, for the first time in three years, used my own voice as my own. Not a sentence I'd been told to read — a sentence I had made myself.

(Continued in Chapter 11.)

Chapter 11. The Third Day

> *_Previously_ — On the second day, Pheugon spoke aloud for the first time.*
> *Reciting the sentence document from memory, the words turned into his own*
> *story. What began as "I was right" ended in "So why am I here." He*
> *released that question into the water and lost consciousness. What he*
> *remembers next is the sensation of his body moving. He was not the one*
> *moving it.*

On the third day, the water stopped rising.

My legs knew it first. It had stayed at my knees for days now, unchanged. I couldn't tell whether that was good news or bad.

Bad news. I know that now. The water no longer rising meant this stretch was designed to balance out at exactly that level. No one had drained the water to save me. It was simply water flowing the way it always flowed.

My body had been submerged too long; the feeling in my legs had gone dull. I pinched my calf now and then. It hurt, but the hurt seemed to arrive from far away.

The air hung heavy and damp. Every breath filled the inside of my nose with the smell of stone. Nothing but that smell. No sound, no light, no other scent.

I didn't know, then, that my body was slowly leaving me. I only thought I was tired. What happens to a body that holds out three days in water — that was the first time I was learning it, myself.

. . .

Two loaves of bread remained. The flask was nearly empty. I scratched a third line on the wall.

I felt my own hand slow down, drawing that line. No strength left. Even scratching the stone with my fingertip had become work.

I sat back against the wall. Something felt wrong with my body. I shook without being cold. I was hungry, and yet the thought of bread didn't come.

My head felt heavy. My neck, leaned against the wall, kept lolling to one side. I shook it a few times, trying to right it.

Once, opening my eyes, my vision blurred. I'm not even sure what "blurred" means, in a place with no light. But that's what it was. As if a thin film had grown over the inside of my eyelids.

I only learned later that this was a frightening sign. At the time I just thought I was tired. I kept blinking. It didn't help.

I opened the flask and took a mouthful. I'd rationed that water carefully, days before, and now I barely registered how precious it was. My body seemed to be taking what it needed on its own. My mind couldn't keep pace with the calculation.

Writing this sentence, I realize freshly that by then, the person I'd been was already beginning to let go of the calculation. I wrote, earlier in this book, several times, that calculating was what let me hold out. But from the third

night on, even that calculation started to falter. The strength to calculate was leaving my body along with everything else.

Sometimes the water's sound seemed to fall into a different rhythm than before. Rising steadily, then swelling once, hard. I couldn't tell whether that was real or something my ears had invented.

. . .

I opened my mouth again.

The sentences didn't come as easily as they had on the second day. My throat was more ruined now. I managed only a few broken words, in a ragged voice.

"…I was right."

I began there again. The sentence I hadn't finished the night before.

"…I was right. That person came to our house, and our house came apart. The Scales measured it accurately. So I'm right."

Speaking it, I knew it was a repetition. I was saying, word for word, what I'd said the day before.

I know now why I repeated it. Because that sentence had never been finished. A person repeats an unfinished sentence, over and over. Until they find the end of it.

. . .

"…I was right."

I said it again. This time something new attached itself.

"…And yet here I am."

I said that sentence and stopped.

That moment was strange. I had believed there was no relationship at all between being right and being here, in this place. And yet the moment I said those two sentences side by side, I felt something come loose. Why would a person who's right be here. That question began, for the first time, to take shape.

I tried to push that dislocation away. My body shook once more.

"…No." I said aloud. "This is just an accident. I just came at a time the gate was closed. This has nothing to do with that."

I was trying, desperately, to keep two things apart, in that moment. That I was trapped in the water, and that I had run. I wanted to stop those two things becoming the same story. One was just bad luck, an accident. The other was something I had chosen. I believed that as long as I kept them apart, I could still remain the person who was right.

A person wants to draw a line between what they did and what happened to them. As long as the line holds, the responsibility splits in half too. I held onto that line, and it held me through that night. Not for long.

But I know now. The two really were related. If I hadn't run, I would never have been in this conduit to begin with. The accident happened on the road I had chosen. It wasn't a thing "accident" could fully cover.

. . .

I hugged my knees under the water. And spoke again.

"…I didn't run."

My voice cracked.

"…I just… wanted to see that city fall. Is that wrong? Our house fell apart. Isn't it wrong for that city, that one city, to go untouched?"

I said that and caught my breath.

"…I'm not a bad person."

Saying that, I heard something different in my own voice, for the first time. Not certainty. A plea. "I'm not a bad person" isn't something a person says when they already know they aren't. It's something said by someone who doubts.

I tried to erase that doubt by counting numbers again. A hundred and twelve cases. No misjudgments. My weight, the lowest in my cohort.

"…I read a hundred and twelve cases." I said. "Not one wrong. The Scales confirmed it."

I felt, in that moment, for the first time, that I was using numbers as a shield. Numbers had always calmed me, in that dark. This time was different. The more I spoke them, the more unsteady I felt. That the hundred and twelve had been right, and whether what I was trying to do here, now, was right — those were two different questions. I was trying to bury them both under the same number.

. . .

I stopped speaking for a long while.

I stop longest, writing this section. Rereading what came out of me here is still hard. And still, I won't cut it. Without this part, what happens afterward makes no sense. I resolved, at the start of this book, that I would rather not write it at all than write it without the parts that shame me. Facing this sentence, I confirm that resolve again.

My body swayed. Whether from sitting too long in the water or something else, I couldn't tell. I opened my mouth again.

I pictured my brother's face, then my mother's, then my father's, one by one, in order. Brother first, then mother, then father. Last I tried to picture my own face. Strangely, that was the blurriest of all.

"…Let my brother come back."

I didn't know where that came from. I hadn't meant to say anything like it.

"…Let my mother come back. Let my father… not live alone anymore."

I still don't know whether I can call this a prayer. I spoke it not knowing who I was speaking to. The Scales? The Scales wasn't a thing that listened to this kind of thing. And yet I spoke as if something were listening.

I fell quiet after that and listened. Not expecting an answer. Only out of habit — a feeling that speaking should be met with some kind of response.

The water's sound stayed the same. I wasn't disappointed by that. I hadn't believed, to begin with, that I had any right to expect an answer.

Looking back, that's strange. I was asking for help while believing, at the same time, that I had no right to receive it. I never thought that contradiction was strange, at the time. It felt, to me, entirely natural. A right person has no need to ask for help, and a person who needs help has already done something

wrong — that's what I'd been taught, growing up. Anyone raised in the world of the Scales thinks that way.

And still I asked. I went on asking even while believing I had no right to. That this was strange, too, I didn't notice, at the time. I just couldn't help asking. There was nothing else left that I could do.

. . .

"…But that city must not be allowed to turn."

I came back to that, again. I don't know how many times I'd already circled back to it.

"…There was never a door like that for my house. That city — only that city — mustn't be allowed a door."

Saying it, I noticed something strange. I was praying for two things at once. That my house would go back to how it had been. And that the Reckoning would never, ever be allowed to go back.

That those two wishes could come from the same mouth at the same time didn't strike me as strange, then. It does now. I wanted mercy for myself while trying, at the same time, to keep mercy from reaching someone else. How much of a contradiction that was, I couldn't see, that third night.

I kept speaking, carrying that contradiction.

"…If there's mercy." I said. "It should have come to my house first. Why did it go to that city first."

I stopped partway through. What I'd just said sounded strange to my own ear. I seemed to believe mercy came in a line, taking its turn — someone first,

someone after.

In that moment, for a very brief instant, I felt something was wrong. If mercy comes standing in a queue, then I was, right now, furious that someone else had taken my place in line. But does mercy really come that way? I couldn't answer that question. I didn't even have the strength, then, to ask it. I just pushed the feeling aside and picked anger back up. Anger, at least, gave me strength to hold on.

. . .

My body felt feverish. I touched my forehead. I couldn't tell, by hand, whether it was hot or cold.

I learned later. I was in a state of mild exhaustion, by then. Three days with barely any food, my body constantly submerged in cold water — of course I was. But in that moment, I couldn't tell whether it was my body or my mind that was the problem.

I closed my eyes and opened them again. The dark was the same. That closing my eyes and opening them made no difference at all felt, for the first time, genuinely frightening.

I couldn't name that fear. Whether what I'd just said was prayer or curse, I couldn't tell, then. I still don't know, exactly, even now. Maybe it was both.

Around then, a strange face rose in my mind. The face of the person who'd come from the Reckoning. Three years ago, at the edge of town, the face that had said to me, "You too. Be well." I didn't know why it came to me now.

I tried, then, to hate that person. In the dark, my body coming apart, I tried to aim anger at that face. It didn't work well. Strangely, that face wouldn't hold still as a target for anger. It was only a sad face. That fact bewildered me. I

had decided, long ago, to hate that person. And now, calling the face back up, my hatred just slipped out of my hands.

. . .

"…Why am I here."

I said that. Like talking to myself.

Having said it, I heard the sentence again, as it came back in my own voice.

I felt, in that moment, that the question carried two meanings at once. One was narrow. Why, of all places, was I trapped here, in this waterway, in front of this closed gate. That one had an answer. Because I'd entered during the closed hours. The other was wider. I was right — so why was I here, now, in this place. That one had no answer.

"…I was right." I said once more. My voice had grown small.

"…So why am I here."

Only the water answered.

That question followed me a long while after this. I still don't have a complete answer to it, even now. I only know this much. The moment I first put that question into words, out loud, I felt, faintly, for the first time in my life, that being right and being all right might not be the same thing at all.

I repeated the question a few more times. My voice grew smaller each time. By the end only my lips moved, hardly any sound left at all.

"…Why am I here."

"…Why am I here."

That sentence rose to the water's surface, and, unanswered, sank back down again.

I didn't count how many times I repeated it. Writing this book, this is the first time I don't regret not having counted. Some things stay whole only if they're never counted.

My body slowly tipped to one side. I didn't try to stop it. Still leaning on the wall, I ended up half-sitting, half-lying. The water reached nearly to my waist. I could barely feel the cold anymore.

I didn't speak again that night. Not because my throat had fully given out. Not because I had nothing left to say. I simply stayed still, having let the question flow out into the water. Where that question drifted, I didn't watch. I no longer had the strength to.

I can't tell whether I fell asleep or lost consciousness, there. The next thing I remember is the sensation of my body moving. I wasn't the one moving it.

I'll end this chapter here. What happened next, I'll write in the next chapter. This is the whole of what I was still able to do for myself, in that dark. Everything after this was no longer my own doing.

(Continued in Chapter 12.)

Chapter 12. Cast Out

> *_Previously_ — On the night of the third day, exhausted past bearing,*
> *Pheugon poured out words that might have been prayer or might have been*
> *curse. What began with "I was right" ended with "So why am I here." He*
> *released that question into the water and lost consciousness. What he*
> *remembers next is the sensation of his body moving. He was not the one*
> *moving it.*

The current lifted my body.

I thought it was a dream. Three full days in that water — it wouldn't have been strange to dream of water lifting me.

It wasn't a dream. I only learned that later. The sluice gate had opened. On its own schedule. Not for me. Things had simply gone back to normal. The same as when it had closed.

I turned this fact over many times since. That door hadn't shut to trap me, and it hadn't opened to let me out, either. A set hour had simply come. I could have died inside that indifference, and I was also saved by that same indifference. That the thing that saved me and the thing that had trapped me were the same kind of thing — I still find that strange, even now.

Before I came fully to my senses, my body reacted first. I think I heard the sound of water rushing hard through the narrow gap past the gate. Or maybe that's a memory I've pieced together since. What's certain is that, at some moment, the water where I'd been sitting suddenly pulled me in.

. . .

My body was swept up in the current.

I couldn't resist. I had no strength left to resist. I struck the wall a few times. I don't remember clearly whether it hurt. I only flowed.

I don't remember that moment in detail. What the body remembers and what the mind remembers are different things. My body still, now and then, recalls the force of that current, the shock of striking the wall. My mind kept nothing at all. I wasn't there to keep it.

The current carried me on a long while. Through narrow stretches, through wide ones, narrow again. I don't know how many times I breathed, carried along in that flow. Whenever my head broke the surface for a moment, I drew breath by instinct.

Once my body struck the tunnel wall hard. At the shoulder. In that instant I came briefly back to myself. Pain had woken me. I opened my eyes and saw nothing. Still in the dark. I closed them again. I already knew it made no difference, open or shut.

In that brief moment I had a strange thought. If I died like this, no one would ever know. The supervisor would believe I was somewhere on the road to the Reckoning; my father would assume I'd arrived safely. No one would ever search this waterway. Strangely, that thought didn't frighten me. I had no strength left even to feel afraid.

The current turned once more. I gave my body over to it entirely. There was no reason left to resist, and no strength left either.

. . .

Light appeared.

Faint, at first. Flickering every time the current shook my body. I couldn't tell whether it was real or something I'd imagined.

I've gone back over that moment many times since. Was I swimming toward that light, or was I just letting the current carry me. I still can't say for certain. Maybe it was both. My body moved toward the light, apart from my will.

At first the light was only a matter of brightness. But as it grew closer, color began to appear. Gray shifting into a hazy gold. Only seeing that color again did I realize how completely I'd forgotten, in three days, that color existed at all.

The light kept growing. The current slowed. I felt myself come out into some wide, open space. It felt as if the ceiling had disappeared. Wind brushed over my head.

Wind. It took a moment to recognize the feeling. Three days without ever feeling it. There's no wind, underwater. I felt that wind on my face, and something in my body responded. Something like a sign that I was still alive.

The current pushed me upward. A narrow vertical passage. My fingertips brushed the wall. Smooth stone. A familiar touch. I had no room left to think about what it meant.

The water gave me one great push. And I struck something solid. Stone. Round, mossy. I only learned later — it was the coping stone of a well.

. . .

I think I lost consciousness there. I don't know if it was brief or long.

The first thing I felt, opening my eyes, was light. So bright my eyes hurt. I closed them again, and opened them, little by little.

Sky.

The sky, seen for the first time in three days. I don't know how to describe that color. Blue wasn't enough of a word. I understood, in that moment, for the first time, how enormous a thing color was. In the dark there had been no color. Not light, not dark. Simply nothing at all. Seeing the sky, I was overwhelmed by the fact that the world held color at all.

Looking up at that sky, for one brief moment, I couldn't tell whether this was a sky I was seeing dead, or seeing alive. Strangely, that distinction didn't seem to matter, in that moment. The sky was simply there. Not waiting for me, not turning me away. Just there.

The touch of sunlight on my face was unfamiliar too. For three days my skin had known only the temperature of water. Now there was a different temperature. Stinging, drying, falling from above. It took me a while even to recognize it as sunlight.

My body was soaked. I lay sprawled on stone ground. My arms and legs had no strength left at all. Moving even a single finger, opening my eyelids the whole way, was hard.

I had no strength to look at my own fingertips, but I could tell by feel alone that my fingertips had gone wrinkled and swollen. My mouth tasted of salt and iron, mixed together. A low ringing wouldn't stop in my ears. Every blink made the light look slightly different.

A chill I hadn't felt in the water came over me now. As my soaked body began to dry, I felt colder, somehow, than I had underwater.

I could feel the warmth of the stone beneath me. Which meant the sun had been heating that stone a while already. Daytime. I still didn't know what time it was, or exactly how many days I'd been trapped. The wall bore three scratched lines, but I had no way to count how much time had passed since I'd drawn the last one.

In that moment, for the first time in my life, I realized I had completely lost track of the days. It was one of the very few moments in this whole book where I lost count of a number. Strangely, it left me feeling clear. Before something uncountable, I no longer needed to count at all.

Sound came back slowly too. At first just a ringing hum. Then, one by one, it broke apart into separate sounds. Far off, a cart wheel rolling over paved stone; a bird's cry; someone bargaining in a low voice. To ears that had known nothing but water for three days, those sounds were too many, too loud. I lay there with my eyes open, trying to pick them apart one by one, and soon gave up. This city was simply living out its day, as if nothing at all had happened.

. . .

That's when a voice spoke.

"…You're not from here, are you?"

I only rolled my eyes toward the sound, not knowing where it came from. I had no strength to lift my head.

I heard that question first, and only after, lifted my eyes and saw the person. That was the order it happened in. The voice came first.

A child's voice. I managed to turn my head, just a little. Beyond the well's coping stone, someone was looking down at me. Backlit, so I couldn't make out the face.

Bare feet. Dust on the tops of them. One toe was tapping idly at a pebble. It might have been getting ready to run, or it might just have been bored.

I tried to answer. What came out of my throat sounded like water. It wasn't words.

For three years I'd made my living by voice. And in that moment, what came out of my throat wasn't a human sound at all. That fact was, strangely, humiliating to me.

I still think about it, why that first question wasn't "Are you all right?" but "You're not from here, are you?" Usually, when someone's pulled out of the water, don't you ask first if they're all right? But that child asked first whether I belonged to this city or not. I'd learn the reason later. In this city, which side you belonged to had to be confirmed before who was hurt. I didn't know that yet. I only felt, then, that the order of the question was strange.

The owner of that voice said nothing for a moment. Seemed to be looking me over. I felt that gaze on me and still had no strength to lift my head any further.

"…You're not dead?" the child asked again. The voice had come a little closer than before. Sounded like they'd crouched down.

I answered by trying to move my fingers, just a little. That was all I could do, in that moment. The child looked down at that small movement for a long while.

. . .

I remember those few seconds very slowly. My body had completely broken down, and yet some strange corner of my mind stayed oddly clear. In that brief moment I thought: where am I. Starting from that well, three days ago — how far had I drifted, carried along, to end up here.

And right after, another thought came. I had run to avoid going to the Reckoning. The opposite direction, toward somewhere I knew no one. But this current had flowed regardless of my will. I had never once chosen where this water would take me.

I wrote, in earlier chapters, that at every fork I chose a direction with no basis for it at all. Looking back now, those choices had never meant anything to begin with. Where the sluice gates would open and close, which way the water would push me — I had decided none of it. I had simply been carried along by the water. To the very city I had tried so hard to avoid, no one but the water itself had brought me.

I've stood a long time, before this fact, between the word coincidence and some other word. Calling it coincidence was easier. Calling it anything else was not. I would only come to accept that other word much later, in a different chapter of this book. Here, I'm still not ready to use it.

I gathered my strength and lifted my head. And I looked, not toward where the child was pointing, but somewhere beyond it.

Those few seconds are the moment I've returned to, in memory, more than any other in this entire book. In that moment I still knew nothing. Who I would meet in this city, how long I would end up staying here — none of it. I only lifted my head. And with that single motion, the next chapter of my life had already begun.

. . .

Beside the well's coping stone, a bronze plate was set into a low post. Rusted. An old plate.

I strained my eyes to read the letters. Blurred. I strained again.

The two characters slowly came into focus.

The Reckoning.

. . .

I looked at those letters. For a long time.

The plate was cold. My fingers hadn't even touched it, and still, I believe, even now, that I felt that cold.

I want to say that no thought came to me, in that moment. But that isn't true. Thoughts came. Only there were too many of them, all at once, and none of them ever became a sentence.

The first thought was this. This is a mistake. I've misread some other sign. I held onto that thought and looked at the letters again. The blur didn't clear, and yet those two characters didn't change at all.

The second thought was this. A little further on might be a different city. The Reckoning is large; this well might just be on its outskirts. I couldn't lean on that thought for long either. I had no strength left to move my body and confirm it.

By the third thought, I could no longer make any more thoughts at all. I simply accepted the fact. I had arrived exactly where I had run from.

I remember what my body did, in that moment. My heart beat slowly, but hard. One long breath came in and didn't go back out for a long time. I only understood later that it was shock. At the time I just felt that something was wrong with my body.

I had run. Away from the Reckoning. Fled into the waterway, trapped for three days with no idea which way I was going. And the place the water had spat me out was, of all places, this city.

I didn't even have the strength, then, to think about whether that was coincidence or not. I only watched those two characters, and felt my whole body say, no. No. It has to be no. And still, there before my eyes, those letters stood. Blurred, and yet unmistakable.

I lay on the stone ground, unable to look away from those letters. Above me the child said something more. I couldn't make out the words.

I've thought about this moment many times since. That someone who fled should be washed back up in the very place they fled from. I didn't know, then, how common a story that is, in this world. I thought it was some especially cruel coincidence, meant only for me. I see it differently now. Maybe it wasn't coincidence at all — maybe there had simply never been so many places left to flee to, from the start. Every waterway leads somewhere, in the end. The places a person can be carried to are narrower than they think.

I'm placing this chapter at the end of Part One. That noon, I lay sprawled at the wellside of the Reckoning. A boy who had run, been trapped three days in the dark, was cast out into the very heart of the place he'd run from. Where the current had carried me, and the moment it cast me out — I had chosen neither. That was the whole of what Part One taught me.

(Continued in Part Two.)

The Forty-Day Clause, Part Two

The Reckoning

Chapter 13. You're Not From Here

> *_Previously_ — Trapped behind a closed sluice gate, Pheugon spent three days in darkness. For the first time, he spoke aloud — words he had never said to anyone. On the third day the gate opened, and the current carried him out. He opened his eyes to an unfamiliar well and an unfamiliar sky. A passing child looked down at him and asked — "You're not from here, are you?" He looked up at the sign. The Reckoning.*

The question came first, and the name of the city came after.

I remember the order. Exactly that order. I heard the question first, and only then did I lift my eyes to the sign. If it had happened the other way around, I think I would have passed out again before I could answer.

THE RECKONING.

Two words cut into stone. A bronze plate set into a low post beside the well's coping. Rusted. An old plate. It meant the city had been calling itself that for a very long time.

I think I laughed, in that moment. No sound came out. My body had no strength left for sound. But the corners of my mouth moved. What kind of laugh it was, I still can't explain. Washed up in the very place I'd fled — after three days, no less, and naked and scoured by the water — whether that was funny or terrifying, I still haven't decided.

. . .

"…Are you all right?"

The child asked again. I hadn't answered the first time.

I tried to answer, but only a watery sound came out of my throat. It felt like three days' worth of swallowed water was still inside me.

The child bent down and threw a rope toward me — one of the ropes that always hung at the well. I caught it with both hands. My hands had almost no strength left, but the child looped the other end around the post and began hauling, putting their whole weight into it.

Not a light body. Or rather — not weight so much as technique. I learned later that this child had grown up at the well. Someone who had learned rope work in their bones.

I was dragged up over the coping stone. And collapsed there.

The stone was warm. The sun was out. The first sun I'd seen in three days.

I still remember that warmth. The first sensation I felt, after three days in the dark. Not resentment, not fear — just warmth. The body was that simple. Even while the mind was tangled, the body still knew warm as warm.

My eyes slowly adjusted to the light. I turned my head to the side. A low wall ran around the well, and beyond it I could see rooftops. All the same color. Same tile, same pitch. In the city I came from, every roof was a different color — depending on means, depending on when it had last been repaired. Here it wasn't like that.

A few people passed by, glanced toward the well, and kept walking. No one stopped. As if pulling a person out of the water wasn't unusual here — or as if, even if it was, no one stopped for what wasn't their business.

I thought, at the time, that this was coldness. I learned later that it wasn't. The people of this city weren't cold. They were all busy keeping their own numbers. Spending time on someone else's business, meddling in someone else's business — either one could be weighed. So no one stopped walking.

. . .

The child crouched beside me. Around fourteen, I guessed. Maybe a year younger than me, but the eyes didn't match that.

"You came out of the conduit?" the child asked. "From down there?"

"…Yes."

"It should've been closed. It's not the hour it opens, these days."

I didn't answer. I had no strength to answer, and I didn't know what to say.

The child looked me up and down. Assessing eyes. Not rude — just trying to be accurate.

"Your wrist," the child said.

"…What?"

"There's nothing on your wrist."

I looked at my own wrist. Nothing there but wrinkled, waterlogged skin. I didn't understand.

"Everyone from here has one," the child said. "A tag. Fitted when you're born. You don't have one. So—"

The child stopped and looked at me again.

"—you're not from here, are you?"

I didn't know, then, what the tag was. Two days later, in the square, I'd see one for myself. And the moment I did, I'd feel for the first time how differently this city ran. Until then, I just sat there in a stolen body.

. . .

"…No," I said. "Not from here."

It wasn't a lie. It couldn't have been, really. I truly wasn't from this city.

"Where'd you come from, then?"

I couldn't answer. I had no idea what would happen if I said the real name of my city out loud. I knew nothing about whether people commonly used the conduits to reach this place, or whether that alone would raise suspicion.

The child seemed to read my silence differently.

"It's fine," the child said. "You don't have to say if you don't want to. Plenty of people here are like that."

"…People like that?"

"People with things they don't want to talk about." The child shrugged. "What's your name?"

I wasn't at all ready for that question.

If someone asks your name, you have to give one. I froze in front of that simple rule. My name was the name that would be written on the Reckoning's sentence document. The name on the herald roster. I knew, by instinct alone, that I couldn't say it here.

Something came out of my mouth before I decided anything.

"…Had," I said.

Only after I'd said it did I realize what name that was.

Why that name came out first, I didn't know at the time. Had was the name of a boy who'd left the training grounds three years before. Maybe I picked it because I'd never run into him again. Or maybe it was for some other reason. I carried that question a long time after that day.

"Had," the child repeated. "I'm Trope."

. . .

Trope stood and looked down at me.

"Can you stand?"

I tried and sat back down. My legs had no strength at all. Trope sighed and pulled me up by the arm. Strong grip.

Standing, I checked my bag. It had stayed on my back through the current, and the strap hadn't torn. I couldn't check whether what was inside had survived. I couldn't open it in front of Trope.

Inside the bag was the sentence document. The Reckoning's sentence of demolition. I'd wrapped it in oiled paper, but after three days underwater I assumed it couldn't have survived. It had. I'd learn later that this was no accident.

Trope started walking ahead. I limped after her.

"Where are we going?" I asked.

"Somewhere to dry off, first." Trope didn't look back. "You show up in the square looking like that, everyone's going to stare."

. . .

Walking, I saw the city for the first time.

Quiet. That was my first impression. The city I came from was loud in the mornings. The market opening, merchants shouting, children running.

This city wasn't like that. People walked. Quietly, at an exact pace. Neither hurried nor idle. The streets were clean. Not a single piece of trash. Every doorstep swept.

And people kept looking up.

I didn't know, at the time, what that habit was. I thought they were checking the sky. Watching the weather. The next day I'd learn they weren't looking at the sky at all. They were looking at numbers hanging high on the building walls.

An old man passed us and nodded to Trope. Trope nodded back the same way. I couldn't tell if they knew each other, or if that was just how everyone greeted everyone in this city.

"Are people here always this quiet?" I asked.

Trope slowed for a moment.

"It's not quiet," Trope said. "Everyone's counting."

"…Counting what?"

Trope didn't answer. She just started walking again.

I thought, at the time, that not answering meant indifference. It wasn't. Trope wasn't holding back words from me — she was someone who had to re-confirm the answer to that question, herself, every single day. I only understood that much later.

We turned a corner and a small square came into view. Not many people. Something stood in the middle — I only caught it in passing and didn't know what it was. A post about twice a person's height, with something fixed to the top.

"What's that?" I asked.

Trope answered without even looking toward it.

"A terminal. There are plenty more besides that one."

"…A terminal that measures what?"

Trope stopped walking and turned to look at me. For the first time, her expression shifted, just slightly. I couldn't tell if it was surprise or something else.

"You really don't know?" Trope asked.

I couldn't answer. I didn't know whether to choose pretending not to know when I did, or actually not knowing.

"…This is my first time seeing one," I managed to say.

A lie. Few people knew what a Scales terminal was as well as I did. But I truly had never seen one shaped like this city's before.

Trope didn't press further. She just started walking again. But after that, the way she looked at me seemed slightly different.

I couldn't read that look, then. Now I know. Trope didn't start suspecting me at that moment. It was the opposite. She had never met anyone who claimed not to know the Scales, and she'd started to wonder what kind of person that made me.

. . .

Trope led me to a small shed not far from the well. It looked like a laundry-drying place. A few empty lines hung there, and an old blanket lay folded in a corner.

"Dry off here," Trope said. "I'll come back in a bit."

"…Why?"

"Why what?"

"…Why are you helping me?"

Trope looked at me for a moment. There was something in her eyes I couldn't read yet.

"It'd be strange to just leave someone who nearly drowned," Trope said. A very simple answer. Simple enough that it made me suspicious.

Trope left the door half-open on her way out.

. . .

I wrapped myself in the blanket and sat huddled in the corner of the shed. I listened to the sounds outside. Footsteps, a door opening and closing, someone occasionally calling someone else's name. None of it carried any

urgency. In the city I came from, evening brought the market closing and children being called home, all layered on top of each other at once. Here the sounds didn't layer. One at a time, in order.

About half an hour later, Trope came back. She was carrying a set of dry clothes and a piece of bread.

"Put these on," Trope said, tossing the clothes to me. "They're my brother's. He doesn't wear them anymore."

"…Your brother?"

"Doesn't live here," Trope said, curtly. A tone that said not to ask more.

I didn't ask more. I took the clothes and changed. Trope stepped outside and stood with her back turned.

I was halfway through the bread when Trope came back in and sat down across from me.

"Had." Trope used my fake name. "What are you going to do here?"

I hadn't prepared an answer for that.

"…I don't know," I said. This time it wasn't a lie.

"Do you have anywhere to go?"

"…No."

Trope looked at me a moment, then nodded. She didn't ask more. She was someone who rationed her questions. I couldn't tell, then, whether that was consideration or indifference.

"I'll come back tomorrow morning," Trope said, standing. "You can stay here. Nobody much comes by."

"…Why do you keep looking out for me?"

Trope stopped at the door. She seemed to be choosing her answer.

"I don't know," Trope finally said. "Just because."

Then she left.

I thought about that "just because" for a long time afterward. Set against what I learned later, that answer wasn't a lie. Trope really didn't know the reason. No — it wasn't that there was no reason, but that she must have thought it was still too soon to put that reason into her own words. I wouldn't learn what that reason was until much later.

. . .

I pulled the blanket around myself. Then I opened my bag and checked inside.

The sentence document was wet, but not torn. The lettering hadn't run. I wrapped it back in the oiled paper and pushed it deep into the bag.

That was the first time I was truly alone inside this city. Stranger, somehow, than three days of darkness. In the dark, at least, I'd known where I had to go. Not now. I was sitting there with the very sentence I'd fled from, hidden in a bag, in the very city that sentence was meant for.

Evening light came through the gaps in the shed. I sat leaning against the wall, wrapped in the blanket. My body was exhausted, but sleep wouldn't come.

I'd hated this city for three years. In those three years, I'd never once actually seen it. I'd only known its name. That hating a place for three years on nothing but a name was possible — until that moment, I'd never once thought it strange.

And now I was lying under this city's blanket, wearing this city's clothes, eating bread handed to me by this city's child.

I didn't see that contradiction clearly that night. I had no strength left to see it. A body that had survived three days had no energy left to think. But I felt one thing. That hatred could go this quiet in front of the thing it hated. I was afraid of that. I didn't yet know what came next, once hatred went quiet.

Somewhere in the distance, something like a bell rang once. Low and short. I didn't know what it signaled. Trope was already gone, and there was no one to ask.

I closed my eyes. And for the first time in a long while, I fell asleep without counting anything.

I wouldn't learn until the next morning that this was the last night in this city I would fall asleep without counting.

(Continued in Chapter 14.)

Chapter 14. The Days Remaining

> *_Previously_ — The child who pulled Pheugon from the well at the Reckoning was named Trope. Pheugon hid his real name and lied, calling himself "Had." Trope brought him dry clothes and bread and let him sleep in the shed. The city was quiet and clean, and people kept glancing up. Pheugon didn't ask why, and fell asleep without counting anything.*

The first thought I had when I opened my eyes that morning was a number.

Habit. Three years of checking my weight first thing every morning — the habit had stayed in my body even in this city, where nothing marked my wrist. I raised my hand, then realized there was nowhere to raise it to, and lowered it again.

I still can't quite explain the emptiness of that moment. Having no number should have been a relief. It wasn't. I didn't know how to live without a number.

Morning light came through the gap in the shed door. I folded the blanket and went outside.

Outside, people were already moving. Someone carrying a water jar, someone with a broom. The same quiet I'd seen the day before held true in the morning too. Nobody was running.

At that point I was still thinking of this city's soon-to-vanish fate and this morning scene as two separate things. I didn't yet know that they were the same morning of the same city — that there was no contradiction between them at all.

. . .

Trope hadn't come yet. I hesitated in front of the shed a moment, then decided to walk, staying close by.

Around a corner I found the same kind of post I'd seen the day before. A post about twice a person's height. A plate fixed to the top, with a number floating on it.

I went closer.

39.

That was all. No other letters. No city name, no clause number, no explanation. Just a number.

I stopped where I stood.

I knew that number. Knew it exactly. Forty days' grace. Sentence of demolition. The number I'd been counting since the day I received the document in the supervisor's office. And that number was already being counted here, in the middle of this city, without me.

I stood in front of it a long time. It made no sense. A sentence only takes effect once someone reads it aloud. I hadn't read anything yet. Not a single letter.

And yet the number already stood at thirty-nine.

. . .

A woman passing by stopped beside me and looked up at the plate. Older woman, carrying a market basket. She looked at the number for a long while, then walked on with no expression at all.

I followed her and asked.

"…Excuse me."

She turned.

"What's that number?" I asked.

She looked at me strangely for a moment, then seemed to place me as an outsider. Her expression softened a little.

"The days remaining," she said. "If you have to ask, you really must be from out of town."

"…Days remaining."

"Until demolition," she said, curtly. "Our city. The notice already came. Just the one who reads it hasn't come yet."

I couldn't breathe.

"…The one who reads it?"

"The herald," she said. "The Scales finished its calculation. The sentence document's already out. But it only really starts once someone reads it aloud. That person hasn't come yet. So everyone's waiting. Nobody knows what happens if that number hits zero and no one's come."

"…Has this happened before?" I asked. "In another city."

The woman shrugged.

"I've heard of it," she said. "Some far-off city, back when my grandmother was young, is what they say. But I don't know anyone who's actually seen it. A

whole city ending up like this is very rare. So nobody really knows what to do, either."

She looked back up at the plate.

"Our Adjudicator's keeping watch on that number. Whatever happens, he's the one who'd know best," she said. "So we're just waiting. Until he says something."

I couldn't say anything, standing there. She probably had no idea why I was standing there like that. It was the first time I truly understood it. The Scales sends its notice to a city the moment its calculation is finished. It's true a person has to read it aloud for it to take effect, but the Scales has already fixed when that person will arrive. The fortieth day. What happens if no one comes that day — nobody knows. I didn't know either.

. . .

After the woman left, I looked up at the plate again.

39.

That was a notice. Not a verdict — a notice. I understood the difference for the first time that day. The Scales had its own way of telling a city this news without me. My running away didn't leave this city in the dark about anything. This city already knew. What was coming for it. How much time was left. Only the hand to actually open that door was missing.

Only I knew that hand was mine.

I kept walking toward the square. The farther I walked, the more plates I saw. On building walls, at the well, at the market entrance. Different sizes, but all the same number. 39.

People walked past them with a glance and moved on. No crying, no shouting. What Trope had said yesterday came back to me. "Everyone's counting."

. . .

Nearer the market, the crowd thickened. A vegetable seller was setting out her stall, a woman selling cloth was arranging her wares. One person was haggling over a price with a merchant. The merchant wasn't giving ground.

"You want a discount because we've got thirty-nine days left?" the merchant said. "Goods sold today get today's price."

A few people nearby laughed at that. Real laughter. I found it strange. Under a number counting down to the city's end, people were still bargaining, still laughing.

I read that, at the time, as calm. I read it differently now. It wasn't calm — it was endurance. Keep doing today's work today — that was the only method these people had left. If there's nowhere to flee, and no way to turn the number back, all that's left is to do today's work today.

Somewhere, someone in an official's uniform rang a bell and called something out. I froze, thinking it was the sentence document.

"West well maintenance starting tomorrow. No water in the mornings," the official called. "Use the east well."

Just a routine notice. People nodded and dispersed. The city was counting the day of its own end while still maintaining its wells.

I felt something in front of that scene I couldn't quite name. I expected to feel anger, and didn't. Not because this city was calm about it, but because the fact that it was still moving as a city at all was what shook me. I had already

thought of this city as a place already finished. But this city didn't yet think of itself that way.

. . .

Leaving the market on my way to the square, I saw an old man.

He was standing in front of a plate mounted on a wall, not moving. Unlike the others who glanced and walked on, he stood rooted to the spot. The hand gripping his cane was trembling.

I stopped and, passing beside him, looked at his face.

He was crying. No sound. Just tears. He didn't wipe them away.

I've never forgotten that old man. The only tears I saw that day. Everyone else was calm; only he wasn't. I wondered, then, why this one man couldn't endure it the way the others did. I ask it differently now. Were the others really enduring it — or had they, like the old man, already spent all the strength they had for crying?

I felt I should go over and say something to him. I didn't. I didn't know what to say. I didn't know if I had any right to say anything at all to this city.

I just walked past. That was the biggest lie I told that day. Bigger than the name Had. I walked past that old man pretending to know nothing, pretending none of it concerned me.

. . .

On one side of the square, some children were playing. A game where you threw stones into a chalked circle — listening closer, they were counting

numbers as they played.

"Thirty-nine, thirty-eight, thirty-seven—"

Each throw lowered the count by one. I couldn't tell whether it was a rule of the game or just the children bringing the number they saw every day into their play.

Something in me twisted, watching them. An emotion I couldn't name exactly. Not anger, not sadness. That these children had turned their city's ending into a counting game, and how natural that looked — that was what shook me.

One child spotted me and asked.

"Mister, can you count too?"

"…I count."

"How many left, you think?"

I didn't answer. The child seemed satisfied without an answer and went back to the game.

. . .

I sat down in the shade at the edge of the square. One question wouldn't leave my head.

Why wasn't anyone fleeing?

In the city I came from, half the people would have already packed their bags. A whole city's demolition, with thirty-nine days' grace — anyone who could move would have moved in that time.

Not here. All that morning, walking, I hadn't seen a single person packing, not a single cart leaving.

I found it strange, almost frightening. Knowing a whole city would disappear, and still doing today's work, selling today's goods, drawing today's water. As if the number thirty-nine weren't real, or as if they believed it had nothing to do with them.

It wasn't that. I only understood by that evening. It wasn't that they didn't believe the number. They believed it too well — so well that there was nothing left to do but believe, and so they chose to live today instead. I didn't know the difference then.

Trope arrived beside me without my noticing.

"What are you looking at?"

I startled and shifted a little.

"…Why isn't anyone leaving?" I asked. "This city's disappearing, you said. Within thirty-nine days."

Trope glanced at the square's plate. Her expression didn't change.

"Wherever you go, there's a Scales," Trope said.

"…What difference does that make?"

"Leaving gets you nothing. Every other city has a Scales too, and its own weight there. Nothing you've built up here disappears. You carry all of it with you."

I thought I understood that at the time. Actually I'd only understood half of it. What Trope meant wasn't only about the system. I wouldn't fully understand it until weeks later, when I heard her mother's story.

"And," Trope added. "This is my city."

She said it without looking at me. She was looking at the square's plate.

39.

I looked at her profile for a long time. I didn't know what to say, so I said nothing.

. . .

We sat like that for a while. Trope spoke first.

"Had," Trope asked. "You don't say where you came from, you don't know where you're going. So what are you going to do with your thirty-nine days here?"

I had no answer to that question. Or rather — I had an answer, but couldn't give it. *I'm here to watch this city fall.* Just imagining saying it made my stomach turn.

"…I don't know," I said again.

"You keep saying that," Trope said. Not laughing, but not mocking either. Just stating a fact.

"…Sorry."

"Nothing to be sorry about." Trope stood. "Come with me, then. If you've got nothing to do, there's something you can help with."

"…What kind of thing?"

"Errands at the Scales. It's what I do."

My body went stiff at that. I hadn't expected the words "at the Scales" to carry so much weight.

"…What do you do there?"

Trope started walking and answered.

"You'll see when we get there."

. . .

Following Trope, I looked back once more at the plate in the square.

39.

I haven't forgotten that number for a single day since. It was a different kind of number from the hundred and twelve cases I'd counted over three years. Those numbers had belonged to other people. This number was one I'd made. No — not made by me. Made by the Scales. And yet I felt, standing in front of it, as if I'd carved it in myself.

It wasn't guilt. Not yet, at that point. It was closer to a strange sense of ownership. This number is mine. I brought it to this city. I had fled, but this number hadn't followed me — it had already arrived here first, waiting for me.

I still couldn't fully feel the hundred and twenty thousand people inside that number as people. Trope was the one exception. Trope had a face, a name, a hand that had pulled me out of the water the day before. The rest — a hundred and twenty thousand — were still just a number to me.

I don't remember exactly when the rest began to gain faces. Only that it started that day, in that square, in the long moment I spent looking at Trope's

profile.

Trope was already walking well ahead. I quickened my step to catch up.

I didn't know, then, what "errands at the Scales" would mean, or what I'd see standing in front of it. I just followed Trope. In a fled city, under a fled name, with a fled sentence in my bag.

(Continued in Chapter 15.)

Chapter 15. Before the Scales

> *_Previously_ — The number "39" hung everywhere across the Reckoning. People lived beneath it, and still no one fled. Pheugon asked why, and slowly began to sense that the number had a hundred and twenty thousand faces. Trope took him along to help with errands at the Scales.*

The Reckoning's Scales was nothing like the one I knew.

In the city I came from, there were six terminals. Three in the square, two at the market entrance, one in the herald office corridor. Small, quiet machines — you raised your hand, and a number appeared.

The Reckoning's Scales was the entire square.

. . .

Trope led me to the middle of the city, an open plaza with clear sky on every side. In the center stood a huge plate, facing the sky. As tall as three or four people stacked together. Beneath it, a long line stretched out.

"This is the main office," Trope said. "Everyone comes here to check. The small plates around the neighborhoods are just notices — the real checking happens here."

Everyone in line held their wrist out in front of them. Something was fastened to each wrist. The tag Trope had mentioned the day before.

Up close, it was a thin metal band. A small groove on the inside. When their turn came, people touched that groove to a stand beneath the plate. A moment later, a number appeared on the plate, above, in the position corresponding to that person.

I found the method strangely elaborate. Where I came from, raising your hand made a number appear on a small screen only you could see. Quiet. Not here. The Reckoning put a person's weight up on a plate the whole square could see, right above that person's head.

That was this city's way. Weight wasn't a private matter here. It was public. I saw that difference for the first time that day, and it would be a long while before I understood what it meant.

The line moved forward little by little. The turn came for the young man standing ahead of me. He touched his wrist to the stand.

A number appeared on the plate, at his spot. It must have risen quite a bit from the day before. His shoulders visibly stiffened.

A few people nearby glanced at the number. No one stared outright, but he clearly knew they'd all seen it. He bowed his head and hurried away.

I saw this city's cruelty for the first time in that scene. It wasn't the Scales that was cruel. The Scales only produced a number. What was cruel was where that number hung. Where I came from, you saw your own number alone. Even if you'd done something shameful, that shame stayed inside you and ended there. Here, that shame hung before the eyes of the entire square.

That day, I thought this the more honest way. If you have nothing to hide, there's nothing to fear. How naive that thought was, I would only understand later.

. . .

Trope didn't join the line — she turned off to the side. There was a small table there, and an old man sitting behind it. He seemed unwell; two canes stood propped beside him.

"You came," the man said, smiling at Trope.

"I'll do it for you again today," Trope said.

Trope carefully lifted the man's wrist and touched it to the stand. He didn't seem able to raise his hand that high on his own. A moment later, a number appeared on the plate. He looked up at it and nodded.

"Same as before," he said. "Good."

"It's not good, it's just what should happen," Trope said. "You're not doing anything these days anyway, Grandfather."

"Doing nothing is the good thing, then," he said, laughing.

Trope set down a water bottle beside him and asked briefly how he was doing. The man seemed to know her well. Like people who'd known each other a long time.

In that short exchange, I began to see a little of who Trope was. A girl who rationed her words about other people's business unhesitatingly lifted the hand of an old man who couldn't move well. I hadn't yet managed to connect those two as the same person.

Standing there awkwardly, the old man looked up at me and asked.

"Who's this?"

"Had," Trope answered for me. "He's agreed to help for a few days."

"Outsider," the man said, glancing at my wrist. "No tag."

"…Yes."

"Tags get fitted at birth," the man said. He explained without being asked — old people sometimes do that. "Can't take it off. There's no way to take it off. You wear it until you die. Proof you belong to this city."

"…And after you die?"

"Even I don't know that," he laughed. "Haven't died yet."

Trope laughed a little beside him. I found the laugh unfamiliar. It was the softest expression I'd seen on her face so far.

I would remember that laugh for a long time. I'd see it a few more times after that, but each time it surprised me. Probably because I'd already noticed, that first time, how rare it was.

. . .

That wasn't all the table work involved. Trope helped two more people there. One a woman who couldn't see well, another a young woman carrying a small child on her back. The woman with the child had no free hands, so Trope touched her wrist to the groove for her.

"You help like this every day?" I asked.

"Not every day," Trope said. "Whenever someone needs it."

"…Do you get paid?"

Trope looked at me as if I'd said something strange.

"No," Trope said. "Should I?"

I couldn't answer. Where I came from, errands got paid in coin as a matter of course. This city seemed to run on a different rule.

When the work was done, Trope touched her own wrist to the stand.

A number appeared on the plate.

4.

A low number. Very low. I felt a small jolt of surprise seeing it. I'd vaguely assumed that someone Trope's age would have accumulated more weight by now.

Trope looked at the number with no expression at all. As if she saw it every day — which, indeed, she did.

"…That's low," I said.

"It should be," Trope said, lowering her wrist. "Living low is the goal, isn't it."

I took that as obvious at the time. In a city with a Scales, everyone lives that way — low, cautious. So did I. But something else was mixed into Trope's answer. I couldn't put my finger on it then. I learned later. For Trope, a low number wasn't a goal. It was proof. Proof that she was different from her mother.

. . .

Trope looked at me this time.

"Had — aren't you going to check?"

I should have anticipated that question, but I hadn't.

"…I don't have a tag here," I said, raising my wrist. Bare skin, nothing on it.

"You can do it temporarily," Trope said, pointing toward the table. "Outsiders can check too. You just write down your name and where you're from."

I stiffened.

I was afraid of two things at once, in that moment. One was having to write a name. If I wrote the name Had into this city's official record, there was even the smallest chance that record could later be cross-checked against my real name. The other was simpler. I didn't want to see my own weight. There had been a reason I'd suddenly stopped my three years of daily checking. I wasn't yet ready to face what I was doing, myself.

"…It's fine," I said. "I won't."

"Why?"

"…No reason."

Trope looked at me for a moment. A look similar to the one from the day before, when I'd said I didn't know what a Scales terminal was. But this time, she held it a little longer.

"Strange," Trope said. "Everyone's curious."

"…I'm not curious."

"That's exactly what's strange." Trope didn't press further. She just left that remark and moved on to the next person.

I've come back to that moment many times since. Trope didn't start suspecting me that day. I know now. That day, Trope had simply met, for the first time, someone who didn't want to see their own weight. The people of this city aren't afraid to see their own numbers. Low, and they're relieved; high, and

they're careful. Nobody wants not to see it. I was, for the first time in that city, someone who didn't dare face their own number.

Even after Trope moved to the next person, I stood by that table for a long while. The stand was right in front of me. Close enough to reach.

In that moment I felt my hand trying, on its own, to rise. Three years of the same motion, every day. My body remembered the rule. I watched that hand and forced myself to hold it back. It felt like holding down someone else's hand.

What I was really afraid of, I didn't know exactly, then. I know now. I wasn't afraid the number would be high. I was afraid it would be low. That the number of someone who'd fled — someone who had decided to abandon an entire city — might still read low. That even the Scales wouldn't notice that.

. . .

We left the square and walked. The sun had passed midday.

"You come here every day?" I asked.

"Almost," Trope said. "Grandfather and that woman who can't see well — there's no one else to help them."

"…Isn't it hard?"

Trope glanced back at me.

"What's hard about it?" she asked back. Not mocking — genuinely curious.

I couldn't answer.

"It's just something I do every day," Trope said, facing forward again. "You don't think about hard or not hard before you do it. You just do it. If I don't, nobody looks after their numbers."

"…Why does that matter? What changes if their number isn't seen?"

Trope stopped walking.

"If a number suddenly jumps," Trope said. "You know what that means? Someone did something to that person. Robbed them, or cheated them, or hurt them. If you don't watch a number every day, that kind of thing can happen and pass right by, unnoticed. That's what scares me. Something passing by, unnoticed."

I had no answer to that.

It was the first time I considered that the Scales might not simply be a tool of punishment. For Trope, that number wasn't a judgment — it was a signal. A signal telling her that something bad had happened to someone. I'd never once held that view before. To me, a number had always been the size of a sin. To Trope, it was sometimes a trace of what someone else had done to a person.

"Who's your grandfather?" I asked, trying to turn the subject a little.

"Neighbor," Trope said. "I've known him since I was small."

"…And your family?"

Trope's pace slowed for a moment.

"None," Trope said. "It's just me."

I couldn't ask further. I felt there was something inside that short answer, but I didn't know whether I had any right to ask what it was.

I thought about that answer for a long time that night. How light the tone was in which "it's just me" came out. Someone who tells a heavy story in a light tone has already told that story hundreds of times before. I didn't know that then. I'd learn it a few days later.

Trope walked me back to the shed. Before we parted, she suddenly asked.

"Had's not your real name, is it?"

I thought my heart would stop.

"…Why do you say that?"

"You're always half a beat late answering to it," Trope said. "Nobody's ever late answering to their own name."

I said nothing.

"It's fine," Trope said. "You don't have to say. I've got things I'm not saying either."

Then she turned and walked away. I watched her back for a long time.

I should have understood, in that moment, that Trope had already seen right through me. But that day, I only felt relief. Relief at not being caught. That I'd already been caught, in all but name, I couldn't see that yet.

Alone in front of the shed, I looked back once toward the square. In the distance, that huge plate was visible. Everyone's numbers hung there, facing the sky. The sun was setting above it.

Looking at that plate, I thought: this city doesn't know my number. However long I might live here, whatever I might do, there's no spot for me on that plate. I thought that was freedom. I know now. It wasn't freedom — it was

absence. I was the one person in this city who was inside it but didn't belong to it. How dangerous that position was, I didn't know then.

Having no number on the plate, and having no name on the plate, were different things. I was free of the number, but not of the name. Somewhere, on the herald roster, I was still written down under my exact name. Pheugon. Assigned to the Reckoning. That name was waiting for me, unknown to this city's Scales, somewhere outside this city.

I pushed that thought away as I closed the shed door. I believed, then, that this was possible. That in a few days, or a few weeks, that name and that place would have nothing more to do with this city. I believed I wasn't hiding — I was only waiting. Without being able to say exactly what I was waiting for.

I didn't check my weight in that square that day. I didn't check it for a long while after, either. Trope was the only one who found that strange, and that it happened to be her who noticed the strangeness — looking back — was no accident.

(Continued in Chapter 16.)

Chapter 16. Her Mother

> *_Previously_ — In the main square of the Reckoning, Pheugon finally refused to check his own weight. Trope found this strange, and before they parted, quietly said she'd already guessed his name wasn't really Had. Pheugon ended the day believing he hadn't been caught.*

The next morning, Trope came late.

I sat in front of the shed and waited a long while. The sun was well up before she appeared. Her expression was a little different than usual.

"…Is something wrong?" I asked.

"No," Trope said. Too quick an answer.

I didn't press her further, then. I thought I had no right to ask. Looking back, it wasn't a matter of right. I was simply afraid. Not ready to hear someone else's heavy story.

. . .

We walked toward the well that day. Where Trope drew water every day. The same well I'd first washed up at.

Filling the water jar, Trope suddenly said.

"I used to play here a lot. When I was little."

"…Alone?"

"With my mother."

I stiffened a little, hearing that word. It was the first time Trope had brought something up on her own.

Trope kept talking, fiddling with the jar's handle.

"My mother taught me how to use a rope, here. You saw how good I am with a rope, right? I learned it from her."

"…And now?"

Trope finished filling the jar and stood up.

"She's not here," Trope said. A flat voice. "She got pushed out."

Trope hoisted the jar onto her shoulder and ran her hand once over the well's coping stone.

"My mother's hand left a mark here, probably," Trope said. "She drew water here every single morning. The stone's a little worn. There, that spot."

I looked where she pointed. The stone really was slightly worn — a mark left by the same hand brushing the same spot for years.

"…Do you remember? Her face."

"Yes," Trope said. "Clearly. It's strange. It's been five years and it hasn't faded at all. I remember her voice too. Waking me up in the morning, calling my name."

Trope paused for a moment.

"But I don't remember much about the last day," Trope said. "Strange, right? The most important day. I came home from school and she was gone. What the weather was like that day, what I ate — none of it, I don't remember any of it."

. . .

I knew the phrase "pushed out." I knew it as a concept. When accumulated weight exceeds an individual's limit, everything that person uses stops, one by one. Housing, employment, market pass, rations. Without anyone laying a hand on them, that person ends up outside the city.

I only knew it as a principle. I'd never seen who it actually happened to.

"…When?" I asked.

"Five years ago," Trope said. "I was nine."

Trope picked up the jar and started walking. I followed alongside. I didn't know what to say.

"What happened?" I asked, carefully.

Trope stopped walking for a moment, then started again.

"It wasn't anything big," Trope said. "At least, not any single thing. But it added up. After my father left first, my mother raised me alone for years, little by little. Cheating on a price, or lying to get more rations. Nothing big, any of it. But it all added together."

. . .

"…So it went over the limit?" I asked.

"Yes," Trope said. "One morning her market pass was blocked. The following week her rations stopped. Then the house too."

"…And you?"

"I was a child," Trope said. "None of that attaches to children. I got to stay."

Something felt wrong to me about that. A structure where only the child stayed and only the mother had to leave. But I couldn't put words to exactly what was wrong.

"Where did your mother go?"

"I don't know," Trope said. "All I know is she left the city. No word since."

"…Alone? Leaving behind a nine-year-old?"

"There was nothing to choose," Trope said. Her voice sped up a little. For the first time, a defensive tone. "The house was cut off, the rations were cut off — from that day on, my mother had no way to live in this city. I could stay, so she left me here. She didn't abandon me."

Trope seemed to turn that sentence over in her own mind after saying it.

"…She didn't abandon me," Trope said once more. This time it seemed less spoken to me than to herself.

We walked in silence for a while. The jar was heavy, and Trope's pace slowed a little. I offered to carry it instead; she shook her head.

I thought, in that moment, how many times Trope must have said that sentence to herself. She didn't abandon me. I understood for the first time then that

there are people who have to say a sentence hundreds of times just to get through today.

. . .

Near the shed, Trope set the jar down. I found myself curious and asked.

"So who did you live with after that?"

"Just alone, the first few days," Trope said. "Then that grandfather came looking for me. The one at the Scales. He used to be our next-door neighbor. He came and cooked for me, found me a place instead of home. From then until now."

"…He's not family, though."

"No," Trope said. "Does that matter?"

I couldn't answer.

"The Scales doesn't know family," Trope said. "It doesn't weigh who looks after whom, anything like that. But people weigh it. Grandfather just weighed it and came. A nine-year-old left all alone."

Listening to that, I felt a strange comfort. That someone stepped in, in a spot the Scales couldn't reach, even inside this exact, precise city. I thought, at the time, that this was an exception. I know now. It wasn't an exception — it was a different kind of arithmetic that this city had made for itself, in every spot the Scales could never finally reach.

Trope set the jar down and sat against the wall. I sat beside her.

"Aren't you angry?" I asked. "At the Scales."

Trope looked at me. Her expression shifted, for the first time, but it wasn't anger.

"Why would I be angry?" Trope asked back.

"…It took your mother."

"The Scales didn't take her," Trope said. "The Scales just did the math. It only calculated what my mother did."

"…Still, though."

Trope looked up at the sky for a moment.

"Because it was right," Trope said.

I had no answer to that.

"What my mother did — it was real," Trope went on. "The lies were real, the cheating was real too. I didn't know when I was little, but it came back to me piece by piece as I grew. I know everything the Scales counted. Every last piece of it. I'd like to say the Scales was wrong. I can't. All of it's true."

. . .

I felt something strange, standing in front of that.

I hadn't known, until then, that knowing the Scales is right and enduring the loss of your family to the Scales could exist inside the same feeling. I'd thought the two stood opposed. If it's right, you can bear it; if it's unjust, you get angry. Trope stood somewhere in between. Knowing it was right, and still, every day, that spot stayed empty.

"…You don't resent her?" I asked again. "Your mother."

"Resent her?" Trope asked back. "I know what she did wrong. But that's different from resentment. My mother did it to feed me. I know that too."

Trope pulled her knees up and hugged them.

"The Scales doesn't count reasons," Trope said. "It doesn't weigh reasons. It only weighs what was done."

. . .

That stayed with me a long time.

It was the first time I felt the Scales' precision as something frightening. For three years, I'd thought that precision made me safe. Precise meant nothing to feel wronged about. Sitting next to Trope, I first understood how narrow a thought that had been. Being precise and not feeling wronged were different problems. Trope's mother had been calculated with precision, and that calculation hadn't been wrong. And still Trope was left alone at nine.

I thought of my own family's story. Someone from the Reckoning had done something that ruined us. The Scales had calculated that precisely too. The disposition had come out precise too. I'd had no complaint about that disposition for a long time. Because it was precise. But that day, sitting next to Trope, I felt for the first time how thin that sentence had been. Precise, and yet nothing came back. Trope's words laid themselves exactly over my own old sentence.

"…I'm sorry," I said. I didn't know what I was apologizing for either.

Trope looked at me strangely.

"Why are you sorry, Had?"

I couldn't answer.

That was the first time I began to see one person of this city not as part of the city I hated, but simply as a person. It wasn't something I'd wanted. I kept wanting to bundle this city together as the number a hundred and twenty thousand, one mass. It was easier to hate that way. Trope kept slipping out of that bundle.

. . .

Trope suddenly changed the subject.

"Pheugon," Trope asked. "Was it like this back home? Someone getting pushed out."

I couldn't answer right away.

"…It was," I finally said. "Not often, though."

"Have you seen it? Someone getting pushed out."

I thought of the hundred and twelve cases. The sentence documents I'd read aloud myself. Several of them had ended in the exact same disposition as Trope's mother. Exceeded the limit, market access suspended, then pushed out. I couldn't remember a single one of their faces. I'd erased them. A hundred and eleven more times over.

"…Yes," I said. "I've seen it."

"How did it feel?"

I nearly told her the truth, right then. I'm the one who reads those sentence documents aloud, I nearly said. The words rose to my throat and I swallowed

them. Swallowing made everything inside me heavier. I didn't know, then, where that heaviness came from. I know now. It wasn't the weight of the lie. It was the weight of realizing, in front of Trope, for the first time, that I wasn't a bystander — I was the one who carried it out.

"…I don't know," was all I said.

Trope didn't press further. She just nodded and stood.

"Let's go. Need to draw water once more before dark."

. . .

We went back to the well. While Trope lowered the bucket, I sat on the coping stone and looked again at the spot she'd pointed to earlier. The place worn by a hand. A mark that hadn't disappeared in five years.

Looking at that worn stone, I thought: the Scales can't measure that. That's not weight. It's a mark time left behind, and the person who left it is nowhere in this city anymore. But the stone still testified that she had been there. I thought, for the first time, that things the Scales couldn't measure might be piled up like this all over the city. I didn't hold onto that thought for long. I wasn't ready yet to see what it meant.

The bucket came up. Trope poured the water into the jar and glanced my way.

"Why do you keep looking at that spot?"

"…It's nothing."

"That's not a nothing expression," Trope said, hoisting the jar to her shoulder. "Fine. I won't ask."

Every time she said that, I felt something strange. Trope was someone who didn't press. But not pressing, and knowing nothing — those were different things. I mistook the two for the same, at the time.

. . .

On the way back to the shed, the sun was sinking low. At the end of the alley, the plate that announced the days remaining came into view. Trope passed it without lingering on it. By now, so did I. Watching a number every day eventually does that to a person. I felt that as frightening for the first time that day.

Trope left first, and I sat alone in front of the shed, watching the sky darken.

"Because it was right." That one sentence followed me all through the night. I set it against my own story. When someone from the Reckoning wrecked our family, the Scales had calculated that too, precisely. The disposition had come out precise too. And yet I hadn't been able to say what Trope said, in front of that disposition. Because it was right. I'd never once put that sentence into my own mouth.

Trope could say it in front of the Scales that had taken her mother. I couldn't say it in front of the man who'd wrecked our home. The same sentence, but one of us lived by it while the other hadn't managed to swallow it in thirty-one years. I didn't know, that night, where that difference came from. I only knew clearly that the difference unsettled me.

And in that unease, I noticed one small thing more. I'd already been in this city for several days now. Under the name Had, helping with errands at the Scales, drawing well water, asking after an old man's health. I was becoming, little by little, a person of this city, day by day. And as I became that person, I kept forgetting the sentence I'd brought to this city, more and more often.

I didn't think, that night, that this was a dangerous thing. I know now. Forgetting and hiding are different things. I thought I was hiding my name. In fact I was forgetting myself. And of the two, the one that would hurt me more, in the end, was the second.

(Continued in Chapter 17.)

Chapter 17. The Herald

> *_Previously_ — Trope's mother had exceeded the weight limit and been pushed out of the city five years before. Trope didn't resent the Scales for it — "Because it was right." That sentence unsettled Pheugon for a long time; he'd never once been able to say the same about his own family's ruin, and for the first time he noticed he was becoming, little by little, a person of this city.*

Starting the next day, I took on one more job.

Trope hadn't asked for it. The old man had asked first. "Could use another pair of young hands." Carrying goods for the market stalls. I said I would. No other reason. It beat sitting in the shed just counting numbers.

I thought, at the time, that this was just a way to pass the hours. I know now. It wasn't. Doing that work, I began learning the names of this city's people, one by one. Learning a name means lifting a person out of a number into a person. I did that work every day without understanding, for a long while, what it really was.

. . .

The market work was simple. Helping set up the stalls in the morning, carrying goods, helping close up in the evening. The merchants knew I was a stranger, but within a few days they stopped minding much.

"Had." The vegetable seller called my name. Very naturally attached to me by now. "Move that sack over there."

I still reacted half a beat late every time someone called that name. Exactly as Trope had once pointed out. But lately that half-beat was shrinking, little by little. I thought it was only becoming familiar.

It wasn't that. It wasn't familiarity — it was dye taking. I didn't know the difference then. Growing familiar means adjusting only on the surface. Being dyed means that name becoming real from the inside out. I was becoming Had, little by little, every day, and Pheugon was receding by that same measure.

. . .

About a week into working the market, something like an incident happened.

There was a wooden board at the market entrance where the day's notices were posted. Well maintenance, ration schedules, things like that. That day an official came to post a new notice, but the person who usually read it aloud wasn't there.

"My throat's gone," the usual reader said beside the official, his voice hoarse. "I won't be able to read for a few days."

People had gathered. Everyone seemed curious what the notice said. The official looked briefly at a loss, then glanced around.

"Anyone here who can read?"

No one stepped forward readily. The people of this city didn't seem to enjoy standing up to represent something. I too stood still, up to that point.

Then a paper crossed in front of my eyes.

"You." The official looked at me. "You're young — you can read, can't you?"

I froze.

In that moment, I thought two things at once. One: no. The moment my voice slipped out, three years of training would show plainly. The way of not stopping, not catching, not holding my breath at a name. If I read in a way this city's people didn't know, someone was sure to ask what it was.

The other thought was scarier. In that moment, I already wanted to read. I wanted to hold the paper in my hands. I'd gone too long without doing the thing I'd done every day for three years.

I took the paper.

. . .

The content was nothing much. A notice that the west distribution station's hours were changing. A sentence composed by the Scales. Short and dry.

I took a breath. Then I read.

Without stopping. Without catching. Straight through.

Looking up when I finished, a few people were watching me with strange eyes. The official was one of them.

"…That's good reading," the official said. "Where'd you learn that?"

"…Nowhere," I said. "I've just read a lot."

Not a lie. But that not-quite-a-lie answer was, in its own way, a bigger lie. I was someone who had read a hundred and twelve cases. Shrinking that down to "I've read a lot" — in that very moment, I was erasing the weight of what I'd done, myself.

The official didn't ask further. I was relieved.

"Mind doing it again sometime?" the official asked. "Just until his throat's better."

I hesitated over my answer.

I should have refused, then. I know now. I had a hundred reasons to refuse. And yet I agreed. Why, I couldn't properly explain to myself, even that night.

"…All right," I said.

. . .

From then on, roughly every three days I stood in front of that board. I read the notices. Ration times, well maintenance, changes to market rules. All trivial sentences. And yet every time I read those trivial sentences, I felt something loosening, little by little, somewhere deep inside my body.

I didn't know what it was, at the time. I know now. I'd been trained into someone who couldn't live without using his voice. Reading a hundred and twelve cases, I'd thought that training had turned me from a person into a tool. But in this city, in a place where no one knew me as a herald, I began using that voice again. And when I found that the voice was still mine, I felt strangely relieved.

I wasn't a tool. I was just someone who happened to be good at reading. I hadn't known until then how much that distinction mattered.

One day the old man was listening to me read and said.

"Your voice, it's good," he said, leaning on his cane. "No anger in it, no rushing. Just pleasant to listen to."

I had no answer to that.

"Where'd you learn to read like that?"

I nearly gave him the true answer, standing in front of that question. At the herald training grounds, I nearly said. The words rose to my throat and went back down. I swallowed it that day too. But the swallowing felt different from before. Before, I'd swallowed it out of fear of being caught. That day — I'm not entirely sure, even now. Maybe it was a swallowing born of wanting to say it.

"…Just, ever since I was little," I said.

The old man nodded. He didn't ask further.

After that, people started coming to me first whenever there was something to read. I read distribution slips aloud for old people who couldn't read them, looked over contracts brought by unfamiliar merchants. Each time, I walked a little further into this city.

I thought this was kindness. Helping people who needed it. I know now. It wasn't just kindness. I was still doing, in the city I hated most, the thing I did best. Every time I did it, people trusted me a little more, and the more of that trust I received, the less able I became to go far from this place.

. . .

That week, one evening, the old man invited me to his table. Trope was there, along with the woman who couldn't see well and a couple of other neighbors. A small courtyard, a single table, everyone gathered around it.

"Sit, Had," the old man said. "There's extra food."

I first tried to decline. But Trope had already set a bowl in my place. There was nothing to do but sit.

The meal was quiet. This city's people rationed their words even at meals. But the quiet wasn't awkward. It was, instead, comfortable. I found that unfamiliar. Where I came from, someone's voice was always raised over the table. Here there was only the sound of spoons.

"Does Had have family?" one neighbor asked. A question tossed out without much thought.

I stopped mid-spoonful.

It was probably the simplest question at that table, that evening. Something everyone else would have let pass without a thought. Not for me. In front of that question, I thought of my house all at once, of the man from the Reckoning, of my scattered brother. And I swallowed all of it.

"…I'm alone," I said. This time, not a lie.

"Ah," the neighbor said. "That's how you drifted all the way here, then."

I didn't answer. Trope glanced at me and looked back at her bowl. As if trying to change the subject. But someone else spoke up first.

"Why'd you come to this city?" the old man asked. No ill intent. He always asked that way.

I sat there with no answer prepared.

It was at that table that I felt, for the first time, that lying to these people wasn't easy anymore. When I'd first told Trope "Had," there'd been no weight to it at all. Just a fake name thrown at a strange child. Lying now, at this table, in front of people who'd sat me down to dinner — that was an entirely different weight.

"…Passing through," I managed to say. "Just ended up staying."

The old man nodded. He didn't press further. No one did. This city's people respected each other that way. I thought I had no right to receive that respect — and yet I received it.

I would remember that table for a long time. The clink of spoons, the old man's laugh, the sound Trope made clearing the bowls. Listening to those sounds, I thought, for the first time: if this city disappears, these sounds disappear too. I couldn't hold onto that thought for long. It felt wrong to hold onto.

. . .

Nearly a month passed, and I gained a quiet place among this city's people. Had, who helps with Trope's errands. Had, who helps with errands at the Scales. Had, who reads the notices. People started attaching "that young man" instead of just "him" after my name. It meant becoming someone whose face was known.

I only thought that was good, at the time. I believed I was succeeding at hiding. But hiding was supposed to mean disappearing. Instead of disappearing, I kept getting filled in. A spot for me was slowly opening up in this city's fabric.

Later, much later, I would learn how dangerous those weeks had been. What I'd hidden was one name. But while hiding that name, I failed to hide something much larger. Myself. I had blended into this city, and someone who's blended in can no longer see that city as a single number. I didn't know that then. Nor did I know it would become the thing that hurt me most, later.

. . .

That evening, I stood a long while in front of the Scales terminal for the first time. I didn't raise my hand. I just stood, looking at that smooth surface.

I tried, that night, to bring back why I'd come to this city. The Reckoning. The sentence of demolition. Article Four, Clause Eleven. But those sentences no longer surfaced as vividly as before. Instead, the old man's voice, the vegetable seller's name, the way Trope hoisted a water jar onto her shoulder — things like that kept pushing into their place.

I was afraid of that. I'd come to hate this city. But to hate, I needed a faceless mass. Once faces began to appear one by one, hatred no longer stood as easily as it used to.

I first heard, that night, of a place called the room of records. The old man mentioned it in passing. "If you want to know why the Scales judges the way it does, go to the room of records behind the square. There's something called precedent, I hear, but I don't know much about it myself." The moment I heard that, I felt like I'd found something to hold onto.

Thinking back on it now, that wasn't an accident. I was afraid of myself, starting to be dyed into this city, and I was looking for a place to set the Scales up as my enemy again. The room of records was exactly the refuge I needed.

. . .

That night, before I fell asleep, I took out the sentence document I'd buried deep in my bag. It had been a long time. The oiled paper still bore the marks of water, but the lettering was intact.

The Reckoning. Sentence of demolition. Forty days.

I sat holding that paper for a long while.

I felt something strange in that moment. This paper was still the reason I'd fled. But that reason no longer burned the way it used to. I couldn't tell whether it had simply dulled, or was turning into something else. I know now. It hadn't dulled. I was already, by then, holding two feelings at once. The wish that this city would fall, and the wish to sit again at the old man's table. I learned for the first time, that day, that both feelings could live in the same person.

I wrapped the paper back in the oiled cloth and put it in the bag. Then I lay down.

I decided, that night, to go to the room of records the next morning. With the intention of finding a crack to bring the Scales down. But beneath that intention was another one I hadn't quite looked into myself. By finding that crack, I wanted to find a reason to hate this city again. A city that kept growing faces — I wanted to turn it back into a number.

That night I didn't know how differently those two feelings weighed. One was logic. The other was fear. That what I believed was logic was actually something fear had ordered — I wouldn't learn that until much, much later.

(Continued in Chapter 18.)

Chapter 18. The Room of Records

> *_Previously_ — Pheugon began reading notices aloud for the city, at people's request. Hiding his name, he was slowly woven into the city's fabric. He sat at the old man's table, and felt, for the first time, that lying was no longer easy. That night he heard, for the first time, of a place called the room of records.*

The room of records was behind the square, down three flights of stairs.

The next morning I headed there without a word to Trope. I didn't want to hear her ask where I was going. If she asked, I'd have to make up one more lie.

The air changed as I went down the stairs. The sounds of the square above grew fainter, and a cool, dry smell took their place. The smell of paper. The kind of smell that comes from a great deal of very old paper gathered together.

The moment I caught that smell, I felt strangely at ease. Paper smell had nothing to do with the Scales — just the smell of old things.

At the bottom of the stairs was a door. Wood, its handle worn pale from long handling.

I pushed it open.

. . .

The room was bigger than I'd expected. Shelves reached the ceiling on every wall, packed with scrolls and boxes. Several long tables stood in the middle,

papers stacked on those too.

An older woman sat at one end of a table. She wore glasses, and there were ink stains on her fingertips.

"New face," the woman said, looking at me over her glasses. Her eyes looked unusually large behind the lenses. "What are you looking for?"

I didn't know how to answer for a moment. *I want to know why the Scales judges this way* would have been too blunt.

"…I'm curious how the Scales decides sentences," I said. Not a complete lie.

The woman looked at me a moment longer. Then shrugged, as though it weren't a particularly surprising question.

"People like that come around now and then," the woman said, standing. "The precedent section. This way."

I felt relief, in that moment. I wasn't the only person in this city curious about the Scales. That fact made me, strangely, a little less lonely. Looking back now, that was a misunderstanding. The others were only curious. I wanted to bring it down.

. . .

The record-keeper led me to one shelf. Better organized than the rest.

"Precedent," the record-keeper said, pulling out a scroll. "The Scales doesn't just look at the current weight when it sets a sentence. It adjusts based on similar past rulings."

"…Based on them, how?"

"For instance." The record-keeper unrolled the scroll. "Say someone steals something. Whether that person later admits their wrong in their own words and makes amends, or denies it to the end — that doesn't register in this weight. Only the value of the stolen goods registers. But the Scales finds similar past cases, and it looks at how those cases turned out, and adjusts this sentence up or down a little accordingly."

I turned that over in my mind.

"So… who decides that? Whether a case is similar or not."

"The Scales," the record-keeper said. "The Scales does all of it. It compares sentences, calculates degrees of similarity. There's almost no room for a person to step in."

I understood, for the first time in that moment, a little more about where the Scales' precision came from. The Scales wasn't just weighing this one case. It carried the entire past on its back. This city's past, and the past of other cities too. I couldn't imagine how vast a memory that would be.

"Are there cases from other cities too?" I asked.

"Plenty," the record-keeper said, pointing toward the shelves. "The Scales trade records with each other. What ruling happened where, and what came of that ruling afterward. It all piles up here."

. . .

I spent that whole morning digging through the precedent records.

At first I didn't even know what I was looking for. I just read the Scales' sentences, over and over. Precise, dry, exceptionless sentences. Individual cases, shop disputes, quarrels between neighbors. All roughly the same

structure. Facts, grounds, disposition. Sentences with no room for feeling to enter. I'd read sentences like that for three years. But these ones here were written for a different purpose than the ones I'd read. What I'd read were sentences delivering a verdict aloud. These were sentences justifying the verdict to itself.

Around noon, I asked the record-keeper again.

"Are there any precedents where the Scales was wrong?"

The record-keeper's hand stopped. She looked at me for a long moment.

"What do you mean by wrong?" she asked back.

"…Where the sentence came out mistaken, or the grounds were mistaken."

"No," the record-keeper said. Firm. "Twenty years I've worked here, and I've never once seen a record like that."

"How would you check? Whether it's mistaken or not."

"There's no need to check," the record-keeper said. "The Scales is a calculating machine. Has a calculator ever gotten two plus two wrong? The Scales is the same. Correct input, correct output."

I found myself briefly at a loss in front of that answer. It had no gap in it. It was the first time I dimly sensed that what I was looking for wasn't a calculation error in the Scales. The calculation isn't wrong. Then the crack had to be somewhere else.

"…Input," I said. "The input could be wrong, couldn't it."

The record-keeper looked at me again. Longer this time.

"That," she said slowly. "Is a different question."

She paused a moment, choosing her words. Her gaze looked me up and down over the rims of her glasses.

"Young man, what are you looking for here." Her question, more direct than before.

I stiffened.

"…Nothing," I said. "Just curious."

The record-keeper didn't seem to believe that answer. She didn't press further, either.

"Whatever you're looking for," the record-keeper said, turning back to her papers. "There's one thing twenty years here has taught me. The Scales isn't wrong. That much is certain. Whether it's frightening or not, that doesn't change."

I held onto those words for a long time.

. . .

I held onto that sentence.

"Who does the input?"

"Records do," the record-keeper said. "Testimony, documents, witness statements. That's what people do. The Scales just takes it in and calculates."

"So if someone puts a wrong record in."

The record-keeper was silent for a moment.

"In theory," she said, carefully. "It's possible. But I've never seen a record of that actually happening. What comes in here all goes through review."

"Who reviews it?"

"The Scales," the record-keeper said. "The Scales again."

I felt something strange in that circle. A person makes the record, the Scales reviews the record, and the Scales sets the sentence based on that record. There was exactly one point in that circle where a person got to step in. The moment a record is first made. Only that moment is touched by a human hand.

I couldn't pin down that point precisely that day. I only left the room with a sense that it existed somewhere.

I decided one thing clearly, leaving that room. The Scales must waver somewhere. If I found where it wavered, I'd have in hand the words to bring this city down. I didn't know then how dangerous that resolve was.

. . .

That evening, Trope asked.

"Didn't see you today."

"…I went somewhere."

"Where?"

I stopped, briefly, in front of that question. A few days earlier, I would have made up a lie without a thought. That day was different. Piling one more lie on her suddenly felt heavy. I wasn't exactly sure why.

"…Just, here and there," I managed to say.

Trope looked at me a moment. Her eyes seemed ready to press further, but in the end she didn't.

"All right," Trope said. "You don't have to say if you don't want to."

She always said that. She'd said it since the first day we met. Every time, I'd felt relief. That day, it wasn't relief that rose in me — it was something else. I was stacking lies on this person, and she kept accepting them. That accepting made me heavier.

. . .

I went to the room of records for three days straight.

The record-keeper grew less wary of me than before. She stopped asking my name. She just called me "the student, there." I found that comfortable.

"I'd like to see records from other cities," I said on the second day.

The record-keeper glanced at me, then pointed toward a shelf much older than the others, further back in the room.

"There," the record-keeper said. "Not well organized. They come from many different cities, and each city has its own way of keeping records."

"Why? Why would records from other cities be needed here?"

"The Scales learn from each other," the record-keeper said. "It's rare for something to happen for the first time here in the Reckoning. Most things have already happened somewhere, once. So it references the outcome from elsewhere and fine-tunes this sentence."

"…Are those records accurate?"

"The Scales compiled them, so." The record-keeper said. But this time, her voice had lost a little of its earlier force. "Though — I can't be certain of that myself. The originals aren't kept here. The original record is received by that other city's Scales, and what's here is what's been reorganized into our Scales' format."

Something snagged in me at that.

"Reorganized — does that mean the wording could differ from the original?"

The record-keeper took off her glasses, then put them back on.

"Only the format changes," the record-keeper said. "The meaning doesn't. That's the Scales' principle."

Listening to that, I strangely wanted to believe it. That the meaning doesn't change. But the very fact that I wanted to believe it made me doubt it all the more. I couldn't explain why, at the time. I know now. I was too desperate to find a crack. Desperation often makes doubt look like the truth.

. . .

I couldn't sleep that night, holding onto that feeling. The Scales isn't wrong. The record-keeper had said so too, and I'd confirmed it myself over three years. Not one miscarriage among the hundred and twelve cases. But if the precedent the Scales relies on had already been altered, somehow, in the hands of whoever first recorded it — I couldn't think that sentence through to the end. The more I thought about it, the more my fingertips trembled.

I was already looking for something by then, without even knowing what exactly. Not a flaw in the Scales, but a flaw in the ground the Scales stood on. If that existed, it wouldn't be the Scales' fault — it would be the fault of whoever made that ground. I couldn't put into words, that night, why that

distinction mattered so much to me. I know now. I wanted to bring the Scales down. I didn't want to bring down the fact that the Scales was right. I couldn't distinguish, then, that those two things weren't the same.

I decided to go back to the room of records the next day. This time, I planned to start not with this city's own precedents, but with records that had flowed in from other cities.

. . .

On the third day, I sat in front of that old shelf all day.

Each box had a city's name written on it. Names I'd never heard before. On some boxes the lettering on the outside had faded so much the city's name couldn't even be read. I opened those boxes one by one. The texture of the paper, the handwriting, the way sentences were composed — all a little different from box to box. Some cities wrote much longer sentences; others were shorter and drier than ours.

Rifling through those boxes, I was overtaken by a strange feeling. This room held, compressed, the lives of cities I'd never once visited. Who had stolen what, who had cheated whom, who had been pushed out. All different names, different faces, but the same structure, over and over. I felt a strange exhaustion in front of that repetition. This whole world was weighing people with the same weight, in the same way.

The record-keeper passed by me around evening and said.

"You there — what are you looking at so hard?"

"…Nothing," I said. "Just browsing."

"Serious browsing," the record-keeper said. Some amusement in her voice. "Coming back tomorrow too?"

"…Yes."

"I'll mark the spot, then. No sense finding it all over again each time."

The record-keeper tucked a small slip of paper into the box I'd been looking at. I found that gesture, oddly, kind. *Looking back now, I know how strange that situation was. I was searching for a hole to bring this city down through, and this city's own people were helping me do it more easily. Without knowing any of it.*

. . .

I had no idea, then, what that would lead to. I was just looking for one crack. I believed that if I found it, I could hate this city again. I didn't know then how thin that belief was. Finding a crack wasn't going to make the old man's table disappear, or Trope's retreating back. I was just enduring day after day, holding both of them at once.

And three days later, I truly found it. A person's name was attached to it. Mena.

I didn't know, when I first saw that name, that it was even a person's name. It was just one of many characters written on the outside of the box. I had no idea, that day, how far that name would carry me, or what I would lose by the end of it.

(Continued in Chapter 19.)

Chapter 19. The Misquotation

> *_Previously_ — In the room of records, Pheugon learned that the Scales adjusts sentences based on past precedent. Records are made by people; the Scales only takes them in and calculates — he dimly sensed there was exactly one point where a human hand touched the process. Three days later he found a name on an old box. Mena.*

I headed for the room of records early that morning.

I found the spot the record-keeper had marked and opened the remaining boxes one by one. Most had city names on them, and inside, the large and small incidents from that city, arranged in precedent form. A few boxes held almost identical content. Someone who stole something, someone who couldn't repay a debt, someone who quarreled with a neighbor. Stories not much different, city to city.

I was growing tired in that repetition. I still didn't know what I was looking for. There was nothing to do but keep opening boxes until something caught.

Then, on the bottom shelf, in a spot less noticeable than the others, I found the small box.

The box was smaller than the others.

The writing on the outside was faded, but readable. Not a city's name. A single person's name, and beneath it, in small letters: "Original testimony."

I lifted the box off the shelf and set it on the table.

Until then I'd assumed every box carried a city's name. This one was different. It carried a person's name. I found that strange. Why was this one alone filed by name instead of city?

I opened the lid. Inside were a few sheets of paper, and a scroll far more worn than the rest. The paper felt so thin it might crumble at a touch. Dust came off on my fingertips.

. . .

I unrolled the scroll.

Handwriting. Not a sentence printed by the Scales. An honest but unpolished hand. There were even traces of having been written in haste.

A name was written at the top.

MENA.

I began reading the sentences beneath it.

It was testimony. Something about a certain city, a certain incident, and a person named Mena who'd been involved with it somehow. Exactly what the incident was, I couldn't fully make out — the writing broke off in places and had worn away with age. But the final paragraph had survived relatively intact.

> *I went to that person many times. I wanted to hear why he'd made that choice. Every time, he turned the conversation aside, or fell silent. On the last day I went to him, I asked. Why won't you say*

> *anything at all. He didn't answer.* ***This one never explained himself.*** *I am setting that down as it is. It is all I know.*

I read that sentence twice. The room was so quiet that even the sound of turning a page felt loud. The sentence hadn't changed by the third reading either.

This one never explained himself.

A simple sentence. An observation about someone. Not a judgment — just a fact. Mena hadn't written that the man was bad. She hadn't written whether he had repented or not. She had only written that he never explained.

. . .

I was about to put the scroll back into the box when I noticed there was more paper inside.

Printed paper. The format the Scales produces. A precedent summary.

I unfolded it.

The first line held a summary of the case. Same incident as the testimony I'd just read. Same date, same names involved. My eyes moved down.

I wanted to see how the Scales had summarized this testimony.

> *According to the testimony of witness Mena,* ***this one never repented to the end.*** *This is applied as a mitigating factor in future similar cases.*

I read that sentence and stopped there.

. . .

I laid the two sheets side by side in my hands.

The scroll read: *This one never explained himself.*

The precedent summary read: *This one never repented.*

I forgot to breathe, in that moment. The two sentences looked similar. As if only a few characters differed. But those few characters were saying something entirely different. "Never explained himself" was a statement about what the man had done. "Never repented" was a judgment about the man's heart. Mena had written only the first. But what survived in the Scales' record was the second.

I stood up from my seat and sat back down again. My hands were shaking. I kept straightening the two papers on the table, over and over, though they hadn't actually gone crooked.

I understood, immediately, what this meant. I'd spent three years confirming that the Scales never miscalculates. But this wasn't a matter of calculation. This was the material that had gone into the Scales, wrong, from the very start. Mena had said "he never explained himself," and the Scales had read it as "he never repented," and preserved that judgment, fixed in place, as a reference factor. And that reference factor was, by the record-keeper's own words, still adjusting the sentences of other cases, somewhere, at this very moment.

. . .

I cross-checked the scroll against the summary several more times. I wanted to be sure I hadn't misread something.

I hadn't. "Never explained himself" and "never repented" were unmistakably different sentences. The original held the first; the Scales' record held the second.

I fought the urge to run to the record-keeper.

I was, strangely, calm in that moment. The excitement, if anything, quieted me. For three years, reading a hundred and twelve cases, I'd lived leaning on the fact that the Scales had never once been wrong. That sentence was the pillar holding up my life. And now, in my own hands, I held proof of a crack in that pillar.

I began thinking, in that moment, about what I could do with this.

. . .

I searched further through the box. I wanted to know who Mena was, what city she was from.

Behind the testimony scroll was a short introductory paragraph. Worn away by half, but a few sentences remained legible.

> *…One who keeps records. Belongs to no city; travels between many, writing down what people say. Sees people from a place the Scales cannot reach, in a way the Scales cannot reach…*

I read that passage several times over.

It was the first time I imagined a person named Mena. Someone whose face and name I knew nothing of. And yet a single sentence she'd left behind was being used, after all this time, inside the Scales' grounds, with an entirely different meaning. I felt that was unjust. Whether I felt it was unjust on Mena's behalf, or on behalf of whoever that sentence had pointed to, I couldn't tell, at the time.

The record-keeper passed by and glanced at the paper in my hand.

"Looking at Mena's record?" the record-keeper asked. She looked surprised. "Not many people know about that one."

Her voice dropped slightly. I didn't miss that change.

"…Is it a famous record, normally?"

"Not exactly famous." The record-keeper shrugged. "There's talk. That Mena's records are scattered across several cities, and each one quotes them a little differently. I've only heard it as rumor myself. Never checked."

I went stiff at that.

"…Several cities? Not just here?"

"So they say," the record-keeper said. "Though that's not particularly strange, really. It's common enough for a record's format to shift a little as it passes between cities."

Listening to that, I was privately drawing a different picture in my head. It wasn't the format changing. It was the meaning changing. I thought, in that moment, for the first time, that this might not be a single simple mistake. If Mena's sentence had been misquoted not just in this city but elsewhere too, then the error was much older, and had spread much wider, than I'd assumed.

. . .

I copied both sentences onto a piece of paper. I was afraid I might not be able to see the original again.

Original: This one never explained himself.

Precedent: This one never repented.

Written out side by side, the difference stood even clearer. Explaining is an action. You can do it or not. Repentance is a matter of the heart. The very thing the Scales couldn't measure itself, the thing closest to what the Adjudicator called "direction." I knew the Scales couldn't weigh that on its own. And yet here, right inside the Scales' own grounds, sat a judgment about someone's heart, brazen. And it was a judgment the original testimony had never made at all.

I was certain, in that moment. This was the crack. If I brought this to the Adjudicator — no, if I told anyone about it before that — one of the Scales' grounds would collapse. And if that ground collapsed, other rulings built on top of it would shake along with it. For the first time, I felt like I had a clear plan.

I stayed drunk on that feeling all through the afternoon. For three years I had only ever been the one who read. The one who spoke someone else's sentence aloud. Now, for the first time, I felt like someone who knew more than the Scales did. That feeling was frighteningly sweet.

I didn't know, that night, how short-lived that certainty would be.

. . .

I noticed a small notation at the bottom of the precedent summary. A case number, and a list recording which other rulings had cited this case as a reference factor since. Not a short list. Ten-some lines of case numbers were laid out.

Looking at that list, a chill ran down my spine. This wasn't a single error attached to one person. Every case listed there might have received a slightly heavier sentence, on the grounds of that wrong sentence, "never repented." I hoped that even a few of them had happened right here, in this city. That would let me show that this error had already exercised real force, right here, in the very city I was standing in.

At the very bottom of the list was an item with the most recent date. I copied that case number onto my paper.

I didn't know. Where that number would take me. I just decided, that day, to follow it the next morning.

. . .

The record-keeper came to tidy up the room toward evening and saw me.

"Late again today," the record-keeper said. "Find anything?"

I hesitated for a moment.

"…No," I said. I quietly closed the box. "Just looking around."

The record-keeper nodded without much thought and went back to tidying.

I didn't feel guilty telling that lie, that night. Strange thing. I'd felt heavy in my chest every time I'd lied to Trope, these past days. But not in that moment. I believed I was doing something right. I learned, for the first time, that a lie

grows lighter in front of something right. I would learn later how dangerous that lesson was.

. . .

I met Trope at the well. Filling her jar, she caught sight of me and tilted her head.

"Your face looks strange today," Trope said. "Something good happen?"

I nearly let out a laugh.

"…Why?"

"Your steps are faster than usual," Trope said. "And you keep touching your chest. Hiding something?"

Only then did I realize I'd been unconsciously touching the paper inside my shirt.

"…It's nothing," I said.

I nearly told her, right then. I found proof that the Scales is wrong, I nearly said. I imagined, briefly, saying that in front of Trope. I couldn't picture what expression she'd make. I couldn't hold that imagining for long. Her mother's face kept overlapping it. Would the Scales being wrong be a comfort to Trope, or would it be something else. I didn't know.

"Strange one," Trope said, lifting her jar. She was smiling. "Well, you'll tell me eventually, I suppose."

Trope walked on ahead. I looked at her back for a moment, then followed.

I thought about that smile all that evening. In front of it, I felt the weight of the paper I was carrying, differently, for the first time. It was no longer evidence for me alone. That evidence was aimed at the very city Trope lived in. I pushed that fact aside, hard. Not yet, I told myself.

. . .

Walking home, I held the paper tight against my chest.

I didn't toss and turn that night, for once. In fact, I slept easily, for the first time in a long while. I believed I'd found something. Proof that the Scales isn't perfect. Holding that proof, I felt I could go back to seeing this city as a number. A city built on an imprecise calculation. What was there to be sorry about in that city's falling?

That was what I was thinking as I fell asleep. The next morning, I took the paper and went back to the room of records. This time, I intended to trace all the way through to how this precedent had actually been used in a real ruling. If I confirmed that ruling had come out wrong, I'd have solid proof.

I didn't know, then, that what I'd find at the end of that trail would be entirely different from what I was hoping for.

That night I read those two sentences aloud several times over. Never explained himself. Never repented. Every time I read them back and forth, the difference felt larger. Someone who never explained himself could simply be a quiet person. Someone who never repented was a sinner. The Scales — no, the Scales' grounds — was turning silence into sin. I stayed caught in that thought for a long while, and eventually fell asleep.

(Continued in Chapter 20.)

Chapter 20. And Yet the Verdict

> *_Previously_ — Pheugon compared Mena's testimony against the Scales' precedent record. Mena had written "This one never explained himself"; the precedent read "This one never repented." He found a list of other rulings that had cited this wrong sentence as a reference factor, and copied down the most recent case number.*

The next morning, I took that case number to the record-keeper.

"Can you find this number?" I asked.

The record-keeper looked at the number and raised an eyebrow slightly.

"This is a recent one," the record-keeper said. "Give me a moment."

The record-keeper went to another shelf and brought back a case file. A thick document. I took it and spread it on the table.

. . .

The case had happened here, in this city — the Reckoning.

I went stiff in that moment. I'd vaguely assumed this would be some other city's affair. It wasn't. Right here, in this very city, to a person of this very city, that wrong quotation had actually been used.

The first page held a summary of the case. The name was covered over. The record-keeper had explained to me once before that this city's precedent files

kept the names of those involved masked over. Instead there was a case number, a date, and the charge.

A fraud case from the market. A merchant who had cheated buyers repeatedly on prices, taking advantage. Multiple victims. Weight had accumulated close to the limit.

I turned the page.

The second page held the grounds for the sentence's calculation. And in that list of grounds, the very reference case I'd been looking for. Quoted verbatim.

> *…According to the referenced precedent, in similar cases where the accused "never repented to the end," the sentence tends to be increased. In this case as well, the accused refused to give a final statement, which is consistent with that tendency.*

I read that sentence and my fingertips trembled. I gripped the document so hard the corner of the page crumpled.

I was certain, in that moment. This was it. Because of this sentence, this merchant's sentence had grown heavier. The wrong quotation, "never repented to the end," had paired with this man's action of "refusing a final statement," and increased the sentence. I was watching that cause and effect with my own eyes.

. . .

I kept reading through the document, right there.

Why this merchant had refused to give a final statement — the reason was noted briefly on the next page. A memo left by a legal officer.

> *The accused acknowledges the act itself but refuses the statement procedure entirely. Reason unconfirmed.*

I paused for breath on that sentence.

Reason unconfirmed. I thought that phrase resembled, exactly, the situation Mena had testified to. The person Mena had met had "never explained himself, to the end" either. The reason was unknown. And here, that same reasonless silence had led straight into "never repented," and from there into a heavier sentence. I felt a chill at how naturally that chain had happened. No one would have felt anything strange about it. One sentence quietly turns into another sentence, that sentence quietly makes the punishment a little heavier, and no one ever notices.

I decided, in that moment, that I had to bring this to the Adjudicator — or anywhere at all. If I laid this document next to Mena's original testimony, side by side, it seemed like it would prove this case's sentence had been wrong. I pictured that scene in my head several times over. Laying the two sentences out before the Adjudicator, saying, "This is wrong." I hadn't thought past that point, what would happen next. I only imagined that far, and leaned on the imagining.

I felt happy, in that moment, for the first time in a while. Or something close to happiness, anyway. I'd spent my time in this city constantly feeling hunted. A name I had to hide, words I had to swallow, guilt that grew heavier, little by little, every day. But that moment was different. For the first time in a long while, I felt I was standing on the right side. A place where I knew more than the Scales. I didn't know, then, how briefly that place would be granted to me.

I didn't go straight back to the shed. I read the document once more from the start, right there. This time, not to find fault, but to make the evidence more solid. I was certain this error must have affected the other cases on that list too. If one was wrong, the other rulings built on it would shake as well. I thought that shaking might reach all the way to this city's own sentence of demolition. That evening, I genuinely believed that.

I stayed drunk on that thought for thirty minutes. I pictured not the city falling, but the city's sentence of demolition itself being voided. That the Scales' grounds were wrong, so the whole thing had to be recalculated — and then the forty days, the clause, none of it would matter anymore. I still had no idea how flimsy that picture was. I already believed I had won.

. . .

I read the document again from the start. This time meaning to make sure I hadn't missed anything.

The grounds for the sentence weren't a single line. Several items were listed. I went through them one by one.

1. Damage amount — a clear figure.
2. Number of victims — seven.
3. Repeated occurrence — at least three times, same method.
4. Confession — the act acknowledged.
5. Reference precedent — the "never repented to the end" tendency.

I circled item five. This was the error I'd come for.

I hadn't yet thought of one thing, at that moment. What items one through four, by themselves, were saying. My eyes were only on item five. That was what I'd come looking for. A person only sees clearly what he's looking for. The rest

passes like background. I didn't yet know, that day, that this background wasn't background at all — it was everything.

I kept reading. The next page showed how much weight the Scales had converted each of these five items into. I went through the numbers one by one.

Weight from the damage amount. Weight from the number of victims. Weight from repeated occurrence. And last, weight from the reference precedent.

I looked at that final number.

It was tiny.

. . .

I looked at the number again. Checked it, then checked again.

The weight added by the reference precedent item was an extremely small fraction of the total sentence. The first four items — damage amount, victims, repetition, and confession — had already brought the sentence, on their own, to almost the same point.

I tried, in that moment, to read the fact differently. Small is still something, I told myself. An error is an error. I clung to that thought. But the more I clung to it, the larger the other number looked.

I calculated it. What would happen if the reference precedent item were removed entirely, and the sentence recalculated from the remaining four items alone.

I knew the Scales' method of calculation. I'd learned it over three years, reading sentences like this. I copied the numbers onto paper and subtracted

and added them, one at a time.

The result came out.

Almost the same.

Only the tiniest difference remained. That difference wasn't large enough to decide whether this merchant would be pushed out of the city or not. With the reference precedent item or without it, this merchant would have received the same disposition.

. . .

I sat in front of that number for a long time.

I collapsed, in that moment. Silently, very quietly. I had come this far to prove the Scales was wrong. I believed I held that proof in my hands. But now, in front of my eyes, sat a different conclusion. The quotation was wrong. That's a fact. Mena had said "never explained himself"; the Scales had transcribed it as "never repented." That was an unmistakable error. And yet that error hadn't changed this case's outcome. Even without that error, on the strength of the other evidence alone, this merchant would have been pushed out just the same.

I saw, straight on, for the first time in that moment, what I had actually come here hoping for. I had wanted the Scales to be wrong. Only if the Scales were wrong could this city's fall remain a righteous thing. But the Scales hadn't been wrong. One quotation had gone bad, and that badness had changed nothing. I knew two things at once, in front of that fact. One: the crack I'd been looking for was real. The other: that crack couldn't bring anything down.

I flipped back through the document from the beginning again. In case I'd miscalculated somewhere. However many times I checked, the same

conclusion came out.

The Scales was not wrong.

Not even this time.

. . .

I looked at the disposition attached at the back of the document. Pushed out. A date was noted. I calculated the date. Not long ago. Very recently.

I realized something strange, in that moment. This merchant had been pushed out while I was already in this city. I'd passed through the market every day and never once known when it happened. A person quietly disappears, and by the next day some other stall fills that empty spot. I would have walked right past that spot. Without knowing.

I tried, for a moment, to bring back the faces I'd seen at the market. A gap between stalls — someone who'd been there a few days ago, now gone. I couldn't remember. I'd only just started learning this city's faces, not long enough yet to notice a face that had disappeared.

. . .

The record-keeper passed by and stopped when she saw my face.

"Are you sick?" the record-keeper asked.

"…No," I said.

"You don't look well."

"…I'm fine."

The record-keeper looked at me a moment longer, then, without saying more, went on.

I don't know how long I sat there in that room that day. I kept running the same calculation over. Remove one item, add it back. The result was the same every time. I tried to find a way to make it come out differently. There wasn't one. The numbers were honest. The numbers didn't lie for my sake.

. . .

I sat in that room late into the evening.

I first, dimly, felt a sentence that would come to run through this whole book. What is precise and what is right are different things. But I'd been mistaken to think that sentence would help me. I'd believed that sentence took aim at the Scales. That the Scales might only be precise, and not necessarily right. But now, the document in my hands was saying the opposite. One of the Scales' grounds hadn't been precise. And yet the Scales' conclusion had been right. That those two things could run apart from each other this way — I hadn't known that until that moment.

I'd found the misquotation. It was real. I hadn't invented it. But that error wasn't a key that could bring this world down. It was just an error. An error that changed nothing. I found that more frightening. If the Scales had been wrong, I could have taken hold of that wrongness and done something with it. But the Scales was wrong and right at the same time. In front of that, there was nothing at all I could do.

I thought, for the first time, differently about what the name of the Scales meant. The Scales measures weight. If the weight is correct, the Scales is right. Deciding right and wrong wasn't the Scales' job. But I had gone on

believing, all this while, that as long as the Scales was precise, that precision was rightness itself. Only holding this one document did I come to know, in my body, that the two were different.

. . .

I put the document back together and returned it to the box. My hands felt heavy.

I don't remember well the path I walked leaving that room that night. Whether I passed through the square, through the market, I'm not sure. But I remember one thing clearly. That was the first time I asked myself the real reason I'd started this investigation. I hadn't wanted to find the Scales' error. I had been looking for an excuse to hate this city again. And when that excuse collapsed this emptily, I lost the ground on which to build my hatred back up.

. . .

I didn't go find Trope that evening. I went straight to the shed. Wrapped in the blanket, leaning against the wall, I called back to mind that morning's happiness. It seemed absurd. Just a few hours before, I'd believed I'd found a new reason this city would fall. Now that reason lay scattered into a few numbers in my own hands.

I thought, for the first time, of my father's face. After the man from the Reckoning had left our house, the disposition the Scales had calculated and handed down. I had endured three years believing that disposition was precise. That old sentence — precise, and yet nothing came back — returned to me that night, wearing a different face. I now knew how precision and rightness differed. But that knowledge gave me no comfort at all. Quite the opposite. If the Scales was precise and right at the same time, then I had

nowhere left to lay the blame on the Scales. Whatever I could blame now had to be something other than the Scales.

I couldn't name what that something was, that night. I only sat in the dark for a long time. A darkness of the same kind as the darkness of the conduit that had trapped me for three days. Back then, water had risen to my knees; this time, nothing rose at all — and yet I felt just as short of breath.

And it was out of that darkness, still not having found my way clear of it, that I would meet the Adjudicator for the first time.

Looking back now, everything I truly needed to learn in this book was already there, that night. I believed that if I proved the Scales wrong, something would come loose. It took a single day to learn that belief was wrong. But what I truly lost, in that one day, wasn't evidence. It was the ground on which to build my hatred. Only after losing that ground did I understand how heavily I had been leaning on it, all along.

(Continued in Chapter 21.)

Chapter 21. The Adjudicator

> *_Previously_ — Pheugon found that Mena's misquotation had actually been used in one of this city's own rulings. But recalculated without that citation, the result was nearly identical. One of the Scales' grounds was wrong; its conclusion was right. He sat in the dark, having lost the ground on which to hate this city again.*

About ten days into my visits to the room of records, the record-keeper told me something.

"The Adjudicator's asking for you."

I nearly dropped the paper in my hand.

"…Me?"

"Who else would it be — you're the only outsider who comes here every day these days," the record-keeper said. Her tone suggested it was nothing much, but to me it could be nothing but a great deal.

Every kind of thought crashed over me at once, in that moment. Had he found out who I was. Or had he simply noticed an outsider rifling through precedents for too long. I had no way of knowing the answer. Only one thing was certain. I couldn't not go. Not going, in itself, would raise suspicion.

"Today?" I asked.

"Now," the record-keeper said. "He said to send you straight over once he'd seen your face."

I stood up without even tidying the box. Climbing the stairs, I thought several times about taking a roundabout route to the Adjudicator's office. A pointless thought. This city had few streets, and whichever way I went, I'd end up at the same door.

Climbing those stairs, I remembered something from my training days. The supervisor had once said that a herald's face is sent ahead to each city's administrator. I'd let that pass over me at the time. I thought it was a procedure that had nothing to do with me. That a picture of my face had already come to this city before I had — I hadn't even imagined that.

. . .

The Adjudicator's office was on the third floor of the Scales building, at the end of the corridor. I stood in front of the door and steadied my breath.

I knocked, and an answer came right away.

"Come in."

The voice was low and calm. I opened the door.

The room wasn't large. A desk, two chairs, a wall filled with filing cabinets. Through the window, the square was visible below. The plate announcing the days remaining was clearly visible from there too.

On top of the filing cabinet sat an old model of a scale. Too worn to be decoration, and too precisely placed to be something left there by neglect. Not a speck of dust on it. The papers on the desk were stacked with their edges squared. The moment I stepped into that room, I felt that its owner was someone who let nothing sit carelessly.

A man sat behind the desk. He looked to be about fifty. Half his hair had gone gray, and his eyes were deep. No sign of hurry in him.

"Sit," he said.

I sat.

. . .

He said nothing for a moment, just looked at me. That gaze felt strangely familiar. Not a judging look. A confirming one.

"I hear you've been coming to the room of records often," he finally said.

"…Yes."

"Going through the precedents."

"…I had something I was curious about."

"What's that."

I hadn't prepared an answer.

"…How the Scales judges," I managed to say.

The Adjudicator tilted his head slightly. He didn't look like he believed it. Nor did he press.

"You're not from this city," he said. Not a question — a confirmation.

I stiffened.

"…No," I admitted. There was nothing left to hide about that. It had already come out in front of Trope.

"Where are you from."

I hesitated again in front of that question. I couldn't say the real name of my city. But strangely, in that moment, a lie didn't come easily to my mouth. I tried to count how many times I'd already lied in front of this man. I couldn't count them. Already too many.

"…Somewhere far away," I said.

The Adjudicator showed little reaction to that answer.

. . .

He opened a desk drawer and took out a sheet of paper. Its edges shone from handling. He didn't turn it toward me. He just set it in front of himself and looked down at it.

"There's a roster of the herald assigned to come to this city," he said. "Whole-city cases are special — we get advance notice too. Name and face. Expected arrival date."

I forgot to breathe.

"That herald," the Adjudicator continued, "never came on the scheduled day."

The room went quiet.

I looked, in that moment, for somewhere to run. The door was behind me. The window was three stories up. I couldn't go anywhere. I could only sit, and wait for whatever he said next.

The Adjudicator looked at me again. There was still no anger in his eyes, no sharpness of interrogation. Just something he'd been carrying for a long time.

"You," he said.

. . .

I said nothing. I could neither deny it nor confirm it. My body froze where it sat.

"Don't be alarmed," the Adjudicator said. His voice softened a little. "I didn't call you in to report you."

"…How did you know."

"The face," he said. "There was a sketch attached to the roster. Not an exact likeness, but the features matched, well enough. And when I heard about a person who wasn't from this city, going through the precedents day after day, I didn't think that was a coincidence."

I felt a strange emotion, in that moment. Fear was the largest part of it, but beneath it was something else. Something close to relief. For weeks, I hadn't been able to show my true self to anyone. And this man already knew. Knew, and hadn't reported me. Why that fact should put me so strangely at ease — I couldn't explain it, then.

"…Why aren't you reporting me," I finally asked.

The Adjudicator put the paper back in the drawer.

"What would reporting change," he said. "If I caught you and forced you to read — would that be a proclamation? That wouldn't be a proclamation. Just sound on paper."

I didn't fully understand what that meant, at the time.

I didn't notice, then, the speed at which his hand closed that drawer. Not hurried, not forceful. A gesture as if whatever was inside that drawer had nothing to do with his own feelings. I only learned later that this wasn't restraint — it was habit. He had probably closed that drawer with that same motion, countless times, for years.

. . .

"What's your name," the Adjudicator asked. "Your real one."

I hesitated for a long time.

"…Pheugon."

The Adjudicator mouthed the name once, silently, without sound. As if confirming a name he already knew.

"Pheugon," he said again, this time aloud. "Good. I'll call you that."

"…To Trope, I'm still Had."

"That's your business, not mine," the Adjudicator said. No reproach in the tone.

I felt, in that moment, for the first time, that I didn't need to hide in front of this man. The first time in weeks. I only realized later, looking back, how tense my body had still stayed all the way until I left that room.

. . .

"Why did you call me here," I asked. "Just to tell me you're not reporting me?"

The Adjudicator glanced out the window for a moment. The plate in the square was visible.

"No," he said. "I wanted to see what kind of person you were."

"…Why?"

"A whole-city case is rare," he said. "This is the fourth one since I've sat in this chair. And all four times, the herald ends up sitting in that chair over there. Eventually."

I didn't fully understand what he meant.

"Has this city had this happen before?" I asked. "A herald not coming."

The Adjudicator was quiet for a moment.

"It has," he said.

"…What happened?"

"That's enough for today," he said. I felt that this was a way of avoiding the answer. But that avoidance felt, oddly, more careful than irritating. As if he'd judged that I wasn't ready yet to hear it.

"Why did you go through the precedents," the Adjudicator asked, changing the subject. "You said you wanted to know how the Scales judges."

"…Yes."

"Did you find anything."

I hesitated a moment, unsure how much to say, then opened my mouth.

"…I found an error," I said. "But the conclusion didn't change."

The Adjudicator's expression turned interested, for the first time.

"Is that so," he said. "That's a good find."

"…A good find? Nothing changed."

"Nothing changing is the finding," the Adjudicator said. "Everyone assumes that if the Scales is wrong, something must come apart. Now you know it doesn't."

I didn't fully grasp the weight of that, at the time.

"That's enough for today," the Adjudicator said, tidying his papers. "I've learned your face now. That's enough."

I stood. I walked toward the door, then turned back.

"…Why do you leave someone who's run away alone?"

The Adjudicator looked at me. A long look.

"That," he said. "I'll tell you next time."

"…One more thing." I asked again, hand still on the door handle. "What happens now. Since I didn't come."

The Adjudicator's expression shifted, slightly, for the first time. Only for a moment.

"That's the Scales' business," he said. "The Scales doesn't stop just because one person didn't come. It finds a way."

"…A way?"

"That's enough for today," the Adjudicator said. I felt, from his tone, that there was no more room to press.

"Go on," he said, turning his eyes back to his papers. "You may keep going to the room of records. I won't stop you."

I opened the door and went out.

I turned that phrase, "it finds a way," over and over in my head, walking down the corridor. I didn't know, then, exactly what it meant. I only left that building carrying a vague unease.

. . .

Out in the corridor, I felt my legs shaking.

Leaving that room that day, I realized for the first time that I wasn't entirely alone in this city. I didn't know, then, whether that was a comfort. Having one more person who knew me also meant one fewer place to hide.

I thought for a long time that night about the air of that room. The Adjudicator's gaze, that calm. He hadn't judged me. And yet strangely, that calm had felt heavier than any judgment. I didn't understand why, at the time. I know now. He hadn't judged me because he hadn't judged me — he had already, before me, watched three people like me. Those three memories had settled, unmoved, behind his calm.

And I would hear, not long after, about that third person.

. . .

I didn't go straight to the shed. I walked across the square. My feet carrying me I didn't quite know where.

Trope was at the well. Drawing the evening water. She saw me and waved.

"Had," she called. I still answered to that name. She didn't know that, a few minutes before, in another room, I'd been called by another name.

"…Yes," I answered, walking over.

"Where'd you go? Haven't seen you since midday."

I stopped, in front of that question. I had just given my real name to the Adjudicator's face. Not half an hour after saying that name, I had to answer again under the fake one.

"…The Scales office," I said, half the truth. "I had business there."

"What kind of business at the Scales office?" Trope asked. An unsuspecting question.

"…Nothing much," I said again.

Trope looked at me a moment, then laughed.

"That again," she said. "Fine. I won't ask."

In front of that laugh, I felt, for the first time, something I could barely bear. She was trusting me. By not asking. And the larger that trust grew, the heavier the weight of the lies I was carrying grew alongside it. That day, I had shed my name in front of the Adjudicator and had to put it back on in front of Trope. Moving between the two, for the first time, felt exhausting.

. . .

That night, lying in the shed, I called the Adjudicator's gaze back to mind.

He had recognized me. And hadn't caught me. He hadn't yet told me why. I wanted to know the reason. Was it simple pity? Or something else? He'd said, "the herald ends up sitting in that chair, eventually." I couldn't tell what that meant. Only, from his tone, I could feel that he'd watched several people like me, before me.

I thought, for the first time that night, that I might not be the only person who had ever fled in this city. That thought made me feel a little less alone. And, at the same time, more afraid. If I wasn't the only one who had fled, where were they now? I would come to know the answer to that question soon enough.

I admitted one more thing, for the first time, that night. Leaving the Adjudicator's room, I had felt, oddly, lighter rather than more afraid. Being found out had made me lighter. Hiding takes strength. I had been spending that strength for weeks, and now that it was no longer needed in front of one person, at least, I understood, only then, how exhausted I had been.

(Continued in Chapter 22.)

Chapter 22. Why You Ran

> *_Previously_ — The Adjudicator summoned Pheugon for the first time. He already knew Pheugon was the herald who'd been assigned to this city and never arrived, but he didn't report him. "The herald ends up sitting in that chair, eventually." Pheugon was gripped by the thought that he might not be the only one who had fled.*

For three days, I walked past the Adjudicator's office several times.

I didn't go in. I had no good reason to. Unless the Adjudicator called for me first, I'd have to make up my own reason to go to him.

I couldn't explain to myself, those three days, why I kept walking that corridor. I already knew that in front of that one man, I didn't have to hide. And that knowledge kept pulling me back toward that door.

On the fourth day, I finally knocked.

. . .

Over those three days, Trope noticed I was preoccupied with something.

"You've been strange lately," she said the second evening, carrying a water jar. "Talking less. Seem to keep drifting off somewhere."

"…That obvious?"

"You can see it," Trope said. "I've lived alone long enough — I can tell that kind of face on sight."

I had no answer to that.

"Well, you don't have to say if you don't want to," Trope said again. I'd lost count of how many times she'd said that by now.

That phrase landed unusually heavily that day. In front of the Adjudicator I could set my name down; in front of Trope I was still wearing it. In those three days, moving between the two of them, I first truly felt how exhausting it is to carry two faces inside one person.

On the third night, I finally decided. I would go back to the Adjudicator and hear whatever he hadn't finished saying last time. I didn't know myself what I would hear. Only that the fact that in that room alone I didn't have to hide kept pulling me back to that door.

. . .

"…Why are you back," the Adjudicator asked, lifting his eyes from his papers. Not a dismissive tone.

"…I had something to ask."

"Sit."

I sat. Less trembling than last time. Still, my palms sweated.

"What's your question."

I'd prepared a question in advance. But sitting there in front of him, an entirely different one came out.

"…Why did you run away," I asked him, instead.

The Adjudicator's eyebrows lifted slightly.

"That's what I want to ask you," he said.

I went stiff at that.

. . .

"…Are you asking me, right now?" I asked back.

"I'm asking," the Adjudicator said, crossing his arms. "Since you brought it up first, I'll ask you the same thing right back. Why did you run away."

The room went quiet.

It wasn't that I hadn't expected that question. I'd known someday I would be asked it. But now that the moment had actually come, I realized I had no prepared answer left standing.

"…I was afraid," I managed to say.

The Adjudicator looked at me.

For a long time.

The air in the room didn't move at all. Outside the window, laborers carrying something made a faint sound that faded away. The Adjudicator didn't even seem to blink. I wanted to look away from those eyes, but strangely, my feet stayed rooted to the spot.

. . .

The silence went on. In that stretch of time, I imagined several times what he might say. That he'd press harder. Or pretend to believe me. Neither happened.

I have turned that silence over, countless times, in the days since. I learned, that day, for the first time, that there are different kinds of silence. Some silences are empty. Some are full. His was the latter.

"You," he finally said, slowly. "That isn't the face of someone afraid."

I lost my breath at that. A cold feeling deep in my throat. Nothing physically wrong, and yet I'd forgotten, for a moment, how to breathe.

"…What do you mean by that."

"I've watched people a long time," the Adjudicator said. "A frightened person's eyes waver. The voice cracks, the hands don't know where to go. You didn't waver your eyes just now, saying that. Your hands stayed still too."

I looked down at my hands. He was right. They weren't shaking.

"…So what if they were," I said. My voice rose a little. "People are afraid in different ways."

"Could be," the Adjudicator conceded readily. "But I saw something in your eyes besides fear."

"…What."

The Adjudicator didn't answer. He just kept looking at me.

. . .

I wavered, in that moment, for the first time. For three years, I'd had exactly one answer for myself, about why I'd run. Afraid. That answer wasn't one I'd

made. It was an answer that had simply attached itself to my mouth, naturally, from the day after I ran. I'd used that answer, unquestioned, in front of Trope, and in front of myself. But the first time I spoke that answer aloud, in front of the Adjudicator, I felt for the first time how thin it sounded.

"…I'm a fearful person," I went on. Defensively. "I was like that back at the training grounds too. Everyone said so."

"Said what."

"…That I never stop reading, no matter what. My supervisor said so."

The Adjudicator tilted his head slightly.

"Someone who never stops reading," he said. "Ran away out of fear?"

I couldn't answer.

In that moment, for the first time, I saw the contradiction myself. For three years, I had never once stopped, reading. I wasn't someone who stopped from fear. And yet, faced with the single greatest proclamation of all, I hadn't even read it — I'd fled. How could those two things live inside the same person. I put that question to myself, for the first time, in that room.

. . .

"…I don't know," I finally said. "Sometimes I don't know myself why I ran."

"A lie," the Adjudicator said quietly. Not an angry voice.

I looked at him.

"…What?"

"I said it's a lie," he said again. "You know. Yours isn't a face that doesn't know. It's only that you're not yet ready to say it aloud."

I didn't know how to argue against that. I wanted to argue. But no words came to argue with. Because he was right. I already knew something, in that moment. I couldn't put it into an exact sentence, but I was certain that something sat there. I was straining every muscle in me not to open it.

"…What do you think I know," I asked.

"I don't know that," he said. "Only you know that. I've only seen, on your face, the face of someone who already knows the answer."

The room went quiet again.

The Adjudicator nodded. He didn't press.

"It's all right," he said. "You don't have to know it right away. There were plenty of things I didn't know at first either."

"…Have you ever run away, Adjudicator?"

The Adjudicator laughed briefly. A bitter laugh.

"I've never run," he said. "Instead I've sat in this chair for more than thirty years, watching people who ran. I'm not even sure, myself, how different that is from running."

I had no answer to that.

"You," the Adjudicator asked again. "What did they teach you, in your training?"

"…How not to stop," I said. "How not to listen. How not to catch on a name."

"Why learn that?"

"…So I could read without feeling. So no name, no disposition, could shake me."

The Adjudicator nodded.

"But," he said. "Right now, in this room, you're shaking, in front of me. That reaction doesn't happen to someone untrained. You're someone very well trained. And yet a person like that — why did you fall apart, of all places, in front of this city?"

I found myself at a loss again, in front of that question.

"…I don't know," I said again. This time, truly not knowing.

"You might not know," the Adjudicator said. "I'm not demanding an answer from you today, either. I just don't want to watch you keep lying to yourself."

The Adjudicator glanced out the window for a moment. The plate in the square was visible. That day's number was one less than the day before.

"If there's one thing I've learned in this chair," he said, looking back at me. "It's that a person never knows why they ran, at the moment they run. They find out later, much later, in some entirely different place. And not even because they wanted to know — they come to know it whether they want to or not."

"…How do you know that, Adjudicator?"

"Because I've watched it three times," he said, curtly. "Three people fell apart in front of this very chair. All three only understood why, later. Only one of them had time enough to tell me."

My ears sharpened at that.

"…Who was it?"

The Adjudicator didn't answer. He only glanced toward the drawer for a moment, then looked back at me.

"That story," he said. "When it's time, I'll tell it. Not today."

. . .

"May I ask one more thing," I said.

"Ask."

"…What happens if I don't read it? This city."

The Adjudicator's expression stiffened slightly.

"You said last time that the Scales finds a way even without a person," I continued. "What does that mean?"

The Adjudicator was silent for a long while.

"Another herald comes," he finally said. "The Scales reassigns. That's the way."

"…When that person comes, do they read it in my place?"

"They do."

"Then what about me? Do I just— become as if I never happened?"

The Adjudicator looked at me for a long time.

"That," he said, "you'll come to know. That's as far as I can tell you today."

. . .

"…Thank you," was all I said, standing.

"Pheugon." The Adjudicator called my name.

I turned back, hand still on the door handle.

"That thing you said, that you ran because you were afraid," he said. "I don't believe it. But I know you want to believe it. How frightening that difference is — you'll come to know that too, someday."

I gave no answer and opened the door.

I left that room without being satisfied by that answer.

That day, walking the corridor, I chewed on those words the whole way. "That isn't the face of someone afraid." That single sentence kept colliding inside me. I wanted to deny it. I tried to find grounds to deny it. I couldn't find any. I truly, in that moment, hadn't known myself what expression had been on my face.

Up to that point, for three years, I had believed I was a child who didn't get angry. I'd told myself the difference — not that anger didn't rise in me, but that I chose not to show it — and I'd believed I understood that difference. But in front of the Adjudicator, I saw the back side of that sentence for the first time. What if it wasn't that I didn't show anger, but that I was storing it somewhere. What if I hadn't run out of fear, but for some other reason.

I didn't manage, that day, to learn what that other reason was. I only felt, for the first time, that everything I'd believed I knew about myself wasn't certain at all. It was a strange sensation. Not the ground shaking — realizing the ground I'd been standing on had never been where I thought it was, to begin with.

. . .

On the way home, I chose a long way around on purpose.

I didn't cross the square. I turned down several narrow alleys instead. I didn't want to run into anyone. Not Trope, not the old man, no one.

Walking that road, I went back over my three years again. I was a child who never did wrong. Not that anger didn't rise, but a child who chose not to show anger. I'd been proud of that distinction. But one question from the Adjudicator had shaken the whole distinction. Not showing anger, and storing anger somewhere — those were different things. I might have mistaken the two for the same thing, all my life.

Walking, I remembered the day I first heard the name of the Reckoning. In the supervisor's office, receiving the document, laughing. I called that laugh relief. Silent, and very brief. That night too, I called that laugh back to mind again. And for the first time, I asked myself whether it had really been relief. If it was relief, relief from what. I left the alley without answering that question.

By the time I reached the shed, night had already fallen deep. I sat wrapped in the blanket, leaning against the wall, and turned the Adjudicator's last words over again. *I just don't want to watch you keep lying to yourself.* I didn't know, at the time, why that sentence stayed with me so long. I know now. It was a kind of sentence I had never once heard before. Not scolding me, not comforting me — and seeing me, exactly, for what I was.

I stayed inside that unsettling all night, before I fell asleep. I kept thinking of that third person. The one whose name the Adjudicator still hadn't given me. I tried to imagine where that person might have gone, what face they might be living with now. I couldn't quite picture it. I didn't yet know how much that person resembled me.

And the next day, still carrying that unsettling with me, I went out to the square — and saw, for the first time, a person who never got angry.

(Continued in Chapter 23.)

Chapter 23. The Man Who Does Not Get Angry

> *_Previously_ — The Adjudicator told Pheugon he was lying to himself. "That isn't the face of someone afraid." For the first time, Pheugon felt the things he'd been certain about himself begin to shift. He carried that unsettling with him out to the square the next day.*

The next morning, I was cutting across the square toward the market.

An ordinary morning, no different from any other. People walked, carried water jars, opened their stalls. The plate announcing the days remaining hung as high as ever.

My steps were slower than usual, that morning. The unsettling from the night before still hung in my legs. I learned, that day, for the first time, that there are days when even walking feels like an effort.

Leaving the shed, I ran into Trope. She was on her way to fill her jar.

"You look a little better today," Trope said.

"…Do I?"

"Better than yesterday, at least." She shrugged. "I won't ask what happened. But looking better's a good thing, so."

I laughed a little at that. Only I knew that "looking better" wasn't quite accurate. I had only shaken through the night, and by morning grown a little used to the shaking.

Trope's words felt strangely comforting to me that morning. Someone saying I looked better also meant someone had kept watching me. I found that gaze both a burden and, at the same time, a comfort.

Trope went off her own way soon after. I kept walking, across the square, toward the market.

The square was slowly warming under the morning sun. I could feel the stone underfoot growing warm. The smell of baking bread drifted from somewhere, and people carrying yoke-poles of water passed by at a steady pace. An ordinary morning.

Then, on one side of the square, I saw people gathered. Not a few. More than twenty, it looked like. All fixed on one spot, their voices raised.

. . .

I went closer, curious what was happening.

A man stood at the center. Worn clothes, a small sack in his hand. People surrounded him, shouting.

"That man stole it!" a woman shouted. "I saw it with my own eyes!"

"I didn't steal anything," the man said. His voice trembled. "This is mine."

"Don't lie!" another man cut in. "That sack — I saw it at that stall earlier. Same exact shape."

The voices grew louder. Some people pointed fingers; some stepped closer, one foot at a time. The man clutched the sack tight against his chest and backed away. Dust rose faintly under his feet, and a few shoes scraped against the stone.

I felt an unfamiliar emotion, watching that scene. I hadn't once seen people raise their voices like this since coming to this city. A quiet, precise, unhurried city. And now that quiet was completely broken.

I found myself thinking again, in that moment, about where this city's quiet came from. I'd assumed it was because of the Scales. Every action left a weight, so people were careful even about raising their voices, about getting angry. But what I was watching now was flipping that thought on its head. Even with the Scales, people could fall apart in an instant. Fear of weight was no match, in the end, for the urge to corner someone.

. . .

"I didn't steal it," the man said again. Nearly in tears now. "This is my son's. I bought it for his birthday."

"Then why'd you try to run?" someone shouted. "If you didn't steal it, why were you trying to run?"

"Look at his eyes, that's the look of a thief!" another voice cut in. The man had no answer, just clutched the sack tighter.

"…I was afraid," the man said.

I froze at that answer. *I was afraid.* The exact same word I'd said in front of the Adjudicator, four days earlier.

I felt a strange awareness in that moment. Was that man using that word as a shield, like me — or was he saying it because he really was afraid? I couldn't tell. Only, that word rang unusually loud that morning.

The people seemed angrier at that answer. Someone shoved the man's shoulder. He staggered back.

. . .

I stood frozen there, not knowing what to do. No courage to step in, no heart to simply pass by. I just stood behind the crowd, watching.

I realized, in that moment, that I was watching this scene the way three years of training had taught me. Not engaging emotion, only confirming facts. Whether this man had really stolen it, or was being unjustly cornered — I was trying to judge it the way the Scales would. But the Scales wasn't here, in this place. All that filled this space was people's voices alone. I felt, for the first time, how dangerous a vacuum that was. When people judge each other in a place with no Scales, there's no margin of error checked against anything at all.

An old woman, at the edge of the crowd, waved her cane at the man.

"People like this are why our city's come to this!" the old woman shouted. "Days running out, and still stealing!"

A few people murmured in agreement. I found that strange. No one had yet actually proven this man had stolen anything. And yet people were already tying him to the whole city's sin.

Then, one person caught my eye.

A man standing at the edge of the crowd. Empty-handed. It was rare, in that square, to see someone standing with nothing in their hands. Most everyone carried a jar, a basket, a tool. He wasn't raising his voice like the others. Wasn't pointing fingers either. He simply stood there, quietly watching the man being cornered.

I thought, the first time I saw him, that he was just another passive onlooker. This city had plenty of those. People who didn't involve themselves in others' business.

But something was different.

. . .

The other onlookers had no anger, but they also had no expression — they looked uninterested. He was different. He was clearly watching the disturbance. Watching the man, the sack, the crowd closing in — watching all of it, one by one. But there was no anger on his face.

Not indifference. I sensed that difference dimly, in that moment. An indifferent person looks away. He didn't look away. He simply — wasn't angry.

I looked at that face for a long time. Strangely, I couldn't take my eyes off it. Why, I couldn't explain then, and can't fully explain now. Only that it was the one face in that square of a different kind.

His clothes weren't anything special. Ordinary city clothing, not much different from anyone else's. His age was hard to guess. At times he looked much older than me; other times, not old at all. I couldn't find a single distinguishing feature on that face. The only thing I could find was that expression — that stillness.

. . .

The disturbance didn't last long. An official heard the noise and came running.

"What's going on here!" the official shoved through the crowd.

Several people spoke at once. The official raised a hand for quiet.

"Hand over the sack," the official said to the man.

The man held out the sack with a trembling hand. The official opened it and checked inside. A small wooden toy was inside.

"…Where'd you get this?"

"I made it," the man said. "My son's birthday's the day after tomorrow."

The official looked a little more inside the sack, then turned to the stall owner standing nearby.

"Did this man take your goods?"

The stall owner glanced into the sack and shook his head.

"…No. All my goods are here. I must have been mistaken."

. . .

The crowd dispersed, one by one. No one apologized. The very people who had just been shouting walked off in their own directions, as if nothing had happened.

The man held the sack to his chest again and walked away with his head down. No one saw him off.

I felt anger, watching that scene. Anger that people had cornered a man on no grounds at all, and anger that they'd scattered as if nothing had happened. I knew where that anger came from. I knew, better than most, how a baseless judgment can break a person. I had stood, for three years, on the side that delivered such judgments.

But that anger felt strangely familiar. I'd felt something like it somewhere before. In front of the Adjudicator, in the moment I myself had shaken, there'd

been something similar there too. I couldn't say exactly what it was, at the time. I know a little more now. I was someone who got angry in front of injustice. Very precisely, too. Only, that anger always tilted in one direction. It burned hot in front of an injustice done to someone else, and went quiet in front of an injustice I myself was committing.

I looked around for that man again — the one who hadn't gotten angry.

He was already walking toward the wronged man. Said a few words. I couldn't hear what. The distance was too far.

The man briefly lifted his head. Then walked on again. The one who hadn't gotten angry stood there a moment longer, then walked off on his own way.

. . .

That was all I saw of him, that day. I didn't know his name, and had no expectation of seeing him again. I just thought he was a strange man. The one person, in this whole city, who didn't get angry where anger belonged.

I had no idea, then, who that man was. I know now. What I saw that day was one of the most important scenes in this entire story. And I didn't notice it at all. I simply walked past him. Only his face, strangely, stayed lodged in my mind a long while after.

. . .

That evening, the old man brought up the disturbance, as if he'd already heard about it.

"There was some trouble in the square, I hear," the old man said, leaning on his cane. "A toymaker nearly got mobbed."

"…Did you see it?"

"No, I heard about it," the old man said. "Doesn't happen much in this city. Something's off in the air lately."

"…Off, how?"

"Fewer days left," the old man said, glancing toward the plate with his chin. That day's number hung low. "When people get anxious, they want to grab hold of someone, anyone, and get angry at them. I was the same at that age."

I listened, and called back that face from the square. The one who hadn't gotten angry.

"…There was one person there who didn't get angry," I said. I didn't quite know myself why I brought it up. "Everyone was shouting, but not him."

The old man looked at me for a moment.

"What did he look like?"

I tried to picture that face. Strangely vivid. But trying to put it into words, there was nothing particular about it at all. Common clothes, common build, common gait.

"…Just ordinary," I said. "But his face stays with me, strangely."

The old man nodded. An empty sort of nod.

"There are people like that in this city, now and then," the old man said. "People who don't get angry. I've seen a few myself. Why, I don't know."

"Why's it odd that someone doesn't get angry?" Trope broke in suddenly, from where she sat eating. She was there at the table that evening too.

"…Not that it's odd," the old man said. "That it's rare. In this city, someone who doesn't get angry is either someone who's never done wrong — or someone else."

"Someone else?" I asked.

The old man shrugged.

"That, I don't know either," he said, laughing. "The older you get, the more there is you don't know than do."

I laughed off that answer. At the time, I didn't take it deeply to heart.

I didn't press further, hearing that. I thought, then, that it was just one of this city's ordinary oddities. I didn't see that man again for a while, after that day. But strangely, that face alone didn't fade, even as days passed.

. . .

I turned back toward the market. Work was still waiting for me that day.

I kept thinking of that face all through the day's work. I couldn't explain why he hadn't gotten angry. It wasn't cowardice. A cowardly person avoids the place entirely. He hadn't avoided it. He'd watched it through to the end. Only, no anger.

I'd never once seen that combination before. A face watching without fear, and yet not angry. I hadn't known that was possible. I'd lived thinking that not getting angry meant looking away. If you don't look, you don't get angry. He hadn't looked away, and still, no anger had risen in him.

I sketched that face over again, several times, that evening, in my mind. It didn't last. The day's other events kept overlapping it. The Adjudicator's

words, Trope's laugh, the two sentences I'd found in the room of records. That night, before falling asleep, I called that face to mind one last time, and then, in the end, let it go. I wouldn't call it back until much later, in an entirely different place.

And three days later, I'd hear an entirely different piece of news, in front of that very plate in the square.

(Continued in Chapter 24.)

Chapter 24. Another Herald

> *_Previously_ — In the square, a man was cornered as a thief on no evidence at all. Everyone else was angry; one person alone was not. Pheugon didn't recognize him, and simply filed him away as a strange man.*

Three days later, I was walking past the Scales office when I stopped.

Beside the main entrance, in the spot where notices always went up, a new sheet of paper hung. The paste hadn't fully dried, and the edges curled slightly. They fluttered whenever the wind blew. A few people had gathered in front of it, murmuring.

I felt no particular unease, in that moment. Notices went up often in this city. Well maintenance, ration schedules, market rules. I was about to just walk on past.

But my feet stopped. Among the murmuring voices, a familiar word reached me.

HERALD.

. . .

I moved in among the people.

The notice was short. The dry phrasing peculiar to a document produced by the Scales.

> *Regarding the Reckoning's sentence of demolition. Due to the non-arrival of the previously assigned herald, a new herald has been assigned. The new herald has already departed for the Reckoning. Expected arrival date to be announced.*

I read that twice, three times.

My body went completely stiff, in that moment. The letters registered with my eyes, but it took time for the meaning to reach my mind. I'd spent these past days among this city's people — helping with errands at the Scales, reading notices aloud, sitting at the old man's table. All that while, somewhere out beyond this city, an entirely different course of events had already been underway.

. . .

Someone standing nearby said, quietly.

"Finally coming, is it." An older man. "How long we've waited."

"Waited?" someone beside him asked.

"Of course," the man said. "Nothing's settled until the herald comes. Staying this way just gets more unsettling. Better it come fast and get the sentence read, whatever it is."

I felt something twist inside me, listening to that.

Up to that point, I had gone on vaguely believing that my running had bought this city time. That if I didn't read, the Scales couldn't do anything. But this

man was saying the exact opposite. My not reading, in itself, was heaping a different kind of unease onto this city. The unease of hanging, unresolved.

. . .

The talk around me went on.

"Why'd it take so long to get assigned, though?" a woman asked. "Our days are down this much already."

"Guess it takes time to find someone, even for the Scales," someone else answered. "Not a job just anyone can do. Someone specially trained, they say."

"Trained, how? Isn't it just reading a paper?"

"You don't know," the first man cut in. "My nephew was training for that. You wouldn't believe how hard it is. Keeping your voice from shaking, never stopping. Years of practicing nothing but that."

"But what happened to the one who was supposed to come first?" the woman asked.

"Don't know," the man shrugged. "Lost, maybe, or couldn't make it. The Scales doesn't tell you that part."

"Poor thing. Must've had some reason."

I felt a chill run through me, listening. *Years of practicing nothing but that.* I was someone who'd gone through those years too. And yet here, in this city, people weren't talking about my years — they were talking about the years of a person whose face they didn't even know yet.

. . .

I stood in front of that notice for a long while.

I felt something had gone wrong in my calculations, in that moment. I didn't yet know exactly what. I just realized, for the first time, that I'd been vaguely assuming the world would wait for me, while I hid here in this city. The world hadn't waited. The Scales had moved on without me. Found someone else, and already set them walking.

I read the phrase "has already departed" on the notice again.

Already. That word weighed the most. I'd thought, all this while, that I was postponing something. Deferring a choice. But that word was saying the deferral was already over. Someone else was already walking. Toward this city.

. . .

I thought about going to find the record-keeper, then didn't. Instead I stood in front of the notice until the crowd dispersed.

I imagined, standing there, that new herald. Someone around fourteen or fifteen, like me? Or someone older? I tried to picture the face and nothing came. I knew nothing about that person at all. And yet, strangely, I felt certain they'd be very much like me. Someone trained to read without feeling. Someone who never stops at a name. Someone who'd sat in the same room, at a different time, and heard the same words from the same supervisor.

I knew that person would read all the way down to that small line of print at the very bottom of the sentence — Article Four, Clause Eleven. Would that person, like me, stop at that line? Or just pass over it? I had no way of

knowing the answer. I only knew, for certain, that they would read that sentence not knowing anything about this city at all.

I went to step into the Scales building, then stopped.

I wanted to go find the Adjudicator. Wanted to ask him what this meant. But my feet wouldn't move.

I felt a strange fear, in that moment. If I went to the Adjudicator, I felt he would finish the words he hadn't finished last time. "That, you'll come to know." I was afraid that "coming" had already arrived. I wasn't ready yet. I didn't even know what I was supposed to be ready for — I just felt unready.

In the end, I didn't go into the Scales building. I turned and walked toward the square instead.

. . .

By the square, word of the notice had already spread. People stood in twos and threes, talking. Expressions varied. Some relieved, some anxious.

I stood in front of the plate announcing the days remaining. Looked at the number.

People kept passing by all around. Someone glanced up at the plate and moved on; someone didn't even look. How quickly this city's people had grown used to that number — that, oddly, struck me as strange that day.

That number looked different that day. I'd watched this number every day. But that day, for the first time, the fact that it had kept counting down without me felt frightening. I'd thought of this number as one I'd made. That by running, I was exercising some kind of power over this number. But now, this number was simply flowing along at its own pace. With nothing to do with me.

I understood, in that moment, for the first time. My running hadn't stopped anything. I'd believed I was holding something back. Time for this city to turn on its own, the possibility of the clause being triggered, whatever it was. But the Scales, when I didn't come, simply sent someone else. Why had I not thought of that, for so long?

. . .

I sat down at the edge of the square. The strength went out of my legs.

For the first time, sitting there, I began to weigh what running away truly meant. I'd believed that running would stop something. Time, or the sentence, or the clause. But the reality in front of me was saying the opposite. I'd stopped nothing. I had only made one more person walk toward this city.

That person was, at this very moment, still walking toward this city. Not knowing anything, like me. No — unlike me. That person would surely come knowing exactly what they had to read. What only I hadn't known, what only I had missed by running — that person might already know it.

I couldn't move for a long time, in front of that thought.

. . .

Toward sundown, I finally got myself up. On the way back to the shed, I stopped several times. My feet kept wanting to turn a different direction. Toward the Adjudicator's office, or toward the room of records. I corrected them, each time.

That evening, I tried not to meet Trope. I didn't have the confidence to face her. I now knew there were two heralds hanging over this city. One already

living among its people, blended in; the other, still faceless, walking toward it. And Trope knew about neither.

But near the shed, in an alley, I ran into her anyway. She stood with an empty water jar.

"You haven't eaten," Trope said, setting the jar down. "What's with your face."

"…Nothing."

"How many times is that today?" Trope crossed her arms. "At least I know something happened today, from that look."

I nearly told her everything, in that moment. That a new herald was coming. That I was the reason. The words rose all the way to my throat, and went back down again. I swallowed it that day too. But that swallowing was unusually heavy, that day. I knew, by then, that what I was swallowing wasn't just one name.

"…Nothing happened," was all I said.

I didn't bring up the notice to Trope that day. She didn't seem to know about it yet. She wasn't someone who kept a close eye on the Scales office's notices. That silence felt, for a moment, like a small reprieve. Until she heard that news, I felt I didn't have to fully face it myself yet.

Looking back now, that wasn't a reprieve — it was simply putting it off. She would hear that news soon enough. Not from me, but from someone else. And on that day, I would have to pretend, once again, not to know.

Trope didn't press further. She picked up her jar and walked off toward her house. I watched her back for a long while, then returned to the shed.

Back at the shed, I wrapped myself in the blanket and sat for a long time.

I turned one sentence over, the whole night. I had run away. But that running hadn't been enough. I didn't know yet, at the time, exactly what that "not enough" meant. I only felt, for the first time, that I was standing in some strange place — neither having left this city, nor properly belonging to it. I was one of the people who knew this city's sin most exactly. And yet I still hadn't properly looked that fact in the face.

I didn't sleep that night, for a long while. Through the window, far off, I could see the square's plate glowing faintly even in the dark. The number was still counting down. Without me. With nothing to do with me.

I didn't know then where this failure of arithmetic would take me. I only sat that night, for the first time, in front of the fact that everything I'd believed I was controlling had already slipped from my hands.

I had thought, when I ran, that it was one complete act. You run, and it's over. I believed nothing more needed to be done after that. That not coming to this city, not reading this sentence, would be enough on its own. But the world didn't take my running that way. The world didn't leave an empty space alone. Wherever a space opened, the world filled it with something else. I hadn't even known how quickly that filling would happen. A day, two days, was enough. While I hesitated, the world had already set the next person walking.

I felt helplessness, for the first time that night, in front of that fact — a different kind than anything I'd felt in front of the Scales, or in front of the Adjudicator.

I suddenly thought again, that night, of the face I'd seen a few days before in the square — the one who didn't get angry. Why that face came to mind, in that moment, I couldn't explain then, and still can't fully explain now. Only, I remember, that face had held a different kind of stillness than the helplessness I felt that night. I envied that stillness. And, at the same time, I couldn't understand it.

That night, I took the sentence document back out of my bag, for the first time in a while. The oiled paper still bore the marks of that old wetting. Holding that paper, I imagined the day someone else would read this sentence in my place. That imagining came unusually vivid. A stranger's voice, reading this sentence in front of this city's people. In front of Trope. In front of the old man. I couldn't picture where I would be standing, in that scene.

I folded the paper back up and put it in the bag. And that night, for the first time, I asked myself this question. Do I really want this city to fall? Or do I just want to not have to read this sentence? I didn't yet know, that night, how different those two questions were.

Looking back now, all of Part Two comes down, in the end, to one sentence. I was washed up in this city looking for a place to hide, and while hiding I became dyed into it, and dyed into it, I went looking for a way to bring the Scales down, and failed, and failing, I faced, for the first time, the price of having run.

I didn't know, that night, that the price wouldn't end there. The arithmetic would keep going wrong, and I would face that wrongness again, more than once.

I counted again, that night, that I hadn't even reached the halfway point of the forty days. A little over twenty days left. I turned that number over in my mouth. Twenty days ago, that had seemed like infinite time. The days that remained felt far heavier than they had before.

(Continued in Part Three.)

The Forty-Day Clause, Part Three

The Forty-Day Clause

Chapter 25. In Search of the Text

> *_Previously_ — When Pheugon failed to come, a substitute herald was*
> *assigned to the Reckoning, and he had already set out for the city. Only then did Pheugon understand that fleeing, by itself, had stopped nothing.*

The news reached me from Trope's mouth.

It was dawn. A line had already formed at the well, and Trope had gotten there before me and filled two water jars. These days I helped her every morning. I'd started because I owed her something; somewhere along the way it had just become habit.

"A new herald is coming," she said, setting down a jar. "The one who was supposed to come didn't, so they've swapped in someone else. There's a notice posted outside the Adjudicator's office."

I couldn't say anything.

My hand, winding the bucket rope, stopped for a moment, then moved again. Luckily Trope wasn't looking at my face. She was peering into the jar.

"Strange, isn't it," Trope went on. "That a herald just doesn't show up. I've never seen that happen before. Maybe he caught a cold."

I nearly laughed. A cold. Trope thought I had a cold. Looking back, that would have been kinder. A cold, at least, gets better.

"…When's he coming?" I asked.

"Not sure. People are saying about a week. The notice didn't give an exact date. Just 'as soon as possible.'"

I counted the number silently. Subtract seven from the days remaining, and the city still had some room left. But that room wasn't room for me.

"Why do you look so shocked, Pheugon." Trope looked at me. "Is a change of heralds really such a big deal?"

"…No." I picked up the jar for her. "It's just news to me, that's all."

Trope looked at me a moment longer, then didn't press. That was who she was. She never dug. I was grateful for it, and guilty in exactly the same measure.

She didn't know I was a herald. Because she didn't know, she could hand me that news as if it were nothing. I was living off that nothing. At the time I didn't even know to call it what it was.

. . .

That whole evening, I thought about one sentence.

If, within forty days, the said city is confirmed to have turned, this sentence shall be rendered void.

In a hundred and twelve readings, I had never seen a sentence like it. It wasn't attached to individual cases. It appeared only on city-wide ones — a sentence that showed up maybe once a decade.

The first time I read it, I'd skimmed past the words "confirmed to have." I'd assumed the Scales would do the confirming. The Scales confirmed everything.

But these past few days, the phrase kept catching on something.

The Scales measures weight. The Scales does not measure direction. I already knew that. It was something I'd learned in the first ten days after I arrived in this city. But faced with that sentence, I'd been deliberately forgetting it. Why I'd been forgetting it, I still wasn't honest enough with myself to say.

The new herald would arrive in seven days. When he arrived, he would read all the way to that sentence too. And then — would it be confirmed, or not?

I didn't know. And not knowing was unbearable.

Even then, I couldn't explain to myself why it was so unbearable. Without that explanation, I went ahead and decided what to do next. That's the strangest part of this whole story — I knew what answer I wanted before I knew what the answer was.

. . .

I spent that whole morning walking the square.

There were boards all through the Reckoning announcing the days remaining. When I'd first been washed up in this city, the number had read thirty-nine. Now it had dropped much further. People passed the boards without lingering on them anymore. They'd grown used to it. I

found that strange — that in a city whose demolition date ticked down every day, people could just walk past the number.

I stopped in front of the bakery. The owner was handing over the last of her bread to a customer who'd come after closing. In the old days she'd have slipped it over quietly, off the Scales' books. This time the customer insisted on paying, and she flatly refused to take it.

I watched the scene for a long time.

That day I took it for ordinary kindness. It was only later I learned that scenes like it had been multiplying across the city around then. But my head was too full of other things that day to take notice. Looking back now, I know what a mistake that was.

I crossed the square. There really was a notice posted outside the Adjudicator's office. Short. **Substitute herald assigned. Arrival date not yet set.** I stood in front of it for a long time. A couple of passersby read it and moved on without comment. To them it was just an administrative notice.

Not to me.

. . .

As I walked, I thought about what kind of person the substitute herald might be.

Faces from training came back to me. We'd all been taught the same way — how not to stop, how not to listen, how not to snag on a name. Whoever came wouldn't be very different. Someone who read without feeling, precisely, to the last line.

At the time I thought of him as something faceless. A tool, moving exactly as it had been trained to move. That I had once wanted to be that tool myself — that, in the moment, I didn't remember.

He would have had a supervisor too. He would have had a name too. He must have, at some point, practiced reading a false sentence with his own name written into it. I didn't think of any of that then. I only began seeing him as a person much later, after he actually appeared at the gates of this city.

When he arrived, he would read this sentence document. From beginning to end, precisely. And he would read down to the last line — Article 4, Clause 11 — without stopping. Just as I had.

I stopped walking mid-thought. I was in the middle of the square. People passed around me.

He didn't know this city. Didn't know Trope. Didn't know that the baker had refused to take her change, or who had helped whom at the well. To him, the Reckoning was just a name on a page.

I thought that fact should have reassured me. It didn't. The opposite feeling kept rising instead, and I was afraid to give it a name.

. . .

The room of records sat behind the square, three flights down.

I'd been there before — it was where I'd found Mena's record. That time I'd gone digging through precedents, the past rulings the Scales drew on. This time what I was after wasn't a precedent. It was the original text the precedents quoted — the clause itself.

"I'm looking for the original text of Article 4, Clause 11," I said.

The archivist was an elderly woman. She studied me a long moment over her glasses.

"It's not here."

"…Not here?"

"The precedents are here. Records of precedents citing the clause. But the clause text itself, we don't keep here," she said, pushing a drawer shut. "That falls under the Adjudicator's authority, not the herald office's."

"Why?"

For the first time, the archivist looked me straight in the eye.

"I don't know. I've worked here twenty years and never once seen the original text of that clause."

"Twenty years."

"I was twenty-two when I first came here." She took off her glasses and wiped them. "In that time I've seen exactly three city-wide cases. This one makes four. And I've never once heard of that clause actually firing."

"All three?"

"All three." She put her glasses back on. "They fell. All of them."

"And why the clause never fired—"

"I don't know." She went on straightening her papers. "I'm just the person who files the precedents. I don't even know who wrote the clause. Nobody does. I hear even the Adjudicator doesn't know."

I made her say it again.

"Even the Adjudicator doesn't know?"

"He said so himself. Long ago." She glanced at me. "Ask him yourself, if you want."

I stood there a moment.

"I can see the precedents, though," I said.

"You already have. Last month."

She remembered me. I couldn't say anything.

Only then did it strike me that I hadn't really been hiding in this city at all. People remembered me. They didn't know my name, but they remembered my face. Hiding, it turned out, wasn't the same as being erased. It just meant no one asked.

. . .

Climbing back up the stairs, I passed a Scales terminal.

There were terminals like it all over the Reckoning. Rest a hand on one and your own weight came up. People did it out of habit, hand on, hand off.

I hadn't touched one since arriving in this city. I hadn't touched one back home, either, not since the day I walked out of the

supervisor's office. Forty days now, coming due, and not once.

I can explain, even now, exactly why I didn't. It wasn't that I was afraid the number would be low. It wasn't that I was afraid it would be high, either. I knew that number would be accurate, at that very moment as at any other, and it was the accuracy I was afraid to see. Accuracy always frightened me. That was the sickness running through this whole book.

I stopped in front of the terminal, then walked on without raising my hand.

At the end of the alley, I saw the man who doesn't get angry again — the same man I'd seen in the square before. This time he was pulling a handcart, and its wheel had dropped into a ditch. A few passersby stopped as if to help, then said they were busy and went on. He didn't get angry. He struggled alone to free the wheel until, finally, a passing child helped him lift it out.

I watched a moment, then walked on.

At the time I just thought he was unlucky. A wheel in a ditch, no one helping. An ordinary day. I didn't even wonder why he stayed so calm about it. I had no room for that. My head was already full with a different sentence.

. . .

The Adjudicator's office was on the third floor of the Scales building, at the end of the corridor. I'd been there twice before — once because he'd summoned me, once because I'd gone looking for him.

This time I was the one seeking him out again.

The door was closed. I stood in front of it and hesitated.

I tried, standing there, to work out what I was actually asking. "Show me the original text" would have been enough. But behind it I was hiding what I really wanted to ask — whose job the confirming was. Whether that job passed to the man arriving in seven days. Or—

I didn't finish that thought. If I finished it, I was afraid I'd catch myself out — find out exactly what it was I wanted.

I knocked.

There was no answer for a long while. Just as I raised my hand to knock again, a voice came from inside.

"…Come in."

I still remember the silence between those two words. I asked him later why he'd taken so long to answer. He didn't answer that either. By then I already knew that not answering was one of his ways of speaking.

I opened the door.

The Adjudicator was sitting at his desk. He didn't look surprised to see me. He'd taken to acting, these days, as if he already knew I was coming. Maybe he really did.

As always, papers were piled on his desk like a mountain. Through the window, the square lay below, and the board announcing the days remaining was visible from there too. His desk was positioned exactly where that board could be seen best. I didn't think that was an accident.

"What brings you," he asked.

I steadied my breath.

"Article 4, Clause 11," I said. "I want to see the original text. Not the one line attached to the sentence document."

The Adjudicator set down his pen.

"Why that."

"I feel like I need to know it for certain."

"Know what."

I couldn't answer right away. I hadn't sorted out for myself what it was I needed to know.

"…I heard a new herald is coming."

The Adjudicator's eyes narrowed briefly. He said nothing. He glanced out at the square once, then back at me.

He looked at me a long time. I couldn't read what that look meant then. I can read it now. It wasn't judgment. It wasn't worry, either.

It was resolve.

"Sit," he said. "This will take a while."

I sat. The Adjudicator rose and walked to the bookshelf. On the bottom shelf was a drawer with a lock on it. While he took out the key, I watched his back.

It looked like the back of a man who had put this moment off for a very long time.

The key turned in the lock with a short, heavy sound. I listened and looked out the window. The board in the square still showed its number. One less than what I'd seen passing through just before. Midnight must have come and gone while I wasn't watching.

That was the first day I actually felt the number drop. Before then it had just been a sign. From that moment, it wasn't.

"No one's ever shown you this," the Adjudicator said, drawing an old scroll out of the drawer. "In twenty-some years, I've taken it out exactly twice."

Even hearing that, I had no idea. What kind of person I'd be when I walked out of that room that night — I truly had no idea.

(Continued in Chapter 26.)

Chapter 26. Article Four

> *_Previously_ — Pheugon went to the Adjudicator to ask for the original clause text. The Adjudicator looked at him a long time, said "This will take a while," and drew an old scroll from a locked drawer. "No one's ever shown you this."*

The Adjudicator unrolled the scroll across his desk.

It wasn't paper. The material was older than that — its edges gone brown and brittle, its color faded along every fold. I'd never seen anything like it. Every other document in the Reckoning came printed by the Scales. This one had been written by hand.

He moved his fingertips carefully as he spread it flat. Not the hands of a man handling something old — the hands of a man handling something long put off.

"Older than the Scales," the Adjudicator said, as if reading my thought. "All of Article 4 is. This clause existed before the Scales took its current form."

"…Who wrote it?"

"Don't know," he said, short. "That's the first strange thing about this clause."

"No one knows? Not even you?"

"Not even me." He looked at me. "No one who has ever sat in this seat knew. Not the Adjudicator before me, not the one before him. I went back through the records — this clause was here before the Scales

office even existed. Who wrote it, when, why — there's no record at all."

"Have you tried to find out?"

"Once," he said, short again. "When I was young. Never found it."

He didn't explain further. I didn't ask further. I understood that his silence was the whole of his answer to that question.

. . .

The scroll held several clauses. Article 4 governed city-wide cases — the ones where accumulated weight crossed the limit and a demolition sentence fell on an entire city, not a single person. Clauses one through ten were familiar territory: conditions for sentencing, grace periods, execution procedure, order of resettlement for the displaced. Exactly as I'd been trained. Even the handwriting was neat, its sentences not so different from what the Scales printed — precise, dry, leaving no exception.

Reading through those clauses, I remembered training. The sentence structures were identical to what my supervisor had made us memorize — subject, condition, disposal. Sentences with no room for feeling to get in. I'd read sentences like that for three years, and it was for reading them well that I'd been sent this far.

Clause 11 stood apart.

The margin above it was unusually wide, as if whoever wrote the body had stopped there, and someone else had filled in the blank space below, much later.

The handwriting differed from the other clauses. Finer, more careful. As if, after finishing the body, someone had sat down separately, at another time, and added this one line on its own.

I read the line without making a sound.

> *If, within forty days, the said city is confirmed to have turned, this sentence shall be rendered void. The confirmation shall be performed by the one who read this sentence aloud.*

I read it twice.

What I'd known ended with the first sentence. What was attached to the sentence document went exactly that far. The line after it — "The confirmation shall be performed by the one who read this sentence aloud" — that, I was seeing for the first time.

Even reading it then, I hadn't yet let the meaning arrive. My eyes read it; my mind hadn't caught up. There are moments like that. Later you remember the moment exactly. In the moment itself, you feel nothing.

"This is the original," the Adjudicator said. "Only the first sentence goes out on the sentence document. Legal requirement. Procedure and effect are all people need to be told — no need to publish how the confirmation works."

"Why not publish it?"

The Adjudicator thought a moment.

"I don't know that either. That's another of the clause's strange points. It could be a document made to hide something. Or—" He cut himself off.

"Or?"

"Or it was hidden because it shouldn't be known by just anyone."

. . .

I sat in the Adjudicator's office and listened to what he had to tell me.

He'd held this seat thirty-one years. In that time there had been three city-wide cases. The same three the archivist had mentioned.

"I was the Adjudicator all three times," he said. "All three times this clause was attached, and all three times I took out this document. Just as I'm doing for you now."

He laid his hand on the scroll. It looked as if the weight he'd carried for so long had settled into his palm.

"All three times, I hoped," he said. "It's shameful, but it's true. That this time might be different. That the sentence might actually move. At thirty, I truly believed that."

"And now?"

He didn't answer.

"…Who to?"

"To the herald."

I looked at him.

"It happened the same way every time," the Adjudicator said. "When the herald arrived, I showed him this document. Told him the confirmation was his to perform. And—"

He stopped.

"And?"

"Every time, nothing happened."

. . .

"All three cities fell." The Adjudicator went on. "The first was when I was thirty. That herald read the sentence and left. He must have known the confirmation clause existed. He never came back."

"Why not?"

"Who knows. Maybe he thought his job was done. Maybe he didn't understand what there was to confirm." The Adjudicator's fingertip traced the scroll's edge. "Whether that city actually turned or not — no one knows. There was no one to confirm it."

I turned the words over. It sounded strange to me, that no one knew whether it had turned or not. I'd been taught the Scales knew everything. Yet faced with the one question that mattered most, even the Scales didn't know, and no person knew, and a whole city had vanished with no one knowing at all.

"So that city," I asked. "Might really have turned?"

"Who knows," the Adjudicator said again. "That's the most frightening part of this clause. Without someone to confirm it, having turned is indistinguishable from not having turned. The Scales can't tell the two apart."

"What about the second one?"

"The second herald wasn't from that city. Came from somewhere else. Read it precisely, left precisely. He never came back either."

"Did you show him this document too?"

"I showed him," the Adjudicator said. "He heard the whole thing, then asked me: 'So you're saying I have to come back later and say whether this city has changed or not?' I told him yes. He laughed. 'How would I know that.' He was right. He'd left without meeting even ten people in this city."

I felt something tighten in my chest, listening.

I thought, at the time, that I understood that feeling. Looking back, I'd understood only half of it. In that second herald, I wasn't seeing myself — I was seeing the man who would arrive in seven days. He too would read that sentence without meeting even ten people in this city.

Listening, I felt something go cold in some corner of my chest. I didn't know what it was then. I know now. It was a premonition.

"The third one," the Adjudicator said, looking at me. "The third was from this city. Born and raised here. Someone who knew better than anyone why this city had come to this."

The Adjudicator's voice changed, just slightly. Slower than before.

"That one left the city as a child. To train. And years later, was assigned back to this very city as a herald. The city he was born in. The city he knew better than anyone."

"…He must have known why it was falling apart, too."

"He knew. In detail," the Adjudicator said. "I don't know about his family. But I knew he didn't remember this city fondly. His hands shook, handing over the papers. Not the shaking of gladness."

I couldn't say anything.

"What about him?"

"He didn't read it."

I looked at the Adjudicator.

"He fled the night before the proclamation."

I repeated the sentence to myself several times. *He fled the night before.* I knew that sentence wasn't about me. And still, I kept finding my own name slotted into it.

"So that city."

"Fell. On the fortieth day, no one read. The Scales simply executed. No confirmation, nothing. If there's no one to read, there's nothing to confirm."

. . .

The room went quiet.

I looked at my hands. They weren't shaking. They should have been.

I thought, in that moment, that the Adjudicator was testing me. I know now he wasn't. He was just telling me facts. That it felt like a test was my own problem.

"…Why did he flee?" I asked. My voice sounded strange.

"Don't know. I never got to ask. I never saw him again after that."

The Adjudicator started rolling the scroll back up. I watched his hands.

"Adjudicator." I called out.

"Yes."

"What is confirmation. That sentence only says the one who read performs the confirmation — it doesn't say what confirmation actually means."

The Adjudicator's hands stopped, mid-roll.

He looked at me for a very long time. I still find that look hard to describe. It wasn't the look of a man withholding an answer. It was the look of a man gauging whether I was ready to hear one.

"That," he said slowly, "we'll talk about tomorrow."

"…Why not now?"

"You've heard enough for one day."

I couldn't press further.

The Adjudicator put the scroll back in the drawer and locked it. The sound rang louder than before.

"Pheugon."

"…Yes."

"I'm not going to ask why you're clinging to this clause so hard," he said. "You don't look like you'd give me a real answer if I did."

I said nothing.

"Come back tomorrow," he said. "Same time."

I got up and walked toward the door. When my hand was on the handle, his voice came again from behind me.

"Pheugon."

"…Yes."

"Seven days, you said. The substitute."

"…Yes."

"I hope tomorrow won't come too late for you."

I didn't fully understand the weight of that sentence then. Walking out, I simply took it for concern. I know now. It wasn't concern. It was a warning.

. . .

It was already evening by the time I got out to the hallway.

The square was visible through the window. People were drifting home one and two at a time. A few children had gathered by the board that announced the days remaining, pointing at the number, talking about something. I couldn't hear what.

Walking down the stairs, I found myself turning the Adjudicator's words over again. *The third one, someone who knew better than anyone why the city had come to this.*

I turned that sentence over the whole way down those stairs. I didn't know, at the time, why I couldn't look away from it. I know now. It was my own story. Not yet finished — but my story had already gone ahead of me and arrived there first.

. . .

Trope was still at the well. It was the hour when the last few people fetching evening water were thinning out.

"You're late," she said. "Coming from the Adjudicator's office?"

I froze for a second.

"…How did you know?"

"That's exactly the path from there." Trope smiled. "Why, is it a secret?"

"…No."

Even then I stacked one more lie on top. I'd said no, but it was a secret. I told her nothing that day. And the fact that I was grateful

she didn't press — looking back now, I see how convenient an excuse that gratitude was.

Trope slung the water jar over her shoulder and glanced at me.

"You've been thinking hard about something lately, Pheugon."

"…Does it show?"

"Yes." She said, walking. "I know that look. My mother used to wear it a lot. The face people make when they're thinking about something that doesn't show up on the Scales."

I had no answer for that.

She didn't press further and just walked on ahead. I watched her back for a moment, then followed.

On the way home, I passed the herald office's wall. There was one lit window on the other side of it. The Adjudicator's office. He seemed to still be in that room.

I watched that light and wondered what he was doing in there. Had he taken the scroll out again? Or was he just sitting, looking out the window? I didn't know then. I don't know exactly now either. I only know that across the thirty-one years he'd spent in that room, he had wanted, at least once, to see that sentence move. That wish had never once come true, and still he had taken out that same scroll three times in that same room, and put it away three times again.

I couldn't sleep that night, back at home. The third herald's story kept circling in my head. Someone born and raised in that city. Someone who knew better than anyone why it had come to this. That person hadn't read it. He'd fled the night before the proclamation.

I envied him. In that moment I didn't even know why I envied him. To put a name to that envy, I would first have had to admit what I wanted. That night, I still wasn't ready for that.

(Continued in Chapter 27.)

Chapter 27. The One Who Proclaimed

> *_Previously_ — The Adjudicator showed Pheugon the original text of*
> *Article 4, Clause 11: "The confirmation shall be performed by the one who read this sentence aloud." There had been three city-wide cases, and all three cities fell. The third herald had been born and raised in that city, and fled the night before the proclamation. The Adjudicator said they'd talk about what "confirmation" actually meant the next day.*

The next day I arrived earlier than the time we'd agreed.

I waited a little outside the door. No sound came from inside. Unlike the day before, I knocked without hesitating.

"Come in."

The answer came quickly this time.

The Adjudicator sat in the same chair as yesterday. There was no scroll on the desk. Instead he sat with nothing in front of him, waiting for me. That absence felt heavier than the scroll had.

"Sit."

I sat.

. . .

"You know what the Scales does," the Adjudicator said.

"It measures weight. Without error."

"That's right. Precisely. Who stole what, who lied to whom, whether a hand was raised to a terminal or not — all of it converts into weight. The Scales does that perfectly."

"…Yes."

"But there's one thing the Scales can't do."

I waited.

"Direction," the Adjudicator said. "The Scales measures weight, not direction. The posture you're sitting in right now, this weight — the Scales stamps that precisely. But whether you're in the middle of turning around, or just sitting still — the Scales doesn't see that. It reads the same value either way."

"Why?"

"Don't know," the Adjudicator said. "That's simply the Scales' limit. The Scales is a machine that measures what has already accumulated. It doesn't measure which way you're facing right now, this instant. There's no method for measuring that at all."

At first, listening, I just took it as another story about the Scales' flaws. Familiar territory. I'd spent two months combing precedents for gaps in the Scales. I still didn't know, at that point, that this particular story was headed straight for me.

. . .

"So whoever wrote the clause," the Adjudicator went on, "handed that judgment to a person. Because it's something the Scales can't do."

"To just anyone?"

"No." The Adjudicator looked straight at me. "Not just anyone. To the one who read the sentence aloud."

I looked at him.

"Why that person, of all people."

The Adjudicator chose his words.

"Think about it," he said. "Who knows this city's sin most precisely. The Scales. But the Scales can't see direction. Who's the next most precise?"

I couldn't answer.

"The one who read the sentence," the Adjudicator said. "That person read out loud — with his own mouth — exactly how much accumulated weight this city carried, and exactly which sins had piled up to make that number. More precisely than any citizen — more precisely even than someone born and raised in this city — that person knows this city's sin, sentence by sentence."

"Wouldn't someone from the city know better?" I asked. "If they've lived here their whole life, wouldn't they know more than the herald?"

"They'd know it differently," the Adjudicator said. "Someone from this city knows it by living it. They know who wronged whom, by rumor, in their body. But they don't know it as exact numbers. What weight the Scales assigned to their neighbor's wrongdoing — they can

only guess, not know precisely. The herald is different. The herald read that number, that item, that sentence aloud, without dropping a single word. Knowledge no citizen of this city holds."

Listening, I understood it. And the understanding frightened me. Knowing precisely and loving had nothing to do with each other. If anything, they might run opposite ways.

"But what if that person hates this city," I asked. My voice cracked. "What if the person who knows the sin most precisely also hates this city the most? How can you trust that judgment then?"

The Adjudicator looked at me for a moment.

"You don't," he said. "The clause isn't trusting that person. The clause is only saying that no one else has the standing to judge. Not entrusted because trustworthy — entrusted because there's nowhere else to entrust it."

"What's the difference."

"A great one," the Adjudicator said. "Standing doesn't choose the person. Whether that person is good or bad, whether he loves this city or hates it — the clause doesn't ask. It asks exactly one thing. Did he read it."

I still had nothing to say.

"So the clause asks that person," the Adjudicator said. "Whether the sin you knew and this city, as it stands now, are different. There's exactly one person in the world with the standing to answer that. The one who read this city's sin most precisely."

"How does the confirmation work," I asked. "Just… think it? Or does he write something down?"

"Speech," the Adjudicator said. "Aloud. This clause was consistent from beginning to end — not thought, not signature. A voice. One sentence is enough. 'This city has turned.' But it can't be said just anywhere."

"Where, then?"

"On the fortieth day," the Adjudicator said. "In the square. Right before demolition executes, with the whole city watching. The same place, the same hour as the proclamation. This time, the confirmation has to be spoken there."

Hearing that, I felt something go cold through my body. It meant that the man who had fled would have to go back to that very spot, and this time with the whole city watching.

. . .

I heard that and stayed still.

The room was quiet. Faint voices drifted in from outside the window.

I suddenly remembered what Trope had said. *The face people make when they're thinking about something that doesn't show up on the Scales.* I hadn't been able to answer her then. Now I thought I understood. What face I'd been wearing, all this time.

I still remember that moment sentence by sentence. It's strange. People usually remember big events in a blur. But that moment alone comes to me one sentence at a time, each arriving separately. Maybe

that's exactly how it happened inside my head. One sentence at a time, in order, everything came down.

Without that man. No confirmation.

Without confirmation. The clause doesn't move.

If the clause doesn't move. The demolition never becomes void.

If I don't read. It means I am — permanently — the only person who ever read this city's sin aloud, and now never will.

If I don't read. This city will certainly fall.

I'd already run this arithmetic once before. Five months ago. That day in the supervisor's office, when I received the papers. I'd looked at those papers and felt relief. I hadn't known then what that relief was. I know now.

I hadn't fled thinking this city would live.

I had fled knowing this city would certainly die.

That day in the supervisor's office, I heard the number a hundred and twenty thousand. I told myself, at the time, it was a number I'd never tried to count. But in truth I'd already started counting the instant I heard it — not as people, but as a possibility. For a city of a hundred and twenty thousand to fall, the clause would have to stay silent. For the clause to stay silent, I would have to not read. I had already finished that calculation in the supervisor's office, at the very moment I took the papers in my hand.

My hand hadn't shaken. I called that composure. The steadiness of a man who'd read a hundred and twelve cases. That was a lie. A composed man is a man whose calculation is finished.

. . .

I looked at my hands.

They were shaking.

Too late. Hands that had never once shaken through a hundred and twelve readings were shaking now, here. And I knew this shaking wasn't coming from fear. It was the shaking of a man caught.

Caught at what. By myself.

My weight had been the lowest in our whole cohort — low enough that the supervisor checked twice. Everyone assumed it was diligence. So had I.

I know now that it wasn't diligence. I wasn't a child afraid of weight. I thought, someday, there'd be a sentence I would have to read, and I didn't want to lose my standing to read it. That the sentence would turn out to be the Reckoning's — I hadn't thought that, back then. Or maybe I already had. Since I was twelve.

Living with the lowest possible weight, and holding the most precisely qualified standing — I'd lived three years not even knowing those were the same thing. And the hands that had earned that standing had fled, in the end, precisely so as not to read the sentence. The person most qualified had chosen, most certainly, not to use that qualification.

For the first time I recalled the moment I'd received the papers assigning me to the Reckoning. Seeing the city's name, I'd laughed. Without a sound, just for an instant. *That was relief,* I'd told myself then.

I was wrong for three years. That wasn't relief. It was certainty. The certainty that the Reckoning had come to me. The certainty that if I read that document, a chance existed for the clause to fire. And if I didn't read it—

I recalled the night I first found the clause. That small print. *Turns.* I read the word three times. That night, I told myself I hadn't "quite grasped what it meant."

A lie. I understood it precisely. I'd read the word three times not because I didn't understand it. The calculation to eliminate that possibility had already begun, right then.

The supervisor had once asked. *You got something with the Reckoning?* I'd said no.

That lie was proof I'd already begun planning to flee. I already knew, then, that if I didn't read this city, the one person who could save it would cease to exist, permanently.

I hadn't fled. I had killed. A city where nothing had happened yet — killed forty days before, in the hallway where I took the papers.

. . .

The Adjudicator watched me for a long time.

He didn't seem to be waiting for me to say anything. He was just watching. Waiting for me to come down that staircase on my own.

I couldn't say anything. There was nothing to say. No excuse, no denial. The Adjudicator already knew. What I had only just come to know, he seemed to have known all along.

He opened his mouth.

His voice was low.

"So it wasn't fear," he said, "that made you run."

I couldn't answer.

I can still repeat that sentence word for word, not a syllable off. It didn't scold me. He wasn't angry, wasn't surprised. He was simply stating a fact. And that one fact brought down, all at once, everything I had spent three years telling myself.

I was a boy who never did wrong. I wasn't a boy who didn't get angry — I was a boy who withheld anger. I was a boy who took care not to lose his standing. Every one of those sentences read differently now. Not caution — preparation. Not restraint — aim.

The day of my first proclamation, I'd erased the shape of the merchant's mouth. And a hundred and eleven more times after that. I called it the fruit of training. I know now. I hadn't been practicing how to erase. I hadn't been practicing how to endure, either. I had been practicing how to wait — for the one day I would not read, toward this city.

The Adjudicator rose from his seat. I thought he would say something more — comfort, or reproach. Instead he simply walked to the window and opened it a crack. Evening air came into the room.

"I didn't tell you this to blame you," he said, looking out the window. "I told you because I thought you needed to know. What happens after that is yours."

I couldn't answer that either. He didn't wait for an answer. He just stood, looking out the window. His back looked like the back of a man who had, thirty-one years running, taken the same scroll out and put it back in.

. . .

I don't know how long I sat in the Adjudicator's office.

He said nothing more. Neither did I. The sun was going down outside the window. The number lit on the square's board quietly cast its light over the whole city, behind my back.

I walked out of that room that day a different person. To be precise, I hadn't become a different person. I had, for the first time, seen the original one. For three years I'd thought I was a good boy. That goodness had been aimed, with precision, in one direction the whole time — that, I learned for the first time that day.

I don't know what Jonah thought, walking toward Nineveh. I don't know how he understood himself, aboard the ship to Tarshish. But I know this now — that fleeing can, sometimes, be a more exact calculation than arriving.

And I had already carried that calculation out.

. . .

I went home that night and sat for a long time.

There was something I wanted to say. I didn't know exactly to whom, or what. I only felt that if I didn't say something aloud, I wouldn't

survive it. For three years I had made a career of reading aloud, and in all that time I had never once said my own story out loud.

I opened my mouth, then closed it again.

The next day, I knocked on the Adjudicator's door again.

(Continued in Chapter 28.)

Chapter 28. The Confession

> *_Previously_ — The Adjudicator told Pheugon the clause's true trigger condition: only the one who read the sentence aloud can confirm it. In that moment, Pheugon understood the real reason he'd*
> *fled — not fear, but calculation. "So it wasn't fear that made you run." That night Pheugon sat unable to speak, and the next day he knocked on the Adjudicator's door again.*

After I knocked, I realized I hadn't decided what to say.

The Adjudicator opened the door. Nothing had changed from the day before. Same seat, same desk. And yet I crossed that threshold as an entirely different person than the day before.

"Come in."

I went in. I sat without waiting to be told.

There was nothing on the desk again today. Where the scroll had lain yesterday, only the wood grain showed now. That emptiness pressed on me all the more. There was nowhere to hide.

Morning light came in through the window at a slant. I watched it touch the edge of the desk and slowly creep along. While I failed to start speaking, the light moved two finger-widths.

"…Adjudicator."

"Yes."

I opened my mouth and closed it again. Three times, maybe.

The Adjudicator didn't rush me. He didn't look at his papers either. He simply watched me.

. . .

"There was someone," I finally said, "who came to our house from the Reckoning. Three years ago."

The Adjudicator's expression didn't change at all. He seemed to have already guessed.

"My father took him in. That was the kind of man he was. Quick to take in strangers."

I stopped speaking there for a long while.

"…Go on," the Adjudicator said. It wasn't a push. It was more a way of letting me know there was another door where I'd stopped.

"He used a room. A converted storeroom — my father hurried a bed in and made it into a room. There was a light on in there every night. He was writing something. Said it was a verification task, copying over my father's ledger."

"…What kind of verification."

"I don't know," I said. That wasn't a lie. "I was twelve. I thought it was grown-up business. I still don't know."

The Adjudicator didn't ask further.

I nearly said I could still close my eyes and see the light leaking through that door crack, then stopped myself. If I said that too, I was sure my voice would break. Instead I caught a breath and moved to the next sentence.

. . .

"For a few months it was fine," I went on. "We ate dinner together. He talked with me and my brother. When we asked about the Reckoning, he'd answer smiling. He said the Scales measures everyone so precisely, no one ever gets treated unfairly."

"You believed that."

"…Yes." I looked at him. "I thought accuracy was a good thing."

"And now."

I couldn't answer.

"Then," I went on, "something changed. I don't know exactly when. There were more evenings my father said nothing for days at a time. I heard my mother crying alone in the kitchen. Twice. The second time was quieter. I stood outside the door, then just turned back."

"Didn't knock."

"…No."

"Why."

I gave that question real thought for the first time.

"…I thought if I got caught, it would be harder for my mother. But I know now. That wasn't for my mother. It was for me. Pretending not to hear was easier than hearing and not being able to do anything."

The Adjudicator said nothing. There was no pity in his eyes. But no indifference either. He was just listening.

. . .

"That winter I saw my father put his hand on a Scales terminal. Once." I said. "A number came up on the screen. I didn't see the number. He looked at it a long while and said, 'It's fine.' I hadn't even asked."

"And that man."

"He left that winter. I walked with him as far as the edge of town. I don't know why. I think I wanted to ask something, but in the end I asked nothing at all. I just said goodbye."

"Did you hate that man."

"Not then," I said. "I didn't know how to hate yet. The hating grew later. Very slowly."

The Adjudicator moved for the first time. He drew his fingertip once along the edge of the desk.

"His name," he asked. "Do you know that man's name."

I looked at him.

"…I know it."

"Not going to say it."

"…No."

He nodded. He didn't press further. I understood then that he had no intention of forcing me any further than I was willing to go.

. . .

"Our family fell apart after that," I went on. "My brother left that winter. Without a word to me. I still don't know where he is."

"Did you ever look."

"No," I said, looking down at my hands. "I wouldn't have known what to ask him if I found him."

"Your mother."

"She went to live with relatives in another city the next year. She asked me to come with her. I said I didn't want to quit training. That was what I told myself then."

"The real reason."

I stayed silent a long time.

"…I don't know. Even now."

"Your father."

"He's still in that city. We don't live together. He lives alone, on the other side of the city. We see each other occasionally. We don't talk about it."

"Not once."

"Not once."

The Adjudicator closed his eyes briefly, then opened them. It wasn't surprise. It was more like the motion of putting something away inside himself.

"The last time we met," I went on. This was something I hadn't been asked, but it came out on its own. "It was a few days before I received the Reckoning case. As we were parting, my father said one thing. 'What case are you reading these days.' I lied, said it was something small. It wasn't a lie then, since I hadn't been given the Reckoning case yet — but I was already, in that moment, practicing how to hide something."

"What did your father say."

"'Take care of yourself.' That was all."

"That was the most he could do."

I nodded at that. Strangely, hearing that sentence from someone else's mouth, it sounded different. It was the very sentence I had told myself for three years, but coming from the Adjudicator it sounded like neither an accusation nor an excuse. Just a fact.

. . .

The room went quiet. Through the window came the smell of evening drawing close.

"The Scales must have calculated it," I said. This was something I wanted to say. "How much everyone's weight went up — I don't know exactly. I never asked. But I know the Scales calculated it precisely. The Scales is never wrong."

"But."

"But nothing came back." My voice cracked. "My brother didn't come back. My mother didn't come back. Our family never became four again. A precise disposal came down, and it fixed nothing."

That was the first time I ever said that sentence aloud. Three years I'd carried it only inside myself. The moment it came out as sound, I understood for the first time how heavy it was. Some sentences weigh far more coming out of a mouth than they do written on paper.

"So I gave that anger away," I went on. "Not just to that one man — to the whole city. I put the whole city where that man had been. I know it isn't fair. I didn't know that then."

"Aside from the fact that he was from this city," the Adjudicator asked, "did you have any other grounds to hate the whole city."

I had no answer for that.

"None," I said, after a long while. "I'd never met a single person from the Reckoning. Not until I came to this city."

"And still you hated it."

"…Yes."

"And after meeting them."

I thought of Trope. The baker. The merchant fixing his weights. The people drawing water at the well.

"…I don't know," I said. "Faces appeared. Once a face appears, it gets hard to hate. And that doesn't mean the hating stops. It just gets harder."

The Adjudicator heard that and passed no verdict. I was grateful for it. And at the same time, frightened. Without a verdict, I had to keep walking through it alone.

. . .

"For three years," I opened my mouth again. "I did nothing wrong. No lying, no anger, kept my weight as low as it could go. Everyone thought it was diligence."

"You thought so too."

"…Yes. But I learned yesterday. It wasn't diligence. I was guarding my standing. Someday there'd be a sentence I'd have to read toward the Reckoning, and I didn't want to lose the standing to read it. I'd been preparing that, three years, without even knowing it."

The Adjudicator looked at me a moment.

"That's the part hurting you most right now."

I nodded. My throat closed and no words came.

. . .

The Adjudicator was quiet a long time.

I thought he'd say something. Comfort, or reproach. He did neither.

"I heard your story," he said. That was all.

"…That's it?"

"That's it." He looked at me. "If I told you it's all right, that would be a lie. I don't know why your family fell apart. Whether what you felt was fair or not isn't mine to judge either. All I know is that you said that story out loud today, for the first time in three years."

I turned that over.

"That," he said, "is enough for today."

"…Adjudicator." I asked. "Why don't you comfort me?"

He thought a moment.

"Comfort is easy," he said. "Saying it's all right takes less than five seconds. I hear your own father said that to you too. You just told me yourself. What did that do for you?"

I couldn't answer.

"Nothing," the Adjudicator said. "That sentence was for your father's own sake. It wasn't for you. I don't want to add one more of those onto you."

"Then what are you doing for me."

"Listening," he said. "That's all. But I don't think that's nothing. You went three years without ever getting all of that out to anyone. Today you did. That's not because I did anything. You did it."

I found that answer disappointing. At the time. I think I'd been hoping for more. Forgiveness, or denial — some sentence that would close this story out. The Adjudicator didn't give me that. I know now. That was the most honest thing he could have given me.

. . .

Walking out, I found it strange that I felt neither lighter nor heavier. I felt something should have changed. I'd finally told the whole story, after three years. And yet my brother still hadn't come back, my mother still wasn't in that city, my father still lived alone on the other side of it.

Speaking hadn't fixed anything. I learned that that day. Just as the Scales' disposal had fixed nothing, my confession fixed nothing either. But one thing was different. The Scales' disposal had kept me locked inside it, alone. Confession had, at least, brought one other person into that room.

I came out into the hallway; it was evening. The square was visible through the window. People stood in line at the Scales terminal. An ordinary sight. But that day the line looked a little shorter.

I didn't know why it looked that way then. I thought it was just my imagination. I know now. It wasn't imagination. From around then, very slowly, this city really was changing.

. . .

Trope was at the well. She saw me and, unlike usual, didn't start talking. She just patted the spot beside her with her hand. An invitation to sit.

I sat.

For a long while neither of us said anything. People fetching water came and went, one and two at a time. An evening bell rang somewhere far off.

"…You have the face of someone who set down something heavy today," Trope said first.

"…Does it show?"

"Yes." She glanced at me. "But it's not the face of someone who set down all of it. It's the face of someone who set down half."

I laughed at that. A sad laugh.

"…That's exact."

"I know that face," she said, resting a foot on a stone. "I used to wear it a lot myself."

I looked at her. For the first time, I seriously considered that she too might be carrying something as heavy as mine.

"…Will you tell it someday, Trope? Until you've set it all down?"

She didn't answer for a long while.

"…I don't know," she finally said. "I've never thought of it as a weight I could set down."

I didn't fully grasp what that meant, at the time.

I know now. She was already handing me, that day, the first line of her own story. I didn't catch it. I was too caught up in telling my own. The price for that came later, in a different place.

We didn't say anything more that evening. We filled the jars, walked together, and parted. As we said goodbye, she added one more line.

"…I'll be here tomorrow too."

I didn't understand, that night, why that sentence stayed with me the way it did.

(Continued in Chapter 29.)

Chapter 29. Little by Little

> *_Previously_ — Pheugon said his family's story aloud to the Adjudicator for the first time. The Adjudicator gave neither comfort nor judgment — he just listened. That evening at the well, Trope said, briefly, "I've never thought of it as a weight I could set down." Pheugon let the words pass.*

I noticed it first outside the bakery.

The baker had always been strict about keeping accounts. Trope had told me so before. But that morning, I watched her send an old man off without paying at all.

"…Pay me next time," she said. "Just take it today."

The old man bowed his head over and over as he left. The baker watched him go for a moment, then went back to kneading dough. As if nothing had happened.

I stood there and watched it. Something felt strange, though I couldn't place what. Two months earlier, I'd have walked right past that scene. A kindness from someone in the Reckoning — I wouldn't have felt a thing. That day, my feet stayed rooted to the spot.

I passed by again the next day, half wondering if it had been a coincidence. But that day too, the baker said the same thing to someone else. "Pay me next time." Hearing it a second time, I understood this wasn't chance — it was a decision.

Until then I'd only known the people of this city as numbers on the Scales. The baker had been a single line to me — "strict about accounts." That day I saw, for the first time, that there was another sentence behind that line.

. . .

A few days later I saw it in the market.

The merchant who'd cheated with his weights — a name I recognized from the precedent files. He was crouched in front of his stall, working at something. Coming closer, I saw he was repairing his weights, filling back in the part he'd shaved off.

"…What are you doing?" I asked.

He glanced at me, then went back to the work.

"…Setting it right."

"Who told you to?"

"No one told me," he said. "It's just been weighing on me lately."

I had no answer for that.

In that moment I remembered the name I'd seen in the precedent database. A weight, a disposal. A person who'd survived only as numbers. But what stood in front of me now wasn't a number. It was a pair of hands. The hands that had shaved the weights down were now filling them back in.

. . .

The habit of counting came back.

I'd once been the boy who counted a hundred and twelve cases. Now I was counting something else. What wasn't stolen. What anger wasn't raised. Words that got spoken. A few of these caught my eye every day.

The girl next door, who picked up an old man's dropped cane and carried it back to him. She'd lost her mother. Trope told me. Since her mother's name had vanished from the Scales, that child hadn't spoken to anyone. That day she'd grabbed the cane and run to the old man.

A young man who'd stopped to help someone who'd tripped and dropped her water jar. He'd always kept his eyes on his own path before — I'd heard that at the well.

Two neighbors who had lived turned backs on each other, meeting briefly in an alley one day and exchanging a short greeting.

Counting these, I thought of the habit from training. That habit of counting a hundred and twelve cases was, here, counting a completely different set of numbers. Numbers the Scales had never once counted.

. . .

One day I went and stood in front of a Scales terminal.

I checked the baker's name. A number came up. I compared it to the record from forty days ago. No change. I checked the merchant too. The same.

I stood there a long while, looking at it.

I thought the Scales was missing something. It seemed strange that a man now refilling weights with his own hands showed the exact same number as when he'd been shaving them down. But thinking again, it wasn't strange at all. That man hadn't undone the act of shaving the weights. He hadn't erased the past — he had simply started living differently, from now on. The Scales had no field to tell the two apart.

That evening I went and asked the Adjudicator.

"Why isn't the number moving? People are clearly changing."

The Adjudicator looked at me a moment before answering.

"Weight accumulates," he said. "What's already piled up doesn't go down. Bread you stole stays on the Scales. Not stealing today doesn't erase yesterday's theft."

"So no matter how much they change, it means nothing?"

"It doesn't mean nothing," he said. "It just doesn't register on the number. The number and what it's worth aren't the same thing."

At the time, that distinction sounded strange to me.

"Then no matter how much this city changes," I asked, "if the number doesn't drop below the limit within forty days, it just falls? Even if people have genuinely changed?"

The Adjudicator looked at me a long time.

"That's exactly why the clause exists," he said. "There are things numbers can never prove. The clause was made knowing that. Something only a person can see — not a number."

"But that person is me."

"That's right," he said. "So I won't ask what you've been counting lately. I'll just say one thing. The numbers you're counting might be more accurate to you than the Scales' numbers."

I carried those words out of the room. Walking the hallway, I counted things off on my fingers. The bakery, the weights, the cane, the purse. Four. Counting to four, I felt strangely settled. Counting still calmed me. Only now the things being counted had changed.

The pile of papers sat on the Adjudicator's desk that day too. I'd never paid much attention to the way he sorted them, but that day I noticed. A clerk had mentioned in passing that he used to push papers aside as he went. Lately, though, the Adjudicator seemed to linger over each page before turning to the next.

"Are you counting something too, Adjudicator?" I asked.

He stopped his hand.

"…Something like that," he said. "Forty years, I've read these papers as numbers. These days I read the names. I can't explain the difference myself yet."

I turned that over for a long time.

. . .

I know now. That distinction was the one that decided this whole city's fate. The Scales knew precisely how heavy the city was. But which direction the city was walking, right now, appeared nowhere on

the Scales' screen. Direction wasn't a number. It couldn't become one.

Once I saw a strange scene in the square.

An older man stood in front of someone else, holding something out. A small pouch. The one receiving it looked confused.

"…What's this."

"I owed you something," the old man said. "Seven years ago. You probably don't remember. I do."

The recipient truly looked like he didn't remember. The old man didn't explain, just pressed the pouch into his hand and turned away.

I asked someone passing by. "What was that about?"

"Don't know," the man shrugged. "There's been a few like that lately. People suddenly going around paying off old debts."

The Scales had already recorded that seven-year-old debt. Converted into weight. That weight wouldn't vanish just because the man handed over a pouch. I knew that, and still I couldn't stop thinking about that scene for a long time. What the Scales couldn't erase, that man was trying to erase anyway, knowing it wouldn't erase.

. . .

Around that time I got to know one person. I won't write her name here. She carried water for a living, and years earlier, the weight piled up from theft had put her just one step short of the limit. I saw her number once, by chance, at a Scales terminal. The room she

had left before crossing the limit was small enough to count on one hand.

She hadn't stolen once, since. I learned that from Trope. Three years, Trope said. And still the number sat exactly where it had three years before. One wrong step away from crossing the limit.

"…So is she," I asked, "still in danger, even after three years of not stealing?"

"Yes," Trope said. "That's how the Scales sees it. Three years of not stealing isn't a number."

I couldn't say anything for a long while after that answer. That three years of patience couldn't move one single number — that was the first time it truly frightened me. What frightened me wasn't the Scales' coldness. It was that the coldness was accurate.

More days passed. I kept counting. Some days five things, some days two. Some days none at all. On those days I felt uneasy, wondering if the city was slipping back.

Around then I noticed the strange place I was standing. I had fled this city hoping it would fall. And now I was falling asleep every night counting the number of good things I'd seen that day. When that shift happened, I can't name an exact date. I just opened my eyes one day and found it had already happened.

That fact unsettled me. Lying awake at night I'd ask myself: do you want this city to live. The answer was different every time. Some nights, yes. Some nights, no. The most frightening nights were the ones when I couldn't answer at all.

For three years I had cultivated exactly one feeling: that the Reckoning deserved punishment. That feeling was simple, and because it was simple, it was strong. But in the two months I'd spent in this city, another feeling had begun growing alongside it. I carried both feelings at once. Both were real. If one of them had been a lie, it would have been easier.

Once I learned the baker's name, hating this city as a single mass grew harder and harder. But liking these people one by one didn't mean I had forgiven the city they'd washed into being. I didn't know how to hold the two apart.

The baker kept giving discounts on credit. Eventually she put up a sign about it outright. The market merchant, once he'd fixed all his own weights, started offering to check the neighboring stalls' as well. The girl who'd picked up the cane now traded morning greetings with that old man every day.

Small things. Small enough that the Scales would never once take notice.

. . .

The number on the board announcing the days remaining kept ticking down too. Thirty-nine, the first time I'd seen it. Now it was well past twenty and falling. People still glanced at the number every time they passed it. But their expressions had changed a little from before. At first everyone had looked at that number with fear. Now, sometimes — only sometimes — people looked at it with something more like endurance.

I had no way of explaining that difference to the Scales. Fear and endurance use the same muscles in the face. The Scales doesn't

measure faces. At first I couldn't tell the two apart either. Only seeing it day after day did it slowly become visible.

I found myself slowing down every time I passed the bakery now. Same at the market, same at the well. Two months ago I'd wanted to move through these streets as fast as possible. Now my pace slowed on its own.

At the time I thought that change of pace was just habit. I know now. It wasn't habit. It was attachment. I was growing fond of this city — the city I had decided to hate.

. . .

Trope had been quiet lately.

I noticed, but didn't press. Since my confession, I'd been busy sorting through my own affairs. What she'd said at the well — "I've never thought of it as a weight I could set down" — came back to me more than once, but something else always interrupted before I could ask her about it.

One evening I saw her standing at a Scales terminal. She hadn't raised her hand — just stood staring at the screen. Different from usual. Usually she raised her hand, checked the number, and turned away at once.

That day she stood there a long time.

I started toward her to call out, then stopped. Her shoulders looked stiff somehow. I felt something heavy coming off her back, but I couldn't put it into words.

I didn't call to her that day. Looking back, that was a mistake. At the time, I believed it was kindness — leaving someone alone who seemed to want to be alone. I'd made that same judgment three years before, outside a kitchen door. I still hadn't learned, at that point, that the judgment was wrong.

I decided that I'd go find her the next day and ask.

That night, before I fell asleep, I thought back to the day she'd first pulled me out of the water. "…You're not from here, are you?" The face she'd made asking that. It had been almost two months since then, and I realized how little I actually knew about her. Her mother had been driven out. She didn't resent the Scales. That was about all I had.

I understood, that night. I had only just barely learned how to tell my own story. I hadn't learned, at all, how to listen to someone else's. I didn't know, then, that I would be learning it the very next day.

Through the window, the number on the board announcing the days remaining glowed faintly in the dark. I watched it a long time before closing my eyes.

(Continued in Chapter 30.)

Chapter 30. Just Not For Me

> *_Previously_ — Small changes had begun appearing all over the city.*
> *The Scales' numbers hadn't moved. The Adjudicator said "the number*
> *and what it's worth aren't the same thing." Trope had gone quiet, and Pheugon had seen her standing a long time at a Scales terminal.*
> *He decided to ask her about it the next day.*

The next day I found her at the well.

The usual hour. She sat on the low stone wall, her water jar beside her. She hadn't started drawing water yet.

"…Trope."

She looked up. She started to smile at me, then the smile stopped halfway.

"…What is it."

"…Is something going on lately?"

Instead of answering, she ran her fingertips along the rim of the well.

"…Nothing."

I didn't believe that. Her face said she knew I didn't believe it, either.

Evening light rippled on the water in the well. The footsteps of people drawing water grew fainter and farther. Soon we were the only two left.

"…Trope." I called again. "Remember what you said, the day you noticed I'd been going in and out of the Adjudicator's office?"

"…What did I say?"

"'The face people make when they're thinking about something that doesn't show up on the Scales.'"

She laughed a little. "You remember that."

"You have that face right now."

Her laughter faded.

After a long while, she spoke again.

"…I won't ask what you heard in the Adjudicator's office," she said. "You'll say it when you want to say it. Instead, let me say something too. Trading."

I looked at her.

"…What."

"There's something I've been thinking about too, lately," she said. "I couldn't find where to put it into words."

. . .

I sat down beside her. We stayed that way a long while without speaking.

"…You stood at the Scales terminal a long time yesterday," I finally said. "I saw you."

Her hand stopped.

"…I was just standing there."

"…Without raising your hand."

She looked at me. It was a look that seemed to be measuring — how much she could say, how much I could bear.

"…Pheugon." She asked. "You've heard about the clause. From the Adjudicator."

I was startled. I'd never told her that.

"…How did you know?"

"In the square. I'm not the only one who's noticed the Adjudicator's window staying lit late these days. And—" she paused. "Your face has changed. Lately."

. . .

"I've known about that clause," she went on, "since I was little."

I looked at her.

"Everyone born in this city knows. By rumor. No one knows the exact content, but everyone knows there's a thing called the Forty-Day Clause, and that it's never once fired. Parents use it to scare children, too. 'If you don't behave, a clause like that will never move for you.'"

"…You grew up hearing that."

"Yes," she said. "I believed it. That if a city became good, it could be forgiven. But Pheugon, I—"

She looked straight at me.

"I've never once thought there was no god."

I had no answer for that. It wasn't the direction I'd expected.

. . .

"A lot of people misunderstand," she went on. "When I say I don't resent the Scales, they think I don't believe in something. That's not it. I believe it exists. Forgiveness, and whatever hands it down — I believe those exist."

"But."

"But." She looked down at the water jar. "I don't believe it reaches me."

Evening light rippled on the water.

"…What do you mean by that."

"The city can be forgiven," she said. "I believe that. What you've been counting lately, Pheugon — I know about that too. The bakery, the weights, the cane. I've seen it too. This city really is changing. I believe that's real."

"…But?"

"I'm not."

She said it very quietly. Not an angry voice. Not a sad voice, either. Just a voice stating a fact.

"There's forgiveness, I suppose," she said. "Just not for me."

. . .

I heard that sentence and couldn't say anything for a long time.

I wanted to argue with her then. But I couldn't find the argument. There was nothing logically wrong with what she'd said. That was what frightened me more. I didn't know how to defeat her words.

"…Why," I finally managed. "Why aren't you, Trope?"

"Remember my mother?" she asked.

"…Yes."

"My mother crossed the weight limit and was driven out. The Scales calculated it precisely. I don't doubt that. But there's something I want to know."

She looked at me.

"Do you know what my weight is?"

I didn't know.

"I know," she said. "I check every day. Other people check to feel reassured. I'm different. I check because I'm afraid the number might suddenly spike. Because I'm my mother's daughter. I think the limit she crossed might be in me too. Inherited. Everyone says the Scales doesn't measure by family. I can't bring myself to believe that."

"The Adjudicator says," I said, carefully, "that the Scales really doesn't measure by family. The records are kept entirely separate."

"I know that too," she said. "I know it in my head. The Adjudicator told me that himself. Several times. But knowing and believing are different. I know it and still can't believe it."

I turned that sentence over for a long time. Knowing and believing being different things. I knew the Scales was right, and knowing that had never once lessened my anger. She knew the Scales didn't measure by family, and knowing that had never once lessened her fear. Knowing didn't take the place of believing.

. . .

She stood up.

"…I'll show you," she said.

I followed her to a Scales terminal near the well. A small terminal standing in a corner of the square. She raised her hand. A number came up on the screen.

I looked at the number. Low. Much lower than I'd expected — well below the city's average.

"…It's low," I said.

"Yes." She lowered her hand. "It's low. Because I haven't done much wrong. But every time I look at this number, I see another number alongside it. One that isn't here."

"…What number."

"The number my mother crossed," she said, pointing at the screen with a fingertip. "It's not written on the Scales. Not anywhere on my screen. But I feel like it's layered behind this one. The number you can't see is scarier. At least a visible number, you can check."

I heard that and looked again at the small screen. Only one number really was showing there. The other number she spoke of was nowhere to be found. And yet, in that moment, I had the strange sensation of seeing it anyway.

We went back and sat at the well.

. . .

"I was born in this city," she went on. "I was born carrying this city's sin along with it. My mother's overflowed weight, this city's overflowed weight — I grew up inside that. It couldn't not have gotten onto me."

"…But if the city turns—"

"Then the city lives," she said. "I'd live inside it too. But that and me, personally, being forgiven are different things. The city living and me being all right are different problems."

That distinction felt foreign to me. And, at the same time, strangely exact.

"Five years ago," she went on, "the day my mother left, my grandfather took me and said something. 'You're not guilty. You just got left behind.' I know he meant it as comfort. But that was the first time I had a strange thought."

"…What thought."

"Someone with no sin doesn't need forgiveness," she said. "Forgiveness is for someone with sin. But I was told I had no sin, and at the same time I was living inside the results of that sin. I felt like there was no place for me between those two sentences. Not a sinner. Not someone to be forgiven, either. Just someone left behind."

I understood, in that moment, that she had carried that one fear every day since her mother was driven out three years before. I had carried one anger for three years. She had carried one fear for three years. We each held something different, and were exactly as heavy.

"What about you," she asked, suddenly. "Being angry versus being afraid — which is harder?"

I couldn't answer right away.

"…I don't know," I finally said. "I was on the angry side. The whole time. But anger at least has a direction. I know who I'm angry at. Listening to you, I think fear might not have a direction at all."

"That's right," she said. "Anger points at something. Fear just points at me."

. . .

"I know I'm strange," she said. "Everyone tells me 'you did nothing wrong.' That's true. I know it too. I never cheated with weights. Never stole anything. But that doesn't make me safe."

"…Why not."

"Because." She paused a moment. "I'm not afraid of something I did. I'm afraid of who I am. I'm the daughter of someone who went over the limit. That fact doesn't change no matter what I do."

I felt something shift, deep down, hearing that.

"Forgiveness," she went on. "For other people it seems to feel like a rule. Do this and you're forgiven, do that and you're not. Not for me. For me, forgiveness exists, and it leaves me out of it. Like everyone's in the room and I'm standing outside the door."

That image stayed with me a long time.

"…Who's in the room," I asked.

"Everyone," she said. "The baker. The weights man. The Adjudicator. You too. Everyone will eventually walk into that room. I get as far as the door. Every time. But I can't grab the handle."

"Why can't you."

"Because I don't know if my hand has the standing to grab it."

I started to say something, then stopped. It sounded too much like something I'd carried for three years myself. *I was a boy who took care not to lose his standing.* She was standing outside a door because she believed she had no standing. Same word, opposite direction.

"I have something similar," I said. "I spent three years guarding my standing. You spent three years believing you had none. But somehow we both ended up standing in the same place. Outside the door."

She looked at me for a long time.

"…No one's ever put it that way to me before," she said quietly.

. . .

I couldn't say anything. I had no comfort to offer. Like the Adjudicator had done for me, I didn't want to tell her it was all right either. I understood now how empty that would be.

"…Trope," I finally managed. "I don't know either. What I should say."

"It's all right," she said. And, for the first time, smiled a little. "I don't need anyone to say anything. Just being listened to is enough."

Hearing that, I thought of the Adjudicator. He had told me the exact same thing. Listening. That's all. That was the first time I truly understood the weight of that word. Listening wasn't nothing.

I turned her words over for a long time that night. Forgiveness exists, but not for her. I found that sentence strangely familiar. I

was angry knowing forgiveness existed. She was afraid knowing forgiveness existed. Neither of us had ever doubted forgiveness. Both of us believed it never reached our own place. I didn't want to hand that place to anyone else. She believed she couldn't fit into it. The directions were opposite. The place we were standing was the same.

"…Trope." I called again. "What if — hypothetically — I could trigger the clause. Would you be saved along with everyone else?"

She looked at me. A long time.

"The city," she said. "I live in it too. But Pheugon, that's the question that frightens me most. The city living and me living aren't the same sentence."

"…Why aren't they the same sentence."

"Because," she said. "The city exists as a number. What the Scales measures. But I, Pheugon — I'm not a number. I'm a person. And a person has things scarier than numbers."

I didn't fully understand the meaning of that, that night.

We didn't draw water that evening. We just sat there a long while, until the sun had sunk completely below the horizon.

"…I'll be here tomorrow too," she said again as we parted. The same words she'd said once before.

I didn't know the weight of those words then.

(Continued in Chapter 31.)

Chapter 31. The One Who Knows First

> *_Previously_ — Trope said what she truly believed for the first time. That the city could be forgiven, but she might not be. "There's forgiveness, I suppose. Just not for me." Pheugon found no*
> *argument against it. The two of them sat at the well until the sun went down.*

I saw the man again in a market alley.

I'd seen him a few times before — in the square, when someone was being unfairly ganged up on, while everyone else was getting angry, he was the one who didn't. I'd taken him for simply an odd man. This time was different.

At the mouth of the market, a woman was shouting. She'd kicked over a stall. The stall owner backed away, both hands raised.

"…I didn't steal it! Why would I steal it!"

"Who else would it be!" the woman shouted. "You were right next to my spot yesterday!"

People gathered. Some took the woman's side, some defended the stall owner. Voices rose.

I stopped as I was passing through. Two months ago I'd have walked right past a scene like this. Now I knew some of the faces in this alley a little. The stall owner had been trading here a long time; the shouting woman was a stranger to me.

The man was standing in the middle of it.

. . .

I'd sensed something strange about him from the first time I saw him. I couldn't have said exactly why. This time, up close, I understood.

His clothes weren't so different from anyone else's in this city. Nothing about him stood out. And yet the spot where he stood was strangely quiet. Right in the middle of the commotion, the noise seemed to drop a full tone around him.

He was looking at the woman. But something about the look was different. Everyone else looked at the stall owner with suspicion. He was looking at the woman.

"…Is something the matter," he asked her.

His voice wasn't loud. And yet it carried clearly through the commotion.

The woman turned toward him.

"…Who are you."

"You're angry about the missing goods," he said. "But that's not all of it, I don't think."

The woman's face flickered.

"…What are you talking about."

"You lost something else yesterday too," he said quietly. "Not goods."

. . .

A chill went down my spine.

The woman stood there, unable to speak. A few seconds later, tears welled in her eyes. The face that had been shouting a moment ago turned into a completely different face.

I hadn't heard anything at that spot. I had no idea what he knew, to say something like that. But the woman understood. She sank down right where she stood and began quietly crying.

The stall owner stood there, still not understanding what had happened. The crowd drifted off, one and two at a time. What could have become a fight ended, just like that.

In that moment, I thought of the Scales. The Scales doesn't know what that woman lost. It only measures what converts to weight. It could weigh the price of stolen goods, but whatever she'd lost the day before wasn't among the Scales' categories. And yet he knew.

. . .

He walked over to the stall owner afterward.

The man was still standing there, looking wronged. The other man stopped in front of him for a moment.

"…You're startled," he said.

"…I really didn't steal it," the stall owner said. His voice shook.

"I know," he said. "That you didn't steal it."

"…How do you know?"

"That sack under your stall." He pointed under the stall. "You bought it from someone else this morning. Paid for it in full."

The stall owner's eyes went wide. I had no idea what that sack was. Neither did the stall owner ask how he'd known. He just nodded. His face looked relieved.

I felt two things at once, in that moment. One was astonishment. He was as precise as the Scales. Precise, but used entirely differently. The Scales would have used that precision to expose a crime. He used it to prove there wasn't one.

The other was fear. If he could know that precisely, there must be something inside me he'd already read too. It was the first time I wanted to shrink away from someone.

. . .

I followed him.

From a distance. He left the market and turned into a back alley. His pace was unhurried. No trace of being in a rush at all.

I stopped him.

"…Excuse me."

He turned. His face was hard to place an age on. Young in one light, somewhere ancient in another.

"…Yes."

"What did you say to that woman just now? How did you know?"

He looked at me a moment, then smiled.

"I didn't know," he said. "I guessed."

"You guess that precisely?"

"I don't know what else to call it," he said. "I just tend to watch people for a long time."

I found the answer strange. It didn't sound like an answer at all.

We walked side by side after that. The alley was narrow, in shade. Laundry hung overhead. As we walked, he occasionally met the eyes of someone passing — not quite a greeting, not quite not one. Just a look that said he recognized them.

I found that strange too. I'd lived in this city almost two months and still didn't recognize most people passing me on the street. He claimed not to be from here, and yet he seemed to recognize nearly everyone.

. . .

"…You could've been angry at her," I said. "Shouting, kicking over the stall. That was rude."

"It was," he said.

"So why didn't you get angry?"

He thought about that for a moment.

"No reason to," he said.

"You just got treated rudely."

"That woman was rude, that's true," he said. "But I also know why she did it. Once you know why, it's hard to stay angry."

I wanted to push back at that. I couldn't find the argument.

That was the first time I truly thought this man was strange. The first time I'd seen him, in the square, I'd just thought he was odd for not getting angry. This time was different. He wasn't holding his anger back. He wasn't angry at all. Those were two entirely different things.

"There's someone I know," I said, "who did something bad to my family. I found myself getting angrier at him the more I got to know him. The more I understood why he did it."

"That can happen," he said. He didn't deny it.

"But you're the opposite. The more you understand, the less angry you get. Why is that different from me?"

He stopped walking and looked straight at me.

"What you know is why that person did it," he said. "I know one more thing than that."

"…What."

"Where that person is right now," he said. "Knowing why someone did something, and knowing which way they're walking, right now, this instant — those are different things. Understanding the reason can

make you angrier. But knowing the direction turns the anger into something else."

I half understood.

"…What does it turn into?"

"That's something you'll have to find out yourself, I think," he smiled. "I'm not the one who gives answers."

. . .

"…If I wanted to know that woman's weight," I asked, "I could just ask the Scales, couldn't I? Why watch people that long?"

"The Scales tells you what that woman did," he said. "It doesn't tell you what she's going through right now."

"What's the difference?"

"What was done is the past," he said. "What's being gone through is the present. The Scales is a machine that measures the past. Not a machine that measures the present."

I turned that over. It resembled what the Adjudicator had told me. That the Scales can't measure direction. But this man seemed to know something even more precise than direction.

"…Are you," I asked, carefully, "from this city, by any chance?"

"No," he said.

"Then where are you from?"

He smiled instead of answering. A smile that deflected the question.

. . .

"…Someone I know," I said, suddenly. "Her weight is low, and she's still constantly afraid. She believes she inherited something. Can you guess her weight too?"

He looked at me. Something in that look made me freeze up for a moment. As if he already knew her.

"That person doesn't believe she inherited something," he said quietly. "She believes that's all she'll ever be."

I lost my breath. I had never told him Trope's name.

"…How did you—"

"I told you, I guess," he said, smiling again. But the smile was a little different this time.

"…Have you ever met her?" I asked.

"Hard to say," he said. Not an answer.

"If you'd met her, you'd know. How convinced she is. Words won't change that. I've tried."

"It's not going to be changed by words," he said. "I know that too."

"Then what does change it?"

He didn't answer. Instead he looked at me for a long time. There was something in that look I couldn't read yet.

"Tell her this," he said. "That she's not the only one who can see what the Scales can't."

"That's it?"

"That's it," he said. "For now."

That last word bothered me strangely. *For now.* It sounded as if there were more, later. I didn't ask when that later was.

. . .

"…What's your name?" I asked, right before we parted.

He answered without stopping.

"Just a man passing through."

"Everyone has a name."

"Not everyone," he said. "Some people just haven't started using theirs yet."

I didn't understand that answer either. He walked off toward the end of the alley and disappeared.

. . .

I went to find Trope that evening and told her what happened.

"He said I'm not the only one who can see what the Scales can't?" Trope repeated. "What does that mean?"

"I don't know," I said. "But he knew exactly what you'd told me, without ever having met you. And I never said your name to him."

Trope's face turned complicated.

"…That's frightening," she said.

"It scared me too, at first."

"And now?"

I thought a moment.

"…I don't know," I said. "It's frightening, and at the same time there's something else there too. That he knew me that precisely and still didn't get angry. I keep coming back to that."

Trope listened and said nothing. She just looked off into the distance.

"…I'd like to meet him sometime too," she finally said. "But it scares me."

"Me too."

We didn't talk about it any more that night. As we parted, she looked at my face a little longer than usual. Like there was something more she wanted to ask, and was holding back.

. . .

That night before sleep, I made a strange decision.

I wanted to confirm whether he really was a man who never got angry. Words hadn't been able to confirm it. He'd already had two chances to get angry and hadn't. I wanted to test him a third time — not by chance, this time, but in a place I made myself.

Even then I dimly knew it wasn't a good idea. But I'd lived three years as someone who held his anger back. What it felt like to hold anger back, rather than simply not have it — I knew that better than anyone. I wanted to know whether he was truly a man with no anger, or just a man holding his back, like me.

That night I thought about him for a long time. He knew people before the Scales did, more precisely than the Scales did. And that knowledge went in a strange direction. The more precisely the Scales knew, the heavier its sentence grew. The more precisely he knew, the lighter he treated people. I couldn't understand that opposite direction.

I had lived believing precision moved opposite to forgiveness. The Scales was my proof. Know more precisely, and the sin becomes clearer; the clearer the sin, the heavier the sentence. But this man, knowing more precisely, saw not the sin but the person. I didn't know where I could learn that difference.

I mulled over whether I should tell the Adjudicator about this. Then decided against it. Even asking, I doubted he'd know the answer. This man seemed to belong to no one, not even inside this city.

From that day on, I put him at the top of a list of strange people. There were no other names on that list. I found myself waiting for the day I'd meet him a second time. Why I was waiting, I didn't know then.

Right before sleep, I thought once more of that woman's face. Shouting, then sinking down and crying. That was the first time I saw what face is left when anger collapses. I never did hear what she had lost. But the face stayed with me a long time.

I tried to hold that face up against my own. If my own anger collapsed, what would be underneath. That night I wasn't ready to answer that question at all.

(Continued in Chapter 32.)

Chapter 32. Provocation

> *_Previously_ — Pheugon met the man again. He knew people more precisely than the Scales, before the Scales did, and still never got angry. He'd even pinpointed Trope's fear exactly, though Pheugon had never told him her name. That night Pheugon decided to*
> *test him directly.*

I found him again two days later.

It wasn't hard. He walked near the market around the same time every day. I waited for him at the mouth of an alley.

"…We meet again," he said, seeing me first. No sign of surprise.

"…I've been waiting."

"I know," he said.

That answer alone shook me a little. I tried to hold on to what I'd rehearsed.

Looking back now, I was already shaking before the test even began. When the one who comes to test gets shaken before the testing starts, that means the test itself was badly designed from the outset.

I'd rehearsed this conversation in my head, the night before, more than once. What to open with, how to push, where he'd break. I was a herald. I'd spent three years training to handle words precisely in

front of people. And I was about to use that training, for the first time, for something other than good.

I walked alongside him. He was in no hurry. That unhurried pace only irritated me more.

The sky was overcast. It looked like it might rain, or might not. We were alone in the alley. I thought that was for the best. I didn't want anyone else to hear what I was about to say.

. . .

"…Sir." I said. "Last time, you said you knew what that woman had lost."

"I did."

"I've lost something too. Guess it."

He looked at me a moment.

"…Shall I try," he said.

"My family," he said. "More precisely, the reason it fell apart. You still only know half of that reason. You don't even know where the other half is."

I lost my words for a moment. It was something I hadn't even told the Adjudicator in full.

I didn't want to admit I was surprised, in that moment. My rehearsed script hadn't accounted for me being surprised.

"…That's right," was all I managed.

. . .

"Then," I asked again, "do you know where that person is right now?"

"Who."

"The person who wrecked my family."

He fell silent at the question for a moment.

"Don't know," he said. "That, I don't know."

"You're not lying?"

"No."

I didn't like that answer. I wanted to believe he knew everything. That was the only way my next question would work.

"…You're on the side of this city's people, aren't you," I said. A deliberately sharpened remark. "Not getting angry, forgiving everyone — that's all a fine story. But that fine story only works for some people. Go say it to Trope. Do you think it'd comfort her?"

"Trope isn't looking for comfort," he said. No change in his voice.

"Then what is she looking for."

"Same as you," he said. "Someone to be angry in her place."

I lost my words for a second at that.

"…What do you mean by that."

"You've been hating the Reckoning on your family's behalf," he said. "The anger your family couldn't raise themselves, you're raising it for them. Trope is similar. Only the direction's reversed. You do it by hating someone else. Trope does it by hating herself."

I wanted to argue with that, and no words came. He was too precise. That precision, I learned that day, could render a person entirely helpless.

. . .

"Then," I said. "If you're that precise. This city's people who stole weights, cheated on rations — you'd know all of it. Name them, one by one."

"Why."

"I'm curious," I said. My voice was already sharpening.

. . .

"Those are things the Scales already knows," he said. "No need for me to say them again."

"Then tell me what the Scales doesn't know," I pushed. "This city's people, all pretending to be good on the outside while still hoping, inside, for the Reckoning to fall. There must be people like that. Name them."

He looked at me a long moment at that.

"There is one," he said quietly.

My heart leapt.

"…Who."

"You."

. . .

I fell apart completely, in that moment.

I hadn't prepared for that answer. I'd expected him to name someone else. That he would point at me — I hadn't thought of that. Or maybe I had thought of it. I just hadn't expected he'd say it so precisely, so quietly.

"…What would you know." My voice shook. "I want this city to live, these days. I've been counting it, every day. How the city is changing."

"You're counting," he said. "But counting and wanting are different. You're still half and half. The part that wants it to live, and the part that once wanted it to fall. Both are still in you."

"…That's not true."

"No?" He looked straight at me. "Then why did you just ask me for someone else's name. You're still hunting for a guilty party inside this city. So that there'd still be proof this city deserves to fall."

I had no answer for that. It was exact. He'd said what even I hadn't known about myself, before I did.

. . .

"…Doesn't that make you angry?" I asked. My voice cracked. "I was just rude to you. I did it on purpose to test you. Doesn't that make you angry?"

He looked at me quietly at that question.

"No," he said.

"Why not! I did it on purpose! I was trying to make you angry!"

"I know," he said. "I knew that too."

"And still?"

"And still," he said. No change in his voice.

In that moment I understood what I'd wanted. I'd wanted him to get angry. I'd wanted him to break, the way I did. If he broke, I could have felt at ease. If it were proven impossible not to get angry, then what I'd endured for three years could be called an ordinary weight, the same as everyone else's.

He didn't break.

. . .

I pushed harder.

"…You've never lost anything, have you," I said. I wasn't choosing my words anymore. "That's why you can talk about forgiveness so calmly. Someone who's actually lost something couldn't talk like that."

At that, he closed his eyes for just a moment, then opened them.

I still remember that instant. It was a flicker. Brief, but I saw it clearly. But it wasn't anger. I didn't know the difference then.

"…I've lost something," he said quietly.

"What."

He didn't answer. I saw the silence as a chance to press harder.

"Not lying? Prove it. Say what you lost. If you can't say it, it was just something you said for effect."

"There's a difference between what can be said and what should be said," he said. "This isn't something to tell you right now."

"There you go dodging again."

"I'm not dodging."

"You are!" I shouted it. My voice echoed through the alley. A few passersby turned to look.

. . .

"…Why don't you get angry?" I finally shouted.

The alley went quiet. A few people passing by turned to look. I had no room to care.

"Why!" I said again. "I get angry. I know how hard it is, three years, holding anger back. And you just don't, without even looking

like it costs you anything. Is that even possible? Can a person be like that?"

He waited for my voice to settle.

"The reason I don't get angry," he said quietly, "isn't that I have more patience than you do."

"Then what?"

"I know where you're standing, right now," he said. "And I know which way you're walking, too. See those two things together, and there's not much room left for anger."

"…What does that mean."

"You came here today to make me angry," he said. "That's hatred. But underneath that hatred, what you really wanted was to see someone who didn't collapse before you did. So you could believe you might not have to collapse either."

. . .

I felt entirely stripped bare in front of that sentence.

That was the first day I learned it. I hadn't gotten angry because he didn't get angry. I'd gotten angry at what I saw in myself. He was only standing there like a mirror.

I stood there and couldn't say anything. My breath came short. My eyes stung, and I couldn't tell if it was anger or something else.

"…What are you," I finally said. "What are you, really. Are you even a person?"

At that question, his expression shifted, for the first time, into something different. Something between sorrow and gladness.

"That question," he said, "isn't one to answer right now."

"Then when?"

"When you're less angry than you are now."

He turned and walked away. I watched his back for a long time. I didn't follow. I had no strength left to follow. Raindrops began falling one by one in the alley.

. . .

I stood alone in that alley for a long while.

I'd gone to break him, and I came back broken. I was ashamed of that. And at the same time there was something strangely light about it. For three years I'd lived proving I could hold my anger back. That day, for the first time, someone had seen through the fact that I couldn't. And the world didn't end when I was caught.

I felt something like what I'd felt confessing to the Adjudicator. I had expected something to fix itself then too, and been disappointed. This time I expected nothing. And still, something, just barely, sat a little differently.

Walking home, I ran into Trope. She looked at my face and started to ask something, then stopped.

"…Something happen?"

"…Yes," I said. "I lost completely today."

"To who?"

"Him. The one I told you about."

"…What did you do?"

I couldn't answer right away.

"…I tested him," I finally said. "Tried to make him angry. On purpose."

Trope stopped walking.

"…And?"

"He didn't," I said. "The whole time. Even after everything I threw at him."

"…Then you didn't lose. He didn't get angry — that's not you losing."

"I lost," I said. "I went to break him, and I got everything I'm holding onto exposed instead. If that's not losing, what is."

Trope heard that and said nothing more. She just walked beside me, step for step.

. . .

I saw the Adjudicator the next day.

He seemed to notice something the moment he saw my face.

"…Something happen?"

"…I met him," I said. "The man who doesn't get angry."

"Ah." The Adjudicator said it briefly. No surprise on his face.

"You know him too, Adjudicator?"

"I've seen him a few times," he said. "Thirty-one years in this city, and you meet a handful of people you can't explain."

"What is he, exactly?"

The Adjudicator didn't answer. He just looked at me quietly instead.

"You wanted to make him angry."

I couldn't answer that.

"I don't even need to ask why you did it," he said. "It's written all over your face."

"…What's written there."

"The face of someone who lost." He said it without smiling. It wasn't a taunt either. "But not a bad kind of losing. There's a way to lose like that."

I turned that over for a long time.

The Adjudicator went back to his papers. But he held the pen a long while without writing anything. I could feel that he had something more he wanted to say, and was holding it back. I didn't ask.

. . .

I never tried to test him again after that day. There was no need to. I already knew the answer. He wasn't a man holding his anger back. He was a man who simply didn't get angry. I had to live it in my own body to finally believe the difference.

But knowing that didn't make me more comfortable. If anything, it made me more uncomfortable. For three years I'd believed that holding anger back was a virtue. The moment I saw that a man who truly didn't get angry actually existed, I understood that everything I'd done was not virtue but simple endurance. The distance between endurance and genuinely not getting angry was far greater than I'd ever imagined.

I didn't know then how to cross that distance. I still don't fully know now. But knowing the distance existed at all was enough to make me a different person than I'd been before that day.

At the well, when I saw Trope again, she looked at my face for a long while and then said briefly:

"…I'll be here tomorrow too."

I was hearing that for the third time now. I still didn't fully take the weight of it in. I watched her back, water jar on her shoulder, until the dark swallowed it whole.

(Continued in Chapter 33.)

Chapter 33. The Substitute

> *_Previously_ — Pheugon deliberately provoked the man who doesn't get*
> *angry. He never broke, and Pheugon broke instead. The Adjudicator*
> *said "there's a way to lose like that." Pheugon, for the first time, admitted the distance between his own endurance and the man's true absence of anger.*

I heard the news in the Adjudicator's office.

"He's arrived," the Adjudicator said. He slid a paper across to me.

I looked at it. An arrival report. Name, herald office of origin, date of arrival. I scanned the name. Unfamiliar.

"…Already?"

"He said a week," the Adjudicator said. "It's been exactly a week."

I found that precision strangely frightening.

. . .

"Where is he, now?"

"Herald office lodgings," the Adjudicator said. "He came to pay his respects the moment he arrived. As procedure requires."

"You met him?"

"Yes."

"…What's he like?"

The Adjudicator thought a moment.

"He reminds me of you, three years ago," he said. "Precise. Steady. Very well trained."

That sentence lodged in my chest.

"…Does he know about me? About the clause?"

"No," the Adjudicator said. "I didn't tell him. No reason to. He came because he was assigned. A city-wide case. Reading the forty-day grace sentence. That's all."

"…He doesn't even know about the clause?"

"The clause gets summarized onto the sentence document. He'll know that much. But not the original text. I'm the only one who has it."

. . .

I wanted to meet him myself.

The next afternoon, I went to the herald office lodgings. I knocked and the door opened right away. Like he'd been waiting.

"…Hello," I said.

He looked at me. He seemed a year or two older than me. His posture was straight. He wore the herald office uniform, pressed sharp.

"…Who are you," he asked.

"…I'm Pheugon." I hesitated, then added, "I've been staying in this city a while."

"Ah." He nodded. "Not from this city, either?"

"…No."

"Neither am I," he said. "Fellow sufferers, then."

I nearly laughed at that. I didn't.

. . .

He let me into the room. It was tidy. Almost no belongings. A few sheets of paper lay squared off on the desk. I recognized one of them as the Reckoning's sentence document.

"…Have you read it?" I asked.

"Of course," he said. "It's the document I'm going to proclaim."

"…How did it feel? Reading it."

He looked a little puzzled at the question.

"How did what feel?"

"…It's a hundred and twenty thousand people."

"That's right," he said. "The biggest case I've heard of. Among the ones I've been assigned, anyway."

"…Aren't you scared?"

He thought about that for a moment.

"Fear and what I have to do are separate things," he said. "I read. Precisely. That's my job."

I felt like I'd heard that sentence somewhere before. It was almost word for word what my supervisor had once told me. In that moment I felt like I was standing face to face with myself, three years ago.

. . .

"…How much do you know about this city?" I asked.

"As much as I need to," he said. "Population, accumulated weight, the breakdown of violations. I've memorized all of it."

"…And the people? Have you met any?"

"Not many yet," he said. "I bought bread from the bakery, talked to the lodging manager. That's about it."

"…Why not more?"

"No need to," he said. "I didn't come here to get close to the people of this city. I came to read the sentence. On the fortieth day."

I wanted to argue with that. I didn't know what to say.

In that moment I wanted to tell him he was wrong. But he wasn't wrong. That was exactly the way I'd been taught, three years before. Don't meet people, so you don't stop reading. That was the core of the training.

. . .

"…Have you heard," I asked, carefully, "about the clause? The Forty-Day Clause."

"I've heard of it," he said. "It's attached to the sentence document. The clause that voids the sentence if the city is confirmed to have turned within forty days."

"Do you know who does the confirming?"

"It says the one who read performs it," he said. Matter-of-fact. "If I read it, I suppose it would be me."

I lost my breath for a moment.

"…How would you know if this city really turned?"

"I wouldn't," he said. Very honest. "I don't know this city. But that's not my job. For the clause to fire, I'd need to confirm it, and if I have no basis to confirm it, then I simply can't confirm it. I just read, and judge things as I find them."

"…So it wouldn't fire."

"Probably not," he said. Not indifferent — just stating a fact. "If I had some attachment to this city, I might see it differently. But I have no reason to. This city, to me, is a number."

. . .

I stood there a long while after hearing that.

In that moment I didn't think this man was bad. He'd done nothing wrong. He was simply working precisely, exactly as he'd been trained. The problem wasn't that. The problem was that the more precisely he worked, the more certainly this city would die.

"…If it's not too forward," he said, "may I ask why you're asking about this."

I wasn't ready with an answer.

"…No reason," I said. "Just curious."

He seemed to find the answer strange, but didn't press.

"…How many days left, now?" he asked, straightening his papers.

I did the math. "…Six."

"Six," he repeated. Then briefly counted something off with a finger. A finger counting dates. "Plenty of time to prepare, then."

"…Prepare?"

"Voice practice," he said. "A case this size means a long reading. I need to decide in advance how many times I'll need water, mid-read."

I couldn't answer. He was already standing there, calculating how many breaths he'd take in front of a hundred and twenty thousand people.

He straightened his papers into a neat pile and saw me out. At the door, he added one more line.

"…It was good to meet you, Pheugon."

I knew that greeting was sincere. That made it weigh on me more, strangely.

. . .

As I left the lodgings, a familiar face was waiting at the bottom of the stairs. The baker. She had something in her hand.

"…Herald, sir," she said. Her voice was careful. "Have this. You must have come a long way."

What she held out was a loaf of bread, wrapped in cloth, still steaming.

He took it. With both hands, at a precise angle.

"…Thank you," he said. "What's the cost?"

The baker's face stiffened slightly.

"…It's a gift."

"Ah." He paused a moment, then said, "Thank you. I'll pay next time."

The baker started to say something else, then just bowed her head and turned away.

I stood there and watched the scene for a long time. He hadn't been rude. He'd been perfectly courteous. And yet something was missing. I

only understood, much later, what it was. He couldn't tell a gift from a purchase. No — he could tell the difference. He just felt no difference between them at all. To the Scales, both weighed the same.

I had been like that too. Just like erasing what the merchant said, that first proclamation. I hadn't known, then, what I was erasing. What this man was failing to receive now — he probably didn't know that either.

. . .

I went to the room of records that afternoon.

I needed no excuse. The room was open to anyone. I stood hidden among the shelves and watched him.

He was already there. Opening the precedent drawers one at a time, copying something out. His fingertip moved along the pages at a steady pace. It never stopped.

The scene felt familiar. Two months ago, I too had sat in that same seat, opening those same drawers. Until I found Mena's record, I'd sat there for days.

I'd been searching for something, then. A crack that could bring the Scales down. What was he searching for now. I was curious. But I didn't go over and ask. Asking would mean explaining why I was even here.

He stayed in that seat over an hour. I watched him reach Mena's entry. His fingertip stopped on that page. Just for an instant.

I held my breath in that moment. Afraid he'd notice — the misquoted sentence, the wrong word, "never repented." I wanted him to catch on it. No — I didn't want that. I didn't even know what I wanted.

He turned the page.

He didn't stop.

In that moment I understood. He wasn't the kind of person who'd catch on that sentence, the way I had. I only realized then that I'd caught it because I'd lived two months in this city. No one catches it from the words alone. You have to have lived it to catch it.

I stood there until he'd finished tidying the drawers and left the room. He never saw me.

. . .

That evening I found Trope at the well.

I sat beside her as she drew water and brought it up.

"…I met the substitute herald."

Trope's hand stopped.

"…What's he like?"

I thought for a moment how to explain it.

"…He's like me," I finally said. "Me, three years ago."

"What does that mean?"

"He doesn't know this city," I said. "Doesn't even try to. He just sees numbers. Population, weight, violation breakdown. He's memorized all of it. But he doesn't know the baker's name. Doesn't know yours, either."

Trope heard that and looked down at the water jar.

"…If he reads it," she asked, "the clause won't fire. Right?"

I couldn't answer. There was no need to. She'd already known the answer when she asked.

"…Six days left, they're saying." She said. I was surprised she already knew that too. "The baker's wife told me today at noon."

Word travels faster than I do. I hadn't known that.

We didn't say anything for a long while. Evening light rippled on the water in the well.

"…Pheugon," she finally said. "Not about him — can I ask about you?"

"…What."

"Are you going to read it?"

I couldn't answer right away.

"…I don't know," I said, after a long while. It wasn't a lie. I truly didn't know.

Trope nodded. She didn't ask further. It wasn't like her to hold back. Usually she'd have pressed once more. This time she didn't.

She filled her jar and stood. Before turning to go, she looked at me once more. She started to say something, then didn't.

I watched her back a long time. That evening, strangely, the water jar on her shoulder looked unusually heavy.

. . .

Walking home, I kept thinking of that room.

The tidy room, the squared-off papers, the unwavering voice. That was the shape I'd built myself over three years. I'd been proud of that shape. Facing it now like a mirror, I felt for the first time how dangerous a shape it was.

He doesn't hate this city. Doesn't love it either. He simply doesn't know it. And that not-knowing was, with perfect precision, blocking off the only chance this city had to live. I understood that day, for the first time, that there was something more frightening than hatred. It wasn't indifference. It was trained ignorance, precisely made.

Six days.

I counted the number off on my fingers. In six days two people would stand in the square. Me, who hated this city. And him, who didn't know it.

I understood precisely, for the first time, that night. That I was the only person in the world who could save this city. That fact didn't excite me. It crushed me.

Before sleep, I thought again of the papers laid out in his room. The squared corners, the unwavering handwriting. I too had lived like that for three years. Keeping the papers straight. Never letting feeling mix into the paperwork. I'd been taught that was precision.

That night, for the first time, I thought about how that precision split into two. One was the Scales' precision. The precision of measuring weight, the precision of measuring the past. The other was a person's precision. When a person tries to be precise, all he can do is imitate the Scales. For three years, I'd been doing that imitation. He was doing it now too. The only difference was that I now knew what that imitation erased.

I lay awake a long time that night. Through the window I could see the lights of the herald office lodgings. A light that seemed like it would come on at the exact hour and go off at the exact hour.

Watching that light, I thought of my own room, three years ago. I used to light my lamp like that too. At the exact hour. And put it out at the exact hour. At the time I thought that was diligence. I know now. It was fear. If I left an hour unaccounted for, I was afraid something would slip in through it.

That friend was probably living inside that same fear right now, without knowing it. I knew it wasn't his fault. And still, standing in front of the fact that his fear could end this whole city, there was nothing I could do about it.

(Continued in Chapter 34.)

Chapter 34. Five Days

> *_Previously_ — The substitute herald arrived. Precise and trained, exactly as instructed, with no feeling in it. If he — who knew nothing of this city — read the sentence in Pheugon's place, the clause would never fire. For the first time, Pheugon felt the full weight of being the only person in the world who could save this city.*

Four days ago it had been six.

This morning, the number on the square's board had changed to five.

I stood in front of it and looked at the number a long time. Five. I counted it off on my fingers. Thumb, index, middle, ring, little. When all five fingers folded down, that would be the day.

I was still counting, even then. Counting wasn't so much a habit as a method. I'd learned, three years ago, that turning something frightening into a number made it a little more bearable. That was why I'd counted a hundred and twelve cases too. Count people, and it's heavy. Count numbers, and it's light.

I tried the same method that day. Five. Just a written number. Fi. Ve. Two syllables. I even counted the syllables. It didn't help at all.

This time was different. No matter how many times I folded it into my fingers, the number five wouldn't get lighter.

. . .

The habit of counting had started at age ten.

I only remembered that after washing up in this city. Our house had eleven stairs. I used to count them, climbing up and down every evening. I don't remember why I'd started. I just found myself doing it, one day.

I hadn't known, then, what I was afraid of. I know now. I was counting how many people sat at our dinner table each night. Four. Then one day three. Then one day one. I told myself I was counting stairs. I was really counting that table.

I never broke the habit, even in training. My supervisor called it concentration. I know now it wasn't concentration. It was defense. Numbers let me step slightly sideways out of the present. When the present was too heavy, numbers became a handle.

That morning, I reached for that handle again. Five. Five fingers. This time the handle wouldn't catch. The number didn't let me step sideways. Instead it set me squarely, facing forward, right in that spot.

. . .

I spent the whole day doing arithmetic.

The first calculation was easy. If I did nothing, that man would stand in the square in five days. He would read the sentence document from beginning to end. Precisely. Without wavering. And having read all the way to Article 4, Clause 11, he would confirm nothing. He didn't know this city. There was nothing for him to confirm.

The demolition would execute as scheduled.

A hundred and twenty thousand.

I remembered the moment I'd first heard that number, in the supervisor's office. I'd thought then it was a number I'd never counted. It was different now. Now I had faces held inside that hundred and twenty thousand. The baker. The merchant fixing his weights. The girl who'd picked up the cane. Trope.

Once a face exists, a number stops being a number. I learned that over forty days. I learned things I hadn't wanted to learn.

The second calculation was more complicated. If I stepped forward.

I would stand in the square and read the sentence document. From beginning to end. And having read the last line, I would have to say this: "This city has turned." Then the clause would fire. The demolition would be void. A hundred and twenty thousand would live.

But the one saying that sentence would be me.

I, who had spent three years living to hate this city, would have to speak, with my own mouth, the final sentence that saved it.

I ran that calculation over and over. The answer came out the same every time. And still I couldn't believe the answer. That the answer was correct, and that I could act on the answer, were different matters.

. . .

I went to see the Adjudicator that afternoon.

"…Adjudicator."

"Yes." He didn't look up from his papers.

"If I do nothing. If he reads it instead."

"Then it's demolished," he said. His voice was calm. "You already know that."

"…So what am I supposed to do?"

The Adjudicator finally raised his head.

"I won't answer that question," he said. "I told you before. The decision is yours. I'm not going to tell you to do it, or not to."

"…Why not." I asked. My voice cracked. "You've waited forty years for this clause, Adjudicator. Surely you'd want to tell me to do it."

The Adjudicator closed his eyes briefly, then opened them.

"…That's true," he said quietly. "I've waited forty years. But that's not a reason for me to tell you anything. The opposite, actually. Because I've waited so long, I'm most afraid of my own wish getting mixed into your decision."

I found that answer strangely honest.

"What you have to confirm," he said, "is whether this city has turned. Not whether I want it to. If I persuade you into this, the confirmation stops being a pure confirmation. It becomes a confirmation with my wish mixed in."

"…What difference does that make? I'm the one making the decision either way."

"It makes a difference," he said. "There's a difference between saying what you yourself have seen, and saying something for someone else's sake. The clause doesn't want the second. The clause wants what you saw."

I turned that over for a long time.

. . .

That evening I stopped at the well. Trope was in her usual spot.

"…Why the face," she asked.

"…Doing arithmetic," I said.

"What kind?"

I wanted to tell her everything. The left column and the right column. A hundred and twenty thousand against family. But the words wouldn't come.

"…I think it would make it harder for you, if I told you," I finally said.

She smiled a little at that. A sad smile.

"…I have arithmetic like that too," she said. "I haven't told you."

I looked at her.

"…What kind?"

"Later," she said, lifting her jar. "I don't have an answer yet either."

I let that pass, at the time. I was too deep inside my own arithmetic. Looking back, she'd already handed me a hint that day. I didn't take it.

We didn't say much more and parted. As we did, she said her usual line.

"…I'll be here tomorrow too."

Hearing it, I thought for the first time that it sounded like a promise. I couldn't have said, then, why it sounded that way.

. . .

That night I started calculating again at home.

I believed calculation would save me. It had, for three years. Weigh the case, count the total, count the dates — do that, and somehow an answer would come. That night, for the first time, I sat before a problem that wouldn't resolve.

I decided to write it down on paper. On the left, reasons to stay still. On the right, reasons to step forward.

On the left, I wrote:

Someone from this city wrecked our home. The Scales calculated it. Precisely. And nothing came back. My brother didn't return. My mother didn't return. My father still lives alone on the other side of the city.

I survived three years on that one anger. If I step forward and save this city, where do I put that anger down?

On the right, I wrote:

The baker. I still don't know her name. She held my hand with flour-dusted fingers.

The merchant fixing his weights. No one told him to. He was setting it right on his own.

Trope. Lost her mother. Doesn't resent the Scales. Believes she has no standing to be forgiven, and still comes to the well every day.

A hundred and twenty thousand.

I looked at that paper for a long time.

The left column was one line. The right column had many lines. But I knew that wasn't the answer. Having more lines didn't mean winning. That one line on the left was a line I'd guarded three years to protect. The lines on the right had formed in two months. Counted by time, the left should win. But I knew that method of counting itself was wrong.

I tried calculating another way. In the hundred and twelve cases I'd read, I'd never saved anyone. I'd only read. I'd only made audible a verdict the Scales had already reached. The hundred and thirteenth was different. The hundred and thirteenth, one sentence from my own mouth could save a hundred and twenty thousand, or leave them to die.

A hundred and twelve to one. I wrote that ratio on the paper, then crossed it out. Numbers made no meaning here. Some arithmetic can't be solved by ratio. That night I learned that a second time.

I thought of my brother. The winter he left, I'd calculated how many days it would be before he came back. Three days. A week. A month. I

counted that way and waited. He never came back. That calculation still sat unanswered, three years on.

That night I laid the two calculations side by side for the first time. The calculation of when my brother would return, and the calculation of when the Reckoning would fall. Both were numbers I couldn't control. But one I was allowed to let go of, and the other I wasn't. I wanted to know where that difference came from.

. . .

That night I sat for a long while, studying my own hand.

Through a hundred and twelve readings, this hand had never once shaken. It shook for the first time in front of the Adjudicator. That day I thought the shaking was the shaking of someone caught. Tonight this hand was shaking for a different reason. I still hadn't found a name for what kind of shaking it was.

I thought again about the number five. Five days. A hundred and twenty hours. Seven thousand two hundred minutes.

I broke the time down finer, thinking it would feel a little less frightening. It didn't. Seven thousand two hundred was a far bigger, far more frightening number than five. That was the night I first admitted that counting couldn't save me.

I folded the paper and put it in the drawer. It wasn't a finished calculation. It was just one I could no longer continue.

. . .

I lay down, and kept counting even lying there.

That night I ran one more strange calculation. If I did nothing, I would end up someone who had, at last, kept that one sentence I'd guarded for three years. Just as the Reckoning had given me nothing back, I too would give the Reckoning nothing back. That calculation was clean. A debt not repaid. Just end it there.

But there was a strange hole in that calculation. Not repaying a debt, and making the debtor's children repay it in your place, were different things. One person from the Reckoning had wrecked our home. I had something owed to me by that man. But if I didn't step forward, the price would be paid not by that man, but by the baker, by the girl who'd picked up the cane, by Trope. I only then understood I'd never properly done this sum. I'd been pounding on the wrong debtor's door.

I sat up. The room was dark. A few stars showed through the window.

I found myself wondering, in that moment, how the Scales would solve this equation. How would it handle the fact that the one who sinned and the one who pays are different people? But the answer was obvious. The Scales doesn't ask that question at all. The Scales only measures who crossed the limit. It doesn't measure who ends up buried under that weight. That was never one of the Scales' fields.

If that was something a person had to do, then it occurred to me, for the first time, that I might be the one who had to fill in that field.

. . .

I lay back down. The number five seemed to hang there on the ceiling.

I counted it again. This time not the days — something else. The people whose names I'd learned since coming to this city. The baker, the weights merchant, the cane girl, the neighbor girl, Trope. Five. Five days, five faces. That coincidence caught at me strangely. Each face seemed to overlap, one for one, with each day remaining.

That night, before sleep, I spoke aloud to myself for the first time. "What am I supposed to do." No one answered. But saying it aloud, just that, made me feel like a slightly different person. I remembered the three days I'd been trapped in the conduit, the first night I'd spoken aloud there. I'd spoken to no one then too. And now, the same.

Looking back, what I truly learned that night was this. Knowing I was the only one who could save this city gave me no strength at all. That fact only left me standing alone. Standing in a spot where no one else in the world stood was not a proud spot. It was only a frightening one.

I don't know what Jonah calculated, counting forty days before Nineveh. But I know this now — some arithmetic doesn't end even after the answer comes. That night, I fell asleep not even sure whether I'd reached an answer at all.

I must have opened and closed my fingers even in sleep. When I woke the next morning, my right hand was still half curled. The fourth finger had folded in on itself. As I straightened it, I thought: yesterday's me and today's me were not the same person. The number was still five. But the person holding that number had changed, a little.

The very thing the Scales can never read was, that night, happening inside me. I hadn't reached an answer. But a direction was forming. The Scales cannot tell the two apart. That night, for the first time,

I thought that I might come to know my own direction before the Scales ever could.

(Continued in Chapter 35.)

Chapter 35. The One Who Walks Out

> *_Previously_ — The days remaining fell to five. Pheugon stood before*
> *the calculation: stay still and the city dies; step forward and he becomes the only person who can save it. He wrote his reasons down*
> *on paper and still couldn't reach an answer by the end of the night.*

Five became four.

I did nothing special that day. I just walked as usual. Past the bakery, through the market, by the well. Trope was sitting by her jar again that day. We didn't say much. But she was quieter than usual.

"…Trope," I asked. "Can someone with low weight still get driven out?"

She looked a little startled by the question.

"…Why ask that?"

"No reason," I deflected. "Just curious."

"…Low weight, and you don't get driven out," she said. "But—"

"But what?"

"…Never mind." She said, adjusting her grip on the jar, changing the subject. "Finish your own arithmetic, Pheugon."

I didn't ask, at the time, what came after that "but." I took her changing the subject as simple kindness. I know now. What came after that "but" was something she'd been about to tell me that day, and then held back.

As we parted, she said the line again.

"…I'll be here tomorrow too."

I wasn't even counting how many times I'd heard it by then. It had become too ordinary a thing to count.

Four became three.

I went twice to the Adjudicator's door that day, and turned back twice. It wasn't that I had nothing to say. It was that I had too much to say, and didn't know where to start.

That evening at the well, Trope packed up earlier than usual.

"…You're leaving early today," I said.

"…Something I need to do," she said.

"What?"

"…Nothing," she smiled. The same smile as always. I noticed nothing in it.

She said the line again as we parted.

"…I'll be here tomorrow too."

I let that pass that day too. Looking back, she was probably saying it with a slightly different weight each time. I couldn't hear that difference in weight. I was good at hearing sounds. What lay behind the sound, I still couldn't hear well.

Three became two.

That evening, Trope wasn't at the well. I just thought she must have something on. I told myself I'd ask her the next day and let it go.

Looking back, that day was the fork in the road. I didn't go looking for her that day. I was too deep in my own arithmetic. I knew she was carrying something as heavy as I was, and still I hadn't checked that weight every day.

I know now. Three days before, when she said "I'll be here tomorrow too" for the last time — that had been the last day I ever heard her say it. I didn't notice, at the time, that it had stopped. Something that has been there vanishing is far quieter than something new appearing.

Two became one.

. . .

The morning the square's board changed to **1**, I felt a strange stillness from the first light of dawn.

The whole city seemed to be holding its breath. People still walked as usual, the bakery still opened its doors. But the footsteps were a little slower. The voices were a little fewer.

I went to the well. Trope wasn't there.

At first I didn't think much of it. She was sometimes late. I sat on the stone wall and waited. Half an hour. An hour. She didn't come.

People fetching water passed by, one after another. I asked them.

"…Have you seen Trope?"

"Not today, no," one woman said. "I don't think I saw her yesterday either."

"…Yesterday either?"

"I think so. Haven't seen much of her lately."

Hearing that, something went cold in my chest. Only then did I count, for the first time, that I hadn't actually seen her in two days. I couldn't understand myself, why that count had come so late.

I started counting then. Half an hour, an hour, an hour and a half. Counting let me forget the anxiety in small doses. But past two hours, even counting stopped working.

I went to her room.

. . .

I knocked. No answer.

I pushed the door. It wasn't locked.

The room inside was empty. The blanket was folded — more neatly than usual. No water jar. The small bundle that had hung on the wall was gone too.

I looked around the room. A small room. Only then did it strike me that I'd never been inside it before. Two months I'd known her, and I hadn't even known where she slept.

A nail was driven into the wall. Something had once hung there. Nothing now. Beside it, a small seashell sat on the windowsill. A worthless thing, the kind you'd pick up scooping water. And yet she'd left it behind.

I wondered, in that moment, why she'd left that shell behind. I thought I might get to ask her later. I didn't know, then, whether that chance would ever really come.

A sheet of paper lay on the desk.

I picked it up. My hand was shaking.

> *Pheugon.*
>
> *I'm leaving the city today. Don't worry. I'm not running away.*
>
> *I've kept thinking about it. Why this city still doesn't look like it's turned. Why the Scales' number won't move. You said people have changed. I saw it too. But the number stays the same.*
>
> *I know my weight is low. But low and not-heavy are different things. I was born in this city. My mother's overflowed weight, this city's overflowed weight — I grew up inside it. As long as I'm here, this city gets counted with me included in its weight.*
>
> *If I leave, the city gets a little lighter. Maybe that's the last bit it needs.*

> *I don't resent the Scales. The Scales was right. I'm just doing what I can do.*
>
> *Trope.*

I read the letter twice, three times.

I felt anger in that moment. But it wasn't anger at the Reckoning. For the first time, that anger was aimed at myself.

For three years I had only learned how to hate someone else. I learned, that day, for the first time, how to be angry at myself. I hadn't wanted to learn it.

I looked again at one line of the letter. *If I leave, the city gets a little lighter.* I knew that calculation was wrong. The Adjudicator had said it plainly. Weight is recorded per person; once accumulated, it doesn't decrease. Subtracting her share from the city's accumulated weight wouldn't change the total at all. She believed that if she left, the city would grow lighter. That belief itself was a calculation the Scales had never once taught anyone.

I had a strange thought, in that moment. She knew the Scales as well as I did. And still she'd made that calculation. Knowing and believing are different things, she'd told me herself, once. At the time I'd only understood it with my head. Now I was feeling the weight of that sentence through a letter in my hand.

I folded the letter and pressed it against my chest. My hand was still shaking.

I thought of her mother. All I had was what Trope had told me a few times. The day her mother crossed the weight limit and was driven out

of the city. Trope had followed her all the way to the gate, she'd said. Her mother never looked back.

I'd wondered, hearing that story, why her mother never looked back. I thought I understood now. If you look back, your steps stop. If you stop, you can't walk again. Trope was probably walking, right now, the same road her mother had walked. Trying not to look back.

. . .

I walked out of the room holding the letter.

I understood now, why she'd been quiet these past days. She'd been doing arithmetic. Same as me. Except I'd been calculating how to save this city, and she'd been calculating how to erase herself. We'd spent the same days on two entirely different sums.

I'd spent three years calculating anger. She'd spent five years calculating her own weight. I'd only managed to break free of my calculation once someone else caught me at it. Hers was still uncaught by anyone.

I knocked on a neighbor's door. An old woman answered.

"…Have you seen Trope?"

"Early this morning," the woman said. "Saw her headed toward the west gate with a bundle. Why, what's happened?"

I couldn't answer.

"…Ask the gatekeeper," the woman said. "He logs everyone who passes through."

I ran.

Halfway there, I stopped in front of the Adjudicator's office. I thought about knocking, then didn't. Instead I shouted through the door crack.

"…Adjudicator! I'm going after Trope! Tomorrow—" I couldn't finish the sentence. I didn't know myself, yet, what I'd do tomorrow.

Footsteps sounded inside. The Adjudicator opened the door and came out.

"…What's happened."

"Trope went outside the city," I said. "She left a note."

The Adjudicator's face went taut for a moment. He said nothing, just looked at me.

"…Tomorrow," he asked. "Will you be back in time?"

I couldn't answer that.

"…I don't know," I finally said. "But I have to go anyway."

The Adjudicator looked at me a long while. Then gave a short nod.

"…Go," he said. "I'll hold things here, somehow."

I felt gratitude and fear in equal measure at that. He hadn't told me what exactly he meant to hold. I didn't ask.

I ran again.

Passing the herald office lodgings, I stopped for a moment. There was a light in the window. He would still be in there, preparing something. Precisely. Steady as ever.

I hesitated a moment, in that instant, over whether to tell him. That I might not be back tomorrow. That if I didn't come back, he would be the one who read. In the end I didn't knock on his door. Saying it out loud would have meant admitting, to myself, that I might not come back. I didn't want to give that possibility a voice.

I walked on. Toward the gate.

. . .

The gatekeeper checked the log.

"…Someone left before dawn. Name was—" He traced the record with his finger. "Trope."

"…Which way did she go?"

"West," he said. "There's nothing out that way. Why'd she leave?"

"…Was she alone?" I asked.

"Alone," he said. "Not fast, not slow. Just walked at a normal pace. Didn't seem like someone in a hurry, either."

Hearing that only frightened me more. If she'd been walking fast, that would have been better. A normal pace meant she'd already made up her mind, completely.

I didn't answer his question. I looked out through the gate.

The plain stretched out into the distance. Not a single person in sight. The sun was already high overhead.

In that moment I realized for the first time how vast the world outside this city was. For two months I had lived entirely inside these walls. I'd always thought of the space outside them only as the direction I'd come from, the direction I would someday leave toward. Now, in that direction, one person was walking alone.

I braced a hand against the gate post and caught my breath. I could hear my own heartbeat.

I understood something strange, in that moment. I had been swept into this city. I had never entered it on my own feet. And now I was about to walk out of it on my own feet. For the first time. And not to save this city — to bring back one of its children. I thought that order was strange. A person had come before the city.

One day left. I counted, on my fingers, how many hours of that day I'd already let slip by. Five. Six. I stopped counting partway.

For the first time, counting was no use at all.

The gatekeeper caught my arm.

"…You heading out too?" he asked. "Tomorrow's the fortieth day. You know that, right?"

"…I know," I said. "That's why I have to go."

He looked at my face a moment, then asked nothing more. Instead he brought out a lantern and handed it to me.

"…Light this once the sun sets," he said. "You can't see a thing on this road at night."

I took the lantern. My hand was still shaking.

"…Thank you," I said.

"Thanks nothing," he said. "Hurry back. I don't know if you're the one who's supposed to be standing here tomorrow or not, but better to have someone than not, I'd think."

I didn't fully understand what he meant by that. But it pushed me forward all the same, strangely.

I realized, in that moment, that I hadn't said anything to either the Adjudicator or the substitute herald about who would stand in the square tomorrow. Nothing had been decided. I knew that, and I was still walking out through the gate. A hundred and twenty thousand lives mattered less to me, in that moment, than one person named Trope. I knew that was a strange order of priority. I didn't want to set it right.

I stepped through the gate.

The sun was sinking to the west. The same direction she had walked.

(Continued in Chapter 36.)

Chapter 36. Going to Fetch Her

> *_Previously_ — Trope left a note behind and walked out the gate at dawn, believing her own weight made the city heavier. Pheugon held*
> *that letter in his hand and, with a single day left, set out through the gate after her.*

Walking out through the gate, I didn't fully know what I was doing.

I had spent three years trying to hate this city. And now I was walking out its gate to find one of its children. I hadn't known, until that moment, that both those sentences could come from the same mouth.

As I ran, I kept turning that strange fact over. If someone had told me, forty days ago, that I would one day risk my life running to save a child of the Reckoning, I'd have laughed in his face. And yet here I was, running. No one had told me to. Not the Scales, not the Adjudicator. I just ran.

The plain was vast. There was only one road. A dirt track running straight west. I half ran, half walked along it.

The sun stood high. Dust rose beneath my feet. Every time my breath grew ragged, I stopped and looked around. Not a single figure in sight.

As I ran, I kept saying her name inside myself. Trope. Trope. I didn't know what the name meant. That was the rule of this world. No

one ever explains what a name means. I only knew that the more I said it, the heavier that name grew inside me.

Some way along, I realized this was the second time I'd walked this road. Forty days before, I had walked it from the opposite direction, toward this city. Back then I hadn't thought of it as walking — I'd thought of it as being swept along. Now I was clearly walking. On my own feet.

. . .

About an hour in, I saw a low pile of stones by the roadside.

At first I took it for just a heap of stones. Coming closer, I saw names carved into them. Small letters, one at a time. Some looked old; some looked fairly recent.

I guessed what it was. The names of people driven out of the city. Who had built it, I didn't know. Family, maybe. Or the people themselves, maybe.

I searched among the stones for one name. I didn't know Trope's mother's name. I couldn't find it.

In that moment I thought I understood why Trope had taken this road. She hadn't fled. She was walking the exact road her mother had walked. Like someone trying to line up the order right.

I knelt for a moment in front of that pile of stones. I didn't know why. It just felt like something I should do.

Looking at those stones, I thought of my own family. Our family had never built a pile of stones like this. My brother had simply

vanished; my mother had simply left. No one had carved a name into anything for either of them. For the first time, I couldn't say which was better — carving a name, or simply forgetting. This city carved the names of those it had driven out. My own family, we had simply erased each other.

I stood up and brushed the dirt from my knees.

I ran again.

. . .

I ran, calling her name. No answer came. The plain was too wide, and my voice too small.

The sun sank further. More than once I wondered if I'd taken a wrong turn. Even with only one road, I kept glancing back to make sure I was going the right way.

In that moment, for the first time, I felt what a world without the Scales was like. Inside the city, anything could be confirmed with a number. Weight, date, location. Outside the walls, none of that existed. I could only walk, only call out, only hope.

I found her as the sun began to lower.

Far off, a little off the road, on a low hill, a single figure sat.
Not a water jar this time — just a bundle beside her, knees drawn up.

I called her name.

She turned. She wasn't startled. As if she'd known I would come.

"…Go back," I said. My breath was ragged.

"…Don't follow me," she said. Her voice had no strength in it. "This is right. For me."

"…What's right about it."

"If I'm not there," she said, half burying her face in her knees, "at least one thing becomes certain. If the city doesn't live, it won't be my fault. If it lives, that won't be because of me either. I just want out of this equation."

"…The Scales' number won't change whether you're there or not."

"I know," she said. "In my head. But Pheugon, I can't shake this feeling that something would be different, just because I wasn't there. I know it doesn't make sense. I know that."

I had no answer for that.

I sat down beside her. Neither of us said anything.

I tried, in that moment, to find something to persuade her with. The Scales doesn't measure by family, the Adjudicator told me so, your leaving won't change the city's weight at all. All true things. But none of it came out of my mouth. I already knew those words would do her no good. Trope hadn't come this far by numbers.

The sun sank further. The wind was cold.

"…You're cold," I finally said.

"…Yes," she said.

That was all. I didn't try to persuade her further. She didn't push me away further either.

We sat like that for a long while. Wind, and somewhere far off, a bird crying. Nothing else.

"…Are you scared?" I asked. A long while had passed.

"…Of what."

"Being out here alone."

She didn't answer, just hugged her knees tighter.

"…I was scared," she said, very quietly. "But strangely, when I saw you running toward me over there, do you know what the first thing I thought was?"

"…What."

"'It's over now,' she said. 'I thought, I don't have to be scared anymore. That's what scared me most. That I could be reassured that easily."

I had no answer for that either.

After a long while, I held out my hand.

She looked at it a long time. Didn't take it. Then, very slowly, laid her own hand on top of it.

. . .

We walked toward the gate together after that.

It was a long road. Until the sun sank completely below the horizon, neither of us said a word. She didn't pull her hand away. I didn't speak again either.

In that silence I kept asking myself, over and over, why I was there. I had spent three years trying to hate this city. And now I was walking, hand in hand, leading one of its children back — a child who had tried, of her own will, to leave it. I never found the answer. I still don't fully have it, even now.

Walking, I suddenly thought of the man who never gets angry. What would he say, if he could see me now. I imagined it for a moment, then stopped. He wasn't here now. In his absence, I felt like I was, for the first time, alone doing something he might have done. That struck me as strange.

I wondered, in that moment, for the first time, whether he had ever once walked out like this to fetch someone. I didn't know the answer. I didn't know, then, that I would come to ask him one day.

Far, far ahead, a small light appeared.

At first I took it for a star. Then the light grew. Not just one — many. In the dark, they gathered one by one into a single mass.

The Reckoning.

I stopped walking in that moment. For two months I had lived only inside that city. Seen from within, that light had just been the lamps that came on each evening. One at a time, familiar. Seen from outside, it was different. From this distance, all those lights became one. Not scattered people — one city.

I looked at that light as if seeing it for the first time. It really was the first time. I had lived two months in that city and had never once seen it from outside.

From inside, each light had been its own. The bakery's light, the Scales office's light, someone's window, lit. I had counted those lights one by one, living among them. From outside, none of that was visible. All I could see was one thing. The whole city gathered into a single light, floating in the dark.

A strange thought came to me in that moment. Did the Scales see the city this way too. Not as individual people, but as one mass. But I soon knew that thought was wrong. The Scales has never seen it from this distance. The Scales only sees from inside, only one by one. Seeing a city as one whole, from this distance — only a person could do that.

Trope stopped walking too and looked at the light.

"…It's pretty," she said, very quietly.

I had no answer to that. I'd never once thought of that city as pretty. And yet, in that moment, I was agreeing with her for the first time.

We started walking again. The light grew larger.

. . .

It was already the middle of the night when we reached the gate.

The gatekeeper came to meet us with a lantern. He asked nothing. He just opened the gate for us.

As we stepped back through the gate, Trope spoke for the first time.

"…Why did you come to fetch me."

I hadn't prepared an answer.

"…I don't know."

"You came without knowing?"

"…I felt like I had to go fetch you. So I went."

She neither smiled nor cried at that. She just lowered her head a little. Then walked on again without another word. I walked beside her, and that was the whole of what we did that night.

I was afraid of that silence. I couldn't tell if it was angry silence or simply exhausted silence. I know now. It was both. And there was a third thing in it too. Shame. She had, that day, been caught — for the first time — wanting to live.

We walked without speaking all the way to her door. She stopped in front of it.

"…Go in," I said. "Get some rest."

She nodded. Before opening the door, she turned to look at me once.

"…It's tomorrow," she said.

I knew what that meant. The fortieth day. The square. Two heralds.

"…Yeah," I said.

"…Pheugon." She called again. "I learned something to be ashamed of today."

"…What."

"I thought choosing to die was the brave thing," she said. "But when you came all that way to that hill, I was happy. Because I wanted to live. I was ashamed of that."

I had no idea what to say to that.

"…Nothing to be ashamed of," I finally managed.

"I don't know," she said. "Not yet, anyway."

She said no more and went inside. The door closed quietly.

. . .

I didn't go back to the shed that night. I just sat on the steps outside her door.

I still couldn't explain, that night, why I had gone to fetch her. I still hadn't decided whether to save this city or not. And yet I hadn't hesitated for even a moment about saving one person named Trope. That those two were the same question — I still hadn't managed to connect that, even sitting on those steps.

I know now. That night, for the first time, I did something without calculating. For three years, and even after coming to this city, I had calculated everything. Weight, cases, dates, reasons. But running out through that gate, I hadn't calculated anything at all. I had simply run.

I didn't know, that night, what that meant. I thought I'd understand by tomorrow. I didn't fully understand tomorrow, either. Only now, little by little, do I understand it.

Far off, the square's board glowed in the dark. I didn't look at the number written on it. I didn't need to.

Tomorrow it would be zero.

I sat on those steps, unmoving, deep into the night. My lantern had gone out long before. In the dark, I looked down at my hand again. It had trembled that morning. It wasn't trembling now.

I didn't know, at the time, what that difference meant. I know now. This morning's trembling was the trembling of a man whose calculation wasn't finished. This hand, not trembling now, wasn't because I'd reached an answer. I still didn't know the answer. Only, that night, I stopped doubting one thing at least. That I was someone who could go and fetch another person. For three years I hadn't known whether I was that kind of person or not.

As dawn drew near, I rose from where I sat. My body was stiff. I walked a few steps toward the square. Far off, the board's number was faintly visible. Still one.

A few hours from now, two people would stand in that spot. One who didn't know this city, and one who could no longer say he didn't. What face I would wear, standing there — I still couldn't picture it.

I walked back to Trope's door. No sound came from behind it. I sat back down in front of that door, waiting for the sun to rise.

I didn't know, then, what it meant to go and fetch someone. I know a little now. Going to fetch someone means not asking first whether

that person is right or wrong. It just means going. That night, for the first time, I did that. Whether I could do the same thing again for someone else, the next day, I still didn't know.

(Continued in Part Four.)

The Forty-Day Clause, Part Four

The Hill East of the City

Chapter 37. The Last Day

> *_Previously_ — Trope, believing the whole city would die for her weight alone, walked out through the gate alone. Pheugon went out to find her. On the way back, the two of them saw the Reckoning's lights together, for the first time, from a distance.*

The fortieth day broke exactly like every other day.

I thought that was strange. The world should have looked different somehow. The sky should have hung low. The birds should have gone quiet. But the sun rose in the same place it had risen yesterday, and the line at the well was the same line as yesterday. The baker opened her shop at the same hour as yesterday.

That morning I found it unbearably unfair. A city was ending, and the sky didn't know it. It wasn't only the sky. The Scales didn't know it either. Today it was weighing people the same way it had weighed them every day before.

. . .

Trope hadn't said a word since we'd reached the gate.

The night before, walking her back the whole way, I hadn't known what to say. I knew why she'd tried to leave. She believed her own weight was pulling the city down. Her mother had been pushed out that way, so she believed it was only right that she go the same way.

I didn't tell her she was wrong. I knew it would do no good. Instead I took her hand and walked. It was a long way. The city's lights had started as points and

slowly grown larger.

She didn't pull away.

When we passed back through the gate, Trope spoke for the first time.

"…Why did you come for me."

I hadn't prepared an answer.

"…I don't know."

"You came without knowing?"

"…It felt like I had to go get you."

She didn't laugh at that, and she didn't cry either. She just lowered her head a little. Then she walked on again without another word. I walked beside her, and that was the whole of what we did that night.

I was afraid of that silence. I couldn't tell whether it was an angry silence or just a tired one. Now I know. It was both. And there was a third thing in it too. Shame. That night, for the first time, she had been caught wanting to live.

. . .

In the morning she shared her food with me. We sat on the steps outside the room where she was staying and ate. Nobody spoke. It felt like the whole city was holding its breath.

"…It's today." Trope said.

"…Yes."

"I'm not scared."

I didn't believe her. Her hand, around the bowl, was shaking slightly.

"…Liar."

"…Yes. I'm lying."

She set the bowl down.

"It's not that I'm afraid of the city falling. I thought it falling was only right, so that part doesn't scare me. What scares me." She stopped, then went on. "What scares me is what happens if it doesn't fall."

I didn't fully understand what she meant, not then.

Now I know. She wasn't afraid of judgment. She was afraid of mercy. Because if mercy came, there would be no way left to confirm whether she really deserved it.

Judgment has rules. Cross the weight and you're pushed out. That can be predicted, and so it can be borne. Mercy has no rules. Trope would never be able to know why mercy came to her. I thought, at the time, that she would have found it easier if she'd simply crossed the weight. I didn't yet know how wrong that thought was.

We sat on those steps a long time after the bowls were empty. The sun climbed a little higher. From the direction of the square, footsteps began to gather.

"…I should go." I said.

Trope nodded. As she stood, she added, very quietly.

"…Whatever happens, thank you for coming to get me."

I had no answer for that.

. . .

On the way to the square, I walked this city slowly for the first time.

I'd lived here over a month, and I'd never once looked closely at these streets. Today I did. There was a sign on the bakery that hadn't been there yesterday — anyone who couldn't pay their tab would simply be given the bread. At the edge of the market, the merchant who'd once been caught cheating his scales was recalibrating one with his own hands. A child passing by picked up the walking stick an elderly neighbor had dropped and carried it to him.

Small things. Things too small for the Scales to register at all.

I counted those small things. I couldn't help it. The habit that had counted one hundred twelve cases surfaced here too. Eight, nine, ten. Ten things in ten steps. I didn't dare work out what that came to across the whole city.

The Scales weighed none of the ten. What isn't stolen, what isn't struck, what isn't lied — none of it carries weight. To the Scales, those were exactly as if nothing had happened at all.

That was the first time I felt the Scales' arithmetic was missing something. I didn't know, then, how to put that feeling into words.

. . .

The square was already full of people.

I had never before seen the people of the Reckoning gathered like this in one place. On ordinary days, even the lines were only a few deep at the terminals.

Today the whole square was packed. People holding children. People leaning on canes. People saying nothing, just staring at the sky. Two old men stood holding each other's hands. One had his face pressed against the other's shoulder.

On the board raised in the center of the square, a number hung in the air.

0.

I looked at that number. I had been counting down from thirty-nine. The first number I'd seen, the day I was washed up in this city, was thirty-nine, and every day since I'd watched it drop by one. Today there was nowhere left for it to fall.

I did a strange arithmetic standing in front of that number. If I'd seen it once a day for thirty-nine days, I had seen it thirty-nine times. Thirty-eight of those times I'd watched it the way you watch a stranger's city. Only the last time had I watched it as my own.

That one time undid all the other thirty-eight.

Familiar faces showed among the crowd. The baker. The market vendor who always drew the longest line at the terminal. The girl next door who used to fetch water with Trope. I didn't know their names. Three months ago that wouldn't have mattered. Now it did.

The baker recognized me and came over. There was still flour on her hands.

"…So you're the one. The boy from the well."

"…Yes."

"You're the one reading it today?"

I couldn't answer. She didn't wait for one — she took my hand. It was a big, rough hand.

"I don't know where to put my thanks." she said. "For coming. For being here."

I couldn't close my hand around hers. She had no idea what I was about to do. She only knew I was the one person who could save this city — not that I had spent all this time wishing it would die.

I remember that hand for a long time. Holding it, I realized for the first time that I was a person with two faces. While this city saw me as a savior, I still thought of myself as a judge.

. . .

The Adjudicator was standing on the platform.

Beside him stood an unfamiliar face — a year or two older than me, with a straight, trained posture, dressed in the herald's uniform. The substitute assigned after I'd run.

I had never seen him before. But I could read him at a glance. That stance, that gaze. I'd seen it every day at the training grounds. A face that had learned not to get angry. A face that had learned not to stop.

A few years earlier, that would have been me standing there — that face, that posture. Looking at him, I knew for the first time how far I had come from that place.

He looked at me. His expression didn't move.

"…You're Pheugon."

"…Yes."

"I was assigned two months ago. You never came."

There was no resentment in it. It was a voice simply stating a fact. That made it harder.

"…I'm sorry."

"No apology is needed." he said. "I only have to do my job. We don't write feelings into the record."

I felt like I'd heard that somewhere before. It was nearly word for word what the supervisor used to tell me.

"…How much have you read."

"This one case." he said. "I was told it's the largest there's ever been."

In that moment I found him frightening. Not because he was a bad person. Because he was me. Me, forty days ago. A weightless face, a voice that never stopped, someone ready to read this city.

. . .

The Adjudicator drew me aside.

"You took your time getting here."

"…Yes."

"And you found Trope."

"…Yes."

The Adjudicator looked out over the square for a moment. His eyes moved between the people, the number, one another, and the platform. Every face there knew what it was waiting for.

"You know something that boy doesn't." The Adjudicator moved his chin slightly toward the substitute herald. "That the clause exists. What it requires. He's only a reader. He does what he was trained to do."

"…So."

"If you don't step forward, he'll read it. And if he reads it, he becomes the confirmer." The Adjudicator looked at me. "He doesn't know this city. He arrived a month ago. How would he know whether this city has turned or not. Weight can't show him that."

I didn't answer.

"The decision is yours." The Adjudicator said. "I'm not telling you to do it, and I'm not telling you not to. For forty years I've never once invoked this clause. I may find out why today."

His voice was even. His hands weren't. Behind his back, they kept crumpling the edge of the papers.

"One thing I'll say." He lowered his voice. "If you read it, you have to read all of it. Not a summary — the full text. From the first line to the last, Article 4 Clause 11 and all, without missing a line. Leave one line out and the clause itself doesn't activate. That's how it's written."

"…Why."

"I don't know." The Adjudicator said. "Forty years, and I never worked it out. Whoever wrote that clause must have had a reason for setting it up that way.

Maybe—" He stopped, then went on. "Maybe it means you can only recognize a city's turning once you know its sin in full. That's only my guess."

I felt the weight of the sentence document in my hand. It was only a few sheets of paper, but my wrist ached.

I heard something in the Adjudicator's voice that day. I didn't know what it was, then. Now I know. It was envy. He had never once had the chance to stand in this place. Forty years living in this city, knowing only that the clause existed, with no one to use it. I had that chance. He hadn't.

. . .

I looked at Trope.

She stood at the edge of the square. Alone, among the crowd, her two hands clasped in front of her. When our eyes met, she gave the smallest nod. That was all.

I didn't know what she was waiting for. Whether she was waiting for the city to fall, or waiting for it to live. Her face looked ready for either.

Someone on the platform rang a bell. The square went quiet. A child began to cry and was quickly hushed by its mother's hand. After that, there was truly no sound at all.

The Adjudicator looked at me. Then at the substitute herald. Then at me again.

"Who reads it."

I looked at the substitute herald. He already had the sentence document in his hands. His hands weren't shaking. I used to look exactly like that. His fingers,

holding the paper, were spaced at precisely even intervals. That's what training teaches you.

I want to say, even now, that up to that moment I still hadn't been sure what I would do. But that would be a lie. I already knew. It was only my feet that hadn't believed it yet.

I took one step forward.

"…I'll read it."

The square looked at me. It felt like tens of thousands of eyes turning toward me all at once. Trope looked at me. Her clasped hands stiffened slightly.

The substitute herald looked at me, then held out the papers without a word. His face showed no resentment, no relief. As he handed the papers over, he added one thing.

"…Read it well."

It was something trainees said to each other. Before an exam, before a first proclamation — something they said to one another. I'd heard those words dozens of times in three years. I never expected to hear them like this.

"…Yes."

I took the papers. My fingertips felt a familiar weight. The weight of one hundred twelve readings, and now, for the hundred thirteenth time, a different weight. I could feel the difference in my hands.

Trope was still watching me. I sent her no signal. There was no signal to send. Even I didn't fully know, in that moment, what I was about to do.

I still remember, in my fingertips, the moment I took that paper. People sometimes ask me what I decided in that moment. I can't answer. There was

nothing that deserved to be called a decision. My feet simply moved forward, and my hand took the paper. The decision came after, while I was reading.

The Adjudicator nodded, very quietly.

"Then." he said. "Let's begin."

Every eye in the square turned toward me. The zero on the board glowed behind my back. A wind passed once, and the edge of the paper stirred slightly. I unfolded it.

I remember that wind. It was very mild. A wind with nothing to do with the smell of water I'd breathed in the conduit forty days before. And yet, strangely, in that instant I thought of that darkness — the three days I'd been shut in, the night I first spoke aloud. Only then did I understand that that night led straight to this square.

(Continued in Chapter 38.)

Chapter 38. The Proclamation

> *_Previously_ — The whole city gathered in the square. The substitute herald was already standing there, but Pheugon stepped forward in his place. The Adjudicator nodded. Pheugon unfolded the paper.*

The first thing you learn when you learn to read is not your voice. It's not stopping.

I had carved this into my body for three years. Not stopping at a name. Not stopping at a charge. Not stopping in front of someone crying. That day in the square, I had no idea where that training was about to take me.

I still think about this sometimes. What would have happened if I'd been someone who knew how to stop. If I had stopped, I would have stopped in front of that sentence. Because I didn't stop, I made it all the way to that sentence.

The hand that unfolded the paper felt strangely light. Forty days before, the first time I'd seen this paper on my desk, my fingertips had trembled. Now they didn't. The trained hand had come back. I was glad of that, and afraid of it, at once.

At the training grounds, the supervisor used to say: "A herald's hand should feel only the weight of the paper. It must not feel the weight of the person written inside it." I'd believed that for a long time. That day in the square, I learned for the first time that both weights could be felt in the same hand at once.

. . .

"The Reckoning." I began.

My voice carried out across the square. It wasn't a loud voice. A trained voice never is. Quiet, but it carries far.

"This settlement, under Article 3, has been found to exceed its accumulated weight limit. The date of judgment was—"

I read the date. It was the same day, forty-one days ago, that I had first held this sentence document in my hands. That day I had laughed, silently, in the middle of a hallway. I never imagined that laugh would lead to this square.

The square was silent. Silent, but the silence was full of held breath. That's the sound a hundred twenty thousand people make when they hold their breath together. For the first time, I felt that number as people.

The people far in the back couldn't have heard my voice well. And yet no one moved. I found that strange. If you couldn't hear, you'd think you'd push forward. But everyone stayed exactly where they stood, as if watching the shape of my mouth was enough, without needing to hear the sound. Maybe they already knew what this sentence meant. Forty days had given them plenty of time to guess.

I learned to count when I was twelve, so I could handle numbers. That day, for the first time, a number handled me.

. . .

I read the grounds.

They were the items the Scales had produced. Lies, theft, neglect, cruelty. Each one converted into a number. It even listed when the city's accumulated total had crossed the limit. Three years and six months earlier.

At that date, my voice nearly wavered. Three years and six months ago wasn't far from the time my own family had come apart.

I wanted to believe that was a coincidence. Even now, I can't fully believe it. The Scales never connected those two events. It had no reason to. The one who connected them was me.

My voice didn't waver. Three years of training saved me, in that moment. Or so I thought at the time.

The items went on and on. I read every one of them, without dropping a single line. The Scales wrote in numbers only, but I knew there was a person behind each number. Behind a line reading "neglect item, accumulated total twenty-three thousand," there was probably a child. Days without food, greetings no one ever offered. The Scales reduced all of that to a single number. I was the one who turned that number back into a voice.

Beside me, the substitute herald stood with the document in his hand, watching me. Something passed across his eyes. I understood only later what it was. It wasn't relief. It was awe. He wasn't looking at me and thinking he was lucky not to be the one standing there — he was looking at himself, and seeing that he hadn't been trained enough to stand where I stood.

I would go on to remember his face for a long time. Forty days earlier, I would have stood in that place with that same face. Unshaken, uninvolved. Whether losing that face was fortunate or a loss, I still haven't decided.

. . .

At last I reached the disposition.

"Regarding this settlement: following a grace period of forty days from the date of judgment, the sentence of demolition shall be executed."

At that instant, a sound rose from the square. Weeping. Not from one person, but from many at once. The sound of breath, held back too long, breaking all at once. A woman holding a child pressed the child's head to her chest. Two old men gripped each other harder.

I didn't stop.

I looked at Trope. She wasn't crying. Her face was different from everyone else's. It was a face that had already expected this sentence. From forty days before — or perhaps from long before that.

Watching that face, I felt a strange certainty settle in me. A certainty that Trope was the least surprised person in that whole city to hear this sentence. She had already believed, for a long time, that she deserved exactly this.

Close beside me, the baker had both hands pressed over her face. The market merchant sank to the ground, still clutching the scale-weight he'd calibrated himself. Someone let out a low groan, calling out not a person's name but the city's. "Reckoning." Someone said it that way — as if the city were a person, as if to comfort it.

I heard those sounds and did not let them break my voice. That's what the supervisor had taught — the discipline of not listening. But I was listening. Listening while pretending not to — that day, for the first time, I truly put that skill to use.

. . .

Maybe I should have stopped there. Most people do stop there. Once the disposition is read, the proclamation is considered finished. I had heard, back at the training grounds, that the clauses attached below were often left unread by custom.

I didn't stop.

Because I had learned how not to stop. How not to stop at a name, a charge, a person crying. There was no exception to that discipline. As long as there were letters left on the page, I read them. That was who three years had made me.

I still return to this moment sometimes. If I had been someone less trained — if I hadn't been, as the supervisor put it, someone who "doesn't stop" — I would have folded the paper right there. The city would simply have fallen. The clause would have gone back to being a dead letter.

The very thing that had made me hate this city was, in the end, what carried me to this place. And now the same discipline that had once made me run — that same discipline was keeping me from stopping.

I thought of Had, at the training grounds. The boy who stopped three times at his own name. "Why don't you stop?" Had had asked me that once, and in that instant, standing in the middle of the square, his question came back to me. I hadn't been able to answer then, and I couldn't now. Only this time, I kept reading without an answer.

Had stopped at a name and never became a herald. I never stopped at anything, and became one. In that square that day, I suddenly envied him. At least he'd known how to stop.

I turned the page. On the next line, in small type.

Article 4, Clause 11.

. . .

I had seen those letters once before, forty days earlier. At my desk, alone, in an empty room at night, tracing them with my fingertip. That time I had been alone. Now I stood before a hundred twenty thousand people.

That night, I'd read this sentence three times. I never asked who was meant by "confirmed" — by whom. I'd assumed the Scales would confirm it. I should have already known, even then. The Scales cannot measure direction. If the Scales couldn't confirm it, confirmation had to belong to someone else. That night, the answer had been right in front of me, and I hadn't seen it. Or rather — I had seen it, and chosen not to. My plan to run was already in place.

Forty days lie between that night and who I am now. In those forty days I was trapped in the conduit, washed up in this city, and came to know its people's faces one by one. Without those forty days, I couldn't have read this sentence now. I could have read it — but I would have read it differently.

My voice came out a beat late. It was so brief that no one in the square could have noticed. But I felt it. Something inside me asked. *Are you really going to read it.*

I didn't answer. There was no time to answer. The paper was in my hand, the letters were in front of my eyes. Reading was the only thing I knew how to do.

"Article 4, Clause 11." I said. "Should this settlement be confirmed to have turned within forty days, the present sentence shall be void."

Reading that sentence took less than three seconds. But I can still say, even now, that those three seconds felt longer than forty days.

. . .

The square stirred. A low murmur spread among the weeping. Many people were hearing of this clause for the first time. It made sense — no adult besides

the Adjudicator had known it existed.

The Adjudicator was watching me from the platform. I read something in his expression. It wasn't surprise. He'd already known I knew about this clause. What surprised him was something else — the fact that I had actually spoken it aloud.

I looked over at the Scales. A terminal stood in one corner of the square. Nothing on the screen had changed. The Scales hadn't logged this reading as anything special. To the Scales, it was simply one sentence turned into sound.

The substitute herald glanced my way. The same clause was surely printed in the document he held too. He would never have to read it aloud himself now — I had stepped forward first. I couldn't tell, in that moment, whether he was relieved or disappointed. Maybe neither. He was simply watching, as he'd been trained to, what was happening right in front of him, exactly as it was.

I didn't understand that moment. I felt something enormous had happened, and yet nowhere in the world was there any sign to prove it. No light came on. No sound rang. Not one figure on the Scales had changed.

I think I'd been expecting something strange. The sky splitting open. The ground shaking. Nothing happened. The most important sentence in the world had just become sound, and the world was still turning exactly the way it had turned forty days ago. I didn't know then that this frightened me. Now I know. A great thing happening with no sign at all — that is the most frightening thing in this world.

Now I know. The confirmation the clause required was never the Scales' work. It was a person's work. And the condition for becoming that person was exactly one thing — to read this sentence aloud, to the end. I had just met that condition.

I met it without knowing I was meeting it. That made it more frightening. I felt like someone who'd pulled a trigger without knowing what he'd fired.

. . .

Somewhere in the square, a low voice asked, "What does that mean." Someone beside them answered, "It means all it has to do is turn." Another voice overlapped. "Who decides that." No one had an answer. Even I hadn't known it, myself, until a moment before.

One line still remained on the paper. In very small type, just below the clause.

"Confirmation is established by the herald's declaration."

I read that line and lifted my eyes from the page.

The square was watching me. A hundred twenty thousand eyes. The Adjudicator. The substitute herald. Trope.

Trope's face had changed. It was no longer the resigned face of a moment before. She understood now what this line meant. Not as fully as I did — but she understood.

I opened my mouth. Nothing came out.

My throat was dry. In forty days I had never once let myself imagine this moment. More precisely, I had worked hard not to imagine it. When I'd run, the goal had been to make sure this moment never came at all. Now that the goal had failed, I had never been trained for what came next. Training had only ever taught me how to read the Scales' verdict. No one had ever taught me how to overturn one.

In three years I read one hundred twelve cases without stopping once. On the hundred thirteenth, I stopped for the first time. It was after I had finished the clause. All that remained was one sentence. That sentence would not come.

The Adjudicator took one step closer from the platform. He said nothing. He simply stood nearer. I couldn't tell whether that was urging me on or standing with me.

Trope didn't move. Her hands still clasped in front of her, she was looking straight at me. Something was in her eyes, but I couldn't tell whether it was fear or hope. Maybe it was both. Even someone who believes mercy will never come for herself can still wish for it to come to someone else.

The wind rose again. The edge of the paper stirred. I didn't fold it. I couldn't fold it yet. A sentence was forming inside me. It hadn't become sound yet.

How that sentence became sound, I set down in the next chapter. Here I will say only this — that in that moment, I did not know what I was about to say. To say I knew would be a lie. My body knew first. My mind followed a long while after.

The square was still waiting for me. A hundred twenty thousand held breaths, all stopped, aimed at one sentence.

(Continued in Chapter 39.)

Chapter 39. The Confirmation

> *_Previously_ — Pheugon read the sentence document from the first line to the last, all the way to Article 4, Clause 11, aloud. The moment he read it, he became the confirmer. The clause required one sentence, spoken by him. The square watched him and waited.*

What the clause required was not a long explanation.

It was one sentence. Six words. "This city has turned." That was all. No lengthy testimony required, no grounds to line up. The whole thing hung on that one sentence.

Even now, I find that simplicity strange. The Scales spends dozens of figures just to assess a single item. Neglect, cruelty, theft, lies — each one carried out to the decimal point. And yet saving an entire city took only six words. Weight required so much language. Turning required so little.

I felt that asymmetry was unfair. I still feel it, if I'm honest. How can the system for weighing sin be so meticulous, while the system for weighing forgiveness is allowed to be so bare? But thinking it over again, it wasn't bareness at all. Weight accumulates, so it needs many items. Turning is a direction, so it only needs confirming once. I only came to guess at that difference standing in that square.

. . .

I had known those six words. Since forty days before.

They weren't printed on the paper. The clause set down no form for the confirmation. The Adjudicator had told me as much, once. "There's no fixed sentence. But by custom, this is what people say. 'This city has turned.'" In forty years no one had ever used that custom. It had only ever been passed down by word of mouth.

I had turned that sentence over on my tongue many times. In the conduit, on the way to the city, in the dark, in places where no one could hear. Back then I thought it was the one thing I would never say. I had no intention of admitting this city had turned. The moment I admitted this city had turned, the very reason I'd run would fall apart.

I had memorized that sentence out of hatred for it. I didn't know then that hatred is what makes you memorize something best.

In the conduit, on the third day, I had spoken it aloud for the first time. Alone in the dark, water up to my knees. "This city has turned." My voice, that time, had been a mockery. I said it to prove how absurd it was. That city, turned? I had laughed, then.

What lay between that laugh and the silence in the square, I don't know exactly. Only that forty days had passed. In those forty days I had come to know the faces of the people in that city, one by one. And I learned, for the first time, that mockery gets harder once you know a face.

. . .

The square was still silent.

I looked at Trope. She hadn't moved. Neither had the Adjudicator. The substitute herald still stood there, holding the papers. Everyone was waiting for me, and yet no one urged me on.

I still can't describe that silence precisely, even now. It didn't feel like pressure. If it had been pressure, it would have been easier. You can resist pressure. That silence wasn't pressure. It was a blank space. A space that would receive whatever I filled it with.

I thought of this city. Its people, living by checking their own weight before the Scales, living carefully so as never to spill over. And I thought of the person from this city who had torn our home apart. Both thoughts were in me at once, neither making room for the other.

I thought of the baker's hand. The hand, still floured, that had held mine. "For coming. For being here." The face that had said those words had no idea what I was about to do.

I thought of one person from the Reckoning. I can no longer remember that person's face clearly. But I still see clearly the back of him, walking out our door. For three years I had believed that back was this city's face.

Between those two faces, the whole city lay. I didn't know which to choose. I still don't.

I looked at the Adjudicator. There was no urging in his face. He was a man who had waited forty years for this place. And yet now that the moment had arrived, he did nothing on my behalf. He didn't even encourage me. He only watched. I learned later that this was his kindness. This sentence was not one anyone else could choose for me.

I looked at the substitute herald. There was no expectation in his face at all. He wasn't from this city, and he understood this sentence far less than I did. And yet he stood there without stirring. His was the face of someone watching another person's forty days as though they were his own.

The wind passed over the square once more. Someone's hem stirred. A child, unable to hold it in, let out a small cough. I learned, then, how loud that sound

could feel.

. . .

I looked down at the paper again. The last line of the clause. "Confirmation is established by the herald's declaration."

That sentence gave me no instructions at all. When to say it, on what grounds to judge, whether I needed certainty or could do without it — none of it was written down. Whoever had written this clause had left the whole judgment to me and vanished.

In that moment, for the first time, I wondered who had written this clause. Was it the same people who built the Scales? Or was it someone else entirely? The Adjudicator didn't know, and neither did I. I still don't. But I felt certain that whoever it was had foreseen this exact moment. That the person who knew a city's sins best, the person with every reason to hate it most, would end up standing in this place.

I thought that design was cruel. And at the same time I thought there could have been no other way. If this judgment had been given to someone who loved this city, it would have been doubted from the start. If it had been given to someone who didn't know this city at all, it would have meant nothing. Whoever wrote this clause seemed to have decided to trust exactly one kind of person. Someone who hated, and yet had kept watching to the very end.

I looked out over the square. Of a hundred twenty thousand faces, I could recognize only a handful. The baker. The market merchant. The girl who used to fetch water with Trope. The Adjudicator. The substitute herald.

And Trope.

For a moment, very briefly, I thought of home. Of the last dinner our whole family had eaten together, before it came apart. I don't remember what we talked about that evening. I only remember that it was growing dark outside the window, and that someone had laughed. That laugh was never heard in our house again.

I tried to tell myself there was no connection between that evening and this square. One was a private matter, and the other belonged to an entire city. But in that moment, inside me, the two sat at exactly the same weight. The Scales would never have calculated it that way.

. . .

I had watched this city change, these forty days. It wasn't the same city I'd first arrived in. The one who used to steal, stopped stealing. The one who never spoke, began speaking to others. A child who'd lost her mother returned a stranger's dropped cane. A merchant who'd cheated his scales recalibrated one with his own hands.

None of those changes registered on the Scales. The weight hadn't gone down. The debt already accumulated remained exactly where it was. And yet I had seen it. I had seen what the Scales could not.

Trope's steps, on her way to check her own weight, had changed somewhere along the way. She used to leave with her shoulders sunk. Lately she left with her head still up. Not because the weight had fallen. Because the eyes that looked at the weight had changed.

The Adjudicator's hands, sorting through documents, had changed too. He used to push papers aside as he filed them. Lately he lingered over each sheet, as if reading the names written on it all over again.

The baker had begun giving away flour. The market merchant calibrated his own scales. None of these were items. They were things the Scales never wrote down. And yet I had seen them, every day, for forty days.

I want to say that in that moment I finally understood why the clause left confirmation to a person. But to be honest, I knew it without understanding it. Understanding and knowing are different things. I couldn't have laid out, in logic, that this city had turned. I simply knew.

Where that knowing came from, I still can't explain, even now. It can't be proven in numbers, the way the Scales proves things. It can't be backed by forty years of experience, the way the Adjudicator's could. I simply, standing there in the middle of that city, knew it.

. . .

I don't know how much time passed. To the people standing in the square it must have felt very long. It didn't, to me. To me, that time was the whole of the forty days passing at once.

I passed back through the darkness of the conduit. The feeling of water rising to my knees, the voice that had spoken aloud to no one. I had first told my own story in that darkness. Words that had begun where no one could hear were now about to end in front of a hundred twenty thousand people.

I passed back through the moment I'd opened my eyes at the well. "You're not from here, are you?" — Trope's face, asking. I had given her a false name, then. Now I stood in this city without a single lie left.

I thought of everything I'd kept hidden — that I was a herald, that I hated this city, the true reason I'd run. All of it had been piling up behind this one sentence. As if the entire forty days had been preparation for this single sentence.

I still haven't decided whether that moment was the end of calculation, or something outside calculation altogether. I had lived my life as someone who calculates. I counted one hundred twelve cases, counted dates, counted reasons. And yet before this sentence, there was nothing left to count.

My throat was dry. My fingertips, holding the paper, had gone slightly stiff. The square was still waiting for me. No one urging me on, and everyone waiting.

The stone beneath my feet was the same stone I had walked every day for forty days. But that day it felt unusually hard. The sun stood directly overhead. My shadow lay short, right beneath my feet.

My mouth opened.

I don't remember which came first — the voice, or the resolve. A single sentence simply went out into the square.

"This city has turned."

Only after I'd finished speaking did I realize I was the one who had said it.

I heard those six words strike the far wall of the square and return, very faintly. It was my own voice, and yet it didn't feel like mine. As though someone else, far away, were repeating it after me.

My voice wasn't loud. It was a trained voice. Quiet, but it carries far. It probably took less than a second for those six words to reach the far edge of the square. But it was enough — enough to overturn the city's whole forty days.

I won't write more about that moment. People ask me what I was thinking then, why I said it that way. I don't answer. It isn't that I have no words. Some

sentences become lies the moment you attach a reason to them. I don't want to attach a reason to that one. Not even now.

. . .

For one instant, the square made no sound at all.

It took the whole square time to understand what I had just done. The Adjudicator's face moved first. He closed his eyes, and opened them again. It had probably been forty years since he'd last seen something like that.

Trope didn't move. Her lips had parted, just slightly.

The substitute herald slowly lowered the papers in his hand. For the first time, I saw something in his face give way. Not the trained face — just a person's face. He had never once been taught this sentence. Nowhere at the training grounds was there any lesson in reading it.

From the back of the square, sound began to spread like a low wave. Someone passed my words to the person beside them, and that person to the next. "It turned." Those two words took time to travel to the far edge of the square. It wasn't the speed of sound. It was the speed of belief spreading.

A low noise came from the direction of the Scales' terminal. People turned toward it. Something was appearing on the screen.

Trope stepped toward me. She started to say something, then stopped. Her lips closed again. I didn't ask what she'd meant to say. I had no confidence, then, to ask.

The baker pressed a hand to her mouth. The market merchant sat where he'd fallen, unmoving. The woman holding her child lifted the child's face up to

look. "Did you hear that." she whispered to the child. The child nodded, not understanding a word of it.

That day, in that square, I didn't understand what I had just done. I knew that a hundred twenty thousand lives had just hung on six words from my mouth, and yet I couldn't feel the weight of it. That feeling came later. Much later, and in a very different way.

The Adjudicator walked toward me. His steps were slower than usual. He came to stand in front of me, and without a word, rested his hand on my shoulder. And then he said nothing at all.

I felt the weight of that hand. A weight the Scales could never measure.

He said nothing, and drew his hand away. I couldn't even guess what words he was holding back. I wasn't ready to hear the words of a man who had waited forty years.

(Continued in Chapter 40.)

Chapter 40. Void

> *_Previously_ — Pheugon said, "This city has turned." The clause activated. It took the square time to understand those six words. A low sound came from the Scales' terminal.*

The screen at the terminal took three seconds to change.

I was counting those three seconds. The habit of counting numbers comes out even at times like this. One, two, three. After three, letters appeared on the screen.

Sentence of Demolition — Void.

That was all. No large lettering, no bell. The Scales displayed that sentence at exactly the same size as every other sentence.

Even now, I find that indifference strange. It was the moment a whole city lived. But to the Scales, it was only one more update. A single item had changed, nothing more. The Scales didn't rejoice, and it didn't grieve. That was only natural. But that day, for the first time, that very naturalness hurt.

Beneath the sentence, in small letters, the grounds were listed. "Confirmer: Herald Pheugon. Declaration received. Article 4, Clause 11 invoked." That was the first time I saw my own name appear on the Scales' screen. Through all one hundred twelve cases, my name had never once appeared there. I had always been the one who read — never the one who was recorded.

That day I entered the Scales' record for the first time. Not as an item, but as a cause. The Scales did not weigh me. It only wrote down what I had done, as grounds. The difference didn't seem large to me then. It feels large now.

A child standing beside the terminal reached out and touched the screen. Fingers landing, then lifting away. Not understanding what it meant, the child looked up at the nearest adult. The adult lifted the child into their arms.

. . .

The square began to make sound only after that.

At first it was one person's weeping. Then several. Then it turned into a sound that couldn't be told apart anymore — weeping mixed with laughter, names being called, people simply crying out.

The baker threw her arms around the person beside her. The market merchant sank to the ground and wept into both hands. The woman holding her child lifted the child up into the air. Not understanding a thing, the child laughed along with her.

Two old men held on to each other. One pressed his face into the other's shoulder and said, "We lived. We lived." The other only nodded, without answering.

I recall that sight often, even now. Not many people ever hear a hundred twenty thousand voices weep at once. It wasn't the sound of sorrow. And yet, though it wasn't sorrow, it wore exactly the shape of sorrow. I learned the difference between the two, that day.

. . .

Trope didn't cry.

I looked at her. She stood among the crowd, taking in every sound rising around her. But her face didn't match those sounds. It wasn't relief, and it

wasn't joy. It was some unfamiliar expression.

I walked toward her. It wasn't easy, cutting through the crowd. Everyone tried to catch hold of me. Reaching for my hand, calling my name, trying to clap my shoulder. I didn't avoid those hands. But I didn't stop, either.

When I reached her, I didn't know what to say.

"…Now." I said. "You don't have to leave anymore."

She looked at me.

"…Yes."

"…The reason you wanted to leave is gone now."

She looked at me for a long time, then shook her head.

"…The reason isn't gone."

I didn't understand what she meant.

"…The reason is exactly the same. My mother was pushed out, and I still inherited that weight. It was the city that the Scales called void. Not me."

I didn't fully understand her words then. Now I do. She was keeping her own share of weight separate from the city's salvation. The city had been saved. But she herself still wasn't sure she had a place inside that salvation.

. . .

On the platform, the Adjudicator was announcing something.

I didn't hear all of it. Disposition procedures, future policy for the Scales, records of the clause's invocation. No one else was listening fully either. Everyone was too busy weeping, or laughing, or holding on to one another.

I looked for the substitute herald. He stood alone at the edge of the square. No one had caught hold of him. To the people of this city, he was still a stranger's face.

I went to him.

"…Thank you." I said.

He looked at me.

"…For what."

"…For coming. In my place."

"I only did the job I was assigned." he said. He paused, then went on. "But I learned something today."

"…What."

"That even if I'd come, I could never have read that sentence." He lifted the paper slightly. "Because I didn't know this city."

I had nothing to say to that. He held no resentment. And that very evenness made things heavier for me, not lighter.

. . .

I stood in the middle of the square and looked at the people.

People, saved. A hundred twenty thousand of them. I had spoken that sentence for them. When I said it, I hadn't known what it meant. Now, in the middle of these sounds, I was only just beginning to understand what I had done.

This city lives.

This city, the Reckoning, the city that had raised the person who took my family from me — lives.

When that thought first entered me, I didn't yet know what it meant. I received it simply as a fact. The feeling took time to attach itself.

I didn't weep among those people. I didn't laugh either. I just stood there. While everyone around me was mixing tears and laughter together, I couldn't manage either one.

Trope looked at me. The Adjudicator looked at me. The substitute herald looked at me.

What did they see in my face, that moment? I still wonder. I don't know what expression I was wearing. But I knew one thing myself. That something inside me hadn't even started yet.

The sun rose fully over the square. Laughter spread outward through the whole city. Listening to that sound, I began, very slowly, walking out of the square.

. . .

The streets were no different from the square.

Doors stood open in every house. Someone had set out a table in an alley and was sharing food. Children ran shrieking through the streets. An old man sat

in a doorway, catching every passerby to say the same thing. "Did you hear? Void. Void." Each time he said it, his voice cracked a little more.

I walked through them. No one seemed to recognize me. That felt, strangely, like relief. In the square, everyone had known my name. Here, I was just someone passing through.

That afternoon, walking the streets, I had a strange thought. These people had no idea what I really was. Some knew me as a savior, some as just a stranger, a passing child. Neither knew the real me. Only two people in this city knew the real me. The Adjudicator, and Trope.

. . .

When I reached the well, I stopped.

That was the place I'd first landed in this city. The well with moss on its stone rim. Forty days before, I had opened my eyes there and heard the words, "You're not from here, are you?"

People were at the well today too. No one drawing water. Everyone sat perched on the stone rim, laughing. Someone had begun to sing. It was a song I didn't know the tune to, but the person beside them joined in, and the person beside them too.

I set a hand against the stone rim. I found the spot Trope had pointed to. The groove her mother's hand had supposedly left there. I ran my fingertip over it.

In that moment I thought of Trope. Was she, right now, singing along with this song? Or was she sitting somewhere alone, turning over again the words she'd said — "the reason isn't gone." I wanted to know which it was. But I had no strength left to go find out.

A while later, I left the well. The singing grew fainter behind me.

Walking away, I turned back once. The silhouettes of the people sitting on the well's stone rim wavered in the evening light. Someone clapped, someone else laughed. That scene felt to me like a painting. A painting I wasn't inside of.

I didn't know then why it looked like a painting. Now I know. I was the one who had made that scene. But the one who makes something usually doesn't get to live inside what they've made. The one who opens the door and the one who lives inside it are different people.

. . .

Passing the bakery, the baker caught me again.

This time she pressed bread into my hands. Still warm.

"…Eat." she said. "No charge today. No one's paying today."

I took the bread. Warmth spread across my palm.

"…Thank you."

"I'm the one who's thankful." she said, her eyes reddening again. "If it hadn't been for you, today would have been the last day this bakery was ever open."

I felt like I should have smiled at that. I tried to. The corners of my mouth wouldn't move.

I still wonder what my face looked like to her in that moment. What did she see in my expression? Sorrow? Being overwhelmed? She didn't ask anything after that — she just patted my shoulder once and turned away. Maybe she saw it exactly right. Maybe she simply thought that wasn't a moment to say so.

I walked a long time with the bread still in my hand. I never took a single bite.

. . .

As the sun began to set, I walked out near the city wall.

Few people came out this far. Everyone had stayed in the square or the streets. I sat down with my back against the wall. The evening wind blew. The day's sounds reached me only faintly from here — laughter, singing, someone calling out a name.

Listening to those sounds, I realized something strange. I wasn't sad. But I wasn't happy either. Neither of those two words could explain who I was, in that moment.

I looked at my hands.

They were shaking.

I looked at that hand for a long time. In the square, reading the clause, that hand hadn't shaken. Not when I read the disposition, not when I said "This city has turned." But now, doing nothing at all, sitting with my back against the wall, this hand was shaking.

I didn't have a name for that trembling then. I do now. It wasn't the trembling of fear. It was something long suppressed, leaking out of my body for the first time.

I sat there a long while, the bread resting on my knees. The sky reddened, then slowly darkened.

. . .

It was full dark by the time the Adjudicator found me.

I knew it was him from his footsteps first. A familiar walk. He came and set his back against the wall beside me. He stood there a long while without a word.

"…Everyone's looking for you." he said. "No one knows you're here."

"…I wanted to be here."

He didn't press further.

"Today makes forty years." the Adjudicator said. His voice was low. "I spent forty years just reading that clause. I never thought I'd see it invoked."

I said nothing.

"It feels strange." he said. "I'm happy, but it doesn't feel like happiness. Do you know why."

I couldn't answer that question. But hearing it, I felt for the first time that I wasn't alone. The Adjudicator, too, was standing there that evening carrying something he couldn't explain. Only his and mine weren't shaped the same.

"…Adjudicator." I said. "What about that person. What about that person."

I couldn't finish the sentence. The Adjudicator didn't ask who I meant. He simply fell silent for a moment.

"If you mean your family." he said. "I don't know. Where that person is now, what weight they've gone on adding since — I don't know. The Scales would know."

"…I never asked the Scales."

"Why."

I couldn't answer.

That was the first time I admitted it to myself. I was afraid to check that person's weight. Afraid it would come out low. Afraid that person, like this city, had turned somewhere too. That possibility frightened me more than the Reckoning's survival did.

The Adjudicator rested a hand on my shoulder once. The same weight as before, in the square.

"Rest tonight." he said. "Think about tomorrow, tomorrow."

He left me with those words and walked into the dark. I watched his back until it was gone completely.

Far off, the singing still carried. Someone rang a bell. This time it wasn't the bell of proclamation, but simply a bell of joy. I found it strange that the same iron could make both those sounds.

That night, for the first time, I admitted to myself that I was holding something back. I still couldn't name what it was. But I knew clearly, at least, that it could no longer be held back.

I couldn't sleep that night. The next morning, I found the name.

(Continued in Chapter 41.)

Chapter 41. Anger

> *_Previously_ — The city lives. While everyone wept and laughed, Pheugon alone couldn't. Night came, and the Adjudicator sought him out. "It feels strange," the Adjudicator said. Pheugon still didn't know why his hands were shaking. He didn't sleep that night.*

I watched morning come with my eyes open.

I hadn't slept a wink all night. My body was tired, but my mind was strangely clear. Leaning against the wall, I watched the darkness turn gray, and the gray turn blue.

All that night I thought of exactly one thing. More precisely — I didn't think it. It simply grew larger inside me, on its own. I didn't try to give it a name. I felt that naming it would make it real.

Once the sun was fully up, I got to my feet. My legs had gone numb. Feeling that numbness, a certainty rose in me for the first time. I had to find him today.

All night I'd gone back over what Trope had said. "The reason isn't gone." She'd said the city's living hadn't changed her own share of the weight. When I heard it, I hadn't understood. Only that night did I understand. I had been saying the same thing. Even with the city alive, the reason our home had come apart hadn't changed. My brother still hadn't come back. My mother was still far away. My father was still alone. Trope's sentence and mine were the same shape. Only she had gone quiet before that sentence, and I hadn't been able to.

. . .

Finding him wasn't hard.

In this city he was always somewhere quiet. Not a crowded place, not a truly remote one either — somewhere between. I'd seen him a few times before. The one who never got angry beside someone being unfairly cornered. The one who knew a person's weight before the Scales did. The one who never got angry even when I provoked him on purpose.

I found him at the dry well near the gate. He was sitting there alone. The commotion of the day before had already moved entirely toward the city center; here it was quiet.

He looked up and saw me.

"…Pheugon."

"…That's right." I said. "You knew my name."

"I knew it a while ago."

I stood in front of him. I didn't sit.

. . .

"I have a question." I said.

"Ask it."

"Why don't you get angry?"

I'd asked this question once before. That time I'd asked it to provoke him. Back then it hadn't mattered whether he answered or not. Today was different. I wanted the real answer.

He didn't answer. Instead he watched me quietly. There was no defensiveness in his eyes at all. That made me angrier.

"I'm angry." I said. My voice came out lower than I expected, even to myself. "And you're not. Why not?"

"…What is it that's making you angry." he asked.

That question became the fuse.

. . .

"This city." I said. "This city living. I knew it. I already knew. I knew this would happen. That's why I ran."

My voice began to rise.

"I've known ever since the night I first read that clause at the bottom of the sentence. That you — no, that this world, this clause — would end up exactly here. That mercy wins, in the end, even in the face of an exact verdict. I wasn't afraid of that. I hated it. That's why I ran."

He didn't move.

"If I hadn't run." I said. "This city would have simply fallen. No one would ever have spoken those six words. I wanted it to end that way. I ran wanting this city to die. Not out of fear. That was my calculation."

In that moment I surprised even myself. I had already admitted this in Chapter 27. I'd said it once before, to the Adjudicator. But this time was different. This time I was saying it out loud, in anger. Admitting it and admitting it in anger are different things.

. . .

"Our home." I said. My throat closed. "Our home never had a clause like this."

He still said nothing.

"There was a person from the Reckoning living in our house. For months. I still don't fully know what that person did, or how. But afterward, someone's weight in our home went up, and the Scales calculated it exactly. Exactly. I don't doubt that precision. I still don't."

I caught my breath.

"But we never had forty days. There was no vine. No one to confirm any turning. My brother just left. My mother just went away. My father is still alone. No one ever stood in front of our home and said, 'This family has turned.'"

Saying that sentence, I realized how long I'd been holding it in. Three years. In three years I had never once spoken that sentence aloud. I had always been someone who read other people's sentences aloud. My own, I had never once read.

"But this city." I said. "This city is a hundred twenty thousand people. A hundred twenty thousand people cheated the Scales, stole, neglected, were cruel. And yet, like a vine growing, all of them lived at once. Because I said six words. Is that fair? Is that really fair?"

"Trope's mother." I said. My voice couldn't stop now. "She was pushed out five years ago too. That was small lies, piled up too. Not one great sin — small things, piled up because life was hard. The Scales measured her exactly, and she was pushed out. Why didn't she have a clause? Why did no one ever say in front of her, 'This person has turned'? Trope still goes to the well looking for her mother's handprint. And her mother never comes back."

In that moment I knew I was using Trope's grief as evidence for my own anger. That wasn't right. But I couldn't stop, not then. I needed more grounds to say this was unfair. Trope's mother was that grounds.

. . .

He didn't answer.

I couldn't bear that silence.

"Say something." I said. "Aren't you angry? Even knowing this isn't fair?"

"…I'm not angry." he said quietly.

"Why not!"

I know I shouted that. It was fortunate no one was near the gate. If there had been, I would have shouted at him exactly the same way in front of them.

"Pheugon." he said. His voice stayed low. A lowness without any anger in it. "What you're shouting at me right now — that isn't aimed at the Scales."

I stopped at that.

Until that moment I hadn't known clearly, even myself, who I was shouting at. His words picked it out. I wasn't angry at the Scales. The Scales hadn't saved this city. The Scales had only updated a number. What had saved it was the clause, and behind that clause stood someone. And that someone, from the very start, was the person sitting in front of me.

"…That's right." I said. My voice shook. "I'm angry at you. The Scales was just accurate. You — you people — made it this way. So you can only give mercy once you know the whole sin. So you hand the key to that door to the

one person who has the most reason to hate it. What kind of design is that? I never got to choose anything inside that design. I just stood where you people built the place to stand."

. . .

He looked at me for a long time.

There was no surprise in his eyes, no defensiveness, no irritation. I couldn't bear that. I think I wanted him to be angry with me. If he had been, it would have proven my anger was justified.

"…I" he said. "I know why you're angry."

"If you know, why don't you say anything?"

"What should I say." he asked back. It wasn't a scolding tone. It was a genuine question.

I couldn't answer.

In that moment I realized, for the first time, that I didn't know what I wanted from this conversation. Did I want him to apologize? To explain himself? Or to get as angry as I was? I didn't clearly want any of those. I just wanted to see something else shake, the way I was shaking.

"…You never get angry." I said. My voice grew smaller this time. "Not once, in this whole world. I find that frightening. Because I know not getting angry isn't weakness. I know not getting angry is far more powerful."

He gave no answer to that.

I caught my breath in that silence. My body was shaking. It was the trembling that comes after you've shouted.

"Am I wrong?" I asked. It came out almost a plea. "Is it wrong for me to be angry?"

"…I never said that." he said.

"Then why won't you say anything."

"…What you want to hear right now isn't an answer." he said quietly. "What you want is for me to be angry along with you."

I started to argue with that, and couldn't. Because he was right.

In that moment I saw the true shape of what I'd wanted. I hadn't wanted to be justified. I already had that in hand. I wanted agreement. I wanted someone to raise a fist beside me at this world's unfairness. And in this whole world, the one person who had every right to do it — the only one — never once raised his fist.

I sank down in front of him, as if my legs had given out.

"…I remember that night." I said. This time I wasn't shouting. I just spoke. "The night my father raised his hand at the Scales' terminal. He looked at the number, and didn't show it to me. He only said, 'It's fine.' I knew, even then, that he wasn't saying that to me. He was saying it to himself."

He was watching me.

"After that, I kept my own number low. As low as I could, always. I thought that if I did, it would somehow fill in for my father's share. It was a child's arithmetic. The Scales doesn't count that way. I know that. And still I lived that way for three years. Not getting angry, not doing wrong, being perfect."

"…That must have been hard." he said.

There was no pity in it. It was just a voice acknowledging a fact. That made it hurt more, not less.

"Whether it was hard doesn't matter." I said. "I thought if I could endure the hardship, something would come back. Nothing came back. Not my brother, not my mother, not a normal father. But this city — the moment I said six words, everything came back to it. A hundred twenty thousand of them."

. . .

We stayed like that a long while.

The wind passed over the dry well. Far off, from the heart of the city, people's voices still carried faintly.

"…I can't go back to the city." I said. It was a sentence I hadn't expected myself. "Not right now."

"…Where will you go."

I looked east. Beyond the wall, a low hill was visible. Somewhere no one much went.

"…I don't know." I said. "I just don't want to be here."

He didn't stand. He didn't try to stop me either.

"…Go, then." he said.

There was neither permission nor refusal in it. Just those words.

I turned those words over for a long time that day. I think I half-wanted him to stop me. If he had, I would have gotten angry at that too. Because he didn't stop me, I lost the next thing I could have been angry at. He had, in effect, taken away one more target for my anger.

Even now I don't regret what I poured out at him that day. Every word of it was true. But I also learned, that day, that after I'd poured it all out, nothing became lighter. Anger doesn't disappear by being spoken. It only moves somewhere else.

I turned and left him there.

Passing through the gate, I met the substitute herald. He was sitting alone in the shade at the foot of the wall. Same clothes as yesterday, same posture. He stood when he saw me.

"…Where are you going?" he asked.

"…I don't know." I said. "I just don't want to be here."

He looked at me a moment, then nodded. He didn't ask anything more.

"…Congratulations." he said. His voice was even. "I think you did the right thing."

That wasn't comfort to me, not then. It made things heavier instead. He saw me as someone in the right. In that moment I wanted to tell him exactly who I'd just been shouting at, and what. I didn't.

I only nodded and passed him by.

A few steps on, I looked back. He was still sitting there. Not an angry face, not a sad one. Just watching me.

I didn't know, that day, what that face meant. Now I do. It was a waiting face. The face of someone who knew that after I'd finished shouting it all out, I'd come back eventually.

I turned my back on that face and started walking east.

Following the wall, the sun climbed higher. Inside the city, yesterday's joy was still going on. The bell rang once more. I heard it behind me as I walked.

I didn't know exactly where I was going, then. I only knew I wanted to get some distance — from this city, from that sound. I didn't admit, at the time, that this was running away. I admit it now. I was running away again. Not from the city, this time — from the feeling the city had given me.

(Continued in Chapter 42.)

Chapter 42. The Hill East of the City

> *_Previously_ — Pheugon went to find him and shouted. "I knew this would happen. That's why I ran." He didn't get angry. Instead he asked, "What you're shouting at me right now — that isn't aimed at the Scales." Pheugon started walking east.*

The hill was about an hour's walk from the city.

I didn't know the direction exactly. I just walked away from the city. As I walked, the ground rose little by little, and before I knew it I was climbing a hill.

It wasn't a tall hill. The kind everyone from this region knew about, but no one ever had a reason to go to. At the top there was dry grass and a few rocks. Almost no trees. Nothing that could give shade.

I wasn't thinking about shade then. Someone who needs shade is someone waiting for something. I was climbing that hill without even knowing what I was waiting for.

. . .

From the top, the whole city came into view.

The Reckoning was a city of low roofs packed close together. A square at its center, streets radiating outward around it. A city wall wrapped the whole thing in a circle. Seen from here, the city looked smaller than I'd thought. Living inside it for forty days, it had felt like the whole world. Seen from here, it fit in the palm of a hand.

I sat looking down at that palm-sized city.

I should have asked myself, in that moment, what I was doing. I didn't. I just sat. I drew up my knees, wrapped my arms around them, and looked at the city.

The wind blew. It was stronger up on the hill than down in the city. My clothes kept flapping.

Inside the walls, I could see the square. Tiny, ant-sized figures were moving. Of the hundred twenty thousand who'd filled that square yesterday, all I could see now from here were a few scattered points of motion. I couldn't tell which point was Trope, which was the Adjudicator.

In that moment I felt a strange relief. No one could recognize me here. I wasn't one of those points either, here. I was outside them. I found that comfortable. And being comfortable made me ashamed.

East of the city, low fields spread out. In forty days I had never once gone out that way. A narrow path ran between the fields, and that path led all the way up to this hill. Probably farmers had once walked it often. Now it was half-buried in grass.

Walking that path, it felt strangely good that no one was there. In forty days I had always been inside someone's eyes. As a herald, as a strange boy, later as a savior. On the road to this hill, for the first time, I became a person in no one's eyes at all.

. . .

I sat there for a long while.

For the first hour or so, I wasn't honest with myself. I tried to think I'd just come out for some air. But as time passed, it became clear that was a lie.

I was waiting for the city to fall.

Even writing this sentence now, my hand shakes. I am the person who invoked the clause. The person who saved the city. The person who spoke those six words with his own mouth. And yet, less than a day after saying them, I was sitting on a hill, waiting for that city to fall.

Some will call this a contradiction. I want to say it wasn't. I never once wished for that city to live. I simply could not keep from saying those six words. I learned, precisely, for the first time on that hill, that a wish and an act can be two different things.

I recalled an old story I'd once heard — a herald ordered to proclaim a city's fall, who ran because he couldn't bear the thought of the city being forgiven. It was something the supervisor had once mentioned in passing, at the training grounds. When I first heard it, I hadn't understood that person. Why hate being forgiven? Why couldn't he stand a city he hated surviving?

I understand now. That person in the story hadn't hated a single city. He must have believed the world had to be fair. The rule that the guilty are punished and the righteous are kept safe. Rather than watch that rule broken, he'd chosen to be the one who never showed up to keep it. I know that feeling in my body now.

. . .

Noon came.

The sun stood overhead. With no shade, I took the sun on my whole body. My throat was dry. I hadn't brought water.

I thought, then, that not bringing water had been a mistake. I know now. It wasn't a mistake. I think I wanted to punish myself. For what, I didn't know then, and I don't know precisely now. I only know I didn't want to be comfortable that day.

Being thirsty brought back old thoughts. The three days trapped in the conduit. In that darkness, water up to my knees, I'd suffered not from too little water to drink, but too much. Now it was the opposite. On this hill there was no shade and no water. I found the contrast strangely funny. Three years ago I'd learned to speak while submerged in water. Now I was losing words for lack of it.

I wrote, in Chapter 10, that those three days were the first time I spoke my own story aloud. On this hill I was doing the opposite. I said nothing at all. There was no one to speak to. I was the one who had left the place where he'd been.

. . .

I thought of the dinner table.

The table where the four of us used to sit. Father, mother, brother, me. And for the months that person stayed with us, five. I don't remember those evenings exactly. Only a few fragments remain. The window growing dark outside. Someone laughing. That laughter never heard in that house again after.

I brought that table back to mind on that hill. It was strange. I had already written about that table in Chapter 3. I'd thought it was a memory already put away. But with hunger and thirst pressing in, the memory came back raw. I couldn't even remember what we'd eaten that evening, but the sense of that empty place stayed with me, somewhere in my stomach.

Almost nothing of the city's sound reached this far. The wind was too strong. Now and then something like a bell seemed to carry, faintly. I couldn't be sure.

I kept watching the city. There was no sign of it falling. The roofs stood where they were. The wall stood where it was. A few threads of smoke rose from chimneys. Someone was cooking a meal.

Watching that smoke, I had a strange thought. What would a city look like as it falls? I'd never once imagined it. More precisely, I'd avoided imagining it. For three years I had wished this city would fall, and never once pictured what that falling would actually look like. Now that I tried to picture it, nothing came.

. . .

The afternoon came.

I was still there. My legs went numb, and I shifted position a few times. I tried moving into the shade of a rock, but the rock was small, so was its shade.

Nothing happened.

I still can't say precisely what I was expecting, then. Was I expecting the ground to split? The Scales to reverse its verdict again? Or just expecting anything at all to happen, so my anger would have somewhere to go?

Nothing happened. The city stayed exactly where it was. The people went on living inside it. Whatever I thought, sitting on that hill, the city didn't care.

At first that felt unjust to me. Then it felt empty. I had spoken the most important sentence in the world. And the day after I said it, the world went on turning in a way that took no notice of me at all.

I closed my eyes and remembered the Adjudicator's voice again. "It feels strange today. I'm happy, but it doesn't feel like happiness." He was a man who had waited forty years. I was a boy who had run for forty days. And yet on this hill, our two strange feelings, standing in different places, wore the same shape.

In that moment, for the first time, I wondered. Was the Adjudicator, too, sitting somewhere alone right now, looking into this same unfamiliar feeling inside him? He couldn't be as angry as I was — he hadn't had my three years. And yet he too had looked like a man who'd lost something. The face of someone who had waited forty years for a place, only to watch it filled by someone else's mouth.

I opened my eyes. The city was still there.

. . .

The sun began to set.

I was hungry. My throat was parched too. As my body wore out, my thoughts grew simpler. I stopped waiting for the city to fall. I just sat.

Looking back later, I thought this was the most honest moment of all. When I'd first climbed the hill, I'd been someone waiting for something. By evening I was simply someone exhausted. In the place where waiting had been, nothing was left. Even my anger had grown tired.

Far off in the city, lights began coming on one by one. Houses preparing dinner. Forty days before, I had once watched those lights from a distance with Trope. Back then those lights had been the place we had to return to. Now they were the place I'd left.

The same lights, and yet the heart that watched them had completely changed in between. I can't say precisely when that change happened. Maybe it was the moment I said those six words in the square. Or the moment I shouted at him near the gate. Or maybe it was here, now, on this hill.

. . .

Night came.

The wind grew colder. I drew my collar closer. The city's lights glimmered far off. Stars began to appear. I turned my back to the city and leaned against a rock.

I thought Trope might be looking for me by now. Maybe she'd asked the Adjudicator. "Where did he go." The Adjudicator would probably have told her the truth. That he went east. Beyond that, he wouldn't have known either. This hill wasn't a place anyone had any particular reason to go.

That night I think I wanted Trope to come find me. And at the same time I wanted no one to come at all. Both feelings were there together. I didn't know, then, which one was real. Maybe both were. A person's heart doesn't come out as a single line, the way the Scales does.

A dog barked once, far away. Then quiet again. I looked at the sky. Stars were multiplying, one by one. Without the city's lights up here, far more stars were visible than inside the city.

I tried not to think anything, watching those stars. It didn't work well. Thoughts kept multiplying too, like the stars. My brother's back as he walked away. The day my mother said it was time to go. My father's, "Take care of yourself." The substitute herald's, "Congratulations, I think you did the right thing." The baker's hand. Trope's, "The reason isn't gone." His, "What you're

shouting at me right now isn't aimed at the Scales." Thoughts came up out of order and sank back down.

That night I tried not to look toward the city. My head kept turning that way anyway. I kept watch over that spot without even knowing what I was guarding.

I was hungry and thirsty. And still I didn't want to go down. Going down felt like it would mean admitting something. I didn't know what. Only that as long as I stayed on this hill, I could still be someone holding on to something.

Looking back now, that was strange logic. I had already saved the city. Whatever I did on this hill wouldn't change that fact. But at the time, I felt that staying on this hill was itself a kind of resistance. Resistance to what, I didn't know. Not to the city, and not to him. Probably to myself. I still hadn't fully accepted the thing I had already decided — those six words.

Out of the habit of counting one hundred twelve cases, I began counting the stars. Twenty, thirty, forty. I gave up counting. It wasn't something you could count. There were too many. I realized, in that moment, that I had only ever lived inside things that could be counted. People's names, charges, dates, one hundred twelve cases. And this thing inside me now — whether it was anger or grief, I still wasn't sure — this couldn't be counted.

I fell asleep on that spot that night. No shade, no blanket, my back against the cold rock.

I don't remember what I dreamed that night. But I remember one thing. Just before I fell asleep, I murmured, very quietly, to myself. "…It's still not over." What wasn't over, I couldn't explain then, and I still can't now.

Thinking about it now, that sentence was a kind of threat. I don't even know who it was aimed at. Maybe at myself. That night, on that hill, I think I wanted to believe something more had to happen. Whether the city fell, or the clause

was overturned, or even if some sign fell from the sky. That night, I wasn't yet ready to accept that nothing at all would happen.

The wind slowly died down. I curled up between the rocks. The stone was cold, and my back ached against it. I fell asleep that way. No shade, no blanket, no answer.

(Continued in Chapter 43.)

Chapter 43. Overnight

> *_Previously_ — Pheugon climbed the hill east of the city and waited for it to fall. Nothing happened. He fell asleep against a cold rock, with no shade and no blanket.*

It wasn't light that woke me.

It was something touching my body. Soft, and a little cold. I reached out on instinct. A leaf.

I sat up.

For the first few seconds I thought I was still dreaming. Green filled my whole field of vision. To eyes still half-asleep, I couldn't tell whether it was sky or leaves. I rubbed my eyes with the back of my hand. The green didn't go away.

I still remember those few seconds precisely. That short gap between dream and waking, where nothing needs to be judged yet. I made no calculations at all in that gap. I just looked at the green in front of me. Looking back, those few uncalculated seconds were the cleanest moment of that whole day.

. . .

Something had grown overnight.

Between the rocks, right above where I'd slept, a vine had stretched out. Not just stretched — it had climbed the rock and curved upward like an arch, its leaves spread wide. Beneath it lay a solid patch of shade, directly over the spot where I'd slept all night.

I couldn't move.

I tried to understand what I was seeing. I couldn't. Vines don't grow like this. It normally takes months, at least a few weeks. But this had grown overnight — while I was asleep.

The leaves were broad and thick, dark green. The stem was as thick as my forearm. Yesterday there had been nothing here but dry grass and rock. I remembered that clearly, because I'd spent the whole day before sitting right on this hilltop.

. . .

I searched for the vine's roots.

They began in a crack in the rock. Almost no soil there. I crouched down to look. No sign of a seed. No trace of anyone having planted it. The stem simply began in that crack in the rock. As if it had always been there.

I looked at that root for a long time. Where this vine had come from, where its seed had blown in from, who had planted it — I never found an answer. I still don't know. But looking at that root, for a moment, an unfamiliar sense passed through me. A feeling like I'd seen something like this before. Like I'd seen something grow from a nameless seed once before. I didn't know then where that feeling came from, and I still can't explain it. I only note here that the feeling was there.

The wind blew, and the leaves shook. Their shadow trembled on my feet along with them.

I followed the vine's whole shape with my eyes. The stem began in the rock crack and split into three branches, two of which twisted together and formed

the arch overhead. The third was still short — as though it hadn't yet decided which way to grow, hanging in midair.

Among the leaves, not yet buds, small white points had formed here and there. I couldn't tell whether these were about to bloom, or just markings on the stem.

I looked closely at those white points, and then took my hand away. Sometimes if you look at something too closely, instead of learning what it is, you end up knowing it less. I decided, that day, not to try to find out what those points were. I decided just to accept that they were there.

I stood beneath that arch and looked toward the city. Morning sunlight came through the vine's leaves in fragments. Roofs and walls trembled beyond those fragments. Only then did I reckon that I'd been on this hill barely a day. It felt much longer. The forty days I'd spent in the city, I could count precisely, in numbers. The time on this hill kept blurring.

Dew had gathered at the edges of the leaves. It sparkled in the morning light. Thirsty, I gathered a few drops on my fingertip. Only a few. I touched them to my lips. Cold and clear.

A few drops of dew couldn't quench my thirst. But in that moment, for the first time, I felt that this hill hadn't abandoned me completely. My stomach was still empty, my throat still dry. But something wasn't leaving me to simply pass through.

. . .

I sat back down beneath that shade.

The sunlight was completely blocked now. After the sun I'd taken on my whole body the whole day before, its absence made my body strangely light.

That lightness felt unfamiliar.

I didn't know, in that moment, how to receive it. I hadn't come here to be comfortable. I had come here to be punished. And yet overnight, untouched by anyone's hand, shade had come to me.

At first I wanted to reject it. I even thought about going and sitting back out in the sun. But my body wouldn't move. The shade felt strangely good. Its being good made me angry.

I touched one of the leaves. Smooth on top, a little rough underneath. Some kind of scent rubbed off on my fingertips. It was different from the smell of this hill's dry grass. I searched my memory for where I might have smelled it before. Nothing came.

Smelling that scent, I can say now — for a moment, with no context at all, an unfamiliar image flickered past. A seed, fallen on some dry ground, a seed no one knew the name of. I have never seen a scene like that. Not in this body, at least. And yet in that instant the scene passed through me like a memory. I can't explain it. I've decided not to try. Some things stay truer left unexplained.

I tried to hold on to that unfamiliar image. Like water slipping through a fist, it vanished faster the harder I tried to grasp it. Within a few seconds nothing remained. Only a scent, a green light, and an unexplainable sense of familiarity.

I ran my hand along the vine's stem. Each joint was a slightly different thickness. Some places had the hard grain of an old tree; others were as tender as something freshly sprouted. That all these textures had appeared overnight kept striking me as unbelievable.

Out of trained habit, I tried to calculate the vine's age. By its thickness, the stem should have been at least a few years old. But yesterday nothing had stood here at all. The arithmetic didn't work. I had grown up counting one

hundred twelve cases. Faced with arithmetic that didn't work, I didn't know what to do. In the end I gave up counting and simply felt the stem with my fingertips.

. . .

Past noon, I was still beneath that shade.

My stomach was still empty. My throat still dry. But it was more bearable than yesterday. I found it strange, how much difference one patch of shade could make.

I thought about the Scales again that day. How would it have weighed this shade? Shade itself carries no weight. It isn't stolen, it isn't a lie, it isn't neglect. Nowhere among the items the Scales measures is there a column for shade. And yet that day I felt, for the first time, how much this weightless thing was actually lifting off my body.

I already knew there was much the Scales couldn't measure, even inside that city. What isn't stolen, what isn't struck, what isn't lied — those too carried no weight. But that day, for the first time, I learned that what carries no weight isn't necessarily light. The shade had no weight, and it saved me.

. . .

I looked down the hill again.

Far along the path between the fields, very small, I saw a human figure walking. Too far to tell who it was. I watched for a while, trying to tell whether the figure was coming this way, or just heading out to work the fields. It grew smaller and smaller, and soon vanished among the fields.

I have to admit I felt disappointed, in that moment. I had been hoping someone would come find me. And at the same time, I had no idea what I'd say if they did. How would I explain the vine that had grown? How would I explain why I was still here? I had no explanation ready at all.

I moved back beneath the vine. The temperature of the shade stayed strangely constant. However the sun's angle shifted, the leaves seemed to bend slightly toward it, in turn. I watched from beneath it for half a day, trying to tell whether that was real or my imagination. It wasn't imagination. The leaves really were shaping the shade to follow me.

Watching that, I thought — so there really are things in this world that move this precisely for exactly one person. The Scales was precise too. But the Scales' precision was a precision that measured me. This shade's precision was a precision that covered me. I put that difference into words, clearly, for the first time that day.

. . .

I was still waiting for the city to fall.

More precisely, using the word "waiting" had begun to feel a little embarrassing now. Yesterday's waiting had had an edge to it. Today's waiting simply remained, out of habit. I looked down at the city. Still there. Roofs, walls, smoke.

That afternoon I had a strange thought. Who had this vine grown for? Not for the city — the city had already lived. So it had grown for me. But was I someone who deserved to receive it? Just the day before, I had climbed this hill resenting the fact that the city lived. That shade should come to someone like that — I still didn't understand it.

Now I know. Not understanding was normal. This shade couldn't be explained by a logic of deserving. That was the Scales' way of doing things. I already knew, in my body, that there was a way other than the Scales' way — I just hadn't yet been able to accept it in my mind.

I reached a hand out past the shade. The sun was hot. I drew my hand back inside the shade. The coolness came immediately. I went back and forth over that line a few times. That one hand could feel heat and coolness by turns felt, strangely, like something I couldn't put down that day.

Crossing that line back and forth, I thought of Trope. She had drawn a line between the city's survival and her own forgiveness. "It was the city that the Scales called void. Not me." I thought of that again, touching the boundary of the shade. There was a line like that too, between what lay inside this vine's shade and what lay outside. Except this line, unlike Trope's, had no condition for crossing it. You only had to move your body.

Far off, a bird called. I listened to it for a long time. It was the first birdsong I'd heard since arriving on this hill. The bird landed briefly on a branch above the vine, looked at me, then flew off again. I followed the direction it flew with my eyes. Toward the city.

. . .

The sun began to set again.

I sat under the shade and greeted my second night there. This time I lay down beneath the vine's shade instead of against the rock. The leaves made a sound in the wind. Low and soft.

Listening to that sound, I was able to fall asleep comfortably for the first time since arriving on this hill. I found that strange, and yet I didn't stop it. I was

still angry. But beside that anger, something else was growing, very small. I didn't know, then, what it was.

I closed my eyes and went back over what had happened the day before. Shouting at him. The substitute herald's even congratulations. The whole day I'd spent waiting for the city to fall. None of it was erased by this one vine. But it all began to settle at a slightly different weight. I couldn't explain why. It simply felt that way.

I don't want to write that my anger disappeared. It didn't disappear. But that night, I learned for the first time that I could hold another feeling alongside anger at the same time. For three years I had lived as someone who allowed only one feeling at a time. Kind, or angry. Holding it in, or letting it burst. Under this shade, for the first time, I felt two things at once. Still angry, and at the same time, feeling that someone was looking after me.

Starlight came through the leaves in fragments. I began counting the fragments, then gave up. I didn't need to count them. I only needed to look.

I didn't know, that night, whom to thank. I didn't know who had sent this vine. And yet I said one thing, very quietly, where no one could hear.

"…Thank you."

Who those words were meant for, I still don't know exactly. Maybe for the vine. Maybe for whatever had made the vine exist. I was a little surprised at myself, saying it. In forty days — no, in three years — I had never once said something like that so easily.

Before falling asleep, I ran my hand once over one of the vine's leaves. I wanted to remember that feeling. I don't know why I wanted to. I just did.

Falling asleep that night, I didn't reckon how long this shade would last. It wasn't that I'd given up the habit of reckoning. Just that, this once, I chose not

to reckon, and simply receive it instead.

(Continued in Chapter 44.)

Chapter 44. What the Names Mean

> *_Previously_ — On the hill, overnight, a vine grew up around the spot where Pheugon had slept and made shade. No one seemed to have planted it. Beneath that shade, Pheugon slept comfortably for the first time.*

On the afternoon of the third day, a human figure appeared again on the path through the fields.

This time it didn't vanish. The figure grew larger and larger, and soon I recognized who it was. A walk with a water jug slung over one shoulder. Trope.

I didn't stand. I just watched her come, still sitting where I was.

I felt something strange in that moment. Gladness and shame at once. I wanted to see her again. And at the same time, I didn't want her to see whatever face I was wearing right now. Over these forty days I had felt those two things together many times. Each time, I'd thought it strange. Now I know it's simply how a person's heart works.

Trope stopped for a moment where the field path ended and looked up at the hill. That must have been the first time she saw the vine too. Even from a distance, that green arch would have caught the eye. Watching her stop, I thought — she must be carrying the same question I was.

. . .

She only caught her breath after she'd finished climbing the whole hill. Sweat beaded on her forehead. She set down the water jug and looked at the vine. She looked at it for a long time.

"…What is this?" she asked.

"…I don't know." I said. "It was like this yesterday morning."

Trope stepped under the vine and touched a leaf with her hand. The same motion I'd made.

"…Who planted it?"

"…No one. No one's come up here."

She didn't press further. Instead she held out the water jug.

"…The Adjudicator was worried. You hadn't come down in two days."

I took the jug and drank. Water sliding down my throat had never felt so welcome.

. . .

We sat side by side beneath the vine's shade.

Neither of us spoke for a while. The city looked small down below. The wind stirred the leaves now and then.

"…The Adjudicator asked again." Trope said. "Whether you'll come back."

"…What did you say?"

"I said I didn't know." she said. "It wasn't a lie. I really didn't know."

I drew up my knees and hugged them.

"…I'm still angry." I said. I said it aloud for the first time.

"…I know." Trope said. "I can tell from your face."

"…I'm sorry." I said. "It's not you I should be angry at."

"…You've never been angry at me." she said. "I'm just the person who brought the water jug."

I laughed at that, a little. Not a real laugh. But something close to one.

I was grateful, in that moment, that she didn't push me. The Adjudicator hadn't either. He hadn't either. In this city, strangely, no one had tried to pull me back until I walked out on my own. I wondered whether that was trained restraint, or something this city had learned in these forty days.

. . .

"…The Adjudicator told me to bring you this too."

Trope pulled a sheet of paper from inside her coat. Old, worn paper, its edges a little frayed.

"…What is it?"

"A list of herald names, he said." she said. "A very old one. It turned up from the very back of the proclamation office's storeroom. He said heralds used to be given names for a reason, long ago. Names drawn from an old language, all of them meaningful. No one speaks that language anymore, so no one knows the meanings now. But this list has the meanings written beside them."

I took the paper.

In that moment I didn't know what I was holding. Now I do. I was holding, in my hand, the answer to a question I had never once wondered about in three years. That I'd never once wondered — that itself was strange. Why had I never once wondered what my own name meant?

Thinking about it now, the answer is simple. I had only ever handled names as sound. In the course of reading one hundred twelve cases, I read hundreds of names. Never once did I wonder what any of them meant. A name was a signpost pointing to a person — not a sentence saying something about that person. At least, that's what I'd been taught. But now, this paper in my hand was telling me that was wrong.

I thought of the training grounds. The day Had had stopped three times at his own name. "Why don't you stop?" he'd asked. I suddenly wondered — what had Had's name meant? Why had he stopped at his own name? Maybe he too had never known what his name meant, and his body had simply reacted before his mind did.

I thought of looking for Had's name on that list, and stopped myself. That wasn't mine to do today. Today was my turn.

. . .

Trope flipped through the paper.

"…The Adjudicator said he found this yesterday. He was looking for something else — he found it by accident. But the moment he found it, he told me to bring it straight up to you. He didn't say why. I didn't ask."

I could guess, then, why the Adjudicator had done that. He was a man who had waited forty years for this clause. Now that it had finally been invoked, he probably knew exactly what I'd be doing on this hill. He hadn't sent me comfort. He'd sent me this. I thought that was very like him.

Trope ran her finger down the list, searching for the name.

"…Pheugon." she said.

I held my breath.

. . .

"…φεύγω." she read the old letters, awkwardly. "It says the meaning here. 'To flee.'"

I heard those words.

For a while I couldn't react at all.

I've gone back over this moment hundreds of times since. Each time I remember it a little differently. At first I remembered it as shock. Later, as relief. Sorting it out now, it was both.

"…Pheugon." I said my own name aloud. For the first time in my life, I heard it as something strange.

"To flee."

And I laughed.

. . .

I laughed out loud. Not loudly. But it was unmistakably laughter.

Trope looked at me, startled.

"…Why are you laughing?"

I answered without being able to stop.

"…I've wondered my whole life why I turned out this way. Why I always choose to run, every single time. When the person from the Reckoning wrecked our home, instead of getting angry, I ran into endurance. When I got the Reckoning's sentence, I actually ran. Just now, I didn't go down into the city — I ran up to this hill instead."

In that moment, for the first time, I could see my whole life as one sentence. I'd had that name since I was born. Whether my parents knew its meaning when they chose it, or just liked the sound, I don't know. But I had lived exactly according to that name. Without a single deviation.

"…My name already knew." I said. "It knew from the start that I'd run."

Trope said nothing, just watched me.

"…Aren't you angry?" she asked, carefully. "That it was decided from birth like that?"

I thought about the question.

"…Strangely, no." I said. "I feel like I should be angry, but I'm not. It's almost lighter." I looked at the light coming through the leaves. "All this time I lived without understanding why I'm this way. Carrying something you don't understand and carrying something you understand — the weight is different. The thing itself is the same, but it feels different to hold."

Trope nodded. Not a face that fully understood. But a face trying to.

"…Did the Adjudicator know?" she said. "This meaning."

"…He probably didn't until yesterday." I said. "That's probably why he found it yesterday."

In that moment I imagined the moment the Adjudicator had found this paper and read my name first. A man who'd stood beside this clause for forty years, learning at last that the boy who had finally invoked it was named 'to flee.' What expression had crossed his face? I felt I might never get to ask. And yet, somehow, I felt I already knew.

. . .

As my laughter faded, I noticed I had a little water in my eyes.

I couldn't tell whether it was tears of sorrow or tears of laughter. Now I know. Both. For three years I had lived without understanding why I was always a person who ran. Living without that understanding is heavy. A name doesn't remove that weight. But the weight got a name. Once something has a name, at least you know what it is you're carrying.

"…It's strange." Trope said quietly. "I've never seen you laugh before."

"…Neither have I." I said. "Not in this book. Not in my whole life."

. . .

Trope looked back down at the paper. Her finger moved slowly down the list. She was clearly looking for her own name.

I didn't stop her.

Her finger stopped.

"…Trope." she read, very quietly. "τροπή."

She didn't read the rest. The paper in her hand trembled slightly.

"…What does it say?" I asked.

She didn't answer.

I looked down at the paper. I read it in her place.

'"Turning."'

. . .

Trope said nothing at all.

I looked at her. She stayed exactly as she was, paper in hand. Her expression didn't move. She didn't seem to blink.

I felt, then, like I should say something. But nothing came to mind. Some silences shouldn't be disturbed. I learned that for the first time that day.

Time passed. The wind stirred the leaves. A bell sounded faintly from the city. Trope still hadn't moved.

Even now I can't say precisely how long that silence lasted. It felt very long to me. She had lived five years not knowing what her own name meant. In those five years, without knowing what her own turning meant, she had checked her weight at the Scales, every single day. And just now, she had learned that her name had been pointing that direction from the very start.

I looked at the side of her face. There were no tears. But the absence of tears looked heavier than tears would have. Some feelings don't come out as tears or laughter. They just stay pooled inside the body.

I set my own laughter and her silence side by side, in my mind, in that moment. Both of us had just had the same weight of feeling suddenly given a

name. I let mine out as laughter. She couldn't let hers out at all. I know it wasn't because I was somehow better than her. My name had only confirmed a self I already knew. Her name pointed to a self she had never once let herself be. Confirming is easy. Letting yourself is hard.

. . .

A long while later, she finally spoke.

"…Did Mom know?" she said. Her voice was very small. "When she named me. This meaning."

"…I don't know."

"…Does Mom think she's turned, right now?" she said. It sounded like a question to herself. "Or does she think I'm the one turning, right now?"

I couldn't answer that. It wasn't a question that could be answered.

I didn't fully understand, that day, why Trope stayed silent so long. I understand a little more now. I heard my own name and laughed. My name only confirmed a self I already knew. But Trope's name pointed to a self she had never known at all. She had lived believing she was the one pushed aside, the one left behind. And her name had been calling her, from the very start, the one who turns.

. . .

The sun began to sink toward the west. The shadows lengthened.

Trope carefully folded the paper again. Instead of putting it back inside her coat, she pressed it into my hand.

"…You keep it." she said.

"…Why?"

"…You're the one who reads things." she said. Then, very briefly, faintly, she smiled. It wasn't a full smile. "I don't have the courage to read this one aloud myself yet."

I took the paper.

Taking it, I understood that the two of us had gone through completely different things that same afternoon. I laughed, and she went silent. I understood, and she was left more confused. And yet both of those responses had come from the same root. We had both, that day, for the first time, looked again at a self we had each thought we already knew.

Trope went down the hill before the sun had fully set. I watched her back until it disappeared among the field paths.

Partway down, she stopped once. She didn't turn around. She just stood there a moment, then walked on again. I didn't ask what that pause meant. She probably couldn't have explained it either.

That evening, sitting alone beneath the vine, I read the two names on the paper again. To flee. Turning. I found it strange that those two words sat side by side. Someone who fled and someone who turns had passed through the same forty days, in the same city. And in the end, it was six words from the mouth of the one who fled that had saved the city. I still didn't know how to make sense of that.

I don't know who gave us those names. Neither does Trope. Neither did the Adjudicator. What was in the hearts of the people who once spoke that old language, when they named two newborns this way — I may never know, not even in the years ahead. But that night, I came away with one certainty: that

these names were not a coincidence. There was no ground at all for that certainty. And still, the certainty stayed.

(Continued in Chapter 45.)

Chapter 45. Withering

> *_Previously_ — The Adjudicator found an old list of herald names. Trope brought it up the hill. Pheugon — to flee. Trope — turning. Pheugon laughed for the first time in his life. Trope stayed quiet for a long time.*

The moment I opened my eyes, my body knew before I did that something was different.

It was the light. Every day until then, even with my eyes open, there had been shade over my face. Today the light was falling straight onto it. It was too bright.

I sat up.

My body was stiff — the result of three nights spent going back and forth between bare ground and rock. I rolled my neck side to side. It cracked. I nearly laughed at the sound. Yesterday's laughter still seemed to linger somewhere in my body.

. . .

The vine had withered.

It looked like it had happened overnight. Every leaf hung downward now. What had been green had turned brown, and in some places, already black. The wide arch had sagged and collapsed down onto the rock. When I touched the stem, there wasn't a trace of moisture left in it.

I couldn't think anything, in that moment. I just stood there and looked at the withered leaves. What had grown in one night had withered in one night too. If you wanted to call that fair, I suppose it was. But I couldn't feel it as fair.

I touched one of the leaves. It broke. It turned to powder between my fingers.

I tried to remember the night before. The vine had been perfectly fine before I fell asleep. I had run my hand over one leaf, said "Thank you" very quietly, and fallen asleep. What had happened in between, I had no idea at all. I didn't remember wind, didn't remember rain. I had simply fallen asleep and woken up, and in between, everything had died.

It bothered me, strangely, that this was the day after Trope had come. The day after that afternoon she'd gone quiet for so long, hearing the meaning of her own name — the vine had died the very next day. I knew there was no connection between the two. And yet I kept placing them side by side, as if one thing had to end before another could begin.

It struck me as strange that I hadn't felt a thing, through that whole night. I hadn't felt anything while it grew, asleep. I hadn't felt anything while it died, either. Both life and death had passed quietly while I slept. That quietness frightened me.

. . .

I was angry.

Even writing this sentence, I still surprise myself. Two days before, I had watched an entire city live, and gotten angry. Angry, watching a hundred twenty thousand people survive. And now, watching one vine wither, I was feeling an anger of about the same size.

I looked at the roots again. Where they'd begun in that crack in the rock, only a dry stub of stem remained now. I tried pulling it. It didn't come loose. The roots were still holding on. Only everything that had grown above them had died.

"…Why." I said it aloud. Alone, on the hill, no one there to hear. "Why this."

In that moment I noticed my own voice was exactly the voice I'd used shouting at him near the gate two days before. Same pitch, same tremor. Only the target had changed. Then it had been a person. Now it was a dry stem. I felt ashamed of that. And still my voice didn't quiet down.

I keep hesitating, writing this part. Is it all right to set this down exactly as it happened. Admitting I got angrier over one vine than over the lives of a hundred twenty thousand people — doesn't that make me look far too small a person. But when I first decided to write this book, I made myself one promise. To write what happened at the size it actually happened. To keep that promise, even this shameful part can't be cut.

I looked around. There was no one on the hill but me. No birdsong either. The bird that had briefly landed here yesterday and flown off hadn't come back. Only wind, passing through the dry grass.

I thought of him. The dry well near the gate. It occurred to me that he might still be there. I felt an urge to go to him again, and shout, this time about the vine. To ask why he'd given it and then taken it away. That urge didn't last long. I already knew he wouldn't get angry this time either. And I had no confidence I could bear that silence again.

. . .

I sank down where I stood.

I really was angry, in that moment. More angry, watching this one small vine die, than I had been watching the city live. I wanted to deny that. But I couldn't. My body had already reacted first.

I touched the withered leaves one by one. They all crumbled. Two days before, they had been smooth and thick. Now the moment my fingertip touched them, they turned to powder.

I set that powder in my palm and looked at it for a long while. Why did this feel bigger to me than the lives of a hundred twenty thousand people? I asked myself that question, and for the first time, I didn't run from it. I sat with it.

I looked at the spot where Trope had sat yesterday. Where she'd folded the paper and pressed it into my hand. I set that memory beside the dry stem in front of me. Yesterday I'd learned the meaning of my name and laughed. Today the vine had died and I was angry. In one day I felt like a completely different person. But really I was the same person. The one who had laughed learning his name, and the one now breaking apart in front of this vine — both of them carried the name of someone who flees.

I realized then that I had been waiting for something, the whole time I'd been on this hill. First I waited for the city to fall. Then I waited for comfort under the shade. And now I was waiting for this anger to pass. I had always been someone who waits. It was only the direction of the waiting that kept changing.

. . .

I didn't move from that spot until noon.

The sun fell over my whole body again. There was no more shade. My throat was dry. There was still a little water left in the jug Trope had left the day before. I didn't drink it. I didn't want to.

Writing this part now, I know how foolish I must have looked that day. Not drinking water that was right there. That wasn't an expression of grief — it was just stubbornness. I think I wanted to punish something. The vine, or myself, or whatever it was that had sent this vine and taken it back — I hadn't decided precisely which.

I gripped the withered stem again. It made a breaking sound. I hated that sound, and kept gripping it anyway.

I thought of Trope's mother. The handprint left on the well's stone rim. A mark that hadn't disappeared even after five years. Trope had said that every time she saw it, it felt like meeting her mother again. Gripping that dry stem, I understood that I too was holding on to some trace of something. Except my trace had lasted only two days, and hadn't been carved into stone. It was simply crumbling apart in my hand.

In that moment I felt a strange envy. Trope's trace could still be touched, even five years later. Mine hadn't lasted a single day. I felt that difference was unfair. And I found myself laughable, thinking it. I was the very person who had just been shouting, days before, that it was unfair for the city to live. Now I was feeling it was unfair that one vine had disappeared so fast. I seemed to have a talent for finding evidence of unfairness in everything in the world.

. . .

After a long while like that, I suddenly stopped.

In that moment I felt a strange sense of watching myself from outside. As if I were standing outside my own body, looking down at myself sitting on this hill, gripping a dead vine. And from that vantage, I asked myself. Pheugon. What are you doing right now.

I opened my hand. The broken bits of leaf blew away on the wind.

I got to my feet and looked down at the base of the hill. The city was still there. Roofs, walls, smoke from chimneys. The same view as three days before. Looking at that view, I wondered what those hundred twenty thousand people would say if they knew that, right now, I was falling apart like this over one vine.

Probably no one would understand. I didn't understand it myself. But in that moment I realized something else too. Maybe Trope would understand. For five years she's held on to one handprint left by her mother. To her, that one handprint matters more than the whole city's survival. I had never once thought her strange for it. And here I was doing exactly the same thing, and thinking myself strange for it.

I noticed something for the first time, in that moment. When the city lived, I had gone to shout. I'd gone to find him and poured out thirty minutes. Now that the vine had died, I hadn't gone to find anyone. I had just sat here alone, working the anger down by myself. The same size of anger, and I was handling it in a completely different way.

And that difference was the strangest part of all. I was someone who reacted more strongly to one vine with a few leaves than to a hundred twenty thousand lives. I didn't know whether I should be ashamed of that, or simply accept it as fact.

I sat back down. This time with my back to the dry stem. I didn't want to look at it anymore.

In that moment, for the first time, I saw my three years differently. I had always thought of myself as someone who never did wrong. Someone who never got angry. And yet in two days on this hill, I had fallen apart twice. Once in front of a person, once in front of a dry stem. I wasn't someone who never got angry. I was someone who stockpiled anger. And anger that's been stockpiled eventually breaks out — at any time, over any size of reason at all. I learned that principle in my body, that day.

. . .

By afternoon, I simply lay down beside that dry stem.

The sun was hot. I didn't shield myself from it. Only then did I feel, in my whole body, that the shade that had covered me until yesterday was gone. My back stung. My throat burned.

Feeling that heat, I thought: I only had this shade for two days. Not forty days, not three years — barely two days. And watching myself fall apart this badly over its loss, I understood for the first time that the size of my anger didn't match the size of what caused it.

The city had been a matter of a hundred twenty thousand lives. And in front of that, I'd shouted, built arguments, reasoned about fairness. The vine had only been two days of shade. And in front of that, I simply fell apart. No logic at all. Just pain.

I think I dozed off for a while in that heat. When I came to, the sun had already sunk far to the west. I didn't know how long I'd lain there. My throat was badly parched. Only then did I finally reach for the water jug.

The water was lukewarm. I drank it anyway. A few mouthfuls brought a little clarity back.

I realized something strange, in that moment. I had refused water out of anger at a vine. But my body couldn't overcome anger. When you're thirsty enough, you drink water, in the end. I found that sad. I'd thought I was enduring some great sorrow. Really, I was just a person with a body that got thirsty.

. . .

I closed my eyes. The sun glowed red through my eyelids.

I think that was the first time I saw the true shape of my anger. I hadn't wanted justice. If it had been justice, the sizes of my anger shouldn't have come out backward like that — bigger for one vine dying than for a hundred twenty thousand people living. I had wanted what was mine. What I couldn't bear was losing something I'd received, something I'd felt was mine. The city was never mine. I only saved that city — I never owned it. But this vine had been there for me, and only me, for two days. It was my shade alone.

When it was gone, I fell apart more than I had watching the city live. That day, for the first time, I noticed that fact myself. Noticing it, at the time, brought no comfort at all.

The wind carried off fragments of dry leaf down the hill. I didn't follow them with my eyes.

Once the sun had fully set, the hilltop grew cold again. I sat there in that spot, with no shade, no blanket. I couldn't even tell anymore whether I was angry because the shade was gone, or just cold.

That night, for the first time, I understood that the anger inside me wasn't only one thing. There was anger three years old, anger accumulated over the forty days, anger that had begun two days before, and today, one very small anger, born of one vine. They were all different angers, and yet inside my body they all boiled at the same temperature. That night I tried to sort them apart, one by one. It didn't go well. Before I could sort them, they were already mixed together.

I drew up my knees and hugged them. Stars began to rise, one by one. The same sky as two nights before. Except tonight there were no leaves left to screen them.

That night, meeting the third night on this hill, I asked myself for the first time. How long am I going to stay here. No answer came. But that I'd asked myself the question at all was, in itself, a little different from before. I was no longer waiting for the city to fall. I was just waiting for something to end. I still didn't know what.

(Continued in Chapter 46.)

Chapter 46. Doest Thou Well to Be Angry

> *_Previously_ — The vine withered overnight. Pheugon was angrier than he'd been watching the city live — and he noticed it himself. That night, he no longer waited for the city to fall. He was only waiting for something to end.*

I heard footsteps the next morning.

I assumed they were Trope's. But it wasn't the gait of someone carrying a water jug. It was slower, more even.

I looked up.

It was him.

I wasn't surprised, strangely, in that moment. Four days had passed since I'd shouted at him near the gate and walked off. I hadn't once expected, in all that time, that he would come find me. And yet the moment I saw him standing there on the hill, I somehow felt I had already known this moment was coming.

He hadn't walked up from the direction of the city. Exactly which direction he'd come from, I still can't say, even now. He was simply there, at some point. I didn't find that strange. Over these three days I had been learning how to grow used to strange things.

. . .

He stood beside the dry vine stem and looked down at it for a moment. He said nothing. Then he came and sat beside me, as if it were nothing at all.

I didn't push him away. I didn't welcome him either.

"…How did you get up here." I asked. My voice had no strength in it.

"…I walked." he said.

I nearly laughed at that answer. I didn't, quite.

I noticed, then, that his clothes were covered in dust. There was dirt on his shoes too. The look of someone who had really walked. I found that strange. He seemed like the kind of person who could simply appear. And yet he'd taken the trouble to walk. I didn't ask why. I didn't ask, but I went on remembering those dirt-covered shoes for a long time after.

. . .

We sat a while without speaking.

The city was visible below. Morning sunlight caught brightly on the roofs. A rooster crowed somewhere, faintly.

I looked at the dry stem. He looked at it too.

"…This." I said first. "Did you send this?"

"…I sent nothing." he said.

"Then what?"

He didn't answer. I accepted that silence, this time, as something familiar. A silence with no answer, and a silence that withholds an answer — I'd learned, in the time since, that those were different things. And this silence now was the latter. He wasn't staying quiet because he didn't know the answer. He was waiting for me to reach it myself.

. . .

"…You were angry." he said. It was hard to tell whether it was a question or a confirmation.

"…Yesterday?" I asked. "Or the day before?"

"…Both."

I picked up a dry leaf between my fingertips. It crumbled the moment I touched it.

"…I was angry both times." I admitted. "But strangely, today, I'm angrier about the vine dying. More than I was about the city living. I know how strange that is."

"…So you already knew." he said quietly.

"…Yes. I figured it out alone, yesterday. No one told me."

"…Did you tell the Adjudicator." he asked.

"…No."

"…Trope."

"…No. No one." I looked at the dry stem again. "It's not something worth telling anyone. The one who saved a city getting angrier over a dead plant — who do you say that to."

"…You told me."

I stopped at that.

"…You're different." I said. It wasn't an answer I could fully explain, even to myself.

. . .

He looked at me for a moment.

There was no judgment in his eyes. No surprise either. I tried to count how many times I'd shouted in front of this person. Provoking him. Getting angry. Nearly crying. Every time, he had looked at me with the same eyes. I wasn't afraid of those eyes anymore.

"Pheugon." he said.

"…Yes."

"Doest thou well to be angry."

. . .

I couldn't answer that question right away.

I can still repeat that sentence back exactly, even now. He said it very plainly. Not loudly, not weighted. In the same tone you'd use to ask about today's weather. That made it more frightening, not less. If it had been a rebuke, I could have argued with it. But it was a real question.

"…Which one are you asking about." I asked. "The city living, or the vine dying."

"…Whichever you'd rather answer."

I opened my mouth, then closed it.

. . .

"…The city living." I managed at last. "I think that's right. My being angry about that. I lost my family, and that city survived without paying anything for it. I spent three years keeping my own weight low, just enduring. And those people just got a little kinder, and got everything handed back to them. Is it wrong for me to be angry about that? I don't think so."

He nodded. Not agreement, not denial — just a nod.

"…You brought up Trope's mother too." he said. "Near the gate."

"…Yes. I did."

He glanced toward the city, then back at me.

"…Do you still think that, now?"

I thought for a moment.

"…That's changed a little." I said. "Back then I used Trope's mother as evidence for my own anger. Thinking about it now, that wasn't right. Trope's grief is Trope's. It wasn't mine to borrow."

"…When did you realize that."

"…Just now. While I was saying it."

He seemed to smile with his eyes alone, very slightly, at that. I couldn't be sure. I turned my head to look more closely, and by then his face had already returned to normal.

"…What about the vine." he asked.

I couldn't answer.

Before that question, for the first time, I felt my own logic give out. My anger at the city had logic behind it. The logic of unfairness. But my anger at the vine had no logic at all. It was just anger at something of mine being gone. I was feeling both angers at the same size, and yet I could explain one and not the other.

"…Am I strange?" I asked. For the first time, there was pleading in my voice. "This whole time, I thought all my anger had reasons. My family, Trope's mother, the unfairness of this world. But in front of the vine, I can't name a single reason. I'm just angry. I must be a much smaller person than I thought."

"…What do you mean by small." he asked.

"…Someone who gets angry without a reason. Not righteous anger — just greedy anger."

"…I've never divided the two that way." he said.

I looked at him. There was still no judgment on his face.

"…What do you mean?"

"…What you call righteous anger, and anger without a reason. I don't think they split that cleanly. A person's anger usually comes in layers. The reason on top looks the most convincing. But underneath it, other things are there too."

Hearing that, I looked back into my own anger again. Beneath my anger at the city — was there really only outrage at unfairness there? Or was there, somewhere underneath, the same kind of thing I'd felt when I lost the vine — a hurt that what was mine hadn't been recognized? I had no confidence I could answer that question honestly.

. . .

"…I don't know." I said. "The vine was just mine. Even though it was only two days. When it was gone, I got angry. Angrier than about the city living. I know that doesn't make sense."

"…Do you think it doesn't make sense."

"…Yes."

"…Why."

I was stuck on that question again.

"…The city is a hundred twenty thousand people. The vine is just a plant. There's no comparison."

"…Whose arithmetic decides there's no comparison." he asked.

At that question I thought, for an instant, of the Scales. The Scales would calculate it that way. That the weight of a hundred twenty thousand people and the weight of one vine can't be compared. But I wasn't the Scales. I was a person. And I already knew that a person's heart doesn't calculate the way the Scales does.

. . .

"…It's my arithmetic." I said. My voice grew smaller. "But my heart doesn't calculate that way. My heart feels that two days of shade, given to me, is bigger than a hundred twenty thousand lives. I know that's wrong."

I paused a moment, then went on.

"…For three years I kept my own weight low and believed that made me an accurate person. Like the Scales. But now I see I'm nothing like the Scales at all. The Scales weighs a hundred twenty thousand people and one vine the same way. I don't. I use a different scale for what's mine."

"…Isn't that just what being a person is." he said.

"…Is that supposed to be comfort?"

"…No." he said. "Just a fact."

"…I never said it was wrong." he said.

"Then are you saying it's right?"

"…I never said that either."

I looked at him. The frustration rose in me again.

"Then what is it. I want to know, right now, whether my anger is right or wrong."

. . .

He looked at me for a long time.

"…I can't give you that answer." he said. "It's not that I'm withholding it. That answer was never meant to be given as an answer, to begin with."

"…Then how is it given?"

"…By living."

I didn't understand what he meant.

"…What does that mean." I asked. "That I'll know after a few more years?"

"…It could take years. It could happen in a day." he said. "I can't set that time for you. But I know this much. This question isn't one that closes with an answer today. Today is just the day you heard this question, clearly, for the first time."

Hearing that, I felt strangely at ease. I had been raised believing every question had to have an answer. A sentence document had a disposition. The Scales had a number. That you could carry an unanswered question and go on living — I heard that, for the first time, in that moment.

"…So I have to go on carrying this question?"

"…Is that a bad thing."

I couldn't answer that question either.

In that moment I wanted to press him further. Something stopped me. Before that question, I felt for the first time that it was all right not to know the answer. Or rather — it was all right to sit here, in this place, not knowing.

. . .

We sat in silence again for a long while.

The city stayed below, exactly as it was. The dry stem lay between us. The wind blew. In that wind, I heard his question again. Doest thou well to be angry.

I repeated that question to myself, again and again. The first time I'd heard it, the sentence had felt like an arrow aimed at me. Each time I heard it again, it sounded slightly different. Now it no longer felt aimed at me — it felt like it

was sitting beside me, facing the same direction I was. I learned, that day, that a question could sit with someone too.

I still take this question out sometimes, even now. When I think about being angry that the city lived. When I think about being angry that the vine died. Each time, the answer wavers a little differently. Some days it feels like I was right. Other days, not. I've decided now to accept that very wavering as the answer. Only the Scales has an unwavering answer. I'm not the Scales.

I never did answer that question. Not that day, and not for a long time after. Even now, writing these words, I still don't have a certain answer to it. Some questions have to stay unanswered to remain questions. I may have already wished, in that moment, for this question to go on following me and never leave.

He didn't stand. Neither did I. We just sat there, side by side, with that unanswered question between us.

The sun climbed a little higher. The city's roofs caught the morning light, one by one. Watching that glimmer, I thought of Trope down there somewhere, and the Adjudicator, and the baker, and countless other people whose names I didn't know, all beginning their day. None of them would ever know what conversation had passed on this hill today.

That fact, strangely, didn't weigh on me. Some conversations don't need to be known by anyone. That day, for the first time, I felt that not everything needs to be proven or explained. In front of the Scales, I had always been someone under proof. By numbers, by records, by evidence. Up on this hill, there was nothing to prove. I only had to sit.

The wind stirred the dry stem slightly. A few broken bits of leaf rose into the air, then slowly settled back down. I followed them with my eyes. He didn't. He was still watching me.

(Continued in Chapter 47.)

Chapter 47. Were You There Before

> *_Previously_ — He came up the hill to find Pheugon. "Doest thou well to be angry." Pheugon couldn't answer. He gave no answer in his place, either — only, "You'll know that answer by living." The two of them sat a long while without speaking.*

The sun was drawing close to noon.

We were still there. He hadn't left yet. I hadn't gone anywhere either. Between us lay the dry stem, an unanswered question, and — strangely — a comfortable silence.

In that silence I thought again about this person. In forty days I'd only seen him a handful of times. Standing beside someone unfairly cornered, in the square. Knowing a person's weight before the Scales did. Never getting angry even when I provoked him on purpose. Even gathering all those pieces together, I couldn't say who this person was. The one thing I could be sure of was that he wasn't from this city. Exactly where he was from, I didn't know.

Fiddling with the dry stem, I suddenly remembered a question I'd been holding back for a long time. I hesitated a long while over whether to say it.

I know now why I'd held that question back so long. It was because I already knew there would be no answer. And still, in the end, I asked it. That day I learned there are questions worth asking even without an answer.

. . .

"…Can I ask you something." I said.

"…Go ahead."

I looked toward the city. It was hard to ask, looking straight at him.

"…You." I said. "Have you been in a city like this before?"

He didn't answer.

I kept going. Once I'd started, I couldn't stop.

"What I mean is, is this the first time for you? Being someone who doesn't get angry, someone who knows before the Scales does, someone who sits with a person like this and asks questions? Is this your first time, or has this happened before? In other cities? With other people?"

I poured all that out without pausing to breathe. It felt as if, if I didn't ask now, I might never ask again.

. . .

He looked at me.

And smiled.

I still don't feel confident describing that smile precisely, even now. Nowhere in this book had I ever seen him smile before. I'd known he was someone who never got angry. That he was also someone who never smiled — I hadn't known that either, until that moment. When he smiled, for a second I wondered if I'd asked something wrong. But it wasn't a mocking smile. It wasn't teasing, either. I never fully worked out, that day, what that smile really was.

"…That's an interesting question." he said.

"…I didn't ask to be interesting."

"…I know."

He kept smiling, watching me. I didn't look away. There was something in that smile. I searched his face for a long while, trying to find what it was. It wasn't only pleasure. There was something like a very old weariness mixed into it too. And yet that weariness didn't feel like exhaustion — it felt like the kind of weariness only someone who has endured something for a very long time can carry.

In that moment, for the first time, I wondered. How much silence had this person passed through, to arrive at this one smile. I didn't know the answer. I still don't. But I could tell that this one smile had revealed, just barely, the weight of everything he'd swallowed down until now.

. . .

"…You're not going to answer, are you." I asked.

"…If I" he said, still smiling a little, "answer that question, what happened on this hill won't stay on this hill."

I didn't understand what he meant.

"…What does that mean?"

"…Some questions" he said, "give you the next question once you hear the answer. And answering that one gives you another. You're knocking on the first door right now."

"…So you won't open it?"

"…Not today." he said.

"…Then someday?"

"…That's not for me to decide." he said.

"…Then who decides?"

He gave no answer to that question either. In that silence, I felt a third kind of silence — different from the other two I'd learned from him before.

That was the first time I met this third silence. It wasn't a silence that knows the answer and withholds it. It wasn't a silence waiting for me to reach it myself, either. It was simply a silence that said, now is not the time. I couldn't find the right words to explain it then. I still can't, fully, now. But before that silence, I felt two things at once — that the answer to this question surely existed somewhere, and that I wasn't the one meant to hear it today.

. . .

I thought I should have been angry at that answer. Strangely, I wasn't.

I didn't know why, then. I know a little more now. There were several questions in this book that never got answered. Why the clause never activated. Who wrote the clause. Why he never got angry. Before all of those questions, I'd always felt only frustration. But before this question, something else came first. In that moment I felt certain he was hiding something. And that certainty — that he was hiding something — was itself proof that something was there.

"…I think that's the answer." I said. "You not answering."

He looked at me. A little of the smile still remained.

"…Think whatever you like."

. . .

"…Just one more, then." I said. "Have you seen this city before, or is this the first time?"

"…Same question." he said. "Just dressed differently."

I couldn't argue with that. He was right.

"…Then let me ask it differently." I said. "I thought this was the first forty days this city had ever had to face. That the clause had activated for the first time too. The Adjudicator waited forty years for it. But you. Is this your first time too?"

He was quiet for a moment.

"…I" he said, "make a distinction between saying something is the first time, and saying it isn't familiar."

I turned that sentence over several times.

"…What's the difference?"

"…Whether something's the first time is a matter of time." he said. "Whether you've been through it before or not. Familiarity is a different matter. There are things you can go through many times and never grow familiar with."

"…So which is this? How many times has it been? Are you used to it, or not?"

"…Same question again." he said. This time he didn't smile. But there was still gentleness left in his voice. "You've put a third set of clothes on it."

I felt a little embarrassed at that. I didn't give up, though.

. . .

I held on to what he'd said.

"…So are you used to it? Things like this?"

He didn't answer. Instead he looked toward the city. The roofs down below were shining in the sunlight.

"…Pheugon." he said. It was the tone of someone changing the subject. "Do you know what that city is doing right now?"

"…I don't know. I'm up here."

"…Living." he said. "It's just living. It lived yesterday, it's living today, it'll live tomorrow. That's the most important thing there is."

In that moment I knew he was changing the subject. I didn't press him on it. I already knew I wasn't going to get an answer. But in that moment, I also felt that the way he changed the subject wasn't a retreat. It was closer to a hand, gesturing to take me somewhere else.

. . .

We went quiet again.

I never heard the answer to that question, that day. I still haven't heard it. Even now, writing this, I don't know what city he was in before, how many cities he's watched through forty days like these, whether this really was the first time.

And yet I've never been able to let go of that question, since that day. I've held on to it the whole time I've been writing this book. The thought that someday,

in some other city, someone else passing through their own forty days, might go through something very close to what happened in this one. That thought unsettled me. And, strangely, it comforted me too.

I saw Trope, far off, climbing the hill. She had the water jug slung over her shoulder again, today too. He saw her, and stood without a word.

"…I'll come again." he said.

"…When?"

"…When you need me."

He left with those words and walked down the hill. I watched, as he passed Trope, the two of them bow their heads briefly to each other. Then he kept walking, and I never did see which direction he vanished in.

. . .

Trope only really looked at me once she'd finished climbing all the way to the top.

"…That person just now — do you know him?" she asked. She was still out of breath. "As he passed me, he nodded, and it was a face I'd never seen before, but somehow it felt familiar."

I stopped for a moment at that.

I didn't know, then, what to tell Trope. How do you explain a person you don't fully understand yourself? In the end I chose the most honest answer I had.

"…I don't really know him either." I said. "But he's helped me the whole forty days."

Trope didn't press further. Instead she sat down beside me and unwrapped her bundle.

"…The Adjudicator said you really have to eat something now." she said. Two loaves of bread and a few boiled potatoes came out.

I took them. My hands were shaking. I only truly admitted, then, how hungry I was.

. . .

We sat side by side next to the dry stem and shared the bread.

We were quiet for a long while. A bell sounded faintly from the city. It was ringing noon.

"…What did you two talk about earlier?" Trope asked again. This time she was asking about the content, not the person.

I stopped, halfway through splitting a potato in two.

"…I asked him." I said. "Whether he'd been in a city like this before."

"…What did he say?"

"…He smiled." I said. "And didn't answer."

Trope listened to that quietly.

"…That's strange." she said. "I've never seen someone smile and dodge a question at the same time."

Hearing her say that, I felt reconfirmed in what I'd just seen — that it really had been strange. In forty days I'd watched this person never get angry. I'd

watched him never smile, either. And today, just once, both of those broke at the same time. I don't think that was a coincidence. I still don't.

"…I think it's strange too." I said. "But it's better than getting angry."

Trope laughed a little at that.

. . .

We sat quietly again. The sun climbed fully overhead. There was still no shade. The dry stem lay between us, casting not even a shadow.

"…What are you going to do with this now?" Trope asked, pointing at the dry stem.

"…I don't know."

"…Are you going to pull it out?"

"…No." I said. "I'll just leave it."

I couldn't explain, then, why I answered that way. I understand a little now. I wanted to leave that stem behind as evidence. Evidence of what, I didn't know exactly. I only wanted whoever came up this hill again someday to know that there had once been shade here.

Trope nodded. She didn't ask anything more.

"…The Adjudicator asked again." she said, a while later. "Whether you'll come back."

"…What did you say?"

"…I answered differently this time." Trope said. "I told him you'd be back soon."

I looked at her.

"…I never said that."

"…I know." she said. "But I wanted to say it."

I had no answer to that. I still hadn't decided when I'd go down. And Trope had already decided the answer for me. I should have felt burdened by that. Strangely, I didn't.

. . .

As the sun began sinking toward the west, Trope left the water jug and the remaining bread beside me and stood.

"…I'll come tomorrow too." she said.

"…You don't have to."

"…I know." she said. "But I will."

She went down the hill. I watched her back the whole way. Partway down the field path, she stopped once again, then walked on.

I could recognize that pause now. It wasn't a pause to check anything. It was just her, taking one more moment to hold me — left behind on this hill — in her heart, before walking on.

I set the question he'd left me and the pause Trope had left me side by side, and looked at them together. Neither one demanded anything of me. Both were simply waiting for me to move on my own. I wondered how long that waiting

could go on. I didn't know the answer. But that day, for the first time, I felt I didn't want to test how long that waiting could last, any longer.

. . .

Alone again on the hill, I opened the water jug and drank. It was lukewarm. But this time I didn't want to refuse it.

The sun sank completely. Stars began rising, one by one. I sat with my back against the dry stem. I remembered counting stars in this same spot a few nights before, and giving up. I didn't count them today either.

That night I kept going back over his smiling face. The old weariness inside that smile. I still didn't know what that weariness had endured. But since seeing it, I began to see him a little differently. Until then I had thought of him only as some strange person who had appeared in this city. Now he seemed like someone who had passed through something even before this city. What he had passed through, I still didn't know. But knowing that he had passed through something at all was enough to make me see him differently.

That night, for the first time, I pictured concretely the day I would go down this hill. Whether it would be days away, or tomorrow, I didn't decide. But that the day was coming — for the first time, in that moment, that felt certain.

(Continued in Chapter 48.)

Chapter 48. The Way Down

> *_Previously_ — Pheugon asked him, "Have you been in a city like this before?" For the first time, he smiled and dodged the question. He left with the words, "I'll come again. When you need me." Trope said she'd come up every day. That night, for the first time, Pheugon felt certain that the day he'd go down the hill was coming.*

I spent a few more days on that hill.

I didn't count exactly how many. Writing this book, I know how strange that is. I was a person who counted three days, counted forty days, counted one hundred twelve cases. And yet I didn't count those days. I never decided not to count them, either. At some point, without my noticing, the habit of marking off days on my fingers had simply stopped.

I still can't pin down exactly when that started. Maybe it was from the day the vine grew. Or maybe from the day he smiled. Either way, from that day on, I stopped being someone who counted time.

Trope came up every day. She'd leave the water jug and bread, sit a while, then go back down. Some days she talked a lot. Other days she just sat beside me in silence and left. The Adjudicator never came up, not once. Instead he sent short messages through Trope. "Take your time." I turned those words over many times. There was no urging in them at all.

One day Trope brought up the substitute herald. He'd already left for another city, she said. Before leaving, he'd left one line. "This case is going to sit strangely in the record." Trope said she didn't know what that meant. I didn't say that I did.

One day, no one came at all. I spent that whole day sitting beside the dry stem, thinking about those small white points that had once looked like they might become buds. Whatever they might have become, they had withered along with everything else, before becoming anything at all. I still hadn't decided, even that day, whether that was a sad thing or not.

. . .

I knew, the moment I opened my eyes that morning.

I couldn't have said exactly what I knew, then. My body simply moved first. I sat up. The dry stem was still there. Withered black, its roots still lodged in the rock crack.

I looked at that stem for a long while.

I've rewritten this scene several times. In one draft I wrote that I cried in front of it. In another, that I laughed. Neither was true. The truth is, I did nothing at all. I just looked. For a long time.

I reached out and gripped the base of the dry stem once. It made a breaking sound. That sound no longer bothered me.

"…Thank you." I said. The same words I'd said, that first time, under its shade. But the words that day and these words today were different words. I still can't explain the difference. I only know that it is a difference.

I stood.

. . .

My body swayed. I hadn't eaten properly in days. I stood a moment, steadying myself. The city lay below. The moment I'd first been washed up at the well forty days before, the first night on this hill waiting for the city to fall, and now — these three moments overlapped all at once.

I decided nothing, in that moment. Writing this book, I've felt the temptation, many times, to write "I decided, then, to..." It would have made for a cleaner sentence. But it isn't true. I didn't decide anything. My body simply stood, and my legs simply began to walk. The decision followed later, little by little, along the way.

I gathered my things. There wasn't much. A few clothes, an empty water jug, and —

I stopped there.

. . .

There was a folded paper tucked inside my coat. Old, its edges a little worn. I took it out and unfolded it.

Two sentences, written in my own hand.

Original: This one never explained himself.
Precedent: This one never repented.

I haven't once thrown this paper away, since the day I copied it out in the room of records. Not on the day I believed it would be evidence enough to bring down the Scales. Not on the day I learned that evidence would overturn nothing at all. Why I never threw it away, I didn't fully know myself, even then.

I looked at that paper for a long time.

Never explained himself. Never repented.

Mena had been someone who, in some city, had watched the difference between those two lines. While that difference quietly reshaped verdicts in other cities, one after another, Mena had probably never known it. Or she had known, and been unable to do anything about it. I still don't know which of those two is the sadder thing.

I thought about leaving this paper up on the hill. It was evidence that had already become useless inside this city. The Scales' conclusion had been right. This paper had overturned nothing. And still, I folded it back up and put it inside my coat.

I couldn't explain, that day, why I did that. I still can't, fully. I only know that I had become someone who knew that this person's — Mena's — sentence had become something else entirely, passing through someone else's hands. And someone who knows a thing like that, I learned that day, cannot leave that knowledge lying anywhere behind.

. . .

Here, for the first time, I have something to set straight about this book.

I am writing these words right now.

I have been writing this from the very first line of this book. And yet, through forty-seven chapters, I never once set that fact plainly down on the page. I only ever wrote "I know," "I didn't know then," "now I know a little more." I never once revealed who stood behind those sentences.

I asked myself why I'm writing this so late. The answer is simple. I felt I could only admit I was writing this once I had come all the way down this last hill of

the book. Right now, before I've even finished coming down this hill, I set it down here. Because I wanted to write it before it was too late.

Why am I writing this.

Mena was someone who kept records. Someone who belonged to no city, who moved between many, writing down what people said. One sentence of hers, passing through a few hands, was turned into something entirely different. She couldn't stop it. Either she had already left that city, or she had already let go of that sentence — either way, she wasn't in a position to protect her own words.

I was afraid of my own sentences ending up the same way. So I decided to set down these forty days with my own hand. In case someone, copying this story out later, turned "he was angry to the end" into "he repented in the end." Or the reverse — turned "he raged to the end" into "in the end he understood it all."

I am neither. I am still walking, somewhere between the two.

That's why I'm keeping this paper. What Mena couldn't protect, I want to protect in her place. And yet I know — keeping this one sheet of paper in my coat won't restore their proper meaning to the rest of Mena's sentences, scattered somewhere across other cities. That wasn't something I could do today. But there was one thing I could do today. At least this one page in my hand — I could keep it safe.

I don't know who will read this book. Maybe no one will. I write it anyway. I never wanted to answer someone the way the supervisor once answered me — "because that's the rule." I wanted to leave behind what happened, instead of the rule. At the size it actually happened, neither adding nor taking away. That was the one proclamation I found I could still make, after enduring these forty days.

. . .

I started down the hill.

The field path was the same one I'd first seen that night, forty days before, going out to bring Trope back. It had been dark then; I'd never really seen the shape of the road. Now it was daylight, and the path lay open before me. A narrow dirt track, half-buried in grass. A path farmers must have walked, once, long ago.

I followed it down.

Writing this sentence, I find it strange that I can say precisely where I'm walking now. For the past three years I had always known exactly where I was supposed to go. The proclamation office. The training grounds. The Reckoning. There was always a fixed destination. But on this path down the hill, there was no fixed place at all. I was simply walking downward, toward where the city was.

My body still had no strength. Every few steps I stopped briefly to catch my breath. Each time, I looked back. The hilltop grew smaller, little by little. The dry stem couldn't be seen from here anymore.

The sun was hot. Dry dirt crumbled under my feet. Somewhere, insects kept up a low, steady chirring. I caught myself listening to each of those sounds, one by one. For forty days, and for a few more days on this hill, I had spent most of my time listening only to the sounds inside myself. The sound anger made. The sound a question made. On this road, for the first time in a long while, I was hearing the world outside.

. . .

Walking, I thought of many faces.

The four who had sat at our table, and then five. Had's face, turning back as he packed his things and walked out. "Why don't you stop?" The supervisor's face, asking, "Do you have some connection to the Reckoning?" Trope's face at the well, asking, "You're not from here, are you?" The Adjudicator's face, saying, "That isn't the face of someone afraid." The substitute herald's face, saying, "Congratulations. I think you did the right thing." And the face, a few mornings before, that had smiled and dodged my question.

I started counting those faces one by one, and stopped myself. I had decided I was no longer someone who counts. But a habit worn into the body doesn't disappear easily. I caught myself trying to count again a few more times, and stopped each time. Stopping, too, I learned on that road, takes its own kind of training.

I thought, too, of his dirt-covered shoes — the ones from the day he'd said he'd walked all the way up. He could have simply appeared, and yet every time, he'd come with dust on his shoes. I noticed dust gathering on my own shoes now too. It felt strange, as if it placed him and me, somehow, on the same road. It was only a brief feeling, but I wanted to hold on to it.

. . .

Halfway down, I stopped and turned to look back up at the hill.

The vine couldn't be seen from here either. Too small, or too far. I only knew that something remained up there. There are things you know are there even when you can't see them.

In that moment I thought of the Forty-Day Clause. That one line, sitting inside the Scales' code, never once invoked. No one had ever thought to strike it out. Even though it looked useless, someone had left it there, inside the text, all

along. I understood that impulse a little now. Some things need to be there, even unused.

I thought of the Adjudicator. In forty years, he had never once seen this clause invoked. And yet, he'd told me, he had never once suggested striking it from the text. I understood those forty years a little now, too. Someone who waits for something doesn't give up the waiting itself, even if they never live to see it used.

In that moment I thought of Trope's mother too. The handprint left on the well's stone rim. A trace that hadn't faded in five years. Walking that road, I confirmed once more that waiting settles into different shapes for different people. For the Adjudicator, one line in a clause. For Trope, a handprint left in stone. For me, one sheet of paper folded inside my coat.

I started walking again.

. . .

The city drew closer, little by little. The outline of the wall sharpened. A few threads of smoke rose among the rooftops. Someone was cooking a meal today too.

Watching that smoke, I thought again of everyone inside those walls — Trope, the Adjudicator, the baker, a hundred twenty thousand people whose names I didn't know, living out their day. How many of them knew that a vine had grown on that hill, and withered? Probably none of them.

Strangely, that didn't weigh on me. I'd already learned this, back in Chapter 46. Some things don't need to be known by anyone. That day, on that hill, I'd learned to simply sit without needing to prove anything. Today I was learning to simply walk, having risen from that spot, without needing to prove anything either.

I thought of the Scales. It was probably still turning somewhere in that city, right now. Someone's theft today, someone's restraint today, calculated without error. The Scales would still not be wrong. And I was still walking a place the Scales could never measure.

I reached a point where the gate came into view. Still a long way off. People moving in and out looked like nothing more than small points from here. I stopped again. The dry well beside the gate came into sight. The spot where he'd said he'd walked here from. No one there now.

I looked at that well for a long while. Whether I would meet him there again someday, or in some other city, at some other well, I didn't know. *I'll come again. When you need me.* I still hadn't decided whether to take those words as a real promise, or just as comfort.

I thought, suddenly, of my name again, and Trope's. To flee. Turning. For three years I had fled. For forty days I had fled. And on this hill, I had fled a few days more. And yet now, on this road, I was doing something that was neither fleeing nor turning. I was simply walking. I still don't know, even now, which of the two it's closer to.

. . .

The path curved in among the fields. I stopped, briefly, at that bend.

I thought for a very long time about how to end this book, here. I considered writing the scene of my arrival in the city. Someone recognizing me in front of the gate. Trope running out. The Adjudicator taking my hand. I wrote scenes like that several times. I deleted them all.

It isn't that I deleted them because I felt I had no right to write them. It isn't that I deleted them because I couldn't clearly remember whether they'd

actually happened. I knew that this book had to end in a question, not an answer. I didn't want to invent the answer.

When I was eleven, I asked the proclamation supervisor, "But why?" He only answered, "Because that's the rule." I didn't like that answer. I didn't know then that it wasn't really an answer at all. I know now. Some questions have no rule, and no answer. There is only the person who keeps walking, carrying the question.

In the first chapter of this book I wrote that I'd wondered why the Scales never speaks its own verdict aloud. I wrote that it was only much later that I came to think about why a person had been placed there instead, and who had placed them there, and why. Even reaching this last chapter, I still haven't found that answer in full. But I know, now, what it feels like to stand in that place.

. . .

Right now, I am standing at that bend.

Mena's paper is inside my coat. Behind me is the withered vine. Ahead of me is the city. I don't know whether I'm ready to go back into that city. I don't know what I'll say when I see Trope again. I don't have an answer, yet, to his question — Doest thou well to be angry.

I am walking, carrying all of this, unknown. For three years I believed that doing something without knowing was the most frightening thing in the world. That's why I always calculated. Always counted. Always confirmed. Right now I am walking without calculating anything at all. And strangely, it isn't frightening.

I started walking again.

The path kept leading downward. The city lay at its end. I hadn't yet seen the end of that path.

Even after finishing this book, I am still on that path. Whether I reached the city or not, I've chosen not to write here. That isn't me hiding something. I learned, writing this book, that some stories must not end in arrival.

The wind blew across the fields. The smell of dry earth came with it, and, very faintly, the smell of someone cooking, carried from the direction of the city. I walked on, breathing that smell in.

My stomach was hungry again. My throat was dry again. This time I didn't turn that hunger and thirst into hurrying. I'd walk a few steps, stop to rest, and walk again. Whenever the thought came that someone might be waiting for me, I found myself, instead, slowing my steps. I couldn't explain why, then. I understand a little now — I wanted to walk this road itself a little longer.

I walk.

And I am still, even now, standing before that question.

Was I right to be angry.

(The End.)

The Forty-Day Clause

Jaehyuk Choi